Times Past and Future

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/35338774.

Rating:	Mature
Archive Warning:	No Archive Warnings Apply
Category:	F/F
Fandom:	She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)
Relationships:	Castaspella/Light Spinner (She-Ra), Castaspella & Light Spinner (She-Ra)
Characters:	Castaspella (She-Ra), Light Spinner (She-ra), Original Character, Angella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Scorpia's Mothers (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Norwyn (She-Ra)
Additional Tags:	Alternate Universe, The Horde (She-Ra) doesn't exist, Shadow Weaver (She-Ra) doesn't exist, Festive fic, I don't really celebrate Christmass, Scorpia (She-Ra) as a princess, Etheria celebrates New Year, Castaspella/Light Spinner (She-Ra) - Freeform, Lovers To Exes To Lovers Again, Other relationships appear, catradora, Scorfuma, Glimbow, seamista - Freeform, Arranged Marriage, Meaning Casta has an spouse, Agreement to keep the appearences, It's all a façade, politics can be so ridiculous, quite sappy, Memories, Idiots in Love, Flirting, Affairs, Princess Adora (She-Ra), prince catra, Yes they will marry here, They are traum-free, You may consider everyone relatively happy, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Hordak does appear later on, but he won't create the Horde, this is a war-free what if
Language:	English
Series:	Part 1 of Path 3
Stats:	Published: 2021-12-25 Completed: 2025-12-31 Words: 98,099 Chapters: 39/39

Times Past and Future

by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

In this Horde-less Etheria, seven kingdoms live harmoniously. Every year, the princesses of every kingdom host a day of celebration during the last week of the year, beginning with Bright Moon, and ending with Mystacor, where the year is received with a show of magical lights in the sky, visible everywhere on the planet.
It was barely the first celebration of the week when the past came back for Castaspella. She was conversing with her brother when they saw the woman arrive, the one who had long ago been Micah's tutor and, not so long ago, unbeknownst to everyone, Castaspella's lover.
They have a week to reconnect, to reminiscence, and get to know each other again. Will that old ember light up again, or is this the final goodbye?

Notes

Alright. Bear with me:
- As there is no Horde, the Fright Zone is replaced by Scorpia's kingdom (her mothers are there too), and according to my investigation the actual name of the place is difficult to discern; the palace we know in the series, called Horror Hall, in MoTU wasn't related to Scorpia and was in a territory called Dark Edge, which I will be using here (I'm going to play with how Scorpia's personality crashes with those names). The place that was Scorpia's territory, would be the Crimson Waste, and while I'm tempted to make it part of her kingdom, it makes little sense. Furthermore, also because there is no Horde, you may remember it was that what Light Spinner used to convince young Micah of helping her; so as it doesn't exist she never performed the spell (more in the fic), **meaning Shadow Weaver never happened, and both Catra and Adora are trauma-free** [*Me, being self-indulgent and rewriting it like I'd like to rewrite my childhood!? Nah, never*]
- I'm also solving a few things with the rarity of Etherian species we hardly see as caused by natural disasters; like the Magicats or whatever Light Spinner's species is. More explained in the fic.
- For the alternative backstory of Adora here, I'm also taking some inspiration from the original MoTU lore, but I think you'll like the idea. Also, speaking of MoTU lore, I'm using the "real names" -according to the aforementioned lore- of both Casta and LS.
- FYI: All four Best Friends Squad are dressed like in Adora's future vision (but Glimmer is still a princess).
- I rarely write sappy stuff, this is to counter festive-season depression; also, the idea came from watching the movie *It's Complicated*, but I don't really like the idea of cheating on your partner -I won't ever understand it-, so instead I changed it to the arranged marriage thing in which Castaspella and her spouse have an agreement.

- Final note for MoTU fans with more obscure lore knowledge: I am taking the liberty of using Arden (that apprentice of Norwyn) as the base for "the spouse", kinda making him my own character. Here, Arden is also Norwyn's apprentice, but they are the same age as Casta, approx, not a guy, and not into women cause I say so.

Without further clarifications, please enjoy.

Chapter 1: Day 1: Bright Moon

Day 1

Bright Moon

As the annual festivities approached, preparations in every kingdom were in full motion. The last week of the year is celebrated in all of Etheria, each place with its respective tradition, and the princesses hosts an open celebration for everybody, one each day of the week. All seven days become the most festive of the year, beginning with Bright Moon, and finishing with Mystacor, where the new year is received with a beautiful light show in the sky that can be seen from almost everywhere on the planet.

The celebrations are always opened by Bright Moon, the first to welcome all Etherians who wish to join the parties. Castaspella had assisted with the preparations in the palace, per her brother's request, and was now receiving guests while the Queen and King prepared to make their entrance. Soon, there was a diverse crowd filling the main hall, and she knew it was time to introduce the regents.

—Attention, please!— she called. —May we receive the hosts of today's festivities. Queen Angella, King Micah, and Princess Glimmer.

The doors opened and all three of them entered the hall, received by a loud round of applause.

—We're soon to receive a new year, and once again, we gather to appreciate all of what we've been given and the people we have met. We appreciate the diversity and richness of our world, and celebrate every kingdom. May the next few days be full of the same joy we relish today— Angella spoke, sounding both imposing and gentle at the same time.

After another round of applause, the party properly began. More people kept arriving, Glimmer went to find her friends, and Micah approached his sister while his wife dedicated a few minutes of her time to everyone in attendance.

—Everything looks quite well! Thank you for handling the introductions, Sis— Micah commented, as he stood next to her. Both were looking at the crowd, standing almost on a corner, as if overseeing the party instead of joining. He kept speaking without looking at her —You’ve never been one to mingle. But, where are they?

—I do not know, nor should I. You are well aware of how it is— she replied, sipping from her cup briefly.

—And if you were asked about it?

—I'd still answer I don't know, although my choice of words would be different.

—Why is the status so important that you subject yourself to this?— Micah asked, clearly concerned.

—You already *know* I had no other choice. The arrangement could have been undone but… After everything that happened… How could I reject their offer? It benefits us both— she replied, trying to keep her voice even.

—So you trade happiness for status— he insisted.

—Excuse you, I can have what you're calling "happiness". The agreement we made is *exactly* for that. I just haven't had time for relationships.

—For four years!? Well, this can be a good opportunity for that, no?— he suggested.

—During the End of the Year week?— she laughed.

—Precisely! With all the people you'll be meeting…

—Like every year…

—Just try to stay open to possibilities. You never know what may happen— Micah insisted. —And speaking of "what may happen", look at that— he pointed out, staring at someone who had just arrived. —Never thought she'd come this year.

As they stared at her, Castaspella replied —Neither did I. What made her change her mind?

—We can ask her, she's heading straight for us— he muttered.

Micah hadn't seen his former tutor since his graduation, but for his sister, it had barely been a few years since they taught together at Mystacor. Light Spinner walked directly at them, almost as if there was no one else in the hall, unbothered by the partygoers around her. The siblings were equally surprised noticing she looked just like when they had last seen her.

—Good evening. Nice party, Micah— she let out with a neutral tone.

—Good evening— they both replied.

—Quite a surprise to see you here— Castaspella added.

—You weren't expecting me, right?

—You haven't come in five years— Micah remarked.

—I supposed both of you would prefer it if I didn't come— she replied. Then, she casually grabbed the cup from his sister's hand and took a sip, carefully holding her veil so she wouldn't stain it. —But when your wife was kind enough to tell me I was welcomed to the festivities, I saw fit to come.

—Are you serious!?— Castaspella complained.

—Absolutely.

—I'm talking about the cup— she specified. The woman returned the cup, and she added —At least ask for permission next time.

—So sorry, Es. I recall you saying that was unnecessary— Light Spinner teased.

—How funny. Because I can't even recall the last time you called me "Esmeralda"— she retorted, noticeably bothered.

—You hurt me— she kept mocking, pretending to be offended. Even with the veil covering her mouth, it was obvious she was smirking. —I, on the contrary, remember the last time you called me "Beatrix". A shame it's such a bitter memory.

—If I may…— Micah interrupted. —We are all aware you didn't leave on the best terms. So, why would you return now?

—As I said, Angella invited me.

—It's not the first time, Light Spinner— Micah quickly replied. —It's the third year she goes through the trouble of finding you and personally reminding you are allowed to come to the festivities.

—Fine. It wasn't *only* that— she finally admitted. —I'll just say she was quite persuasive.

—Sure— Castaspella grunted.

—Why are you in such a bad mood, Es?

—I don't know. Why are you in such a good mood, *Bea?*— she asked back, mocking her tone.

—Shouldn't I be? I hadn't seen you in such a long time…— she teased.

—Yet you have no new tricks— she swiftly deflected. —If you actually missed me, try speaking to me like a normal person. You can't just jump into your teasing after so many years— she reproached.

—How very mature of you— she admitted. —In that case, would either of you mind telling me a bit about how things have been?

—May I?— Micah asked his sister. She nodded and he began —The past few years have been quite calm, especially since our girl has been spending more time with her fellow princesses.

—I see she has grown a lot. Any improvements with her sorcery?

—Quite a few, yes. It seems like Adora’s friendship inspired her to train and unleash her full potential. Although she’s not training in Mystacor— he replied.

—Can’t blame her. She’s better off learning from you or your sister.

—That’s mean, Bea. Mystacor’s performance has improved a lot— Castaspella pointed out.

—You can defend your precious kingdom all you want, but that old fool is not ready to have a half-human half-angelic sorceress in the academy— she insisted.

—Why is it so difficult for you to show any respect for the Head Sorcerer?

Despite Micah sharing his sister’s irritation, he was so amused by their bickering he could hardly hide a giggle; which earned him an annoyed look from her.

—There are far more skilled sorcerers who should have his place— Light Spinner sentenced, looking right into her eyes. —And if you ask “like you?” then you entirely missed the point.

—If you don’t mean yourself, who could you possibly mean?— Castaspella questioned her, increasingly annoyed.

—Eh, Sis— Micah interrupted. —Why don’t we return to some more casual conversation?— he gently suggested.

—Right, right. Excuse me, I got carried away— she apologized.

—You were telling me about Glimmer. Who are those she’s talking to?— Light Spinner asked, looking in the direction of the princess and her friends.

—Those are Bow, her boyfriend, princess Frosta, Catra, and Princess Adora— the sorceress replied.

—And who would she be? Not a princess I had heard of.

—Adora? She’s from a neighboring universe. I believe you must have heard at least *something* about her.

—I recall that someone important from another universe was brought into this one to learn about our magic. Never had the time nor the interest to ask for the details about it. Would you mind?— she requested.

—Well, you did hear of Queen Marlene.

—Yes, the human Queen from Eternia. I presume that's her mother.

—Exactly. The Queen brought her as a little girl, to be raised here and not only learn about magic, but about all of Etheria— she explained. —She has been traveling from kingdom to kingdom, and her contact with all the runestones revealed she had some connection to the magic of our world.

—How so?— she asked, interested.

—Apparently, when she was eighteen and her mother had come to look for her, something *happened*, it's still unclear what, and Adora suddenly manifested some magical form no one had seen before— Castaspella recounted.

—The mythical warrior I've been hearing about? Is that her?— she asked, looking back at Adora with a surprised expression; she looked much younger than imagined.

—Indeed. It seems that Queen Marlene knew it could happen and wanted her to manifest these powers. She then gave her the choice, to either return home or stay in our universe.

—I'll presume she decided to stay.

—She first took three years solely to explore Etheria and her new powers— she explained, looking at Adora too. —It would appear she found her place with us in Etheria, and also someone special for her. Rumor is, they might marry soon.

Light Spinner let out a laugh and looked back at Castaspella as she asked —Since when do you regard rumors?

—I just mean…— she quickly replied, stammering and keeping her sight on the girls. —She *did* choose this world over her home just for Catra; the lady next to her.

—One of the few survivors of the collapse of Halfmoon, am I right?— she guessed, looking back at them.

—Yes. Apparently, she's been with Adora almost since she arrived in Etheria— she commented with a smile. —No wonder they... Oh, no. Please don't.

The sorceress interrupted herself as she looked back at Light Spinner. Something inside her froze; it felt like the past had returned only to slap her across the face.

—What?— the woman asked, oblivious.

—I know that look— Castaspella uttered with severity.

—What are you talking about?

It was difficult to know whether Light Spinner was pretending or genuinely hadn't realized. However, she couldn't disguise her indignation, neither in her expression nor in her speech.

—The way you're looking at Adora; noticing her prowess. I saw that same look back then.

—You remember *that*?— she asked, finally looking back at her with total surprise.

—Of course I remember! It was merely 5 years ago!

—All of Mystacor seems to have erased me from their memories since my banishment— she pointed out. —I walked by Norwyn on my way here and he didn't even spare me a look.

—You quite literally insulted him to his face and called him an "Old ram". What were you expecting!?— she asked, indignant. —Not to mention you called him “old fool” just earlier!

—He deserved it— Light Spinner replied, rolling her eyes.

—We're not having this argument again. I'll tell you exactly the same I said last time— Castaspella sentenced, looking away in disbelief.

Considering it a good moment, Micah interrupted —Hey, sorry to intrude but, Sis, I think *someone* is looking for you.

All three of them looked in the direction he pointed and saw a tall, red-haired magician walking their way.

—Ah, yes. I believe it's high time you introduced me to your spouse— Light Spinner commented.

Rolling her eyes, Castaspella pleaded —Please don't start.

—I had heard you married— she continued, speaking in a lower tone. —Arranged? For status? Is all of that true?

—It is.

—Why would *you* need status?

—We *also* had this conversation already— Castaspella insisted, barely able to hide her indignant expression.

But before the woman could bother her further, the cheerful voice of the magician interrupted and called their attention.

—Do my eyes deceive me!? Light Spinner!?

—Good evening, Young Arden— she greeted them.

—Oh please, even Norwyn no longer calls me that— they let out, blushing a bit. —Wouldn't have thought you'd remember it.

With a similar tone, the woman replied —How could I not? I still remember you graduated a few years after your fellow apprentice here—, she gestured at Castaspella, —As well as I remember your *support*.

—And once again, I apologize for contributing to your banishment— they quickly reacted, with a sincere expression and briefly bowing forward. —You must understand I was a beginner tutor and couldn't risk my position.

—Of course. No great damage was done— she acknowledged. Then, with an ambiguous tone, she added —It was you two who ended on thin ice. But now you have married and regained Norwyn's trust. What a happy ending.

While Micah, his sister, and some of the partygoers who were eavesdropping, reacted with surprise and even indignation at her bold remark, Arden let out a hearty laugh.

—Such a great sense of humor!

Castaspella could feel her heart skip a beat. They were completely misunderstanding the situation. She locked eyes with Arden and they noticed her expression was extremely tense.

—That was hardly “sense of humor”. She's just mocking you in a seemingly respectful way — she sentenced with fake indifference only they could recognize.

—I suppose it depends on how you see it— they replied, challenging her. —Wouldn't it be better for you to take it that way? It's less stressful.

She understood what they meant. Why even was she resisting? The sorceress held their stare for a few moments before finally giving up.

Resigned, she sighed —Fine, fine. You're right.

—Well, you really *are* a smart one after all, Arden— Light Spinner chuckled.

Castaspella whispered —You don't understand what you're talking about.

Right after, she emptied her cup and practically pushed it into Arden’s hands before turning around and walking away. They caught the cup, giggling, obviously amused.

—I'll encourage you to follow her— Arden told Light Spinner, winking at her.

—So I plan— she replied with a knowing look. —Excuse me— she said, politely bowing at both Micah and Arden. It didn’t take her long to catch up to Castaspella, who was just leaving the main hall. —What a show.

The sorceress stopped on her tracks and turned around sharply, hissing —Stop it. You really have *no* idea of anything.

It was clear how angry she was, yet Light spinner didn’t hesitate and smoothly asked —Don't I? Then please, by all means, enlighten me.

—All they said, it doesn't really mean what it's supposed to mean. It's but a... coded language, if you may. Something only they and I understand— she replied, trying to calm herself down.

—Oh, I can imagine. Which is why they told me to follow you— she admitted. It was clear she knew more than Castaspella thought, but wouldn’t reveal how much. —Why don't you tell me what that meant?

The sorceress looked around, the corridor was empty. Yet it didn’t feel safe enough, so she pulled Light Spinner by the hand into an empty balcony.

Taking a deep breath, Castaspella began —When they said "sense of humor", it means Arden recognized you as... A possible interest for me. They said "great" precisely because they were

trying to encourage me, and the same goes for when they insisted. Then, "depends on how you see it" is their way of telling me I'm just stopping myself out of fear.

She seemed a bit exasperated at the end of her explanation, and Light Spinner couldn't let the opportunity pass.

—Why would you?— she teased her, stepping forward.

—Can you blame me for fearing only bad things can come from... us?— she asked back, looking away shyly without moving away.

—Is that so?— the woman insisted, taking another step forward, and wrapping an arm around Castaspella's waist. —Yet I recall you admitted they were right. Does that mean…

—That I... may want to take a chance. Yes— she confessed, blushing. When she finally looked back, she added—But I have a lot of reservations, woman, and you're *not* making a great case for yourself.

—You're still so cute when you're angry— she laughed, nearing her face. —But if I have to convince you… Would you like to know the *real* reason why I came this year?— she offered, towering over the sorceress, letting the veil brush her face. Greatly surprised, Castaspella looked up into her eyes and nodded; something, possibly hope, seemed to have lit up her expression. —It's true that Angella came to invite me again, but… This time she also told me something *very* interesting about your marriage with Arden.

—You can't be serious. She really…?

—Told me about that arrangement?— she interrupted. —Yes.

—B-but why?— she asked, baffled.

—Perhaps I made it obvious that hearing you had in fact married them is what kept me away — Light Spinner admitted, rolling her eyes. —Do you think it wouldn't hurt me seeing you with someone else, Es?

—I-I never… How could I know?— she whispered. —You felt so betrayed when I didn't leave with you…

—But you were right. It was selfish of me to ask you to abandon everything because *I* was banished— she admitted. —And it was also my fault; I should have listened to your warnings.

—I still helped you with that spell. You were *so* invested— Castaspella recalled. —If Micah and Arden hadn't told Norwyn, I know you would have tried it.

—Almost twenty years of work; of course I would have tried!— Light Spinner exclaimed. Then, her expression fell. Holding her closer, her free hand reached for the sorceress' cheek as she neared her face, and whispered —But I should have known I'd lose you.

—I thought you hated me now— Castaspella sobbed, leaning on her. —This arrangement felt like a joke; I had already lost you, what was the point?

—Perhaps it's time to make use of it?

She let out a sad laugh and hugged Light Spinner.

—But it has some rules; it's really important to follow them or it's all over— she warned.

—I'm not losing you a second time. Tell me the rules, I'll stick to them— she promised, gently tilting her head up.

The relief Castaspella felt was evident in her smile. She was finally relaxed, her expression softened, and once again looked like the young sorceress Light Spinner had left five years before.

—Let me explain everything. You already know the agreement was done back when I was a kid. So I could have turned it down but…

—…Your association with me left you in a tight position, I recall.

—Like you said, not only me but also Arden for intending to benefit from the spell too before changing their mind. So we were both on probation, and the arranged marriage hadn't been annulled yet— she started again. —So, Arden had this idea… None of us wanted it, they don't even like women, while I… just wanted you. So we agreed to marry, make it look like we *are* a couple, but then each of us could have a partner more to our preference— she continued. —The conditions are to keep everything strictly secret, the priority is always to maintain the façade. We help each other with this, it's the best for both of us, and in public it's important to keep our interactions subtle enough.

—So I can't tease you? What a shame— Light Spinner mocked.

—Well, everyone may remember your teasing; not only with me but with just anyone. So, as long as you don't make it obvious…— the sorceress was considering, until she interrupted.

—Does that mean you like my teasing?

—Since when I don't?

The woman laughed and held Castaspella's waist with both hands.

—That's the Esmeralda I remember— she muttered. —Can I kiss you now?

—Can I take off your veil?— she asked back, looking away sheepishly.

—Of course.

Castaspella slowly reached for the sides of the veil, fixed behind her ears, and carefully removed it. She had missed that little detail, the feeling of being allowed into the most vulnerable side of her. And when Light Spinner kissed her, she suddenly felt as if back in the

time before her banishment. Once again, she was happy, safe, at ease; once again, she felt loved.

They lost track of time, the sun had set and a fresh night surrounded them. The party would go on until midnight, but plenty of guests retired earlier, so Castaspella gave Light Spinner indications to find her in Mystacor, and returned to the main hall.

The sorceress found Arden and, after half an hour of mingling, arm in arm, pretending they were saying their goodbyes to go home, they finally left Bright Moon. Arden informed her they would be in Seaworthy until the next day and return for the festivities in Dryl, so she would have the house for herself.

—Then I suppose you'll be back at noon?— she asked.

—Approximately. Yes. That will leave me plenty of time to prepare for tomorrow's party— they replied, stretching a bit as they walked side by side. —But, tell me! How did it go?

—Oh, please— she huffed, wanting to dismiss them. But it was clear Arden wouldn't drop the subject. —Fine. It was fine.

—Does that mean she's alright with the conditions?

—O-of course. Just… Why are you asking so much?

Arden couldn't help laughing at her furious blush.

—At long last you finally have *someone*! Of course I'm thrilled!

—Go be thrilled with someone else.

—Hopefully, tonight will fix your bad mood— they commented mischievously.

—Arden!

—Sorry, sorry! I'm leaving— they laughed. —But really. Try to enjoy it, Casta. You've been brooding about this for five years. Don't you think it's time to enjoy yourself?

—And what if it happens again?

—Even if it only lasts this week, believe me: you'll feel absolutely renewed— they insisted. —Now, go. Good night.

They quickly disappeared with a spell and Castaspella was left alone. She gathered her courage and finally went to meet Light Spinner where she had told her.

—Bea?— she called when she arrived.

—I was afraid you'd change your mind— the woman replied from behind. Before the sorceress could turn around, she grabbed both sides of her torso and whispered into her ear —I'll presume you haven't.

Castaspella placed her hands above Light Spinner's and replied—Like I told you… I have some reservations but… I won't just cower without trying.

The sorceress teleported them both to her house. As soon as they appeared, Light Spinner wrapped her arms around her and kissed her face over and over again, repeating how much she had missed her. Castaspella barely managed to lead her into the room before the woman attempted to undress her, but once inside, she just surrendered to her thirsty touch.

They were ravenous. Exchanging kisses and touches wasn't enough, they needed to re-explore each other again, they wanted to know just how much they had changed, and whether they still fit each other. Their gasps and moans soon made it clear they still belonged together, and after a few hours, they had finally exhausted themselves.

Castaspella comfortably rested her head on Light Spinner's chest, while the woman kept her wrapped in a warm hug. Slowly, they felt like falling asleep.

—Rest well, Es.

—Sweet dreams, Bea.

—This is enough of a sweet dream already— she teased, making Castaspella smile.

—I'm glad.

Chapter 2: Day 2: Dryl

Day 2

Dryl

The late morning sun woke up Light Spinner as it reached her eyes, exhorting her to wake up at long last. Reluctantly, the woman sat on the bed, laying her back against the wall, and finally noticed the empty space next to her.

—Es?— she called out, almost scared finding herself alone.

A moment later, Castaspella opened the door and walked into the room holding a tray. Light Spinner hadn't seen that kind smile in so long it made her nostalgic, she could barely believe the time they had been apart.

—You're finally awake, Bea— the sorceress said as she went to sit by her side on the bed. —Here, tea and a cake.

—Smells delicious— she noticed.

Light Spinner took a sip of the tea and recognized the flavor; once again, a wave of nostalgia invaded her, but she brushed it away.

However, Castaspella noticed her surprised expression and asked —What is it?

—I'm… surprised you went through the trouble of buying this to prepare me breakfast. Are you trying to impress me?— she teased, unwilling to reveal her thoughts.

—How mean! I *cooked* it!

The woman looked back at her with complete surprise.

—In all seriousness now. Are you trying to impress me!? How long have you been up!?

—About two hours or so— she replied casually. —I needed to… cook for a while.

—Wait… So, you made this in two hours?— she insisted. Castaspella nodded and Light Spinner couldn't help asking —So you're anxious?

—Of course. How wouldn't I?

—I can't believe you're stressing out about this already— she laughed. —Relax, Es. Nothing's going to happen; if my memory serves me right, we're perfectly capable of keeping this a secret— she reminded her, before eating some of the cake.

—It's… fine. Don't worry. I just ought to get used to this— she let out with a sad smile.

Light Spinner realized she was too tense and it was better not to bother her anymore, so she just enjoyed the breakfast Castaspella prepared her, and shared some with her trying to distract the sorceress. Once done, she took the tray back to the kitchen and left Light Spinner to put on her clothes. Around an hour later, as they discussed how and where they would find each other in Dryl, they heard the door and knew Arden had arrived.

—Casta?— they knocked on the door. Before she could answer, they added —Are you awake, Dear?

Castaspella froze and looked back at Light Spinner, gesturing for her to be quiet while pointing at her veil; Arden using an endearing term like that meant there was someone else in the room.

—What's going on?— the woman whispered as she struggled to put on her veil; but the sorceress insisted she had to keep silent.

—Perhaps she's still asleep, please give me a moment— Arden said outside. They quickly entered the room and closed the door behind them. —You're still sleeping? I thought you said you'd only take five more minutes— they exclaimed, making it obvious they were pretending for whoever was outside. Then, they whispered —We have *huge* problems.

—Who is it?— Castaspella asked.

—Norwyn. *Again.*

—Of course— she grunted. —I'll go see if I can convince him to leave…

Castaspella took a deep breath before leaving the room, pretending she had dressed in a rush, and left both Arden and Light Spinner alone. They looked at her with a knowing look and it took the woman all her willpower not to laugh.

—Go ahead… Don't be shy… Is she still *functional* after half a decade?— Arden asked in a low voice, mischievously.

—How subtle— she let out, smirking. —But if you want to know… Just like back in her twenty-nines.

—Finally! Perhaps you'll get rid of her perpetual grumpiness— they laughed, barely able to keep their voice down.

—Of course not, that's part of the bundle.

Once again they could barely hold their laughter, but soon enough, Castaspella was back in the room, with an expression of relief that indicated Norwyn was gone.

—Did he ask anything?

—Whether I knew where Light Spinner had gone last night— she replied, rolling her eyes. —Doesn't he have more important matters to attend to?

—None at all, Casta. He's been nagging everyone about this all morning— Arden replied. —But now, it's time to get ready for another party!

—The room is all yours— Castaspella assured them. —Let's go, Bea.

—What!? Are you serious? You're going like that again?— they asked, indignant.

—What's wrong with my clothes?

—Oh, come on. I understand never making an effort if you had no one to impress, but will you *really* let this opportunity pass?— they insisted. —I'm sure our esteemed Light Spinner would *love* to see your golden attire.

—No, no— she quickly replied, ignoring the look the woman was giving her. —I'm not dressing like that, I don't like making a scene like you.

—Scene!? I put on a whole show! And all the better if it sells our façade, no?— they suggested. —If anything, just do it for her visual delight— they added.

—My visual delight implies *fewer* clothes— Light Spinner teased.

—I'm sure, but that would scandalize the people at the party— they added, much to Castaspella's mortification.

—I can't believe you two teamed up to mock me— she whined, covering her flushed face with both hands.

—What else did you expect? You're so easy to fluster, Es. It's too tempting— Light Spinner mocked.

—What have I brought upon myself…— the sorceress lamented dramatically, making them both laugh loudly.

That evening, the couple arrived at Dryl, fashionably late, and took a few minutes to mingle together, noticing how Norwyn kept his sight on them since their arrival. However, even with the matching outfits, it was still noticed they had spent barely five minutes together before going their separate ways. Castaspella found Light Spinner speaking with a couple, Princess Adora and Catra. They were wearing the same formal outfit from the previous day, and each held two tiny cups a robot butler had handed them.

—Good evening— the sorceress approached them.

—Ah, Es, how nice of you to join us— Light Spinner taunted.

—I can always leave you to speak alone if you prefer— she retorted.

—Nonsense. We were discussing the fall of Halfmoon. I'm sure you'll be interested— she told her nonchalantly.

—Good evening, Castaspella— Adora greeted her as soon as the sorceress looked their way, while Catra briefly bowed next to her.

—Do you mind if I join?

—Not at all— Adora assured her. —Just… Wow! That dress makes you look so different— she noted.

—It looks a lot like yours, Adora— Catra commented.

—That's right— Castaspella agreed. —Arden had it made, and it wouldn't surprise me if the similarity was intentional.

Their conversation eventually returned to their discussion of Halfmoon, the earthquakes that buried the underground kingdom, and the few families that managed to escape. Both Adora and Catra shared bits of their stories, how they had met, and their travels through Etheria.

Then, it was their turn to ask the sorceresses about them, and while Castaspella had little to share that they didn't know, Light Spinner had hundreds of anecdotes about her exile.

—But, I don't understand— Adora interrupted. —Why were you banished? I heard too many stories.

—Well…— the sorceress sighed. —I had a project, an old spell I worked on for two decades, aimed at invoking a great power from the core of the planet— she began, reminiscing. —It required far greater power than mine, and it had to be executed perfectly or it could backfire. But before I could ever test it, I was reported to the Head Sorcerer and the council, who saw fit to banish me as I had already ignored several years of recurrent warning.

—But, it *could* have worked. The power I unlocked, I can feel it comes from this planet. Maybe your project wasn't so different— Adora reflected.

—It's not the same, Love— Catra interceded. —Your mother knew you'd manifest those powers, while that spell is an experiment, she just said so. And with all the precautions it required, it's only natural for the Head Sorcerer to forbid it— she affirmed.

—But, isn't banishment too extreme?

—Excuse me, Princess, but Catra is right— Light Spinner interrupted. —I kept working on that spell despite being reprimanded for years. Only banishment would guarantee I'd no longer have access to the scrolls I need to continue with it.

Castaspella looked at her with admiration.

—This is the first time I've heard you admit your recklessness— she remarked.

—Very funny— she replied mockingly. —But now that we're on the subject: could I ask you, Princess, about those powers of yours?— she requested, looking back at Adora.

—Ah, of course. I… If I'm not mistaken, everyone has heard about how I turned into this powerful warrior, with great strength and a magical sword, right?

—That's what everyone has been talking about. Yet no one knows what happened that first time you manifested such form— Light Spinner replied.

—It was… It was a test, from my mother— Adora began, looking away with a grim expression. Catra quickly got rid of the cups she was holding and gently grabbed Adora's shoulder, noticeably concerned. —I'm alright, don't worry— she muttered, forcing a smile.

—Why don't you let me tell them?— Catra suggested. Adora took a deep breath and accepted, seemingly relieved when she looked back at them. —When the Queen of Eternia came for her three years ago, she had a portal open right in front of us, and sent some troops through it— she began, with a serious expression. —We were in one of Bright Moon's gardens, expecting someone to inform us when her mother arrived at the palace, like when she had first brought Adora here. But instead, those soldiers came to attack us out of nowhere. Queen Angella was furious after that, but Queen Marlene insisted she had to do it.

—I hadn't heard a word about it— Castaspella let out, astonished.

—It's better that way— Catra sighed. —We weren't ready for an attack, but confronted them anyway; yet, even after knocking out half of them, they still overwhelmed us— she continued. —Soon, they knocked me out and… A warrior goddess was suddenly there to save my fur— she concluded, looking back at Adora with loving eyes and half a smile.

—So… your mother set you up to force your transformation— Light Spinner reflected.

—It was a scary experience, if I'm honest— Adora admitted. —That's why I took the time to re-explore this planet and my powers. I needed to find their true purpose and how they were related to Etheria— she explained.

Adora wanted to continue, but Glimmer appeared from behind and interrupted them, shouting —Adora! We need you now!—. She seemed in a rush as she grabbed her arm, ready to teleport, yet she halted and stared at Castaspella. —Auntie, what are you wearing?

—Don't you have more pressing matters, Dear?— she asked back, refusing to talk about her attire again.

—Right! Right! See you later!— she farewelled and teleported away with both Adora and Catra.

Light Spinner laughed as she looked back at Castaspella with an amused expression.

—That was certainly interesting— she commented. —Would you accompany me to get some aperitifs?— she invited. Both sorceresses made their way to the nearest table, full of bite-sized appetizers that lasted a mere second in their mouths. —So, how are you liking the party, Es?

—I always enjoy the festivities. And here it’s so charming! Princess Entrapta is quite a nice host— Castaspella replied.

—How can you possibly consider Princess Entrapta a good host?— Light Spinner asked, genuinely surprised.

—Why do you think she isn't?

—Everything here is tiny *on purpose*— she began, mildly annoyed. —Including the food and drinks. They can't possibly be enough to satisfy anyone.

—She just likes it like that, you may consider it Dryl’s custom— the sorceress replied. —Besides, the Princess makes sure there is more than enough of everything for us to have as many servings as needed to be "satisfied". I believe that‘s very considerate of her.

—Then what about the literal robotic guards posted all around the place? It's almost like a prison— Light Spinner argued. —Why would she keep such tight security and confine us to this sole area?

—No, no, Bea. You misunderstand. The Crypto Palace is said to be such a labyrinth even the Princess herself can get lost here. This is just preventive.

—Es, we have *magic*— she replied in a condescending tone. —If the Princess can't retrieve someone who got lost, our sorcery certainly can.

—And what if none of us even realizes someone got lost? What then?— she defied her.

—If no one realized…— she began, presumably smirking under the veil.

—Do *not* finish that sentence— Castaspella warned her. She massaged her temples while exhaling a long sigh. —I had almost forgotten how mean you can be.

—You *love* it— she responded smugly.

—*I* do. Others don’t.

—Whyever would I care about others?

—*Basic respect*— she hissed, crossing her arms in front of her chest. —How many times do I have to remind you?

Despite her obvious annoyance, Light Spinner took a step forward and replied —A few more…

Castaspella looked away, feeling her face burning already, and reminded her —Not here, please. You know the rules.

—We can perhaps slip through the security— the woman suggested. —If we get lost I can always get us out.

—Disappearing at the same time is still suspicious— she pointed out. —Come on, Bea. Just keep it safe— she pleaded.

—Fine. As you prefer— she finally accepted, retreating a few steps.

While Light Spinner sampled more of the tiny appetizers in the table in front of her, Princess Perfuma arrived and greeted —Oh, good evening, Castaspella. What a charming dress! Will you wear it the rest of the week?

Despite the kindness of her comment, the sorceress felt too ashamed and her face reddened with embarrassment.

—No, no. I couldn't, it's too eye-catching.

—That's the point— Light Spinner mumbled.

—Finish eating! Then Speak!— she told her off, making her shake with laughter.

—Oh, I'm sorry. Who is she?— Perfuma asked, realizing she had accidentally ignored the woman.

Castaspella called her attention and asserted —Bea, I believe the Princess would like to greet you—. As she noticed Light Spinner using a napkin under her veil, she looked back at the Princess, saying —Not the best timing, please give her a moment.

Shortly after, the woman turned around and briefly bowed at the Princess.

—Good evening, Princess Perfuma. My name is Light Spinner.

—Oh, so that's you!— she reacted, both surprised and excited. —I'm so glad to find you! I've heard so many guests talking about you and I really wanted to meet you myself.

—Really? What kind of things have they said?— she asked, raising a brow, already suspicious of what she may have heard.

—I better not say it. Some people are just so mean— Perfuma replied, looking away with a conflicted expression.

Castaspella giggled and commented —She's meaner, believe me. Just go ahead and tell her, she'll laugh it off.

Perfuma seemed shocked to hear it, but Light Spinner admitted, presumably smirking, —She's right. I couldn't care less about their gossip. However, I may clarify for you whether they are true or not.

Perfuma considered her offer for a moment and finally said —In that case… One of the first things I heard is that… um, your village's eradication was your fault—. She looked away before adding —That you abandoned them.

Castaspella looked away with a grim expression, she knew the story. But Light Spinner seemed amused, her stance remained relaxed.

—How charming…— she let out with a chilling tone. —Well, that's certainly out of context. I tried to warn my people about the disaster yet they ignored me; what happened was hardly my fault. Have you heard of the eruption of Candila?

—The volcano? Yes.

—My village occupied the whole extension of land around the foot of the volcano— she began. —We had one of the most prosperous societies thanks to the richness of the land, and my race has a great affinity with magic, yet only the elders would learn sorcery. I wanted to learn too, despite being too young for them, so I fled to Mystacor when I was ten, and two years later I knew more than enough to return and help the elders with their investigations about the tremors from the previous years— she continued, speaking casually. —I discovered it was the volcano and warned them it was inevitable, it *would* erupt. Our best chance was for everyone to learn sorcery so we could save our village, but no one heard me. I also offered to get help from Mystacor but they refused—. Her tone became bitter as she went on —In the four, almost five, years it took for the disaster to strike, enough people could have learned at least basic protective sorcery. But instead, they tried making the usual ditches to deviate the lava, raised barricades... None of that worked, it was far more terrible than expected— she lamented, looking away for a moment. —Only the elders could escape, taking a person or two with them at most, because their sorcery allowed them to teleport to safety.

—What happened with those survivors?— Perfuma asked, concerned.

—The elders might already be dead or about to die, and I haven't seen any of the survivors ever. I don't know where they went.

—I-I don't see how that could be your fault… Why would people blame you?— Perfuma insisted with a confused expression.

Castaspella looked sideways at Light Spinner; she took a deep breath before replying — Because, after ignoring my warnings and rejecting my plans, I *left* them. I knew they would perish, yet I did nothing. I was full of rage and just watched the disaster happen from the safety of Mystacor. It wasn't my fault that they perish, but it is true that I abandoned them.

Her tone was severe, quite like the first time the sorceress had heard her, but back then she could also see her sorrow. Now, it was perfectly hidden by her veil and she sounded more detached. However, Princess Perfuma looked pensive, and after a moment of reflection seemed even more confused.

—But... if I'm not mistaken, you were perhaps fifteen at the time. You couldn't have done much more, you did all you could— the Princess argued.

Castaspella grabbed her left arm nervously and told her —I have always said the same. But most people, as you've heard, blame her.

—Well, I *could* have warned other kingdoms about the volcano to get them to help...— Light Spinner admitted nonchalantly.

—If you're *so* determined to blame yourself I suppose I can’t change your mind— Castaspella retorted with annoyance.

—You suppose right—. The woman looked back at the Princess and asked —What else have you heard?

—Um, there's also this other thing, about your banishment— Perfuma began. —People just comment bits of the story: that you were seeking forbidden powers, and using younger sorcerers to help— she continued, once again looking conflicted as she spoke. —I really don't know how to put it kindly, it all sounds so horrible. A-and they also talk about Castaspella… and Arden. I-it's all very confusing.

—Don't fret, I'm not fragile— Light Spinner joked. —And yet again, there’s a lot of missing context, in my opinion.

—More like the rumors are cherry-picked parts of what happened— Castaspella uttered, visibly offended.

—Listen well, Princess. If you want to know what actually happened, that's fine. But don’t attempt to discuss with the gossipers, nothing good comes out of it— the woman warned her.

—I… Understand— Perfuma accepted. —I just want to know the truth.

With a heavy sigh, Castaspella said —Alright then. Go ahead.

—Before finishing my studies, I found an old scroll, difficult to decipher, that spoke about some great source of power within Etheria— Light Spinner began. —It was around the time of the eruption, so it seemed like a good idea to focus on something else, and I began working with that scroll. It took me five years to fully read it, but once I could, I began attempting to fix that faulty spell and make it work.

—She was my brother's tutor at the time, and he tried to help her— Castaspella continued. —One of the first versions they made was quickly discovered by Norwyn before they could attempt it, and she was warned for the first time not to try again.

—However, I kept tinkering with it, drawing more perfected versions, and getting more warnings every time I was discovered.

—When I began working as a tutor alongside her I was around twenty or something and, at first, preferred to stay away. However, some years later I *also* tried to help her— the sorceress admitted.

Light Spinner let out a chuckle and continued —She was merely twenty-four but knew enough to discover some of the elements I had been missing, which helped me polish the spell even more. And, by that time, Arden had just graduated, had no idea what we were doing, yet tried to follow up.

—Five years later, she was actually going to attempt the spell for the first time, and Arden was going to help because they wanted to get some of the power it may concede— Castaspella went on. —They felt like it was taking them too long to learn sorcery the traditional way.

—But they got scared at the last minute and went to Micah, who explained why the project was first shut off, and they both reported me to the Head Sorcerer— Light Spinner concluded, poorly disguising her resentment.

—And you were banished before ever doing it?— Perfuma asked.

—Correct. They knew that, after so many years of continuing a project I should have abandoned long ago, I wouldn't drop it any time soon— she recognized.

—And… What is that thing they say about both Arden and Castaspella barely escaping banishment?— the Princess then asked. —If they didn't participate...

—In my case, I tried to defend her— the sorceress quickly replied. —I tried… to convince Norwyn he was going too far and that banishment was unnecessary, but the decision was made— she explained. —On the other hand, Arden themselves admitted they wanted to get power from the spell, so Norwyn *could* have banished them too. However, it was also them who decided to report her, so he let them stay.

—I see…— Perfuma uttered. —I'm so sorry, it all sounds so terrible. People shouldn't speak about things they don't know— she lamented.

—We're pretty much used to it, Princess, worry not— Light Spinner dismissed her.

Perfuma couldn't stay much longer to talk and soon farewelled, but it hadn't been a whole minute before Princess Entrapta came out of nowhere, wanting to greet them.

—Good evening, my guest! How are you enjoying my social event?— she asked them with a bright smile.

—It's all very pleasant, Princess. Thank you for hosting it— Castaspella replied in a very diplomatic manner, holding a small drink.

—Would be much better if the portions weren't mice-sized— Light Spinner grunted.

The sorceress rolled her eyes, resisted the urge to cover her face, and instead said —Please excuse her. She's always this negative, it's nothing personal.

—Oh, I see. Is she your spouse? Everyone's talking about it— the Princess innocently asked, seemingly excited to meet her. However, when she saw Castaspella almost choking on her drink while Light Spinner loudly laughed, she stared at them, puzzled, and asked —Did I say something wrong?

As soon as she could recover, the sorceress replied —No, no. My… Spouse is Arden, they must be somewhere around here.

—Oh, well. Sorry for the confusion. Enjoy the evening!— Entrapta apologized before leaving as fast as she had arrived.

—A charming personality— Light Spinner let out, mockingly.

—Shut up— Castaspella whined. —If she said that, we're certainly doing something wrong, Bea.

—It was an honest mistake, Es, don't panic— she replied, too calm for the sorceress' taste.

—You *know* why I'm saying it— she insisted. —Please don't make me regret it.

—In that case, I suppose I better retire now and see you later. Could I perhaps wait for you at your house?— she asked.

—Actually… no. If Norwyn decided to spontaneously visit because of his suspicions…

—Why exactly would he be allowed to break into the house like that?— she asked, confused.

—Because it's… The place is his— she admitted with a sigh. —He *knew* it was too strange that, after trying to dissolve the arrangement, we suddenly accepted out of the blue.

—So he's… Manipulating you into behaving like an actual couple?

—You could say so…

Light Spinner let out a sigh, wishing she could properly comfort her, hug her. But it was true that they were perhaps being too obvious.

—Let me wait for you there. I'll keep myself hidden with magic— she requested.

—It's risky.

—I *won't* ruin it, Es, I promise.

Chapter 3: Day 3: Dark Edge

Day 3

Dark Edge

It was already past midnight when Castaspella arrived at her house. Everything was in darkness, the light of the moons entered through the window but barely illuminated the insides. Yet that glow was enough to project long shadows on the floor and walls, which suddenly moved, startling the sorcerer. She jumped back and pressed herself against the door, struggling to turn the lights on with a spell.

Loud laughter suddenly resonated through the room and all lights turned on before Castaspella could draw the spell.

—Curse you, woman!— she yelled, realizing it was just Light Spinner pranking her.

—Your face was priceless! I don't regret it!— she kept laughing.

—Get out— she replied, deadpan.

—Can't take a joke anymore? It was just an illusion! Whatever happened the last five years that ruined your sense of humor this much?— she teased.

Castaspella rolled her eyes and, pretending to be thinking about it, she harshly replied, with a mocking tone, —Let me see… Perhaps it was the fact that you called me a “backstabber”. Or, it could have been how you totally disappeared for two years afterward. Or, how the first notice I finally got of you came from *Angella*, instead of yourself. It could also be that you still haven't apologized for being *such* a jerk to me, despite all I did to defend you.

Light spinner stared at her in disbelief. She wasn't expecting such an explosion of rage out of a mere prank. But her expression was unmistakable, her blood was boiling.

—Es, what happened?— she asked, concerned yet afraid of making it worse if she approached.

—You have *no idea* what I've been through these years! Because you *weren't there*! So stop, just *stop*, talking about the past five years as if I had simply been on vacation!

—Es… L-love, I didn't mean to… I’m truly sorry— she stammered, finally moving closer. Castaspella seemed on the verge of tears but made no move to stop her, so she reached out and hugged her. —I never meant to offend or hurt you in any way— she whispered. —And I'm sorry that you felt like you couldn't express all of this before.

—I’m so… So sick… Of all of this… I swear…— Castaspella sobbed. —I'm *always* pretending, *always* looking over my shoulder just in case I'm being supervised… Then you

reappear, I let myself relax… And suddenly I have a target on my back *again*! Tonight I almost messed up!— she continued, hugging Light Spinner tighter the more she spoke. —I *had* to give up. I had to… Accept it. I had finally resigned to this as my life… Then you decide to return and my delusion shattered: I was not living… I was just *existing*.

—Es— she sighed, sorrowfully. —Why didn't you leave?— she asked, caressing her hair and feeling she'd cry too any moment now. —Why would you stay here if it meant you had to sacrifice so much?

—I told you… I couldn't leave with you— the sorceress sobbed. —Mystacor is all I have.

—That's not true. You have your family, your brother would have received you. I'm sure if Micah knew you felt like this, he'd have encouraged you to abandon it all— she sentenced, letting go of her to gently tilt her face up. With a pained look, she admitted —I shouldn't have left you like that either, but you shouldn't have endured all of this because of that. You deserve better, Es.

—It doesn't matter now— she let out. —I'm already doing this and I can't ditch Arden after they trusted me so blindly.

—What are you talking about?

—Out of the two, I was in a better position because, as you said, I could always go with Micah. But, Arden?— she began, shaking her head. —This is the only chance for them to keep their job, have a roof, and food every day… Until each of us is able to make a name for ourselves, we have to keep up this façade or Norwyn will banish us too. Arden had no reason to trust me, especially with how angry I was at them for betraying you… But they did.

—Neither of you betrayed me, Es. I shouldn't have said that— she stated, caressing her cheek. —While I understand why you prefer to keep this up, I still have to insist: don't subject yourself to such suffering. You're living this like a prisoner in a fancy cell.

—It won't be forever. I just have to hold on for enough time— she replied, drying her face.

Light Spinner took off her veil and kissed her forehead.

—You should listen to yourself. You're phrasing it like a criminal waiting for the end of their sentence— she teased her.

—And if it is?— she asked. —You were banished, I wasn't penalized. This might as well be my punishment.

—If you want a *punishment* that bad, I can always fix that.

—Bea!

Light Spinner laughed daintily and held her by the waist.

—Is that a no?

—It's a threat. I'll kick you out if you keep pushing it— she retorted.

—You know I just *love it* when you threaten me— Light Spinner reminded her.

Castaspella groaned and leaned back, knowing she wouldn't let her fall. The sorceress allowed her to take her into the room and soon her earlier rage and frustration were set aside, along with their clothes.

That day, the festivities would take place in the kingdom of Dark Edge, where Scorpia and her mothers ruled over the Scorpioni. Princess Scorpia would be the host for the first time and got help from the other princesses to organize the party. It was difficult for plenty of reasons, the Princess almost panicked when she learned her mothers wanted her to do it on her own, but as soon as she told Perfuma, the Princess called their friends for help.

The most complicated part was representing the customs of Dark Edge in the party: Scorpia had never connected with their traditions, she was "too cheerful" according to the Queens, yet they refused to force them into her, like her grandfather would have done. Instead, they allowed the Princess and her friends to freely represent their customs as they saw fit.

Mermista and Frosta helped her with the food for the party, Glimmer made sure the kingdom's colors properly decorated the place, and between Entrapta and Perfuma they handled the area around Horror Hall. Princess Entrapta used her drones and bots to find a safe path from the limits of Dark Edge to the entrance of the royal residency and, just to be sure, they finally asked Adora and Catra to scout the place and make sure nothing would attack the guests as they arrived.

In past years, reaching the Horror Hall, home of the Queens, was a tricky venture, and few Etherians would attend the festivities there. But this time, everyone was certainly surprised. The beautiful path of bright green vines and dark red roses that now lead to Horror Hall was extremely far from what anyone would have expected when arriving at Dark Edge, and now, both Castaspella and Arden stared in absolute awe, unable to believe their eyes.

They had agreed to "casually" meet Light Spinner there, yet it was someone unexpected who appeared from behind and distracted them from the gorgeous path.

—Good afternoon. I see you've arrived early— Norwyn greeted them, in a casual tone.

—Good afternoon, Head Sorcerer— they both greeted him, disguising the chill they felt.

His sudden appearance was too suspicious, it couldn't be a coincidence, and Light Spinner's arrival just a moment later only worsened their gut feeling.

—If it isn't the Head Sorcerer himself. What a quaint reunion— she commented casually. —Good afternoon.

—Good afternoon, Light Spinner. I was expecting you— he replied, much to their consternation.

—You were? I'm surprised— she let out, perfectly hiding her annoyance.

—I may have noticed you three have reconnected since your return— he began, starting to walk into the path towards Horror Hall. All three of them walked alongside him in silence. —I suppose there's much you may have to discuss, reminiscence, but I have to remind you all: Light Spinner can't be allowed into Mystacor, even for a *friendly* chat.

The three of them stopped in their tracks and Castaspella turned to look at him, seemingly ready to jump. Yet it was Arden who first voiced their indignation, perfectly matching hers.

—What is that supposed to mean!? She hardly poses a threat, has not expressed ill intentions at all, and…

—Rules are rules, Arden— Norwyn interrupted with a severe tone.

—Worry not, Norwyn. I have no interest in setting foot there— the sorceress assured him.

Her expression was flawless, nothing betrayed her thoughts, yet the Head Sorcerer wasn't easily convinced. He began walking again, hands on his back, and the three mages renewed their walk, a few steps behind.

—Then I suppose it wasn't you who was seen last night breaking into our archives, no?— he asked.

—What!? With all due respect, Head Sorcerer, those are serious accusations— Castaspella remarked.

—I happened to notice Light Spinner left early yesterday, and this morning I was informed someone had been caught trying to steal some scrolls from our restricted library, to be precise — he explained. The sorceress exchanged a look with Light Spinner, but she was just as stunned. —It wouldn't be a surprise if you wanted your old studies to continue that dangerous project, yet for the safety of Etheria I have to make sure that never happens— he concluded.

—Excuse me, Head Sorcerer. May we speak alone?— Arden requested. —Casta, Dear, why don't you accompany Light Spinner to Horror Hall in the meantime?

Norwyn had no excuses to refuse and simply watched as the sorceresses walked away together.

—What is it, Arden?— he asked in a respectful manner, despite his annoyance.

—I'd like to ask you, Your Majesty, to stop this hunt— they began, their tone unusually serious. —I can't possibly explain the stress this whole situation is causing us, and I believe banishment was enough of a punishment. Light Spinner doesn't deserve more harassment.

—Perhaps you're still too innocent to understand the seriousness of her return— he began, speaking with a condescending tone. —Don't you remember why you decided to report her intentions? Or how your *wife* defended her with such fervor she almost followed her into exile? It's very difficult for me and the council to believe the woman can't easily influence her, use her or you to gain access to Mystacor, and achieve what she wants.

—I am- Excuse me, Head Sorcerer, perhaps I misunderstand— Arden stammered. —Would that mean we still have no credibility? You still can't trust either Castaspella or me?

Norwyn's expression revealed little, but his tone sent a chill through their spine.

—You can still earn that trust. I'm sure it won't be long before there are more… Substantial proofs of your compromise. Am I correct?

—Norwyn… you can't really mean…— Arden tried to speak but felt breathless. They were in utter disbelief and could only express —Now you're imposing on us the responsibility of having children!? Does it even matter what we want!? Whether either of us has even considered such a thing!?—. Arden was so bewildered they could barely control themselves. —I-I apologize for being rude, but I am *not* subjecting myself to this!

—Be reasonable, Arden. This is for your own good— Norwyn insisted, pretending he hadn't just witnessed their outburst. He kept walking down the path, knowing Arden wouldn't follow, and concluded —You are smart enough to make the right choice.

Inside Horror Hall, dark desert roses and vines resembling those of the Whispering Woods decorated the walls, columns, chairs, and tables. Plenty of guests had already arrived and were commenting on how different the place looked that year, some even asked their thoughts on the party to the Scorpioni they knew.

The Queens of Dark Edge arrived shortly after Arden entered the hall, and everyone looked at them as the regents and their daughter stood proudly in front of the throne. The shorter, white-haired Queen stayed next to Scorpia, who seemed too nervous, while the taller Queen took a few steps forwards and addressed the guests.

—Welcome to the third day of the End of the Year week— she began, silencing the few people who were still talking. —It is with great joy that I present to you this year's host: our daughter, Princess Scorpia, to welcome you all— she stated, looking back at her, encouragingly.

—Go ahead— her mother whispered, gently pushing her forward.

Scorpia advanced shyly and was left to give the welcome-speech. However, she was too nervous and kept clicking her pincers against each other, refusing to look at the crowd in front of her. Nearby, Princess Perfuma called her attention and gave her a thumbs up with a bright smile, and Scorpia finally relaxed enough to take a deep breath and begin.

—Em… Welcome! Everyone. Uh… I hope you all enjoy the party today! I-I know it's not the usual style, I…— she stammered a bit as she began, still feeling unsure yet wanting to say something. She looked down, feeling defeated, and let out a long sigh closing her eyes. She couldn't do it. At least not like that. After a moment, she looked up again, determined this time, and started over. —I don't really fit here— she stated. —I know everyone thinks I'm nothing like my mothers, or have a personality that makes no sense for the Princess of Dark Edge, and perhaps shouldn't be the host of this party— she continued. —But, I love our

culture. I enjoy seeing so many Scorpioni sharing this place with people from all over Etheria, chatting, drinking, and eating together, and I wanted all of you to experience what I have with my friends. We're nothing alike, at first I was even scary to them with my pincers and all—, she laughed, —But we're not that different! It's just a matter of changing our perspective, adapting a bit, giving each other a chance!— she sentenced excitedly. —I called my friends to help me with this party, and thanks to them we have our customs presented in a way that everyone can enjoy. The decorations are appealing but still show our colors that, oftentimes, come across as dark; our food, which usually seems inedible, was cooked and served so that it looks tasty like other dishes yet retains our typical flavors and ingredients— she explained. —And I know this place is called Horror Hall, but that doesn't mean it *has* to be scary. Does anyone think the way the room is arranged somehow erases our culture? Because I think it looks really nice, and it's still my home— she remarked. —So… I just wanted to thank my friends, and wish everyone a happy time.

Everyone in attendance applauded her speech and Scorpia joined the other princesses, relieved to have finished already; then, accompanied by Perfuma, she began her rounds to check how the guests found the party.

From a distance, both Light Spinner and Castaspella observed; it was amusing to see the Scorpioni Princess with her friends, especially after that speech, noting such a contrast between Scorpia and her mothers. But soon, their companionable silence was interrupted by Arden's arrival.

—Ladies— they said, calling their attention. As the sorceresses turned towards them, Arden let out —I can't believe how aggressive Norwyn is about this.

—I suppose he's still on edge after all I did— Light Spinner commented. —Let's just say I've always been difficult to handle or control.

—You think so?— Castaspella mocked her. —I'm not sure how you weren't banished earlier.

—Mean.

—Coming from you, that's almost flattering.

—I guess the council is putting a lot of pressure on him— Arden interrupted, noticeably nervous as they looked for the proper words to explain what Norwyn had told them. —And unfortunately, we're still not trustworthy.

Castaspella's expression darkened, and even Light Spinner seemed surprised.

—I'm suddenly seeing the appeal of calling him a "fool"— she muttered.

The sorceress laughed and, smirking, replied —That's *so* good to hear.

—It's… frankly maddening that these five years somehow meant nothing— Arden admitted, their fist tightly closed. —He… he said something that made my blood boil.

—What was it?— Light Spinner asked, discretely grabbing Castaspella's hand to keep her calm.

—Well, he suggested, or rather ordered, that we…

—Good afternoon, my guests!— a voice suddenly interrupted, calling their attention. Princess Scorpia had just arrived to greet them.

—Princess! Good evening— Castaspella replied, quickly collecting herself and adopting a more diplomatic attitude.

—Princess— Light Spinner said, bowing briefly almost at the same time as Arden behind her.

—Is everything enjoyable? The food and the drinks?— she began asking, excitedly. —Have you found your assigned table?— she added before they could answer.

Castaspella was a bit overwhelmed but, used to handling tactful matters with the royalty of Etheria, she easily managed to reply —We haven't had a chance to try the food yet, and no… we didn't know there were assigned tables.

—Oh right!— Scorpia realized. —Where's Entrapta? She had the tables' organization, I think — she asked Perfuma, barely controlling her nervousness.

—There— the Princess noticed, and waved at Entrapta. —Do you have the table assignments for Mystacor's guests?— Perfuma asked her as soon as she arrived.

—I have it right here!— she replied, taking out a digital device. —Names, please— she requested.

Arden and Light Spinner looked at the sorceress and she let out a sigh before replying — Castaspella, Arden, and Light Spinner.

—Let me see… Here!— Entrapta began. —I was told you're the sister of King Micah, right? —. The sorceress nodded and she continued —We placed you with him, and Queen Angella, and the Head Sorcerer of Mystacor. We also added your friend and your spouse to the table. Sorry I confused them yesterday.

She sounded genuinely sorry and Castaspella quickly replied —Please don't worry, Princess, it was just a mistake.

—Oh, it was them?— Scorpia noticed. —Uh, boy, good thing I didn't say anything, I almost asked who was who— she nervously laughed, once again clicking her pincers. —I should have known, the matching outfits and all— she added, unable to shut up.

—We'll leave you to enjoy the party now— Perfuma interrupted, gently holding Scorpia's arm to calm her down. —Let's go.

Light Spinner chuckled when Castaspella turned around with a dismayed expression, and commented —Really smooth, Es. You haven't lost it.

—Very funny— she muttered, looking around to find her brother. —There's Micah, let's go.

The three of them arrived at a large round table where Queen Angella sat with Micah to her right, and Norwyn to her left. Without hesitation, Light Spinner went to sit next to the King, Castaspella sat next to her, and Arden between her and Norwyn. They all spent a few tense hours eating and drinking together, all conversations entirely casual, but Angella kept shooting questioning looks at her sister-in-law. At the same time, Micah was *trying* to have a normal conversation with Norwyn and Arden, but the Head Sorcerer would throw indirects every five minutes, very obviously aimed at Arden and incomprehensible for the King, making him considerably uncomfortable.

Meanwhile, skillfully attentive to both situations, Light Spinner silently ate, amused by Micah's puzzled expression and Castaspella's struggle to ignore Angella. She'd sometimes try and tell them something, yet she preferred to remain as uninvolved as possible. However, when Arden suddenly stood up and left the table, she was the one to go after them.

About an hour or so later, they were still away, so Castaspella excused herself and left the table too. Outside Horror Hall, the sun had long set, and the sorceress found them both seated on one of the benches made of intertwined vines along the walls of the place, sufficiently illuminated by a nearby torch.

As she approached, she noticed Arden had a large slash on their left arm and asked —What in the world happened!?

The magician kept their sight down, they looked ashamed, but Light Spinner just sighed and invited her to sit down so she could explain.

—I suppose Norwyn pressed them a little too much and that's why Arden left— she began. —*But*, they recklessly wandered outside, away from the marked path, and we should be thankful Princess Adora and Catra were nearby, no?— she continued, indirectly reproaching the magician. —Long story short, something came out of the sand and attacked Arden; I found them here with Catra tending to their wounds.

—I presume you finished healing that— she noticed, closely inspecting the gash. —What were you thinking!?

—I wasn't. I-I felt… disturbed— they let out. —Everything's dark, I didn't even notice where I was until that thing jumped me.

—And what happened?— she insisted. Arden seemed unwilling to speak so she addressed Light Spinner —You said Norwyn pressed them? With what?

—The archive.

—No- I can't believe- What is his problem!?— Castaspella exclaimed.

—He wants a name. Nothing was really stolen but it's clear he won't just let it pass— Light Spinner explained.

—He already asked! I understand he won't easily trust you, and I'm outraged he still won't trust us either, but this is insane!— she let out, sharply. She shook her head and looked at the sorceress with a sad expression. —Bea…

—Yes?— she quickly asked, raising a brow as she anticipated her question, which only made Castaspella instantly contrite.

—Look, Love, I don't… I don't mean to doubt you, but…

—You want to ask if I sneaked into the archive— Light Spinner interrupted. —It's fine, Es, after all, you still blame your bias for my banishment, it's only natural to go against it.

—I just feel so conflicted. It *is* a serious accusation, and while I want to trust you, I can't just dismiss the possibility, because it could have been anyone— she explained. —I personally have free access to the restricted library, yet I always have to declare what I want to look for. And, Bea, your whole project is still there *because* I made sure they wouldn't destroy it. Whatever happens, if you ever recover it, test it out, and everything… fails… Whatever happens, *will* be my fault.

The sorceress placed her hands on Castaspella's shoulders and gently pulled her closer.

—If I ever did that, it would be my fault and mine alone— she sentenced, intensely looking into her eyes. —However… About your question…

—It was me— Arden interrupted, still looking away.

—You don't need to…

—Please, Light Spinner. Allow me— they requested, finally looking back with a forlorn expression.

—Go ahead— she sighed.

—I went into the archive. I didn't exactly break in because I also have access but I didn't declare my motives, just slipped inside late at night— they explained, shifting their position carefully as the wound still hurt. —I felt… I've always felt guilty for ruining her lifetime project but, after her banishment, I had no clue where to find her, so it made no sense to steal the scrolls and papers back then.

—But… Why did you…

—The investigation *is* hers, Casta. After you told me how long she had spent on it, how much she had worked to perfect it… It's her *right* to have it. And now was the perfect chance to return it to her— they insisted.

—Arden, you *know* everything that's at stake. I also wanted her to succeed, make it possible to access that magic despite the dangers, but… That's the problem, it's more dangerous than

anything we know— Castaspella reminded them.

—We have little dimension of its true power and hazard, yet I'm still sure it *could* be done— Light Spinner explained. —Only thanks to her I have some… idea of how it can affect others — she admitted, gesturing at the sorceress, —And, still, I tend to neglect that unless she reminds me.

—It's a huge risk, Arden. And you were seen. None of this is worth it— she insisted.

—When you told me what you did, I have to say it gave me- It made me think I could recover my work and try it somewhere far from all the kingdoms— Light Spinner commented, a bit too casually for Castaspella's comfort. —But if Norwyn noticed… It would be repeating my past mistakes. I have this strong *need* to complete my one important project… and the price for it is barely keeping me controlled. So it is better if you don't make things easier for me. You didn't- What you did back then was only sensitive; if I've ever been bitter about it, it's mostly because of how right you were to do it. It *was* the right thing, I was… wrong. And I *hate* that.

Castaspella's first instinct was to hug her; she had rarely heard the sorceress admit when she was wrong, and her hands were shaking. It was obvious she was struggling, battling her own impulses.

—I should… Tell Norwyn everything. It's not fair for you to have him following your every move because of my recklessness— they considered.

—After he told you we're not trustworthy, it's better if you don't tell him what you were truly going for— Castaspella pointed out, her voice low as she felt guilty for suggesting a lie.

—Don't worry. I can handle that— Arden assured her as they stood up. They thought about telling them what Norwyn had said earlier, arriving at Horror Hall, but their mood was already too tense. —Also… I think we should retire for the night, it's almost midnight.

Castaspella and Arden arrived at their house walking together, knowing full well they were being watched, but as soon as they entered the house, the magician farewelled and teleported away with a spell. Castaspella let out a long sigh and turned on the lights, finally seeing the sorceress seated on a sofa near the window.

—The view from here is quite nice— Light Spinner commented nonchalantly. —Better when the place is in darkness.

—I'm aware. I'd usually spend sleepless nights looking at the sky from there— Castaspella replied, walking closer as she dismissed the lights. —It felt nostalgic.

The sorceress stood up and wrapped her arms around Castaspella's waist, holding her closer as she said —The view from my window wasn't this good.

—It was good enough— she assured her, gently removing her veil.

The sorceresses began kissing; Light Spinner's hand caressed her torso, somewhat anxious to feel her body, but the sorceress quickly grabbed her hands and held them in place.

—What are you doing?

—What do you think?— Castaspella asked back, with a provocative look.

—Want to take control?

—Perhaps

—Good for me…— Light Spinner replied, smirking.

—But, I swear, if you tear this dress...

—I won't. Don't worry.

Her tone was serious but her look said otherwise, so she insisted —Just do me a favor and take it off gently.

—Alright...

The sorceress chuckled as she began pulling her dress, but before she could take it off, there was a knock on the door. They stared at it in silence for a moment until the door slowly opened. Light Spinner gestured at Castaspella to stay silent and quickly hid them both with a spell. The Head Sorcerer had just intruded into the house and seemed to be looking for something. Holding her by the waist, the sorceress kept them both invisible as they watched Norwyn registering the place. He went into the room for a moment, then came out seemingly having found nothing of interest, and barely ten minutes had gone by when he finally decided to leave.

—He must have been wrong— he muttered, right before closing the door, sounding clearly annoyed.

Light Spinner dismissed the spell and turned at Castaspella, her expression between confused and concerned.

—Wait right here— she ordered, letting go of her.

—But…

—Please…

The sorceress quickly put on her veil and left through the window, immediately concealing herself again. She rushed to follow Norwyn until he met with a young sorcerer and lingered nearby, close enough to eavesdrop, cloaked by her spell.

—Your information was *wrong*. I went through the whole place while it's empty, and there is no trace of Light Spinner's presence. I can't believe I just registered their house *like that* while they were away! I was not supposed to cross that line!

—But I *know* what I saw!— the voice of the sorcerer cried out.

—Clearly, you don't!

—I know I saw her at the house. It *had* to be her!— he insisted, furious.

—Unless you can bring me proper proof, I am no longer registering them or their spaces again— Norwyn sentenced. —I have already upset them enough; even our suspicions about the archive intruder were wrong. And the council's decision of pressing them to have children only worsened this whole situation. We *can't* go on like this.

The Head Sorcerer turned around and left, joining his hands behind the back with a proud stance, as if nothing had happened. When Light Spinner looked back at the sorcerer, he was letting out his frustration in a fit of rage, barely holding a shout and stomping the ground like a child. It took the sorceress a moment to recover from the shock, and slowly, she made her way back to the house.

Chapter 4: Day 4: Plumeria

Chapter Notes

> I realized I broke the pattern here; usually, whatever happens after midnight automatically cuts to the next day (hence, chapter), like the beginning of this one BUT, you'll see at the end I included next day's morning…
> I'd change it but *it's too good of an ending for this chapter!* So I'll just assume my place as author and say: to hell with consistency… (just this once)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 4

Plumeria

Castaspella was seated on the bed in her room when the woman returned, looking hysterical.

Light Spinner practically ripped off her veil as she indignantly asked —The council wants you and Arden to have a child!?

—Wait, *what*!?

The sorceress stood up, feeling lightheaded, and stared at the ground, trying to process her words; she couldn't understand where that came from. Light Spinner realized she was horrified and her surprise only increased.

—You didn't know!?

—Wha-what… just— Castaspella stammered a bit, and interrupted herself. After a moment, she looked up at the woman and severely asked —What exactly happened!?

Light Spinner let out a sigh and explained —I followed Norwyn; he met with a sorcerer, someone I couldn't recognize, who had told him I was here. Then Norwyn insisted he wouldn't keep bothering you two, and that pressing you to have children only worsened the situation.

—Well, no. No, no. This… This is the first time I've heard about that— Castaspella uttered, shaking her head repeatedly in complete disbelief.

—Perhaps someone told Arden and they already refused. That could be what Norwyn meant — she suggested. —Es, look at me— she requested, but the sorceress kept looking away with a defeated expression. —Love, please.

—I'm so sorry, Bea. This… We're cornered. Do you understand?— she sighed. —This must be what Arden was trying to say when the Princesses interrupted. We are still not trustworthy, and they know that's all we aim for; they can and *will* ask this of us because we just can't refuse.

—They can't force you, Es. Neither of you wants this; even if you had married out of love, this isn't something you can be pushed to do— Light Spinner insisted, gently holding the sorceress' arms and trying to look into her eyes. —And I absolutely refuse to allow it.

—Bea…

—No, this is a whole new level— she interrupted, increasingly angry. —Your selflessness, your sacrifice, it was hardly worth it because that old ram doesn't have enough of a spine to

endorse his own pupil, let alone defend you and be considered “biased” or controlled by Micah.

—Bea, he has a responsibility to all of Mystacor; and this particular matter can affect our whole world, so…

—Stop it, Es. Stop thinking about the others. We’re talking about you— Light Spinner remarked.

—Are we?—. Her tone was sad but also accusing. —Or is this you refusing to lose me?

—Would it be so wrong if it was?

—Then don’t pretend and just tell me you can’t stand the thought of someone else having me — she defied her.

—Fine! I can’t. I do *not* want to think, at all, about anyone else touching you, or even seeing you naked! That’s… That’s my… *My privilege*! That’s exactly why I stayed away all these years! When I heard you married Arden I almost came back just to rip them apart!— she blurted out, outraged. —But that isn’t why I’m saying this, Esmeralda! I want you to be a bit, just a bit, more selfish now! Think about what you want, what you don’t, and stop complying!

Castaspella sat again on the bed and laid down. She closed her eyes for a moment and took a deep breath.

—I only know… All I want, I can only get it once this is over— she sighed. —As soon as our positions are secure, as soon as we’re safe, then… I can do anything, have anything…

—And what do you want? What have you wanted but given up on these past years?

—Plenty of things, I won’t lie— she replied. —Some things are so insignificant now I no longer want them; the only thing I’ve always wanted, and still want…

—Don’t say it’s me. That’s too cheesy, even for you.

—Then I won’t say it— she chuckled.

—You’re so predictable…

—Actually— Castaspella mumbled, suddenly realizing something. She held herself up with her arms and looked at Light Spinner as she explained —I’m not really predictable. *You* can guess what I think, what I’ll say or do. No one else can. I’ve been told, repeatedly, that I make unforeseen decisions, and often surprise everyone because of my unexpected conclusions.

—I… suppose you’ve always been an open book to me.

—So are you to me. Just like I don’t care if you’re possessive, short-tempered, proud, reckless… I even find your spitefulness amusing; you’re a bit too creative when it comes to

being mean— the sorceress laughed. —But you're so intelligent… and truly appreciate people's capabilities, although you rarely admit as much; you don't try to be politically correct and your harsh sincerity helped me improve a lot— she continued. —Even if you have a lot of questionable traits, I love you regardless. There's not a single soul in this world quite like you, for the good and the bad.

—So I'm a nightmare you just happen to relish— she teased her.

—You're *my* nightmare, Bea; one I'm not letting anyone else suffer, for their own good— she replied, returning her mocking. —The last five years only proved to me you have always been the one thing I wanted, with everything it implies.

Light Spinner went to sit next to her and cupped her face while whispering —Keep saying that and I might just take you away with me.

—I really shouldn't find that so attractive, but I guess I do.

—I'm glad— the sorceress chuckled, and planted a kiss on her lips. —But now we better catch some sleep before sunrise, don't you think?

—Sleep… Sure— Castaspella scoffed.

The party in Plumeria began that afternoon, earlier than in the other kingdoms, as they preferred to enjoy as much sunlight as possible, before lighting up the bonfires at night to keep the cold at bay. As the guests arrived, they found multiple piles of wood prepared all around, with tree trunks and thick vines surrounding them for people to seat, and everyone was given floral crowns or wreaths to wear that day. Most of the Plumerian children kept walking and playing about the place while their parents and the guests were seated around the unlit pyres, chatting amicably.

Castaspella was seated alone in front of the only bonfire that had no one else around, fighting sleep while she sipped some fruit juice she had been offered earlier. Soon, Queen Angella noticed her and approached, only to realize she was falling asleep sitting, the floral crown on her head about to fall. She let out a sigh and carefully placed a hand on the sorceress' shoulder to try and wake her up.

—Casta?— she called. —Stars, is she really sleeping?— she wondered. She looked back at the guests mingling and it took her a moment to locate either her husband or Light Spinner among them. However, as soon as she found the sorceress she waved at her to approach and asked in a low tone —What exactly did you two do last night? She's completely knocked out!

The woman barely held a chuckle before replying —It's not what you think, your Majesty. Trust me.

—Then what was it?

—She was too stressed last night; we learnt some... disturbing things and she was unable to fall asleep for hours— Light Spinner explained, her expression less playful and more concerned.

—What? About what?

—It seems like the council of Mystacor is trying to pressure her and Arden to have children.

—What!? Since when!?— the Queen exclaimed.

—It seems to have been a recent decision; I overheard Norwyn mention it, that's how we know. She hadn't heard about it before— the sorceress explained, her expression increasingly serious.

—It's insane! The council has already ordered them around for years without ever giving them a break, and now they dare impose this on them!? I can't believe Norwyn allows this to happen!— Angella let out, indignant.

—In any case, there's little we can do for now— Light Spinner sighed. —I'll wake her up, Princess Perfuma is about to give her welcome-speech.

—There's a bit more than just her speech, so make sure she stays awake, please— the Queen requested, before leaving them to rejoin Micah.

The sorceress took the cup from Castaspella's hand before it fell off and with her free hand cupped her face, gently brushing her cheek while tilting up her head. The sun in her eyes forced her awake and once she began opening her eyes, Light Spinner blocked the sun.

—Your skills to sleep sitting in such an up-straight position are unparalleled— she mocked her.

—My... what?— Castaspella mumbled.

—Es, Love, you fell asleep— the sorceress began. —We're in Plumeria, the Princess is about to speak.

—This isn't good— she groaned. —And my head is killing me.

Light Spinner let go of her face and quickly used a spell on the cup of juice she had taken from Castaspella before giving it back to her. The woman drank it without making questions, and made an effort to stand up so she could join the rest of the guests for Perfuma's speech. They bickered for a moment about why the sorceress had rejected the floral crown offered to her, but they quickly fell silent as Princess Perfuma called everyone’s attention.

—Good Afternoon, everyone! And welcome to the fourth day of the End of the Year week!— the Princess began, speaking in such a loud voice she could be heard by everyone. —It’s an honor for me to have you all as my guests here today, and more importantly, I’m excited to share this day with you— she continued. —However, I’m cutting my speech short, because I’m really happy to lend this moment to Princess Adora: she has an important announcement to share with us!

As Perfuma took some steps back from the center of attention and Adora stepped forward, Castaspella excitedly commented —Oh, it's happening!

—What?

—Just listen— she replied, shushing the sorceress while keeping her sight on the Princess about to speak.

—Good afternoon, everyone, and thank you for your attention— Adora began, addressing the guests with a smile. —Princess Perfuma was kind enough to give me this space so I can share some thoughts I've been wanting to tell everyone in Etheria— she explained. —As you all know, I came to this universe to learn about the magic of your planet, and my journey around Etheria allowed me to connect with your world in a way I wouldn't have imagined. I'm not talking about the powers I developed, I even feel that's just the ultimate consequence; I was able to meet with every part of Etheria, every kingdom, the people… And I can say I've found a family with all the Princesses and my friends here— she continued, looking around and gesturing at her friends. —And three years ago, I was given the choice to either stay or return home. But I felt a bit… Lost. I suppose— she sighed, conflicted. She took a deep breath and straightened her back before restarting —Realizing there was a whole part of me that represented this world entirely trusting me… it left me thinking: why had Etheria chosen me? I couldn't see myself deserving it when I was just… an experiment, so to say. I wanted to be able to answer that question, if I couldn't then I would return to Eternia, and accept my mother was right—. Her expression was still sad but a soft smile appeared before she finally said —I am glad to say I now know why your world chose me, and not only will I stay in Etheria, but also, on the last day of the End of the Year week, I will marry the love of my life, Catra.

She turned around to look at her and extended a hand, encouraging her fiancé to move closer. As Catra joined her, all the guests applauded them, some cheered, and one by one, everyone in attendance took a moment to congratulate them.

—That was an interesting speech— Light Spinner commented. —She really loves this world, doesn't she?

—It was so heartfelt— Castaspella replied, keeping her sight on Adora and Catra as they were congratulated. —And they seem so happy.

—Well, I guess we should congratulate them too, right?

The sorceresses patiently waited for the guests around them to leave before approaching the couple, and Adora waved at them with a happy smile.

—That was such a beautiful speech— Castaspella said, first thing, as soon as they were close enough. She held her empty cup with both hands as she added —And I'm thrilled about your wedding being in Mystacor, I know you'll love the ceremony.

—Oh, thank you— the Princess replied. —We hope it's not an inconvenience, but with the Head Sorcerer in charge of weddings, it really seemed like the best idea.

—Don’t worry, it’s no inconvenience, Dear. We’ll be delighted to host it— Castaspella assured her.

—We wanted to congratulate you both on your engagement— Light Spinner chimed in, subtly reproaching the sorceress.

—Right, of course. Congratulations to you both!

—Thank you— Catra replied, stoic.

—Yes, thank you both— the Princess quickly added, more cheerful.

Castaspella noticed some coldness in the reply, which Adora seemed to be making an effort to cover. Her expression fell as concern overtook her.

—Is there anything wrong, Catra?— she asked, worried.

—Absolutely not, please, don’t mind me.

—Love, please— Adora insisted, yet she refused to speak about it. The Princess sighed and finally explained in her stead —Perfuma told us about… Candila. What Light Spinner told her. And it especially affected Catra; as you may know, she didn’t have the chance to help her people in any way. So she feels… taken aback by someone who cared so little.

Adora’s explanation was as respectful as possible, yet Castaspella felt the need to say something. However, Light Spinner subtly stopped her and preferred to answer herself.

—It is true, I ultimately didn’t care for them— she admitted. —Mostly because I found no reasons after they had repeatedly rejected my help.

—You should have tried to help regardless— Catra automatically replied, with a severe tone.

—I didn’t care enough to do so, and I still don’t care that much about others; as I said, I have no reasons to do it— the sorceress replied, absolutely unapologetic.

—That’s not what Arden told us— Adora quickly interrupted, noticing Catra’s annoyance. —They told us you care, and a lot, about Castaspella— she recalled, gesturing at the sorceress.

—Doesn’t mean it’s a selfless feeling, Princess— Light Spinner countered. —I only care about her because she’s the only person who has never judged me; I’d say she believes more than me that I can be better.

—And I agree with her— Adora sentenced. —Despite the wrongs you’ve done, if you care for at least one person, then you have the potential to care for many more— she insisted, supporting Castaspella.

—I am sorry, but I can’t agree with either of you— Catra let out, crossing her arms in front of her chest. She then addressed Light Spinner, and admitted —Someone like you is frankly despicable for me.

—Catra!— Adora reproached her, slightly upset at how disrespectful that had sounded.

However, the sorceress was unbothered and even agreed with her as she said —“Despicable" might as well be my second name.

—Bea! That's enough!— Castaspella reprimanded her, fully annoyed.

—Please try to- to remain respectful— Adora requested. —You don't need to agree but don't insult or mock each other either.

Catra took a deep breath and rephrased —I didn’t mean to be disrespectful, but I can’t feel any sympathy for someone who abandoned her people like that. However, rest assured I won't waste my energy on hating you either, it won't solve anything. But I won’t apologize for saying what I think.

—That's completely respectable— Light Spinner said.

—Good.

—If anything, I apologize.

—No need— Catra replied, and walked away.

Princess Adora gave them a pained, apologetic, look before following her fiancé.

—That was... Intense— Castaspella uttered.

—You're too naïve.

—Why!?

Light Spinner chuckled cynically at her indignation.

—She had *every* reason to literally jump at my throat and didn't— she explained. —I was just *lucky* she's such a stoic person.

—Why- Why would you say that, Bea?— the sorceress asked, confused.

—Because I am not— she simply admitted. —I can hardly understand how she could control her anger like that. You know perfectly well I can’t.

—It's quite admirable of her, I guess.

—It is…— she sighed.

As the party went on, the sorceresses sat with Arden, Angella, Micah, Princess Mermista, and Sea Hawk, and shared various frutal dishes while listening to the sailor narrate his adventures, all suspiciously ending with him setting one or more ships on fire; before an hour had passed, Castaspella had to stop her very irritable woman from lashing out at the poor

man and couldn't divert her attention for a moment or the sorceress would explode. However, at some point before the bonfires were turned on, Light Spinner managed to get some alcoholic beverage and it became easier for her to entirely ignore Sea Hawk, allowing Castaspella to relax a bit. Unfortunately for her, that was when Angella took the chance to speak with her after she ignored her the previous night.

—Can we talk?— the Queen asked, sitting next to the sorceress. —I believe we have a few matters to discuss.

—Angella, I don't know if it's a good time…

—Please listen— she interrupted. —Last night Micah was very confused and concerned because Norwyn and Arden seemed to have some parallel conversation he couldn't understand, and now I have to suppose it's related to the… inappropriate request from the council. But Light Spinner said you only knew about it later than that so I still want to know what was upsetting you last night— Angella explained.

Castaspella let out a long sigh before replying —Actually, that's not what they were discussing yesterday. And, about the council… Just, please don't tell my brother. Things would get out of control.

—On that I agree— Angella admitted. —I won't say anything for now, but eventually he'll have to know.

—I suppose— the sorceress sighed again. —The problem last night was that Norwyn straight-up accused Light Spinner of breaking into the archive and then Arden was told we're still not trustworthy, which is why they now dare ask… *this* of us— she explained. —Turns out Arden wanted to recover her project, they still feel guilty for her banishment. And with Norwyn on our back, if that were known, if any of us makes a single mistake… we're done for.

Angella seemed confused; she already knew everything was quite delicate, but it felt like she was now missing some context, and asked —What does it mean that you're not "trustworthy"? I don't understand what's happening with the Head Sorcerer.

—Norwyn has always had his suspicions, you know that already. And they have known Arden almost their whole life, it wouldn't be improbable that he at least suspects I'm not exactly Arden's type. And while he might have overlooked that all these years… well, with Light Spinner back, he's now keeping a close watch on us— Castaspella let out. —I'm anxious all the time, fearing anything can ruin us both in a second.

—Casta…— Angella began, wanting to say something comforting, but interrupted herself when something behind the sorceress distracted her. —Oh, that's not good.

Castaspella turned around, a moment before a very drunk Light Spinner reached out to pull her up. The sorceress was unbelievably strong and, for a moment, she couldn't avoid being dragged from her seat and away from the bonfire.

—Bea, stop! What are you doing!?

—What does it look like? I'm taking you for a dance!— the woman replied, trudging the words.

—No, no. You can't! We can't!— Castaspella insisted, trying to break free from Light Spinner's grip. —You know there are too many people here, and we've already been too suspicious earlier— she reminded her.

—Who cares!?

—I care!

Castaspella didn't bother keeping her voice down anymore. She yanked her hands free and kept yelling at her she was drunk and had to leave. Nearby guests looked back at them and, as soon as Arden realized, they went for the sorceress and made a show of excusing themselves for the night. Once they teleported to the house, the magician was about to teleport back and see if they could discretely help Light Spinner return, yet it was unnecessary, as the sorceress had already teleported into the house.

—Where do you think you're taking her, rascal!?— the woman threatened, throwing herself at Arden.

—Stop!— Castaspella exclaimed, as she caught the sorceress before she could reach them. —What on Etheria did you drink!?

—Part of me wants to laugh, but part of me is terrified— Arden uttered, clearly in shock, holding their wounded arm that still hurt a bit. —Am I safe?

—Yes you are, don't worry, but if you prefer you can go and I'll handle her.

—You're not going anywhere, pretty kid!— she said in a derogatory way, her speech wobbly. —You married *my* woman, I'll make you pay!

—Shut up! You're drunk!

Castaspella's annoyance had already reached its limit, yet the sorceress had a way of worsening it regardless.

—I- I'm out. I have a date later, and I'd like to stay alive for it— Arden sentenced, hiding their nervousness. —You have… quite a fierce lover, Casta. I'm impressed.

—Better leave before I let her jump on you— the sorceress threatened, barely maintaining her hold on Light Spinner. The magician teleported away in an instant, and Castaspella released her, saying —Since *when* does drinking hit you this much?

She felt exhausted and couldn't stand any longer, so she pulled out a chair and took a seat while Light Spinner recovered her balance. Watching the woman struggling to maintain herself up, all too dizzy to look up, was a new experience. The sorceress had always been so collected, yet she knew something like this could happen if she got too drunk; it wasn't her current state what surprised her, but rather the fact that she couldn't hold her drinking this time.

—What do those Plumerians put in their distillates?— Light Spinner mumbled. —Es… I ruined it, didn't I?

—Almost.

Castaspella leaned against the table and took a deep breath; it had been nerve-wracking for her, she realized the woman wasn't in full control of her actions but still felt angry at her for being so careless. And yet, she couldn't bring herself to give up on her. She extended a hand at her and pulled her closer; the sorceress hugged her, letting out a long sigh, while Light Spinner mumbled mostly incomprehensible apologies. Shortly after, she took her to the room, helped her out of her clothes, and let her fall asleep while caressing her hair; she felt conflicted, part of her regretted all of this, yet she couldn't ignore her feelings, she loved her and that had never been under her control.

The sorceress woke up alone when the sun reached her eyes. While she brushed off the drowsiness, Light Spinner entered the room carrying a tray with two mugs of tea and a plate of the cake Castaspella had cooked; the moment she saw the woman, all trace of sleepiness vanished.

—Are you… have you been walking around the house *naked*!?

—The place is empty save for us, I don't see the issue— she shamelessly replied as she reached the bed, and sat next to her.

—Bea, there are no curtains. *At all*.

—And?

The fact that Light Spinner kept answering so nonchalantly and casually sipped her tea, made Castaspella indignantly insist —If someone saw you I have *nothing* to say as an excuse! Woman, you have to be more careful! Have I not made that clear already!?

—*Okay, mom*— she mocked her, rolling her eyes with a smirk.

—You're double my age!

—I'm *not* seventy!

Now it was Castaspella's turn to tease her back, so she simply replied —Check your math, that would be sixty-eight.

—Same difference…— she commented, annoyed.

—Well, fifty, seventy; *same difference*.

With her teasing, she got on Light Spinner's nerves in the same way she'd always get into Castaspella's, so the sorceress retorted —I'm forty-nine! We'll see if you think it's the same in fifteen years.

Castaspella gave her an amused look and picked up her mug. She kept staring at her with a rather intense look as she slowly sipped the tea, and Light Spinner kept silent out of sheer curiosity.

—Oh, so you plan to stay that long this time?

The sorceress smirked and let her free hand wander her exposed skin, saying —You’re not getting rid of me any time soon, Love.

Chapter End Notes

A few things to note:
As Adora and Catra are literally trauma-free, they have grown in healthy environments, etc, you will notice Adora is more diplomatic and Catra is quite stoic (I know, I used that exact word, I have no better adjective). But, regardless, Adora maintains her good heart and endless hope in people, while Catra also maintains several traits of her relationship with SW.
This Light Spinner is quite different from the SW we know and had no influence whatsoever in Catra's life or development, yet they still have some things in common: they are both unapologetically honest, yet Catra recognizes and regrets her wrongs, while LS recognizes but rarely regrets her wrongs. They are also both very impulsive, a bit like in the series, but Catra is in full control and -as you read- doesn't start unnecessary fights, while LS barely controls her anger and almost entirely depends on Casta stopping her.
So, Catra's behavior is what I think it would be if she hadn't grown traumatized, while LS's is literally... me. Well, that was my note. hope u enjoyed it or sorry if you didn't.

Chapter 5: Day 5: Salineas

Chapter Notes

> I'll say it only once: They have sorcery --> they can have/make a fridge.
> Nerd explanation: the first fridges were literally just wood cabinets with cooling elements like… chunks of ice. So yes! That would be a cupboard with a spell, I don't care if it makes sense or not 😂

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 5

Salineas

It was almost noon when Arden arrived at their house in Mystacor, noticeably annoyed; they leaned against the door letting out a long sigh.

—I have been sorely fooled once again!— they dramatically exclaimed, knowing Castaspella had to be in the kitchen as they could hear the sound of dishes. —What wouldn't I give for something sweet and decadent to ease my pain…

They heard the sorceress' footsteps before she peered out from the dining room asking —Again? There has to be something in the fridge. What happened now?

The magician followed Castaspella back into the kitchen while they ranted —It was *just* like the last time. I seem to attract a very specific kind of people; they are *always* the same! At first, they seem perfect, they understand me, it's a dream come true; and before I realize it, they have been doing the exact same thing that made me break up with the previous one! I- Wait, sorry, I'm making little sense here.

Arden stopped themselves, took a deep breath, and opened the fridge. There was a dish with one last slice of cake and they took it, smirking; just what they wanted.

—You could just try telling me what happened this time— the sorceress suggested, barely sparing them a look as they sat on the countertop, legs crossed, and began eating.

—Hmm, let me think— they let out, already chewing a bite of cake. —Remember the one I told you about before? How they approached with a drink, invited me to dance, seemed to have the same likes as me…— Arden began. Castaspella nodded, her sight still on the dishes she was washing, but attentive to their words. —This guy did something really similar! He guessed what drink I wanted, and what song I liked more, and even took me to that place in Seaworthy I told you about… He was so similar to basically everyone I've dated the past year! But *again*, he also began hiding things from me, and being a hypocrite, and I realized I just *can't* trust him, like I couldn't trust any of my lovers before!— they explained. Arden angrily ate more cake, and as soon as they had swallowed, added —What am I doing wrong?

The sorceress finished washing that moment and dried her hands as she approached, a bit concerned.

—Why would it be your fault? It's not like you have pushed them all to deceive you.

—But it's… Perhaps I just don't see what's right in front of me, or I just…— Arden tried to speak but felt at a loss of words. They didn't know how to express what they were feeling and, out of instinct, simply changed subjects. —This cake was really good, Casta. You're

treating her nicely— they commented with a smirk. —Speaking of which, where is Light Spinner?

The sorceress realized what they were doing but preferred to humor them.

—She left not so long ago, I'm not sure to where. We'll meet in Salineas later— Castaspella sighed.

—Are you two alright?

—Yes… I mean, better than last night. She won't try to attack you, don't worry— she laughed.

—I have to admit I thought you'd fall apart after last night but… It's nice to know you're much stronger than that— they admitted, with a soft expression. The sorceress noticed their sad smile and, for a moment, didn't know what to do. So she just waited until Arden spoke again —I think… that's what I want.

—What?

—A love just as unconditional as yours— they quickly replied. Raising their sight at her with a determined look, they continued —You both have this… I don't know how to say it, but I mean, you two aren't always fine, I'd even say you bicker more than anything, and yet it seems to be part of your love language. Yes, Light Spinner is a wicked person usually, and I say it with the utmost respect, but I believe you wouldn't like her that much if she wasn't—. Arden realized that had sounded weird said aloud, but could only chuckle and add —Correct me if I'm wrong, but I think we can all agree it's part of her essence.

Castaspella let out a chuckle and covered her blushing face. The magician wasn't wrong at all, she herself had dwelled on that fact several times.

—Fine, yes, you're quite right. I appreciate a lot of things from her that are heavily tied to her being unapologetically mean, and yet it could really be a good thing for all of us if she were, at least, a little more respectful— the sorceress replied.

—Definitely— they agreed. —From what I've heard, she seems to want everyone to be her enemy or something; she keeps calling Norwyn a fool every time, she's been considerably blunt when speaking to different Princesses, and I even heard Prince Catra complaining about her nonchalance. To get *her* that worked up, Light Spinner must have been especially annoying.

—Oh, she already uses the title?— Castaspella noticed, ignoring the rest for a moment.

—They are marrying in less than three days! I think we can already address her by the new title— Arden replied, a bit cocky.

—Better avoid doing that in public at least until the ceremony— she suggested. —And, back to the subject… I'd say, in fact, Light Spinner was quite insensitive; she kept saying she cares little for other people, including her own race and…

—Oh, I get it— Arden interrupted. —It is well known how much of a delicate subject everything related to Halfmoon is for her— they pointed out. —In that case, I have to admire Catra's self-control, but no wonder she was so angry.

—Ah, wait, you just reminded me: have you gotten our instructions for the last End of the Year party? If I'm cooking again, I'll need to buy plenty of supplies between today and tomorrow— Castaspella reminded them.

—Sure! I think I left our letter somewhere in the… It should be on the shelf— they finally said, unsure. —And I'm on entertainment duty, again!

—Of course you are— she laughed, rolling her eyes, before going for the letter. A moment later, Arden was already hearing her complaints, which they could hardly take seriously. —Are they insane!? This is too much!

—Remember there's a wedding, Casta!

—And why didn't they send this *earlier*!? I don't have enough hands or spells to do all of this on time!

Arden left the kitchen and joined her in the main hall, saying —In fact, you have. I'm more than glad to help, and I doubt our esteemed Light Spinner would refuse *you*; if we all use a little sorcery, we won't have to rush, either.

Castaspella looked at them for a moment with a deadpan expression before replying —I never know whether that "esteemed" is supposed to be honest or just sarcasm, but I'll have to disagree; I seriously doubt she'll help.

—You'll never know if you don't ask.

—And perhaps I should never know— she shook her head. —I better go buy some things before the party; these will be two long days.

That evening, Castaspella arrived alone and late at the Salineas Castle. She had missed the Princess' welcome-speech and, currently, Sea Hawk's shanties had everyone's attention. The sorceress took a moment to admire the beautiful decorations, in tones of gold and purple contrasting with the blue and cyan of the throne room, until someone called her attention from behind.

—Good evening, Castaspella.

—Good evening, Norwyn— the sorceress replied with a polite smile and a brief bow. —I've just arrived but, is there anything I can help you with?

—On the contrary, I presume if you arrived so late it's related to the preparations for Mystacor's party in two days— he clarified, in an unexpectedly kind manner. —Have you encountered any problems? We're aware it's much more than usual, will you manage?

The sorceress quickly shook her head and assured him —Absolutely not, you don't need to worry, Head Sorcerer.

—Fantastic. That's good to know— he let out before briefly saluting and walking away.

Castaspella felt confused and lingered a moment; why was he acting so cordial all of a sudden? It should be what Light Spinner had heard the previous night: he wouldn't bother them anymore without proper proof.

—Hey! Casta!— a voice called, drawing her attention to a huge door leading outside the throne room and into a large corridor. —Come with us! The food is in the other hall!

The sorceress couldn't help laughing a bit as she noticed a very energetic Arden calling out to her while Light Spinner stood next to them, poised and collected as usual, giving her a look that reminded her patience is *very* limited.

—Please, calm down, I'm coming— she laughed as she approached them. —I hadn't noticed there was another hall.

—This one is mostly for mingling, listening to Sea Hawk's…

—…Wails?— the sorceress interrupted, much to Castaspella's nuisance.

—…Shanties— Arden completed. —The other hall has all the food, drinks, tables, and such.

—I see. Let's go, then— she accepted.

They walked through the corridor, noticing there were various spare rooms being used to store guests' belongings, or occupied by parents whose little kids had fallen asleep; meanwhile, the sorceress told them how amicable Norwyn had been just earlier. By the time they arrived at the other hall, they had changed subjects; now Light Spinner also knew about Arden's latest suffering, even if she hardly comprehended a single thing.

The three of them grabbed a bowl of some savory "sea stew", as the butlers had called it, and took a seat at the table nearest to the door, one of the only left. And yet, they weren't even finished when Arden suddenly stood up, blabbered an excuse, and promptly left the hall.

—What's gotten into them?— Light Spinner asked.

Castaspella looked around for a moment before recognizing someone, and replied —That must be him.

—The hypocrite Arden was rambling about?

—Yes, I saw them together during some of the previous parties, and… Wait, what!?

The sorceress interrupted herself and Light Spinner could have sworn she even got paler. She stared at him until he left the hall but still didn't say anything else.

—What happened?

—I think… I swear I just saw his eyes change. A lot.

—Could it be something of his species?— the sorceress suggested, trying to find a logical explanation and calm her down.

—Not at all. No Sea Elf does that.

—Is it *really* something concerning?

—I… I'm not sure. I hope it isn't— she replied, finally looking back at her empty bowl. —I should get more food, perhaps I just imagined it.

Light Spinner followed her to get a serving of some spicy dishes and considered what to answer, before finally saying —I think you saw right, but I'm sure it's nothing concerning, or rather, it's nothing Arden can't handle.

The sorceresses talked a few more hours, Castaspella explained to her she would have to cook for the festivities in Mystacor, beginning that night and, eventually, they returned to the throne hall, where their conversations could remain private, covered by the loud music and shanties of Sea Hawk who was, surprisingly, still singing.

—… But can you really blame me for feeling a bit unsafe? I still think it was a very difficult situation and, perhaps, we were just lucky— Castaspella told the sorceress, making a conscious effort not to get any closer.

—Then I'll suppose this is entirely unbearable for you— Light Spinner commented with a casual tone that poorly hid an obvious tease. —Worry not, Es, I won't provoke you this time.

—Which I… appreciate, really…— the sorceress stammered. She had been noticing a burning sensation on her stomach, but now it was increasing to unbearable levels, and Castaspella could barely keep standing. —I… think I'm feeling… unwell.

The sorceress almost fell to the ground and Light Spinner barely managed to catch her before she hit the ground. Almost immediately, Arden arrived running and helped the sorceress hold Castaspella up. They both remembered the spare rooms in the corridor between both halls and took her that way.

—You know I'm the one who has to do this— Arden reminded her, whispering.

Yet Light Spinner whispered back —I just happened to be next to her, it's normal to try to help.

Some concerned guests, who had noticed when the sorceress doubled down, began clogging the corridor behind them as they arrived at a room.

—Just remember you can't get in with us— Arden murmured again. —You can teleport inside, but don't make it obvious.

—No problem— she muttered. Right after, in her normal voice, she made a show of saying —I'll get the door—. She opened, waited for them to walk inside, and closed it quickly. Immediately, she turned around to address, with a severe tone, all the people who had gathered —Nothing to see here. Return to your business and leave them alone.

—But we want to know if she's fine— said an attendee.

The sorceress contained herself to reply, as calmly as possible, —You may ask Arden about it once they are out. Just don't clog the door, have some respect—. Light Spinner stalked off, going right through the group and, as soon as she had enough space, used a spell to teleport away. A moment later, she appeared inside the room, complaining —They are all such gossips. I can't believe I had to insist so they wouldn't press their ears to the door.

—I'm aware— Arden sighed. —That's why we had to bring her here.

The sorceress looked at Castaspella, curled up in the middle of the bed, hugging her legs close to her chest with a sorrowful expression.

—What happened to her?

—It's not the first time, don't worry— Arden assured her. —Micah has told me about it. She must have eaten something that didn't sit well— they continued. Light Spinner went to sit next to the sorceress, who turned around and hugged her waist, still clearly in pain. —She just needs to rest and drink this— the magician finally said, shaking a small vial. —In a while she'll be fine— they asserted, handing it to her.

—Thank you—. While Light Spinner helped her drink it, she noticed Arden locking the door of the room, and curiously asked —What are you doing?

—It's too risky to open the door with so many people wanting to spy inside— they replied. —I'll teleport outside and make sure no one comes to bother. However, do be careful— they added. —Princess Glimmer may teleport inside to check on her aunt.

—I'll keep it in mind. Thank you.

Arden looked back at them for a moment; the sorceress was holding Castaspella against her body and caressed her hair, wanting to calm her. They finally teleported away and appeared outside the room in front of a moderate group of people who startled them.

The magician cleared their throat and sentenced —Well, well. Please don't fret. She will be fine, just needs some rest.

Inside the room, the sorceresses remained on the bed and could hear Arden outside, occasionally having to stop those who approached the door, intending to “check on her”. Little by little, Castaspella felt the pain ease and, eventually, she could breathe easier.

—Thank you, Bea— she muttered.

—Of course, Love. Just rest.

An hour went by and the sorceress fell asleep, Light Spinner felt sleepy too, yet a sudden pink flash caught her attention, and all her drowsiness vanished when Glimmer appeared in its place.

—Wha- What's going on here!?

Princess Glimmer stared at them in absolute confusion. While she had been commenting with the other princesses how her aunt was practically always around Light Spinner, she still wasn't expecting this scene.

—Please, Princess, keep your voice down— the sorceress requested. —We wouldn't want anyone hearing us, would we?

Her tone was mischievous enough to let Glimmer know this was exactly what it looked like.

—I… Can I ask since *when* has this been happening exactly?

The sorceress chuckled at her consternation, then casually replied —Since your *wonderful* party, of course.

—*What*!?— she exclaimed, barely managing to keep her voice low enough. —But… Wait, *you* were who mom meant?

—So you are aware of that agreement?

—With Arden? Yes, of course— the Princess replied, crossing her arms in front of her chest, as if offended by the question. —But I was sure mom meant someone with whom she had already…— Glimmer began saying, but interrupted herself. Light Spinner's look said enough. —Oh, *you* were her partner before they… Oh, stars! *Oh, stars*!

—Princess, please— the sorceress reminded her. —And yes, in fact, for quite a few years we were together but no one knew. Except your mother, by mere accident, of course.

—I should have known— the Princess laughed. —But it's so… Wow! Just how did it happen? When? And how did *dad* not know!?

—Your father had long left Mystacor to live in Bright Moon by then, Glimmer— Light Spinner replied. —Even before your aunt graduated.

—Oh, right! I think dad mentioned he moved in when I was born, so… A few years before that— she reflected. The sorceress nodded and the Princess asked —Could I… ask how your relationship began? If it wasn't through dad, how did it happen?

Light Spinner raised a brow, considering. She seemed genuinely interested, and perhaps it wasn't so wrong to explain, much better than letting her imagination run wild.

—Of course. But do your aunt a favor and *don't* spread it— she finally agreed. Glimmer nodded excitedly and took a sit on the edge of the bed. —When Casta had just graduated she

must have been around your age, and she was so weary of me she would usually avoid being in the same room if there wasn't someone else. I think she didn't even speak to me, mostly because she wouldn't dare— Light Spinner began, greatly surprising Glimmer. —However, with time, most of our pupils were the same, and it was better for us to properly communicate. So one afternoon she came to see me for some serious tutoring-related business, but I was too busy with my project to pay her any attention— she continued, but interrupted herself with a chuckle as she reminisced. —She was *so* annoyed because I kept focusing on my scrolls! Yet she took a look at what I was doing and effortlessly noticed a few relevant details, like how the spell endangered the caster's life. However, when I asked her about it—, she laughed again, —She got extremely nervous, unable to answer! I supposed I had intimidated her.

—It's so hard to believe she ever feared you in the slightest— Glimmer commented, her sight on Castaspella, soundly asleep on the sorceress' lap.

—Right!?— she smiled. —When she tried to leave, sputtering a myriad of apologies, I decided to invite her to stay and have some tea so we could discuss a bit more. I have to admit it was mostly out of curiosity for her observations— Light Spinner continued. —Her expression changed completely, any sign of fear was gone; she stayed and, for a few hours, we talked about her area of focus during her studies and her tutor. She had worked with defense spells and was one of Norwyn's pupils, which explained her initial reservations regarding me, and made it even more surprising that she had dared to be anywhere near me— the sorceress commented. —But it also became clear to me why she noted all the safety issues of the spell so easily.

—She always thinks about safety first.

—She does. For years I just relied on her taking care of safety, so you can imagine my exile was pretty hazardous— she replied, making Glimmer laugh. —We talked for hours that day, until it got dark, but I was too interested in her *opinion* of my project, on what she could potentially improve, and couldn't let her leave, so I invited her to stay for dinner too— she went on with a nostalgic expression. Then, the sorceress considered something for a moment before continuing —Well, you are no child, I can tell you plainly what happened. She stayed for dinner but refused the wine I offered, which led to me mocking her about her age; I'd tell her "aren't you twenty-four? You should be able to handle a drink"—. They both laughed for a moment before the sorceress concluded —Then… I can't properly remember how, but let's just say I woke up with her between my arms, naked.

The Princess had to cover her mouth with both hands to stop herself from screaming, and felt her face warm as she blushed and commented —That was fast.

—We weren't that intimate back then, Princess, I hadn't even taken off my veil— she clarified.—But, believe me: neither of us was drunk; she kept refusing to drink because it was the middle of the week, and I can perfectly hold my wine, so you could consider it was… mere lust— Light Spinner added, laughing then at how Glimmer's face only got redder.

—I- No, well- I suppose it's… Normal? Perhaps?— she stammered, noticeably nervous but still wanting to hear the rest of the story. —So how did you become more intimate?

—Let's just say, after that night she got *bold*; she knew I had… liked it. I must say it was probably her new boldness that finally enticed me— she answered, rolling her eyes a bit as she remembered. —Listen: your aunt is a very smart and caring person, she's funny, determined, sometimes insecure yet always willing to give her all to help others— Light Spinner enumerated. Her expression darkened as she admitted —She's selfless in a way I can never be; I probably owe her my well-being, if not my life, because I never regard collateral damage, neither other people nor myself.

—So she…

—She helped me with that project, and almost everything else too. Before I realized it, she was indispensable for me; I would have been banished from Mystacor much sooner if it wasn't for her.

Princess Glimmer let out a smile. She looked at her aunt once again and realized she was now opening her eyes. Had she heard all of that?

—You are unbelievable, Bea— Castaspella groaned.

Light Spinner cackled and replied —Are you surprised, Es?

—That wasn't something to tell *my niece*— she insisted, her voice weak but clearly annoyed.

—Aw, but I wanted to know!— Glimmer complained. —Like… how you both call each other names no one else uses for you. That's so adorable!

—It began as a taunt— Light Spinner let out, nonchalantly. —But we are both too stubborn to take offense and it became something… personal.

Later that night, as Castaspella was feeling much better, she began cooking her due for Mystacor's party, with help from Arden, who was still a bit depressed but wouldn't admit it, and even Light Spinner gave them a hand with some spells to avoid wasting ingredients.

None of them slept that night, after all, they could sleep the next morning before the party; they hadn't ever spent any "quality time" together before, and it felt surprisingly nice for them. The sorceress would often take a moment to sit back and reflect: Castaspella and Arden were certainly good friends, which was convenient in their particular situation, and Light Spinner couldn't help wondering how she had been so fortunate.

Chapter End Notes

Me? Giving Castaspella my own ailments (again)!? Never.....

._. I'm a menace to this woman.

Chapter 6: Day 6: Kingdom of Snows

Chapter Notes

I wasn't going to make this dramatic, or psychological… but guess who's instincts overtook?

At least it's bearable, I think…

Day 6

Kingdom of Snows

It was already past noon when Castaspella and Light Spinner finally woke up. They got dressed and went to the dining room for breakfast, where they found Arden already sipping tea.

—Well, you're finally up! Good morning!— they greeted them.

—Good morning— Light Spinner replied, casting a little spell to prepare two mugs of tea.

—You didn't have to sleep on the couch, you know?— Castaspella reminded them.

—Well, I didn't feel like bothering your brother so early in the morning to ask for a spare room— they answered without looking back. —Besides I couldn't sleep much, if I'm honest. And it was *very* difficult to contain myself, so much food and I can't eat a single bite.

—No, you can't. There's still left-over cake, if you want.

—Wait, there is *more* cake? I thought I ate the last slice yesterday!— Arden exclaimed.

—Your mistake was thinking she cooked a single cake— Light Spinner chimed in. She handed Castaspella a steamy mug of tea and took a sip of hers. —She was so nervous with this whole… secrecy, she woke up early to cook.

Arden looked to the side as they sheepishly admitted —I can't deny I always win whenever she's stressed so…

—Don't! Don't finish that sentence or I'm throwing away those leftovers!— the sorceress threatened.

—Please, Love, we both know you wouldn't— Light Spinner defied her, casually sipping her tea.

—How are you both so different yet so similar!? Just my luck!— Castaspella complained.

—You love us!— Arden replied, laughing.

—Really!?

The sorceress finished her tea and returned to her room, leaving them both to laugh and finish their breakfast. Moments later, Light Spinner went into the room too and leaned against the wall next to the window.

—You know we're just joking, right?

—Of course, Bea— she replied, looking back at her with a tired expression. She was trying to make the bed but let go of the sheets a moment to straighten up, and added —I'm not angry at you either, of course. It gets a bit annoying, but I know neither of you mean any harm… It's nice, how you two keep trying to lift my mood.

—You deserve it, Es.

The sorceress focused on the bed once again, but it had to be remade entirely; the sheets were loose, the cover had fallen to the ground, and the mattress cover was half out too.

—A little help here, Bea. If you don't mind.

—I *do* mind— the woman replied, looking out of the window.

—Are you *serious*!?— Castaspella exclaimed. She let go of everything, approached her, and angrily complained —You are *also* sleeping here, remember!? You could really help at least a bit!

Light Spinner let out a long sigh, rolled her eyes, and simply said —Then, allow me.

With a flick of her wrist, she cast a couple of small spells and quickly made the bed.

—That was… That was *not* what I asked for— Castaspella let out in a low tone.

—You make it all very complicated, Love— the woman replied, dismissively.

—No. You don't understand, Bea— she replied, shaking her head slowly, noticeably disappointed. —I *like* doing things without sorcery, not being reliant on it, managing myself without the "magical help"— she explained, calmly. Light Spinner wouldn't dare answer; she stayed silent while the sorceress took a deep breath and let out a long sigh, concluding —You really didn't understand: I asked for *help*, not this, I wanted you to help me, not just "get it done". You *need* to listen to people.

—I do listen perfectly!— she huffed, almost offended.

—You *hear* but don't *listen*!— Castaspella retorted. She spoke in such an irritated tone they both fell silent. They stared at each other for a moment; it was difficult to discern what Light Spinner could be feeling, but she was unmistakably grief-stricken. Finally, she closed her eyes, turned around, and said —Perhaps we were right to break up back then—. The sorceress wanted to reply, but before she could, Castaspella raised a hand, barely turned her head, and clarified —I *don't* want to give up on you for something this little, but I can't help feeling like I'm the only one trying while you just… are.

She finally left the room, leaving Light Spinner shocked for a minute. What was she thinking!? She should have known being so disdainful would upset the sorceress. In fact, she knew it, but hadn't stopped a single second to *consider* it.

She eventually left the room and found Castaspella busy washing dishes; she approached from behind, muttering —You are right, I apologize. I still haven't learned to listen to you.

—Not just me, Love. Everyone. You should be a bit more mindful in general.

—I don't think I can be *that* considerate even if I tried— Light Spinner replied, rolling her eyes.

Mildly annoyed, yet letting out a smile, Castaspella replied —Fine. Let's start small: listen to what I ask of you instead of trying to magic your way through all domestic chores.

The sorceress turned around and walked a few steps, dramatically replying —Sorry to disappoint, Love; I haven't had to be this domestic in too many years.

—When have you ever been domestic!?— she exclaimed, almost breaking the dish between her hands. —No, I'm sure you couldn't actually be domestic to save your skin!— she reproached her, rolling her eyes.

—Fair…— Light Spinner admitted, looking back. —But perhaps my skin isn't even worth the trouble.

—You have to be kidding me.

—Perhaps you care about me too much.

Castaspella looked back at her, annoyed, and threatened —Do you want me to throw a dish at you!?

—Try me.

—I don't think so… Only the poor plate will suffer— the sorceress lamented, continuing to wash the dishes.

A few hours later, the three of them arrived at the snowy mountain where the Palace of the Kingdom of Snows rises imposingly under a darkened sky. Light Spinner had all three of them enveloped in a warming spell, yet she was already feeling exhausted by the time they arrived at the entrance. Many of the attendees were wearing warm clothes, but others were just as exposed to the cold as they were.

A guard quickly came to welcome them, in a way, saying —Please hand in any weapons before entering the main hall. You can also be lent warming clothes if needed.

They stared at the guard's masked face for a moment before finally doing as told, and shortly after they were led to a room with plenty of coats in different sizes and colors.

—Finally— Light Spinner groaned, dropping her spell and sitting on the floor, laying against a wall.

—We told you to let us help; this is a very draining spell…

—I should be more than capable to keep it for longer even— the sorceress complained, interrupting Castaspella.

—Please, Love, be more gentle with yourself.

—You don't need to pamper me, Es.

—Well!— Arden interrupted, sensing some tension. —Grab a coat and leave, ladies; I'll be near the appetizers table.

Once they left, the sorceresses noticed the silence of the room. Castaspella offered her hand to help her up, but the woman pulled her down onto her lap. The sorceress laughed, shaking her head with light-hearted annoyance, and Light Spinner took off her veil before pulling her in for a kiss.

Meanwhile, Micah and Angella were just arriving at the palace and came across Arden as they exited the room of coats; when they mentioned Castaspella was still inside, the King walked into the entrance, only to freeze right before crossing the door, as he found the sorceresses kissing.

—Wha-

He opened his mouth to exclaim in surprise, yet Angella swiftly pulled him back, delicately covering his mouth.

—Don't interrupt!— she prompted.

They both remained next to the wall, a few meters away from the door, trying to speak in hushed tones.

—When did this happen!? *How* did this happen!?— Micah began asking, utterly confused.

—But you *knew* your sister was seeing someone!— the Queen replied, almost as puzzled.

—But I thought it was like… her lover from before the marriage!

—I- Dear, who exactly did you think her lover was?

—Um… honestly I don't know.

Angella stared at him, her lips pressed, as she considered whether to tell him or not. However, soon enough her husband opened his eyes as much as possible. He understood.

—Wait.

—Yes, Darling— she sighed, her expression a mix of endearment and pity.

—And you *knew*!?

—I- Of course!— she exclaimed, as if it had to be obvious. —How else did you think I convinced Light Spinner to come this year!?

He looked to the side, raising a brow, and admitted —She didn't say it, just told us you had "your methods".

—And what exactly did you think that meant!?— she insisted, indignant this time.

—I-I don't know! Persuasion!?

The Queen covered her eyes, unable to hide a mild flush. She felt a bit embarrassed, but mostly wanted to laugh at how gullible Micah was.

—You're so innocent, my Love…— she let out, lovingly smiling at him. —And she made it sound *so* bad…

Angella felt embarrassed only thinking about how that must have sounded for others, but the fact that he had completely missed it just widened her smile.

—And since when do you know?

—Quite a few years— she replied, looking away with a nervous grin. —I may have walked into them, um… *kissing*. I think when Casta was twenty-five?

—And how long had *that* been happening by then!?— he inquired, trying to keep himself calm.

—No more than a year, as far as I know.

Micah looked away and stared at the distance. It made sense, perhaps. He was still astounded but that would explain why she had defended Light Spinner so fervidly when she was banished. Now he even regretted a bit his role in the whole subject, but he knew he had no other choice, and knowledge of their relationship wouldn't have changed his decision.

Princess Frosta's speech was short; from up in her throne, she welcomed everyone, thanked all attendees for leaving their weapons at the entrance respecting the rules of hospitality, and finally declared the beginning of the party. Shortly after, she had left her throne and joined Princess Mermista and Sea Hawk.

—Accident or not, it's your duty as Host Princess to fix all inconveniences of your guests— Frosta reproached Mermista.

—I am *not* in charge of the food! How is this my fault?— she retorted, crossing her arms in front of her chest.

—But, Princess, wouldn't it be proof of your magnificence if you showed interest in your guests' well-being?— Sea Hawk tried to convince her.

—Listen, Mermista: you are supposed to follow the protocol! You're in *my* palace now, and I expect proper manners to be exercised— Frosta insisted.

—Fine! I will check on the sorceress, but please stop bothering me, you two— she finally agreed.

Sea Hawk seemed delighted and hugged her briefly, Princess Frosta also seemed satisfied, and immediately looked around, searching for Castaspella. As soon as she saw her, the three of them approached; she was on her way to her table, accompanied by Light Spinner.

—Good evening, Princesses, Sea Hawk— the young sorceress greeted them.

—Good evening— Frosta replied. —Welcome to my palace, may you enjoy the party today without any hindrance.

—Thank you, Princess Frosta— she replied, a bit confused. —But I'm sure there's nothing to worry about.

—It's only proper— she insisted.

Then she looked at Mermista, but she was looking away, uncomfortable. Frosta frowned and was about to call out to her, but Sea Hawk interceded first.

—My dear Princess here has something to say too, don't you, Dearest?

—Erm… I'm sorry my food poisoned you, that wasn't supposed to happen— she uttered, still too nervous to look at her.

—Please, that was not…

—Are you serious!?— Frosta interrupted, despite Castaspella's effort to defuse the situation.

—Alright! I really mean it! I'm sorry if anything in the food that was served made you ill. And… I should have checked on you yesterday but didn't have the chance— Mermista finally apologized, earnestly.

Castaspella smiled kindly as she replied —I appreciate it, but I assure you I'm fine, Princess. I was just a bit nervous, and also ate spicy food; I know it wasn't your fault. Besides, I recovered after a few hours.

—As long as you could enjoy the party…

—Absolutely! It was fantastic, including the food— she affirmed.

—We're glad to know!— Sea Hawk exclaimed with excitement. He wrapped his right arm around Mermista and added —Aren't we, Dearest?

—Well leave you to enjoy the party then— Frosta declared, always following proper Princess protocol.

While the three of them left, Light Spinner tilted a bit towards Castaspella and whispered —Is that normal?

—Not really— the sorceress admitted, as they continued walking. After a moment, she added —It seems to be that Frosta's high regard for all procedures couldn't let it go unaddressed.

Castaspella let out a chuckle while the sorceress replied —For such a young Princess, she's definitely one of the most respectful people I've met until now.

—I'm sure you only liked that she's just as direct and blunt as you— she mocked her.

—She has a spine, that's quite commendable.

—Oh, shut up— Castaspella let out, rolling her eyes, yet smirking a bit.

For a few hours, only the music of the band accompanied the conversation of the table where Mystacor's most prominent figures were seated. The whole council and Norwyn had been assigned there with Arden, Castaspella, and Light Spinner. As expected, the whole council pretended the woman wasn't there; Princess Frosta could have ensured she stayed on the table, but nothing would make them speak to her or regard her in any way.

—I insist, Es; it's better if I leave now— the sorceress argued. —I realize Arden is presenting to the council something very important for them. And every councilor is looking at me sideways as if I didn't notice.

—Bea, it's normal… But you have the same right as anyone to be seated here, them being rude shouldn't make you leave— Castaspella replied. —That's what they want.

Instead of replying, Light Spinner just drank carefully from her cup while paying attention to what a councilwoman was telling Arden.

—…And if you can properly adapt the technique, it should let us spend our energy more efficiently, right?

—Precisely: most spells are incredibly draining and yet, occasionally we need to keep them up for too long— Arden explained. They elaborated a bit more —Sometimes, that can be fixed if we draw the spell on the surface to be affected, but when we require the spell to move with us, we have no other option but to keep using our own energy. Like- I presume we all arrived at the palace keeping ourselves warm with a spell, right?

—Indeed— a councilman agreed. —Yet, we came in groups and took turns so we wouldn't exhaust ourselves.

—However— another councilman interrupted. —I believe I saw you arrive with… your wife and Light Spinner. The woman looked *very* exhausted— he remarked. —If you have such expertise in magical energy expenditures, sure you could have pointed out it would happen.

—I… I did. I suggested we take turns as you did, but she was sure she could hold it for enough time— Arden replied, starting to get nervous. —I didn't push the matter because she is, in fact, quite powerful.

—Not enough, it seems— he pointed out.

Without a word, Light Spinner stood up and left. Neither Castaspella nor Arden could react fast enough to stop her, and when they looked back at the table, the Head Sorcerer was staring at them with a serious expression. She couldn't go after her or his suspicions would be confirmed, while Arden wouldn't throw away this opportunity; it was too relevant for their future in Mystacor and they might not have another one. They had no choice, both remained at the table; Castaspella could no longer pay attention to the discussion, just kept eating and let the music of the band distract her.

Barely an hour had passed, the last dishes had been served, and some guests were already preparing to leave, when an Acolyte from Mystacor rushed into the ballroom, followed by a dozen guards trying to stop him.

—Please! No! I have to- Head Sorcerer! The archive! She's crazy! Like possessed!— he began yelling, as the guards grabbed him and took him away. —She stole her project!

—This can't be…— Castaspella uttered, skeptical. She looked back at Arden, they had the same look of disbelief. —Right?

At a nearby table, Micah and Angella looked at the sorceress and her distraught expression said enough; they could anticipate what would happen if this was true.

—We have to return to Mystacor now— Norwyn sentenced, standing up from his chair, promptly followed by the whole council. Right after, he approached the Princesses table and addressed Adora —Princess, I request your assistance. This sorceress is very powerful and we can't let her escape with that research.

Adora gave him a firm nod, stood up along with Catra, and both of them joined the group that had gathered in the middle of the ballroom. The regents of Bright Moon had already approached the mages and Micah took the initiative of leading the casting of a massive teleportation spell.

On the stairs of Mystacor, a few meters above the end of the stairway, a group of scared mages tried to keep Light Spinner from fleeing with the bundle of scrolls she had stolen from the archive. Cutting her way from all sides, and knowing she couldn't use sorcery without letting go of her investigation, they could at least stall her until help arrived.

The sorceress' stance and expression were akin to that of a feral beast. Her eyes alone kept everyone at a safe distance, and anyone who dared try taking the scrolls from her earned a shriek like that of a madman.

—Away! You won't take this from me again!

Light Spinner had been focused on every move the mages around her made, until something called her attention. It was as if she had felt the sheer power of the Princess as soon as she appeared and looked back at her; Adora strode forward with a severe expression, but the sorceress was too out of her mind to feel any fear. She just saw a menace, someone who would take away the work of her life, she had to flee or she would lose it all.

—Out of my way!— she roared at the sorcerers to her right, threatening to walk right through them. —Now!

But when she managed to scare them enough and intended to run away, Castaspella impeded her escape, getting in her way with both hands raised, in a desperate attempt to calm her down.

—Bea, please! Don't do this!— she pleaded.

—Out of my way! Don't you *dare* stop me, Esmeralda!

—I won't move! Please stop it! This is madness, you know it!

—Move away or I will move you!

Castaspella's expression only grew more determined. She could see that craziness in her eyes, just like when she was banished, yelling at everyone they were cowards and didn't even deserve the power they already had. Noticing she had no effect on her, she recoiled slightly, but forced herself to stand her ground.

Behind Light Spinner, Adora and Catra finally reached the sorceress. Their serious demeanor was enough to know they wouldn't allow her to leave with that dangerous project, no matter the cost.

—Surrender the scrolls at once, Light Spinner. We are not letting you go with them— Adora sentenced.

The sorceress turned around, her sight fixed on the Princess; she carefully dropped the scrolls and immediately cast an offensive spell. The shot missed her by a hairsbreadth as Catra pushed Adora out of the way and quickly threw her claws at the sorceress. But another spell, like a shield, intercepted Catra's strike.

—Don't harm her! She's out of her mind!— Castaspella begged.

—Stay out of this!

More spells, punches, and swats came and went; Light Spinner jealously protected her project, Adora kept trying to recover it, Catra deflected the hits the Princess couldn't catch, and every strike thrown at the sorceress was immediately deflected by Castaspella.

Eventually, Catra realized the fight would never end if they continued like that, and instead focused on the young sorceress; noticing she wouldn't attack them and was only focused on

protecting Light Spinner, it was easy for her to best Castaspella, and soon she had managed to drag the woman away from the fight.

—Listen. Listen!— Catra urged her. The sorceress' sorrow was evident in her expression, but she couldn't let her emotions get in the way, and kept her serious tone as she said —You *have* to let this happen. She won't be harmed, I give you my word.

Before Castaspella could reply, they both heard Adora cry out —For the honor of Grayskull! —. She had transformed into the legendary warrior, She-Ra; she was now much higher than the sorceress, her power at the surface, and approached Light Spinner pointing at her with a bright sword. But none of that seemed to intimidate the woman. —I thought I told you to surrender the scrolls immediately.

—Never! You are all cowards! Like those elders from my village! Fools! All of you!

—Adora!— Catra called her. It was clear there was no way to stop the sorceress, and knowing how much of a threat Light Spinner currently was, she could guess what She-Ra was about to do. When the Princess looked back, Catra requested —Don't hurt her.

She gave the sorceress a pitiful glance then stared at She-Ra again, who nodded once before looking back at Light Spinner. Her sword shone for a moment, changed its form radically, and before the sorceress could react, it had enveloped her wrists tightly and pulled her to the ground.

—For the last time: give up the scrolls, abandon this project forever, or face the consequences of threatening all Etheria.

Despite She-Ra's warning, Light Spinner kept resisting, and madly yelled —It is *not* a threat! This is a breakthrough! The next step of sorcery as we know it! It only needs enough power to restrain it! *A power like yours*!

—Nothing justifies endangering the whole world, you are blinded by your thirst for power— She-Ra sentenced with severity.

—You are afraid of the powers you have!

—No. You don't know true power. Yet— she replied, shocking Light Spinner. She-Ra slowly closed the distance, her full height towering over her, saying —But you will.

—Even if you end me, you know I'm right!— the sorceress yelled, desperate.

—No. You are out of your mind— she denied. She-Ra raised both hands and reached out, concluding —But you can still learn, if you start to listen.

The moment her hands surrounded the sorceress' head, a bright light emanated from them both. No one understood what was happening, and Castaspella desperately shook, trying to escape Catra's restraint.

—Wait, wait!

Light Spinner began screaming; at a distance, the regents on Bright Moon and the Head Sorcerer observed the scene with troubled expressions. Was this the only way? What would be the consequences? What was the protector of the world doing to the woman who endangered Etheria?

—It's almost done— Catra assured Castaspella, but she was still crying while pulling to break free.

Light Spinner's screaming ended the moment She-Ra withdrew her hands, and the sorceress yelled —Beatrix!

—She will be fine— Catra insisted, feeling her sorrow.

The woman fell to the ground, motionless, and Catra finally let go of Castaspella, who immediately ran to her side.

—Bea, Bea! Wake up… please— she begged as more tears fell.

Behind her, Adora returned to her normal form, and the restraints holding Light Spinner's wrists vanished.

—My… why- Why did…

—You're fine, you're alright— Castaspella interrupted her, noticing her breathless but at least conscious enough to speak.

—No…— Light Spinner exhaled, disturbing the sorceress.

What could she mean? What exactly had happened to her?

Pushing through her uneasiness, Castaspella tried to comfort her —Don't worry, I'll take you- you just need to rest.

Princess Adora finally decided to intercede, assuring —She will be fine, she only needs to adjust to her new condition.

The sorceress tensed and questioned —What did you do?

—Gave her a second chance. I trust you can help her.

But that wasn't what she had asked.

Castaspella's expression darkened; she looked back at Adora and, with a fiercer tone, repeated —What… *What* did you do?

The Princess looked away, anticipating her reaction, and sighed before replying —Sealed away her magic. She can no longer use sorcery.

Her scowl vanished in a second, replaced by despair. She looked back at Light Spinner and felt as if something inside her had broken.

—That's almost worse than killing her.

—For her. But not for you— Adora sentenced. —And *that* is what she needs to learn.

Castaspella let her tears fall again; with her cheeks already wet, she finally uttered —I… thank you, for sparing her.

Adora only placed a hand on her shoulder and pressed reassuringly for a moment. Then, she left to rejoin Catra and check on the mages that had handled the sorceress before their arrival.

Seeing the situation under control, the Head Sorcerer finally approached, accompanied by two acolytes who picked up the scrolls and took them away promptly. Behind him, Arden and Micah walked closer, followed by Queen Angella, but after what they had seen and heard, they didn't know how to proceed.

Arden noticed how Norwyn just stood about a meter away from the sorceresses and rushed to their side, intending to parry his suspicions.

—Can she get up? We need to get her to a proper bed to lay down— they said, eyeing the Head Sorcerer.

—No, no. She's too weakened.

—I'm… *not* weak— the woman managed to complain.

—You can't move a muscle, that's what I'm talking about, stop being so…— Castaspella retorted, but couldn't finish her reproach. —Just keep quiet, Bea.

—We can't stay here, Casta— Arden insisted. They looked back at Norwyn and requested —Please, allow us to take her to our house. She needs to rest, she's in no shape to return to wherever she lives. A-and she's no longer a menace.

The sorcerer kept a straight face. A silent denial. He didn't have the heart to reply, noticing how concerned his pupil was, but neither they nor anyone would convince him; being the Head Sorcerer, he *had* to enforce their laws and keep the woman away.

—Excuse me, Norwyn— Angella stepped in. —I'm sure this situation calls for an exception, wouldn't you agree?

—I apologize, Your Majesty. Magic or not, allowing her to stay unsupervised and free is a violation of our laws and the banishment she was sentenced to— he replied, his tone serious yet not malicious, almost pained. —The only place in Mystacor she's going to, is an empty room within a containment spell.

—We are *not* leaving her on the cold floor like an animal, Norwyn— Micah interrupted. —I know what she's done, but we just saw her lose her sorcery!— he insisted, angry yet keeping his composure. —I believe we should take her to Bright Moon, then.

Angella nodded and supported —We have more than enough spare rooms. If you find it so troubling to do us such a favor, Head Sorcerer, at least allow us to take her away.

Norwyn stared at the Queen for a moment, but didn't waver, he couldn't. Finally, he nodded and moved aside, letting them help Castaspella and Arden take Light Spinner away.

That night, in a dimly illuminated room, the young sorceress held the woman between her arms; as soon as they entered the spare room and lay on the soft bed, she passed out and Castaspella preferred to be left alone. She feared what Light Spinner's reaction could be once she woke up, her state of mind was uncertain.

Meanwhile, a few meters away from the room, Adora and Catra were telling Glimmer and Bow everything that had happened.

—…I know this was the best thing to do— the Princess assured. —I trust your aunt will manage this better than anyone.

—I still can't feel any sympathy for her, but… What I felt when I was holding back Castaspella…— Catra sighed, looking away for a moment to find the proper words. —I can assure you all, she was more than willing to give everything up to make sure that sorceress wasn't harmed.

Glimmer looked down, her eyes closed, and uttered —I spoke with Light Spinner, back in Salineas, and she admitted only Aunt Casta could keep her and everyone around them safe.

—But, is Light Spinner crazy?— Bow asked, confused and concerned.

—I don't think so— Adora replied. —Based on our previous interactions, I can say for sure she just lost control; presumably, something triggered her, but now that I've locked away her sorcery, she won't ever be a threat if something like this were to happen again.

—And we both agree that Castaspella can help her tame those impulses of her; she's probably the only person she wouldn't harm— Catra added. —Back in Mystacor, she managed to stall the sorceress because she wouldn't move away yet Light Spinner kept yelling at her to do so, never attempting to attack her.

Glimmer let out a long sigh and Bow placed a hand on her shoulder before hugging her for a moment.

—I think we should speak with mom— she let out. —I don't want my aunt to have to deal with all the gossip that may start tomorrow. She'll have enough with this, the party, and the wedding.

Chapter 7: Day 7: Mystacor

Chapter Notes

I am so sorry for the delay!
I was tasked with... cutting carrots and tomatoes RIGHT when I had finished writing...
This chapter was really difficult to finish but I hope it's to your taste cause here I'm posting with a hand orange from the carrots, and the other smelling like tomato… Plus, my claw-like nails kept stabbing the carrots, I'm at my limit yet don't want that to affect my writing

BUT I DIGRESS
Please enjoy the chapter ^-^

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 7

Mystacor

Castaspella could barely sleep that night. She'd rest for an hour or two, then wake up with any move Light Spinner made, and see the woman was still sleeping. And so, she'd keep looking at her, how her brow furrowed with some troubling dream, until she fell asleep for another hour.

Ultimately, she woke up when sunlight came through the windows, and held the woman in a tight embrace, barely holding back her tears. Castaspella caressed her hair until she stirred; moments later, Light Spinner opened her eyes and shifted the position of her head to look at the other side.

—Bea?

—Mhmm?

—Good morning, my Love— Castaspella said, her voice almost breaking. —How do you feel?

—Weak.

—I'm sorry…— she let out, her voice finally faltering.

Light Spinner lifted her head and looked at her; the sorceress was silently crying and her expression of deep sorrow confused her for a moment before the memories of the previous night returned to her.

It hadn't been a nightmare.

—She took my power…

—Bea…

—Why? *Why*!? How dare she!?— Light Spinner began asking, her tone increasingly louder.

—Calm down. Please— Castaspella begged, trying to stop her from getting up. —Wait, wait. You shouldn't get up so fast, Love, please— she insisted, trying to cease her crying.

—I- I'm- Why didn't she just kill me?— she finally asked, laying down again, next to her this time. She stared at the ceiling, only now noticing —We are in Bright Moon.

Castaspella sat up and looked at her with a sad yet tender smile, as she explained —Micah and Angella made sure you wouldn't be… Kept as a prisoner in Mystacor.

—That ludicrous ram always refused to keep prisoners— she grunted. —He was surely bluffing.

—Bea. Please. What happened last night was very serious— the sorceress remarked. —Do you understand that?

—Yes, yes. I should have been executed right there.

—No. You- you actually don't get it— Castaspella denied. —You were out of control.

—It’s not the first time.

—But you were given another chance. Adora wants you to recover.

—No. She sentenced me to a fate far worse than dead— she snarled.

—I know that's how you feel, but…—she began. Castaspella lay down next to her, their faces barely a palm away, and caressed her exposed skin as she continued —Do you think I’d let you die instead? I know nothing would ever make you suffer more than losing your power, but I refuse to lose you. Power is *not* worth it.

—I am nothing now… You already lost me— she replied, never looking back at her.

—Bea, you aren't your power.

—Your infinite kindness won't be enough this time, Es. Just… Give up.

—I won't. Ever— she sentenced. Castaspella sat up once again, cupped her face with one hand, and leaned forward but stopped right before reaching her lips, to add —Now it’s time for me to be a bit possessive—. When she finally kissed her, for a moment she felt her liveliness return; Light Spinner gripped her torso, pulled her on top, and kissed her back intensely. But shortly after, she pushed her away just enough to break the kiss. —What's wrong?

—You have no future with me— she sentenced. —And don’t try to reply with some sappy speech. I can already guess all you will say.

—Bea… Don’t estrange me again. Please, think about it— she begged.

—I can't promise anything— she insisted. —And now you have a party to help with, just go.

—Promise me you’ll come.

—I just said I can’t promise…

—Then I’ll just have to trust you will.

All preparations for the party were almost done; the Head Sorcerer showed up to supervise everything, tables and chairs in place, all ready for the wedding ceremony, the food properly stored to be served later, the mages in charge of entertainment seemed to be practicing, and the acolytes who would act as butlers were already fixing trays with appetizers.

Seeing everything in order, Norwyn decided to address the one important matter he needed to solve before the council showed up. He went for both Arden and Castaspella and took them somewhere more secluded so they could discuss without dragging unwanted attention.

—I suppose you both know what I brought you here for, and before you begin, do know the council is expecting to settle this matter as soon as possible; they might be more prone to choosing the quickest solution, which you both know very well— he warned. —So I expect you both to give me a proper explanation.

Meanwhile, somewhere not so far away, Light Spinner had finally managed to arrive at Mystacor. Fortunately for her, almost everyone was busy preparing that day's party, and she could easily avoid being seen. She went to look for Castaspella; she needed to talk with her one last time. Her decision was made, but she couldn't just disappear without saying a word.

She had asked Micah to use a little spell to find her, and finally arrived at an empty corridor he had indicated her. Hearing the voices of both Norwyn and Arden there, she guessed what was happening, and remained hidden in the shadows, listening.

—What we saw says otherwise— Norwyn insisted, having interrupted Arden once again. —It's true that both you and King Micah showed as much concern as her for the woman, but neither of you fought back or cried for her like that.

—This isn't the first time I've defended her, Head Sorcerer— Castaspella reminded him, intending to disguise it a bit. —Why should last night be regarded differently than when she was banished?

—And what makes you think we're seeing it differently?— Norwyn argued, turning the argument against her.

—You can't be serious— she retorted. —If that was the case, why wasn't I banished too, or accused like now?

—We supposed you had been sensible enough to abandon your *infatuation* for her, seeing how she had fallen in disgrace.

—Norwyn, please. This is ridiculous— Arden interceded. —We have been nothing but loyal to Mystacor, complying with everything you and the council asked from us…

—Yet I recall you firmly denying the last request— he reproached them.

—Because pressuring us to have a child is madness! And wouldn't in any way prove our trustworthiness better than the last four years!— they argued.

—Wouldn't it be because your charade would completely crumble?— he defied them.

Listening to all of this, Light Spinner's blood was boiling, she could barely stand remaining there, and that last accusation simply shattered her self-control into pieces.

—That's enough!— she interrupted, surprising the three mages as she stalked their way. —I'm sick of your endless idiocy! You're letting the council pressure you into a grumpy capricious man, making the lives of your *own* pupils miserable! They have taken enough of you already!

For a moment, Norwyn was completely shocked, yet he quickly recovered and indignantly inquired —How dare you appear here again!? Your banishment makes it clear that you…

—Save it! You're just deflecting because you know full well I'm right!— she interrupted. —Grow a backbone and think for yourself!

—Enough! Leave now or I'll make sure to have you sealed within a containment spell!— he threatened.

Castaspella looked back at Arden with a troubled expression. They looked down, understanding, and then raised their sight at her once again, in time to see her mouth an apology before getting between Light Spinner and Norwyn.

—She will stay— the sorceress sentenced. —May I remind you, Head Sorcerer, that for this day this is actually allowed; Mystacor is open to *everyone* in Etheria, meaning the banishment sentence doesn't apply today.

—What are you doing? Es!— Light Spinner asked from behind her, stunned.

Right after, Norwyn also inquired, with a rather knowing look, —Do you understand what you are doing?

The sorceress looked back at Arden for a brief moment before replying —I understand.

—This is a mistake, Castaspella.

—You are right, Head Sorcerer. It's the best mistake of my life— she assured him with absolute confidence.

Norwyn could barely hold back his surprise, Arden looked at her with pride, and Light Spinner hid a smirk behind her veil; none of them had witnessed her boldness in years now.

—You are both aware of the consequences this will have— he remarked, joining both hands behind his back.

—With all due respect, Head Sorcerer, I think we have sacrificed more than enough already — Arden noted. —We can't keep doing this, pretending to be a couple; we live like roommates, never sleep in that room at the same time and, being honest, I am *not* interested in women that way, so I wouldn't have married Casta if it wasn't for all the drama the council made five years ago!

Norwyn looked away for a moment, shook his head, and finally looked back at them as he asked —Why would you do this for so many years?

—We had no other choice— Castaspella began. —We faced banishment for something I could have prevented… *Should* have prevented. And Arden would have nowhere to go— she continued. —While I could simply go with Micah, or even follow Light Spinner wherever she went, they had no options and came to me offering an agreement before that old marriage arrangement was nullified.

—So you chose to help them— Norwyn sighed, looking away once again. He took a deep breath while closing his eyes, and after a moment finally spoke again. —I understand how the council's decisions have affected your lives, the sacrifices you had to make… and yet, the council might still want to banish you both.

—I have to disagree— Arden quickly interrupted with a smug tone. —So many tutors have retired lately, I don't think they would dare banish two of the few who remain, especially not with how big our classes are— they began. —And may I also remind you my project has been of great interest for all of them? It's *really* hard for me to believe they will banish me.

The relief Castaspella felt was obvious in her expression: they had actually managed to fulfill their goal, made enough of a name for themselves to be safe. The Head Sorcerer had to hold back a smirk, but felt glad realizing Arden was right.

—In that case— he said, addressing Castaspella this time. —*If* the council allows you to stay despite your relationship with Light Spinner, you would still be punished, mainly because of all the years you've been pretending to have lost your sympathy for her.

—Then I will take full responsibility; I suppose I'll lose all my privileges until I earn them again.

—Oh, I'm sure you'll get them back soon— Arden commented.

—But not the permission for the forbidden documents— Norwyn clarified. —And you won't be allowed to live here either ever again— he added. She nodded, then Arden, and he concluded —In that case, I will undo your marriage soon. For now, I have a wedding to officiate.

With this matter finally settled, the four of them entered the main hall, finding most of the guests already there. The wedding would begin early, so that the rest of the festivities could proceed according to schedule, and everything was almost ready. As soon as Norwyn indicated it, the ceremony would begin.

Queen Angella waved at them and they three joined her and King Micah, taking a seat next to them.

—Did we just see you walk in with Norwyn!?— she asked them, barely hiding her surprise.

—That's correct. We told him everything— Castaspella admitted.

—You all will have to tell us everything later— Micah pointed out.

—Now silence, you all, the ceremony will begin soon— the sorceress shushed them. Next to her, Light Spinner seemed uneasy and she whispered —What is it?

—Is it too rude to ask how long this will take?

Castaspella rolled her eyes as she replied —Quite, in my opinion. However, if you want to know… The Princesses will give their speeches, then Catra and Adora make their vows, and then acolytes finish the ritual.

—Alright, I suppose I can bear a few hours— the woman replied unexcitedly.

—You could be a bit more receptive. Listen to their speeches, try to understand what they want to express…

—It's starting— Arden interrupted, noticing the Head Sorcerer taking his place behind the stand.

—Welcome, everyone, to the final day of the End of the Year week— he began. —This year we have the pleasure of witnessing the union of the protectors of our world, Princess Adora and Catra. It is my greatest honor to open today's festivities with this ceremony— he went on. —Now, I invite everyone to receive them.

From the other side of the room, they both entered the hall, arm in arm, and all attendees rose from their seats to applaud them. Once they reached the stan where Norwyn waited, he gestured at the first row on the left, where the Princesses were seated, and Glimmer stood up. She walked closer to them, looked back at the crowd, and began her speech.

—I've known Adora and Catra for some years now, and all I can say is that they taught me a lot. Their strength, the way they both connected to our world, their unique appreciation of Etheria, and their will to discover the best in everyone… It all showed me I didn't really know my own world, that I hadn't given its people a chance, not even to myself! If I've grown so much the past few years, it's all thanks to them— Princess Glimmer expressed. —I'm overjoyed to know they have found happiness, and now share it with us! You two deserve the best!

As she returned to her seat, Adora giggled briefly while everyone applauded. Her parents looked proudly at Glimmer and next to them Castaspella had to hide a laugh when Light Spinner noted how the Princess had inherited Micah's speech skills.

Next, it was Entrapta's turn, and she didn't waste a second; holding herself up by means of her hair, and clutching the same digital device she always carried around, she began reading, with great enthusiasm, —I met Princess Adora exactly five years and thirty-seven days ago, and her world's technology turned out to be my greatest project until now! I've been so excited since, *ecstatic*! That must be what Catra made you feel if you will now pledge to

spend your whole life with her! I'll be monitoring your happiness level from today on, and my calculations indicate they should double within the next few years!

As the Princess concluded her speech, Adora smiled at her and nodded wanting to thank her. The other Princesses were the first to applaud her, and shortly after, everyone else did too. This time, Light Spinner's remark was more surprised. She had mentioned that the speech had actually been quite good, regardless of how she worded it, the message was clear: Entrapta noticed Catra makes Adora happier than anything, and hopes they will make each other even happier be for years to come.

After her, it was now Mermista's turn; she took a deep breath to focus before beginning —I remember the day I met Adora, and how I insisted I couldn't trust her for being from another universe. I was so mean to her, but she never resented me; I almost expected her to hate my kingdom because of that, but instead, she loved it. For two years she was solely dedicated to meeting my people, learning from them, helping whenever she could, and never gave up on me either—. The Princess let out a long sigh, not daring to look at her. —Despite being so bitter at her, and even making Catra, her best friend, constantly uncomfortable with my powers, she never disrespected me and insisted on having a proper audience with me. And one day, some of the friends she had made in my kingdom took her to see the Sea Gate; I felt the exact moment in which she connected with The Pearl, it was a warmth that felt nostalgic, it reminded me of my father's embrace— she went on. She finally looked at them, only allowing herself half a smile, and concluded —I understood Adora is a friend of Etheria, and I'm glad to see you both *finally* marry. Although I could have believed you were already married back then, you know?

With that final teasing, Princess Mermista returned to her seat while everyone applauded, some laughed, and even Adora couldn't hold back her laughter, noticing Catra was blushing so much after that last remark. This time, Light Spinner made no comments, but even with her veil on, Castaspella could recognize her expression; she was mulling over something that Mermista had said.

The rest of the Princesses didn't give a speech, Scorpia was too shy, Perfuma had preferred to leave her time for Mermista's and Glimmer's speeches as they were longer than the time they were allowed, and Frosta had preferred to express her well-wishes more privately instead of in front of the multitude.

After a few moments, a couple of acolytes arrived, carrying an urn full of Lunar Lenses dust, which they used to begin drawing two identical spells on the ground, guided by Norwyn. Upon seeing the urn, Light Spinner tensed noticeably, and Castaspella quickly took her hand.

—Breathe, calm down— she told her, keeping her voice down. —I understand, and it might be better if you just look away.

—I… I'm fine— the woman replied, letting out a long sigh with her eyes closed. —But, tell me, why the binding spells? They aren't supposed to be *literally* bound to each other, right?

—Of course not. Those are for the rings— she replied, keeping her attention away from them. —Each ring will now be bound to one of them, and after their vows, Princess Adora will give Catra the ring bound to her, and vice versa.

It took a while for the rings to be ready as this was the most solemn part of the ceremony, but once they were done, it was finally the moment they had all been waiting for.

—Before this union can be sealed, you should make your vows— the Head Sorcerer announced, according to protocol. —On this occasion, as you have decided to use your own, who shall pledge?

—I will— Catra replied immediately. Everyone fell silent and she took Adora's hands as she began —The day I met you, I was a stray child who had nothing left in this world and loathed the surface of Etheria. I had just lost my family, my home and, by mere chance, you found me in the Whispering Woods—. Her expression was noticeably sorrowful, her ears were down, and she gripped her hands as if her life depended on it. —I never expected you to be the one who would teach me to love this planet, to heal and overcome the tragedy of Halfmoon, and to understand I couldn't live hating all of Etheria for it either— she continued. Then, looking directly into her eyes, she went on —You have a way of seeing the best in people, even in those of us who couldn't ever see it; I owe you so much, Adora… If this was the only way I could meet you, then I wouldn't ever change a single thing. The way I see it, you aren't just the protector of Etheria, you're a beacon of hope for everyone, not an experiment, or a weapon. You're much more than anyone could have imagined, and I've been granted the chance to repay you in kind—. Catra shifted her grip on Adora's hands and now cupped them both together. Her expression softened as she concluded —I shall protect you for the rest of our life, against anything and anyone who tries to harm you, from anywhere in this or other universes. I love you, Adora, I-I always have, and from today on, I won't ever let anything separate me from you.

Adora barely held her tears and asked —You promise?

—I promise— Catra replied, with absolute confidence.

As they tenderly smiled at each other, Norwyn gestured at the acolytes and they were given the rings. It took them a moment to put it on each other's fingers. Then, they held hands once again, but this time for the final step of the ceremony. The Head Sorcerer guided the acolytes as they cast a final spell, sealing their union.

Minutes later, it was done, they both kissed and Nowryn sentenced —Everyone, I present you: Princess Adora of Etheria, and Prince Catra of Etheria.

After a loud round of applause and the long time it took for everyone to congratulate them, the festivities for the end of the year began. The first meal was soon served; the tables had around eight and ten people each but, because of some issues that may not have been accidental, neither Castaspella nor Arden had an assigned table. Instead, they had to sit at one of the free tables prepared for unexpected guests. It didn't take long for one of such guests to join them, and since their arrival, they hadn't given them a break.

—It was merely an observation— they were telling them. —After hearing so many people commenting on the matter…

—Even if the Princesses themselves were saying it, why would you decide it's correct to call it "disrespectful"?— Castaspella interrupted, barely controlling her indignation.

—Es…

—Because it is. This is a social gathering, we are eating, it is disrespectful to have her face covered like that!— they insisted.

—According to who!?

—Es!

—Everyone!— they laughed, as if it were obvious.

Arden nearly choked on their drink, anticipating what would happen now.

—Mind you, where she comes from, what is disrespectful is *showing* your mouth, yet you don't see her here asking us to cover them, do you?— the sorceress remarked, too annoyed to notice Light Spinner trying to stop her. —You shouldn't ask for the opposite either!

—But it sounds to me like we're *not* where she comes from. Are we?

—Um, if I may…— Arden tried to intercede.

Yet Light Spinner raised a hand and finally silenced the three of them. She finished her drink and then faced their obnoxious companion with a look that sent goosebumps down their spine.

—You see… Just like most of us decide to cover our bodies with clothes, while others prefer to use much less, or even like you and I use footwear, while others, like Prince Catra for example, remain barefoot, so I wear a veil— she began with a chilling tone. —For me and my people, our mouth, sometimes even our whole face, is quite private, something we would only allow our most intimate circle to see. Hence, you asking me to take it off is akin to me asking you to take off your bottom clothes, underwear included.

With that, they immediately blushed with embarrassment; Castaspella, politically correct as always, held back a laugh and simply smirked, but Arden cackled loudly. How wouldn't they after such a fatal ridiculing?

Midnight approached quickly, the light show would soon begin with the new year, and the women had retired to a rather secluded corner, away from the crowd. They weren't speaking, just enjoying a companionable silence; Castaspella noticed how gloomy Light Spinner was, looking at the distance. It was clear it had to be because of the loss of her sorcery.

—Want to tell me what's on your mind??

—I don’t think you’ll like it…

—You still think it would have been better if she…

—It’s not about that— the woman interrupted her.

—Tell me, please.

—I was- When I came here earlier, I was looking for you to say goodbye— she finally admitted.

The fear that gripped the sorceress’ heart was evident in her expression as she asked —What do you mean?

—I was going to leave again. I didn’t want to- I felt like I couldn’t stay with you after last night; after what I did— she explained. —But you were so confident when you confronted Norwyn… The way you just decided to risk it all, for me. I don’t deserve it, Es.

—It was my decision, Bea. If you’re going to talk about deserving or not… Don’t I deserve to choose who I want to share my life with?

Light Spinner finally looked back at her and recognized —Even after all you told him, I was still going to leave, mostly because of how our relationship will affect the council’s sentence for you. But I did listen to those speeches during the ceremony, as you asked me to. All they said… I suppose Princess Adora taught me something too—. She sighed deeply, her veil fluttered for a moment, and her look softened. —I now understand why she spared me, and it would be all in vain if I abandoned you once again. So I’m choosing you like you chose me; I don’t know where we’ll live now, but I’ll remain by your side.

The women smiled at her and they only looked at each other for a moment, until a voice addressing them called their attention.

—I’m so glad to hear that— Adora said. She and Prince Catra approached them, walking side by side, each holding a tall cup with a golden rim. —I wanted to make sure what happened last night hadn’t affected either of you worse than anticipated— she admitted, looking away shyly. She looked back at Catra for a second and finally, added —And I’m happy that you attended our wedding.

—Wouldn’t miss it for the world— Light Spinner let out, obviously teasing.

—Don’t be so mean— the sorceress reprimanded her, lightheartedly.

—So your sense of humor remains untouched— Catra mocked her, smirking. —You’re a lucky woman having so many people who care about you; perhaps, if you can learn a thing or two, I might find you less despicable.

—How kind of you— the woman teased back.

Castaspella and Adora could only laugh at that, but before their amicable bickering could continue, colorful flashes drew their attention to the night sky. The light show had begun, and

suddenly the whole party fell quiet, even the entertainers halted their music to admire the silent concert of lights.

—Happy new year— Castaspella said.

—Happy new year— Princess Adora replied.

Chapter End Notes

I know
And yes, I *just* did that

Well, this will be all for the time being, I won't be posting in January so I can get enough done to begin posting in February. You can always go nag me all you want on Twitter, I have a tendency to spill the beans cause I get too excited about my writing, so…

HAPPY NEW YEAR, GUYS! THANK U FOR READING (^o^)/

Chapter 8: A New Year

A New Year

One year later…

Chapter 9: Day 1: Bright Moon

Chapter Notes

Well well

Doing more of this!

This year I'm struggling a bit to write, but hopefully I'll be able to post them all in time

Anyways, welcome to a new year!

P.s.: if you have read *Throw away The Mask*, there's a surprise for you here!! 😉

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 1

Bright Moon

Second year

It was midday when the young sorceress arrived at a cottage in the Whispering Woods and knocked a few times on the door before a seemingly tired Light Spinner opened the door for her.

—I would greet you properly, but we both know why I won't— the woman said. —What do you want, Es?— she grumpily asked.

Castaspella took a deep breath, eyes closed, and walked inside, asking —Do you remember today starts the End of the Year week?

—Of course.

—I know what you will say…— the sorceress began. —But I really want you to come this afternoon. Please…

—Do you, now?— Light Spinner asked, stepping into her personal space. She then took off her veil and asked —And why exactly should I go?

Right after, she wrapped an arm around Castaspella's waist and pulled her closer, which made the sorceress blush deeply.

Such a simple gesture unleashed a stream of memories: all the times Light Spinner had done the same, how she had quickly seduced her each time, and how much of a relief a simple kiss could be.

Now she wanted it.

—I-I… Well… I…— she tried to reply, but stammered as she was far too flustered. —Bea…

It was useless. She couldn't fight it.

With a sigh, Castaspella gave in and leant forward to kiss Light Spinner.

Question forgotten, the woman held the sorceress tightly and walked her to the sofa, never breaking the kiss. Both laid down and continued to kiss, hands roaming each other's bodies, hungry and desperate.

Oh, it was exactly as they remembered it. Exactly as it had always been.

The same strength, passion, desire, fierceness, along with just enough tenderness; the gentle, considerate little gestures that only expert lovers could have.

That only they could have for each other.

After a while, both were breathing heavily while resting in each other's arms.

—I miss you— Castaspella sighed, eyes shut.

Without hesitation, Light Spinner kissed her neck and muttered —I'm still not getting back with you, understood?

Of course…

How could she ever forget?

Sudden bitterness ate at the corners of their little bubble that had enveloped the women since the initial kiss, and just like that, they were back in reality.

Feeling defeated, the sorceress carefully unwrapped her arms from around the woman and sighed deeply. Light Spinner let her go and only watched as Castaspella tidied her clothes and approached the door.

—I still want you to go to the party, please— she insisted. —Will you?

—I shall see…

"For the sake of old times" she thought, but wouldn't dare say it. At least it wasn't a resounding "no", so she would have to take it.

Resigned, Castaspella left the place on her own; the woman was alone again. She touched her lips, still feeling the ghost of their kisses, and laid back on the couch, sighing and closing her eyes.

That sorceress… Her weak spot…

All the memories she so carefully avoided, all the passion she had kept sealed, it all had been set free with a simple touch.

Now Light Spinner was alone with those memories, and they kept demanding one thing: Castaspella.

Yes.

She wanted her again.

Perhaps, and only perhaps, she should go after all.

Later that day, back in Bright Moon, preparations for the party were in full swing. Once again, Castaspella was helping with them, giving orders left and right, while her brother, his wife, and his daughter, all got ready to welcome the guests soon.

—…No, no. Those go on the tables to the right— the sorceress indicated. Promptly, two servants left to change the wrongly-settled plates, and another pair replaced them showing her pieces of fabric. —Ah, right— she sighed, thoughtful. —Let's go with that one. Last year you used the other one, remember?— she decided, pointing at the light lilac piece. They immediately left and the sorceress took a deep breath before turning to address yet another person who approached her. —And what do you have- Oh! Delwyn, I'm so sorry— she let out, poorly disguising her surprise.

A tall man, with light-blue hair, deep fully-blue eyes, and white long marks under his eyes, stood in front of her with an attire that completely stood out among the people of Etheria.

—Yes, me. Who were you expecting?— he curiously asked, smiling amusedly.

—More servants with trivial questions about how to prepare a party that is not even my responsibility…— she honestly replied.

Surprised, he took a step forward and, with a gentler tone, told her —If you are *that* tired, why don't you take a break? I believe you've done more than enough already.

—I promised to help with this— she reminded him.

—*Help*, not *take charge*. Which you seem to have forgotten again— he insisted. —Wouldn't you say this place looks quite party-ish already?

—Barely…

Castaspella rested back against a wall and let out a deep sigh. Right on cue, he offered his hand for her to take and pulled her out to a balcony. Once there, they both took a deep breath and he rested his hands on the edge, looking out.

—Could you talk to her? Maybe do a bit *more* than just talk?

—Yes.

—What a tone. I understand it didn't go that well…

—Could have been better— she complained, resting her elbows on the edge next to him. —But I wasn't expecting a direct answer either. I'm not *that* naïve…

—You're not naïve at all, Casta— he immediately told her, looking back at the sorceress. But she wasn't listening to him; she just looked down to the kingdom extending under them and sighed. —Hey… You hear me?

He reached out and placed a hand on her arm which made her jump slightly as she was lost in memories.

—I would be lying if I said I don't miss her— she finally sighed. Her mind was filled with the images and sensations from earlier. She closed her eyes and pushed herself back a bit, taking a deep breath as her mind went over the memories. After a short moment, she added —Why am I even doing this?

—This conversation again?— he asked back, amused. —Should I fetch Arden?

—Of course not. Don't you dare— she retorted, squinting. —I just mean, in general…

—If you don't know the answer, Dear, don't expect *me* to know— he replied, shaking his head and looking down. —On another note…— he suddenly changed topics. —Shouldn't you get changed already?

—I-I plan on using this— she replied. —I don't think I can put on the outfit you gave me… — she admitted, smiling apologetically at him.

—I can always ask my daughter to help you. I know our clothes are a bit complicated for you, Etherians.

—It just has so many buttons, zips, and straps…

—Humor me, Casta. Let Namai help you— he pleaded, placing a hand on her arm. —Just for this week.

—Fine— she sighed. —I'll get her to help me— she accepted, moving back to return inside. —But I don't want to hear a word…

In reply, he grinned sheepishly and passed a pair of fingers over his lips, in a "lips sealed" gesture. But she knew it meant nothing and finally retired, shaking her head with a smile.

The party was well started, the Queen had given her speech, and everyone in Bright Moon gathered at the main hall in the palace. Light Spinner walked in with a serious expression, took a drink from a passing servant, and went straight to greet the royal family.

However, she was barely half-way through the hall when a voice stopped her.

—Nice of you to join us…

The woman immediately halted and turned around to face the sorceress she hadn't recognized.

It was undoubtedly Castaspella, but her clothes…

She wore a light-pink sleeveless shirt with a turtleneck, and a blue coat on top, attached with something similar to a belt that had some kind of clasp Light Spinner had never seen. The shirt was long enough to cover her hips but she could still see the shorts she wore, leaving her legs bare all the way down to her boots.

Stunning.

Weird choice for a party, but delightful to her eyes.

—Interesting choice of wardrobe— the woman finally let out, right before taking a long sip of her drink. —I didn't recognize you, Es. What… exactly are you wearing?

Light Spinner couldn't help but frown as she tried to figure out what the sorceress had put on, and Castaspella's expression little by little turned smugger as she noticed.

It wasn't her intention, but realizing the attire had her full attention, she decided to take the chance.

—Oh, this?— she began, moving closer. —Well, it may seem quite strange to you because it's a present I got from… *out of this world*. This is what our friends from Ak'kelon use for parties— she explained, purposely showing off her body. —What do you think, Bea?

—Ak'kelon?— she repeated. Completely ignoring the question, she asked —So you have, in fact, been going out with the ambassador of that planet? I had heard a few things, but wasn't sure.

—I don't know what you heard, but I rather you asked me whatever you want to know.

—And I just did.

—Yes— Castaspella sighed, rolling her eyes. —But, if what you said earlier today is true, I don't see why that would be of your interest— she added.

With an unamused expression, the sorceress got herself a cup from the closest tray moving around the party and took a sip, waiting for Light Spinner's reply. The woman, who had emptied her cup of wine, quickly exchanged it for a full one and drank half of it before even looking back at Castaspella.

—*Many* things are of my interest, woman. I thought you knew already— she finally reproached her.

—Oh, so now I should be aware of your every quirk…

—You hurt me— Light Spinner interrupted, mockingly exaggerating. —You mean you aren't?

—Beatrix…

—If that's how things are, Es, then never mind. I shall not take any more of your time— she sentenced, before taking another sip of wine. —I'll leave you alone and go greet your brother and his family, as I initially intended…

—Will you, now? What a coincidence!— she quickly responded, moving closer again. —It just so happens that I was on my way to find Micah.

—What a coincidence, indeed— Light Spinner let out between her teeth. —Then I presume you'll accompany me— she said, walking past her.

—You presume right— the sorceress replied, falling in step with her.

It didn't take long for them to find the royal family, and both were promptly invited to sit with them. However, that may have been a bad decision, seeing how the women seemed to be in some kind of cold war.

Conversations were kept civil through the whole dinner, but everyone noticed how Light Spinner's remarks always seemed to have some subtler comment addressing Castaspella who, in turn, wouldn't stop reproaching the woman.

But that wasn't all. The women were insatiable in terms of drinking, so it didn't take long for them to get drunk. *Very* drunk.

And, with that, all subtlety was dropped.

—So that's how you wanna do it, my little sorceress?— Light Spinner finally asked, after emptying her cup, somehow not dragging the words yet.

—You *lost* your right to call me yours— Castaspella immediately replied, struggling to keep her eyes open or maintain her speech tone.

—You said it yourself… you'll *always* be mine…

—I-I said that before you *ditched me*!— she complained, raising from her seat. —*Ya-ya* know!? I'm not… exposing my family to this anymore…— she added, starting to drag her speech a bit. —We'll… uh… continue this *canversation* somewhere *priveit*, Beatrix— she decided, messing up a few words.

Without waiting for a reply, she grabbed the woman by the arm and pulled her along, dragged her out of the hall, and practically pushed her into a spare room. Light Spinner didn't offer any resistance and barely faltered when being pushed inside.

—What, woman?

—You… are… uh… *nasty*— Castaspella began, stepping into her personal space, face just a breath away from her veil. —You can't just do this to me… It's… unfair…

—What, Es? What is so *unfair* to you?— she asked back, grabbing the sorceress' chin and pulling her a bit closer.

—*This*!

—You can always walk away…

—That's the problem! I don't want to!— she exclaimed, still speaking a bit dissonant but landing all words correctly.

—Then perhaps… you're in luck, my sorceress.

Her voice sounded low and husky, absolutely enticing for Castaspella, who felt her knees tremble and couldn't help but hold onto Light Spinner.

—*Wha'*… does that mean?

As a first answer to her weak tone, the woman took off her veil and leant forward just enough for their lips to brush.

—That you get to have *fun* tonight… If you want it.

And Castaspella's reply, was immediately closing the distance to finally kiss her.

Oh, the spark of passion that quickly burnt wild like a raging fire…

The touches, far hungrier than earlier, and the kisses, deep enough to leave them breathless.

They felt like floating and didn't even register when their clothes ended up on the floor or when they reached the soft bed that sank under their weight.

Castaspella didn't have to think to turn off the lights with a little spell, still used to doing so despite the months they had been separated, and only the moonlight leaking through the windows illuminated their naked silhouettes.

The lovers were, once again, quenching their thirst for each other's bodies, entirely forgetting their past fights, the words said when they broke up, and what was supposed to be the end of their relationship.

Their passion was just too strong, even for them.

Chapter End Notes

Oh right

For a visual of Casta's Ak’kelon attire:



Chapter 10: Day 2: Dryl

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Day 2

Dryl

Second year

The smell of hot coffee woke up Light Spinner early in the morning. Her body felt a bit sore but she couldn't help smiling as soon as she recalled what had happened the previous night.

A part of her, possessive and passionate, would always feel delighted realizing it was as if Castaspella's body was *made* for her. But then there was the part of her who decided to leave the sorceress, a more calculating and somewhat considerate part that reminded her they couldn't, *shouldn't*, be together.

And yet, before she could get up and leave, before she could even notice *where* Castaspella was, a tray was set down on the bed in front of her.

She had brought breakfast for them *both*.

Now what?

She needed breakfast, but this was…

—Good morning, Love— Castaspella said, planting a kiss on her temple.

Exactly that.

The woman was frozen in place, unable to decide what part of her she should listen to.

Oh, it would be such a shame to waste the delicious breakfast the sorceress brought her… But she didn't want to give her the wrong idea.

Ugh… Never mind that.

What harm could it do to just enjoy this for a while? She simply had to make it clear as soon as it was over.

Just like the day before…

And like every other time they would end up entangled in something remotely romantic.

—Tell me you didn't prepare this yourself— Light Spinner finally said.

—Oh, no, no— the sorceress replied, gesturing dismissively with a hand as she sat down on the bed next to her. —I'm practically banned from the kitchen here; the cooks don't like it

when I overtake cooking— she explained, giggling.

Well, that only made things more difficult for Light Spinner. She adored that laugh of hers, and being reminded of how skilled she can be…

Damned be her. She missed her too much.

—Better…— the woman let out before stuffing her mouth with a pastry.

—Careful there— the sorceress laughed. —I promise no one will steal your food.

But she had to keep her mouth shut; she couldn't allow herself to voice her thoughts, no matter how much she wanted to tell Castaspella what she felt.

Nope.

It had been decided that she *wouldn't* let her know. It was better to make her think it was all mere lust. That it had always been…

The breakfast went by mostly silent, and once the coffee and pastries were all gone, the sorceress, who was the only one dressed, picked up the tray to take it back to the kitchen. But Light Spinner called out to her before she could open the door.

—You do know this… doesn't mean we're back together, right?

Of course.

Of course she knew.

But she hoped the woman wouldn't mention it.

Ugh, knowing her, she should have expected it…

—Yes, I know— she sighed, looking down, voice noticeably bitter.

Immediately, she opened the door and left before Light Spinner could add anything else.

That morning, while the decorations of the party in Bright Moon were being taken down, some of the guests who had stayed in the spare rooms could be seen walking around the palace. The Queen had offered them to stay until the party in Dryl, and even invited them to have lunch together.

Meanwhile, princess Glimmer had gathered the kids that stayed the night and, with her friends, organized some games in the gardens to pass the time until the food was ready. Their parents had gathered around and watched with amusement as they tried to catch each other, "marking" whoever was caught, which meant they now had to catch someone else.

—Come here!

—Can’t catch me!

—Over here, turtle!

The kids kept yelling taunts and laughing loudly while running around the yard with the Best Friends Squad. It was evident that both Adora and Catra were holding back, while Glimmer decided not to use her powers, and Bow, perhaps too lenient, let them catch him easily.

Castaspella watched with a smile as her sight followed a pair of siblings who kept running together: both with blue and red hair, mismatched eyes of those same colors, and clothes that looked *just* like what she wore for the party. The girl, Namai, who had helped her dress up the previous day, and her brother, Kharyn, a boy almost as nimble as prince Catra.

Seemingly out of nowhere, Delwyn appeared on Castaspella’s left, slightly startling her.

—Oh, my! Delwyn. Don’t jump on me like that— she laughed.

—I merely walked— he replied, a bit mockingly. —I see my children are having fun.

—They certainly are— the sorceress agreed. —Although they seem a bit… wary still. Look how they stay together at all times…

—Can you blame them? Etheria is full of wonders, some of them dangerous. And they came specifically for this party week. They don’t know the place— he reminded her.

—I *told you* to bring them before so you could show them around. Did I not?— Castaspella reproached him.

—Yes, perhaps I should have… but they don’t really like leaving home, you know?

—It’s… understandable, of course.

—Help!

A sudden cry interrupted their conversation and everyone looked back to see that one of the kids, Kharyn, had tripped and fallen over the edge of the short walls surrounding the gardens.

—Oh, no! Wait!— Glimmer exclaimed, before teleporting away and quickly returning with Kharyn. —Here…

Everything happened so fast…

Standing nearby, a baffled Light Spinner just observed as the boy ran to his father, while Glimmer supported herself on her knees, exhausted. The woman’s hands were still in a position that would have cast a sigil, if her powers weren’t blocked.

Frustrated, the woman couldn’t help but approach Adora, who was far too concerned for Glimmer to notice her at first, and called her attention by saying —You, Princess! This is your fault!

—What!?

Ignoring Catra's indignant cry, the woman blurted out —I could have saved that kid! Your friend wouldn't now be on the brink of passing out! You did this to me!

Light Spinner wasn't even thinking. She was *reacting*.

Her furious exclamations caught everyone's attention, but Adora stopped anyone feinting at interfering with a look. She even held back Catra next to her. The only one she didn't stop, was Castaspella, who carefully approached from behind Light Spinner.

No one comprehended Adora's decision, but she didn't care. She understood the woman's pain, having realized how power meant everything to her to the point of insanity. And the only person she knew would be safe from her brewing madness, was the sorceress now holding her shoulders.

—Bea… please— Castaspella called her, with a soft voice. While the girls left to help Glimmer, she handled Light Spinner, speaking gently and calmly. —You *need* to understand that, sometimes, you should let others handle things. Glimmer did it perfectly. Her power was the most appropriate for this.

—But it *drained her*. She didn't have to! I could have…

—No, no. Listen, please— the sorceress insisted, cupping her face. —You didn't need to handle this. Glimmer did a good job and would have instinctively done the same even if you could cast that spell.

—I don't care— the woman sentenced. —I was *useless*. I can no longer do one of the only things I could… do for you and your family— she argued, frowning angrily. She then grabbed Castaspella's hands and removed them from her face. —Stop trying, Es.

And with that, she left the gardens.

By the time Light Spinner finally calmed down enough to rejoin the festivities, the party in Dryl had begun. She arrived when the servant bots were in the middle of getting more food from the kitchens, meaning there was nothing left to eat or drink.

Oh, she was so ready to find that princess and complain…

But someone stood in her way and bowed deeply for a moment, leaving her speechless.

—Good evening, Light Spinner— he said.

—Ah… You're that ambassador— she noted, trying to hide her surprise.

—My name is Delwyn Zhaleh and, as you said, I'm an ambassador, yes. From…

—I know where you're from— the woman interrupted him. However, he didn't drop his cordial expression and politeness. —You're the one who's been… going out with Castaspella, no? The clothes she wore yesterday… she said they are from your planet.

—Ah, yes. That's correct— he admitted, smiling shyly and looking down into his glass. —But, um… I wanted to… Ahem… thank you— he finally said. —I heard what you said, about wanting to save my son this morning, and I… appreciate the gesture.

—I don't need your pity, Ambassador…— she promptly replied, gesturing dismissively with her hand. Much to her fortune, a servant robot passed next to her that same moment, carrying cups of wine. She grabbed a tiny cup, almost growling under her breath, but controlled herself and only told Delwyn —If there's anything you would like to say, go ahead and say it.

Right. He had another reason to have approached her.

But he wasn't confident enough and had tried to delay the matter.

Except the woman wouldn't allow it.

—Alright, alright— he sighed. —I don't… mean to pry or anything… But I wanted to ask you: why did you break up with Castaspella?

Light Spinner didn't look at him as she was carefully drinking, holding her veil over the cup, and only when she was done did she finally look back.

There was some… emotion in her eyes that Delwyn couldn't decipher.

—Now, now… I wonder what your interest in the matter is— she let out, with a chilling tone. —Unless, perhaps, she sent you to ask…

—I was under the impression she knew…— he admitted. —I always thought it was a matter of her not wanting to speak about it.

Well, that wasn't far from the truth. Most likely, even if Castaspella knew, she wouldn't say it. And, normally, Light Spinner wouldn't say it either.

But this shyness he showed was so unexpected… It gave the woman the sensation he genuinely wanted to know. Out of concern? Or some kind of confusion he couldn't help but try to figure out…

In any case, something took over her and she decided it was better to tell him than let his imagination run wild.

—Well. If you have such a pressing need to know— Light Spinner began. —Truth is, after a few months, she began… talking about *marriage*. More and more as time passed by— she explained. —After half a year, I couldn't take it anymore and decided it was better to simply end our relationship, seeing how we had *very* different views on the matter.

—But…

—Good evening, esteemed guests!

Right as Delwyn was about to ask why she had taken such a drastic decision, princess Entrapta appeared to personally check on them as she liked doing with all her guests.

—Good evening— Delwyn replied, bowing respectfully.

—Evening— Light Spinner let out, remembering how she had gotten angry before about the size of the cup. However, realizing now how silly that was, she refrained from saying anything about the matter. Instead, she recalled the previous year and told the princess —Thank you for hosting.

—My pleasure!— Entrapta cheerfully thanked them. —I hope you're enjoying yourselves— she added, before looking down at her tablet. —My statistics say at least eighty percent of the guests will enjoy this party…

—I'm sure everyone will, Princess— Delwyn affirmed.

—That would be an unexpected outcome but great news!

—Please do enjoy yourself too, Princess— he added, smiling.

—Oh, I am! Thank you for replying to my satisfaction question! Goodbye!

And with that, she left.

—That was interesting— Light Spinner commented. She then closed her eyes and took a deep breath. —If you don't mind, I would like to speak with some more acquaintances of mine. Excuse me.

As a silent reply, Delwyn simply bowed respectfully and each went their way.

—Oh! Light Spinner!— Micah exclaimed when she found him and his wife. —I'm quite surprised to find you here, I won't lie. A-after what happened earlier…

—Please, that was a simple fit of rage. Nothing to be petty about— she replied, dismissively, drinking yet another tiny cup.

—That's quite right— Angella commented, surprised to hear *her*, of all people, saying that. —And we saw you speaking with Ambassador Zhaleh just a moment ago.

—Ah yes… But why are you surprised?— the woman asked, raising a brow. —As it was his kid whom I intended to save, he wanted to thank me.

—Ah, of course— the Queen let out, shaking her head and ignoring her question.

However, the King didn't ignore it and casually replied —Well, it's quite surprising because we didn't think you'd be on such friendly terms with Castaspella's boyfriend.

Boyfriend.

Light Spinner's expression, even with her veil, was of such utter shock that the Queen almost choked on her drink.

—You didn't know? Didn't any of them tell you!?— Angella asked, in disbelief.

—I knew they were… going out together, which is *not* the same as being actual partners. And *that* I didn't know at all…

Her composure was impeccable. If they didn't know her, they would have thought she was honestly unfazed. But they were familiar enough with her.

—You…

—Never mind that. It is certainly not my business…— Light Spinner finally said, pretending disinterest. —Now, if you excuse me. I am quite tired, so I will retire— she lied, taking advantage of the fact they didn't know she had *just* arrived. —Please send my regards to your daughter— she farewelled.

She was, most certainly, not unaffected.

Angella and Micah exchanged a concerned glance and silently agreed not to meddle. After all, perhaps *they* had been wrong to use such a term if neither Castaspella nor Delwyn had mentioned it.

And speaking of the couple, Delwyn had quickly found the sorceress and both were talking by the food tables. Next to them, Kharyn and Namai were eating a lot of tiny appetizers while they had a serious conversation.

—I mean it, Casta. Just be *honest* with yourself!

—I am… And I think it's a mistake to go after someone who doesn't want to be with me— she argued. —At least *you* are interested in having a good relationship with me.

—But we both know, you may like me, but you *love her*— he insisted, taking her hands. —And from what I spoke with her, it's evident she still loves you too! So-something is stopping her, but she's… How to say it? She's cold and mean to everyone *except* you. And she listens to no one other than you! It's like she doesn't consider anyone to be worthy of her time and respect, *except for you*!

Yes… She already knew that.

The sorceress closed her eyes and took a deep breath, holding back his hands.

—But that may be part of the problem. It may not be love what she feels for me…

—What else would it be?

—Perhaps she's just interested in certain aspects of me since back in Mystacor, when I helped her with that cursed project that doomed her— Castaspella speculated. —Or maybe she found me useful, and now that I'm not…

—Nonsense— he interrupted. —I told you. My spouse was a lot like her. I know that personality. She's an unmovable rock only you have any kind of influence over. And that's because she gave you that power over her. *She*, who loathes weakness, allows herself to be vulnerable in front of you and only you.

And again, Castaspella already knew that; he was right.

However, before the sorceress could say anything, Namai called her father's attention from behind and shyly asked —Are you… talking about theyi?

Delwyn's expression immediately softened and he caressed her cheek while saying —Yes, dear. That's how theyi was, remember? Only let *us* see their true feelings, because they loved us very much.

—Yeah…— she sighed. The girl let out half a smile and hugged her father, whispering —Don't worry, they are always with us, dad.

Once Namai let go and returned with her brother, Delwyn turned back to look at Castaspella, a bit flustered.

—That was…

—Very adorable of you both— the sorceress interrupted.

—Right— he laughed, awkwardly scratching the back of his neck. —Sorry for the interruption.

—It's alright… Um, may I ask: is "Theyi" the name of your spouse? I-I never asked because I didn't want to pry…

—Oh, no, right. I don't know why I never mentioned it— he interrupted, noticing she was also getting a bit awkward. —No, that's what the kids called them. Their name was Amari'Ahmar, which, ironically enough, means "Immortal red".

—Oh, I see.

—Now!— Delwyn quickly said, keeping the sorceress from speaking further. —Let's not digress. Please: go after her.

—But…

—Casta, I told you plenty of times I just want you to be happy! And it's clear to me *she* is your happiness!

—I…— she tried to argue, but gave up. With a sigh, she looked up at him and nodded. —I should… go then.

—Good. Allow me to accompany you.

—Of course.

Being almost midnight, the sorceress and the ambassador walked side by side, saying their farewells as they approached the exit of the hall, and parted ways shortly after.

Delwyn took a moment and stood there with his kids, watching as the sorceress went into the Woods with a certain spring in her step.

Chapter End Notes

So, a note: “theyi” is like “mommy” or “daddy” but gender-neutral (as, according to my research, many parents just invent a term for themselves). I wrecked my brain coming up with that (._.)

Anyways: if you have read *Throw away The Mask*, now you have a new bit of lore about Delwyn XD

Chapter 11: Day 3: Dark Edge

Chapter Notes

I apologize, I've started posting one day earlier, so this is actually today's (27th) chapter...
Day 4 shall be posted tomorrow...

Day 3

Dark Edge

Second year

It was well past midnight when Castaspella arrived at Light Spinner's cottage. She had walked all the way there telling herself this was the right choice, that it was what she wanted so she had to be brave and do it, yet when she was at the door, she couldn't help but hesitate.

—I can do it… I should do it…— she let out, before taking a deep breath with her eyes closed. —Yes.

Feeling suddenly emboldened, the sorceress knocked on the door several times, and impatiently waited for Light Spinner to open.

But when she finally did, it was evident that she was *very* drunk.

—What?

—Bea, I…

—Never mind… shut up and come in— the woman grumpily said, dragging the words a little. —Forget why you're here… Just do whatever but don't annoy me— she uttered.

—I- A-alright— Castaspella stammered, and went to sit down on the couch. —Can… we talk?— she then asked, after a short, awkward silence.

Light Spinner only poured herself another glass of wine and, silent, went to sit next to the sorceress. At first, she said nothing, only drank carelessly, veil off, and leant back.

—And what should we… talk about?— she finally asked. —Oh, wait… I know. Why don't you… tell me why you hadn't mentioned that-that ambassador is your *boyfriend*?

Her bitter tone evidenced her annoyance, and her expression showed the feeling of betrayal Light Spinner had tried to hide earlier.

—It's not what you think— Castaspella replied, looking down, slightly ashamed. —If you allow me, I can explain.

—Explain away— she told her, knocking back her glass.

—Alright— she sighed. —After we… broke up, I was… a *wreck*. I fortunately had Micah to look after me, but I sincerely thought I wasn't… worth caring for, you know?— she began.

—Then a few months ago, I met Delwyn by chance, started talking, and before we realized, we had told our personal stories to each other.

—You always trusted easily…

—Not really— Castaspella corrected her, looking away. —I tend to give that impression but… I usually can't. I'm friendly but remain wary, Bea. I wasn't just wary of you back in Mystacor when, you know, I graduated and all. I was wary of everyone, but with you it was more evident because I could hardly be friendly to you— she explained, smiling fondly. —But you being so honest is what allowed me to trust you with more ease, and… I suppose with Delwyn it was because he's a good listener and very empathetic.

—How charming…

—Look…— the sorceress sighed, looking back at Light Spinner. —No one outside my family had cared for me in the slightest since you left me. He was the first one to actually listen and show concern. And I couldn't help but care about him too after hearing what he went through! I just…

—Fell in love *with'im*?

—No— Castaspella immediately replied, looking down again. —There's something we both agree on: we *like* each other but we don't… *love* each other. We want the other to be happy, we care about the other, but it's more like a friendship. Like it was with Arden— she clarified.

—But this time, your… relationship wasn't *fake*— Light Spinner complained.

—No. That much is true… We thought having a relationship would help us get over our grief, but it only made us realize just how much we… love the one we lost. We simply *can't* get over it— Castaspella admitted. —*I can't get over you*.

—And that's why you're here? To, what? Revive the relationship I ended?— the woman asked, dragging the words a bit more than before and leaning forward, closer to the sorceress. —What do you want from me, Es?

—I just want you— she replied, placing a hand on Light Spinner's cheek. —I *need* you, but I won't force it. I want you to love me freely like before.

—Like when we would sneak through the corridors on that floating island to make out? Like when we worked on my… project only to end up having sex whenever we made a breakthrough?— the woman asked, smirking smugly but looking sleepy from the drunkenness.

—I suppose— Castaspella replied, caressing her cheek tenderly as she recalled those moments. —Did you love me? Or was it just lust and the thrill of a secret relationship?

—Don't be stupid, Es… I wouldn't… play with you in any way— Light Spinner admitted, interrupted by a yawn. —But what future do you expect to have… with someone like me?

There's *nothing* for you…

—I don't care about that. All I want for my future is to spend it with you— Castaspella confidently answered. —What do *you* want, Bea?

—I want my powers back. I want *not* to live the rest of my life like a mediocre, powerless, former sorceress.

—But what do you want for the future?

—I…— she began, but yawned again. —I don't know. I don't have a future, Es.

—Bea…

Light Spinner tried to say something more, but her voice was unintelligible as she began falling asleep. Castaspella still had her hand cupping her cheek when her eyes fluttered shut, and she couldn't help but let out a smile.

What a woman…

Early in the morning, the smell of breakfast woke up Light Spinner, and she promptly tried to get up when she recalled the previous night. However, a splitting headache stopped her and she groaned angrily.

It was one of those moments when she would kill to have her magic back… But it wouldn't happen any time soon. So she only waited a moment for her headache to calm down and finally left the room.

Having smelled the breakfast, she was hardly surprised to find Castaspella in the house, but realizing the sorceress had slept on the couch greatly shocked her. Her blue coat and the black harness that attached it were lying there, so all Castaspella was wearing was the pink shirt and shorts.

It was *quite* the view.

—Good morning— Light Spinner let out. —Did you carry me to my bed?

—I did— the sorceress replied, without looking back until breakfast was ready. —And now, I believe you need to eat something. Your head must hurt a lot— she commented, placing everything on the table. —Come…

And she was right.

With some food and tea on her stomach, the headache slowly receded, and she couldn't help but think that Castaspella must have enchanted it to help ease the pain. However, she didn't comment on it.

The women spent all morning there, talking and keeping each other company, until it was time for the party in Dark Edge.

Although they arrived together, it wasn't long before they had to separate, as they had been placed at different tables this time.

—So? Did it go well?— Delwyn asked, as soon as Castaspella sat next to him.

—Good afternoon to you too— she replied, mockingly. —But yes, you could say so… at least we spoke.

—And!?

—And she thinks I have no future with her…

—Oh. Wow. She's…

—Really complicated, I know— Castaspella interrupted.

And before she could continue, the Queens of Dark Edge entered the hall, silencing everyone.

This year, the welcome speech was given by both of them *and* Scorpia, and everyone listened carefully. The party, once again, had been prepared by the princesses' joint efforts, and the food enticed everyone.

For a while, Castaspella and Delwyn ate in silence, not even listening to the discussions other sorcerers were having. Only by the time the desserts arrived, did their conversation restart.

—Casta?— he called. She hummed questioningly, but kept eating, so he continued —Can I ask you what you plan on doing now?

Confused, Castaspella looked back at Delwyn and, raising a brow, asked —As in?

—About… you know… *her*.

Right.

What did she plan?

She hadn't thought about it at all; she had no idea.

And since Light Spinner asked her, her only certainty was that she wanted to be with her.

But plans?

—I don't know… I don't- I have no idea where we stand, what our boundaries are… We spoke about it but she was too drunk, I think. So I just… don't know— the sorceress replied, looking down at her food.

—Oh, don't know what?— the councilor next to her asked.

For a second, Castaspella was speechless, triggered by the realization she was being heard, and only then did she pay attention to the rest of the table. *Everyone* was looking at her now.

—I-I… was just talking about, you know… the-the tutoring and such…— she stammered, desperately looking at Arden, who quickly caught on.

—Right. I remember you were talking about it the other day— they interrupted. —It's difficult to decide, I suppose.

—Do you have any particular plans, Castaspella?— Norwyn decided to ask, curious. —Perhaps there's a position in the council that might interest you?— he then suggested. —Or maybe your ambition is to become Head Sorceress?— he added, more as a joke as he merrily laughed.

—Oh, no, no. I- Being honest, I don't… have… any specific ideas yet— she admitted, trying to disguise her nervousness with a smile. —But I suppose I still have plenty of time to decide, don't I?— she added. Before anyone could reply, she stood up from her chair and excused herself. —If you don't mind, I'll go for some fresh air now.

—Careful out there!— Arden reminded her.

—Don't worry, I won't make your mistakes— she laughed, and finally walked away.

However, the calmer she seemed, the more it worried both Delwyn and Arden, who decided to leave the table too.

At first, Delwyn intended to go after Castaspella, but after she left Horror Hall, he lost her. Giving up, he preferred to go find Arden instead, and it turned out they were near the entrance, talking to none other than Light Spinner.

—Then *what* is going on with her!?— they asked, exasperated. —I saw you two arrive together. What did you tell her!?

—Absolutely nothing— the woman sentenced, squinting. —I swear, I did nothing this time.

—Maybe that is exactly the problem— Delwyn interrupted, inserting himself in the conversation. —Other than her family, Casta has little to no contention, and she feels like a burden to them. Losing you has affected her more than you can imagine, and…

—And what?— she cut in. —She told me just last night how *you* care so much for her.

—It's not the same, Light Spinner.

—Then what, pray tell, is the difference, Ambassador?— she asked, folding her arms.

—Castaspella and I care for each other greatly, but our relationship never worked— he began. —It may not have been like her marriage to Arden here— he continued, gesturing at them. —But you must understand: she loves *you and only you*— he concluded.

—And you?

—I have to admit… I am eternally in love with my late spouse. There is no one for whom I'll ever feel the same way. They remain my only love, like *you* remain Casta's…

—Nonsense— she uttered, looking away.

—Please, trust us, Light Spinner. She's completely devoted to you— Arden insisted. —Did you know she teaches her students about you? That she uses your techniques for many sigils? Or that she still refers to you as the best tutor Mystacor has ever had?— they told her. —What's more: she defends you whenever someone speaks ill of you; without hesitation or fear of the consequences.

—I insist. You're her everything— Delwyn sentenced.

And that much she knew. Which was exactly the problem.

Because Castaspella was her everything too, she was far too afraid of ruining her.

Chapter 12: Day 4: Plumeria

Chapter Notes

I apologize in advance: this chapter is rather short...
But well, I came to the beach to visit my BFF and had to rush a tiny bit. I promise I will compensate it!!

Now I hope you enjoy!

Day 4

Plumeria

Second year

—So you didn't check on her last night?

—I told you she needed it!

—And I told you it would give her the wrong message— Light Spinner sentenced, trying to put a stop to Delwyn and Arden's scolding.

The three had arrived at Plumeria's party a bit earlier in the afternoon, and now pretended to be listening to Perfuma's speech while, instead, discussing Castaspella once again.

—Please, we're begging you. You *do* care for her but she needs you to *show it*!

—But *I* don't want to deal with the implications. She doesn't need the false hope— Light Spinner argued.

—I sincerely don't understand you— Delwyn finally admitted.

—Lately, neither do I— Arden agreed. —Whatever happened since last year?

—None of your business— the woman replied, looking around for someone handing aperitifs. —I need a drink now…

Meanwhile, not so far from them, Castaspella was carefully listening to princess Perfuma, in the company of her family. It amused her that Glimmer was extremely excited and, as soon as the speech was over, she rushed to find her friends, leaving her parents and Castaspella alone.

—She's full of energy— Angella laughed.

—Indeed. But it's so good to see her with her friends— Castaspella commented. —She really enjoys their company, you can see it in her expression.

—That's right— the Queen admitted. —And talking about enjoying their company…— she then added, pointing to where Light Spinner, Delwyn, and Arden were standing.

—Ah, right— Micah noticed. —I meant to ask you before, Sis. How is your relationship with Arden now? Because they seem really friendly with both Light Spinner *and* your boyfriend.

—Oh, I'm more interested in how well she and Ambassador Zhaleh get along— Angella admitted. —How can it be? One would think they would be at each other's throats for you— she added, barely holding back a laugh.

—For starters, Arden and I remain friends. Not much has changed— Castaspella began, sighing in annoyance. —And about why Bea and Delwyn get along, I simply have no idea. I didn't even introduce them, they met on their own— she continued. —But… well, I think it's a good thing. This curious friendship, if it can be called so, is much better than animosity of any kind, wouldn't you say?

—Yes, I suppose. But it only makes me more curious— Angella insisted.

And, in fact, it was also making Castaspella *very* curious.

Perhaps she could, just for a moment, take a closer look.

—If you excuse me…

Sitting alone around a bonfire that had just been lit, the ambassador, the sorcerer, and the woman kept talking about Castaspella, sure they were far away from other guests and wouldn't be heard.

—…That's as much as I know— Delwyn was saying. —And it seems to me that not even Casta knows why you left her.

—I don't understand it. Unless you were having issues in private that none of us could see, it was very sudden!— Arden exclaimed. —So why!?

Fed up, Light Spinner emptied her glass and asked —You two won't leave me alone until I tell you, will you?

—Definitely not— they instantly replied.

—It would clarify a lot for us. We just want to know your side of the story— Delwyn explained, being more diplomatic.

—Alright then— she finally agreed. —It was actually very simple: Es began talking about marriage. After a few months, I saw no other choice but to end our relationship.

—What!?— the both of them exclaimed.

—You can't be serious!— Arden indignantly said.

—You had… mentioned that to me before, but I couldn't believe it. That was your- That's *really* why you left her? But… why? Wouldn't you ever marry Casta?— Delwyn asked, more confused.

—No. Never.

Never.

The word resonated on the sorceress' ears, making her almost drop the cloaking spell covering her. It was too hard to bear, she wanted to cry right that moment, but she wouldn't want anyone to see. She had to quickly leave and find a place secluded enough to cry alone.

Meanwhile, the shocked ambassador exchanged a glance with the magician, who was just as stunned as him, then stared at Light Spinner.

—Why!?

—Normally I would tell you two to mind your own business, in a nastier way that is, but I'll make an exception just this time— the woman began. —It isn't a decision I made lightly. I have my reasons. And if you two *really* care for her, then you will surely understand— she commented. —Es gave up everything she had, *just for me*. During this year she barely managed to earn back a few of her permissions in Mystacor, as you well know, Arden. There are beginners with far more privileges than her!— she angrily explained. However, she suddenly hesitated and her anger was replaced by indignation, or perhaps *pain*. —If I were to marry her, she may even be banished from Mystacor too! I can't do that to her! I won't take this from her after all the efforts she has made! She has given that kingdom her whole life, and I've taken enough from her already! I will *not* ruin her life! I have *nothing* to offer that can possibly be worth as much!

If they didn't know better, they would think she was angry, utterly furious, but both of them had a keen eye and noticed it was a mix of fear, sorrow, and self-hatred.

—That's not true— Delwyn boldly said. —For her, your love is worth more than anything in this world.

—She would marry you in a heartbeat, without hesitation— Arden assured her. —Although she cares for the kingdom, she wouldn't let anything or anyone take you from her again— they insisted.

—And that may be one of the problems…— Light Spinner sighed. She looked down at her hands, irritated, and let out —I should have left the day my powers were sealed.

—And don't you think she would have gone after you?

—I know for a fact she would— Arden commented, looking away with a smirk.

—With how stubborn she is, of course she would! Which is exactly why it could only be *me* leaving *her*! She should focus on herself, her sorcery, growing within Mystacor's ranks…

—She doesn't want that!— the magician interrupted. —She doesn't want any future, anywhere, without *you*!

—I can confirm as much, and… I understand the feeling. Trust me: it won't "pass", she will always feel like that— Delwyn assured her.

Losing their patience, Arden shook their head and explained —Listen: back when we pretended to be a couple, Casta would spend half of her time just looking for you. It eventually became more dangerous so it was also more difficult for her, but I swear, all those years, what we talked about the most, was you! Where you could be, what you could be doing, who could help her find you…

—That is what I mean when I say I will ruin her life! She risks far too much for me!— Light Spinner insisted, increasingly desperate. —Why can't you see it? You should be keeping her away from me! Safe! Not helping her get me back!

—Excuse me, but what we can see is that you *both* still love each other, and if Casta would rather throw away her life for you, then that's *her* choice and she knows what she's doing— Delwyn argued.

That much was true. She would do the same after all…

Resigned, Light Spinner took a deep breath and exhaled slowly.

—I sure hope you're right, *pretty boy*…

Chapter 13: Day 5: Salineas

Chapter Notes

So... we lost internet today. My apologies but I couldn't post earlier... I'm actually doing this from the phone rn because wifi is still not working...

Anyways, hopefully this is well edited heh
Please enjoy!

Day 5

Salineas

Second year

A new party was just beginning. All the princesses, save for Mermista, had gathered to talk before it was time for the welcome speech, and Perfuma was at the center of the conversation.

—Do you think I did something wrong? Ma-maybe I should have checked on my guests earlier…

—I don't think you were the issue— Scorpia promptly replied. —Right, guys?

The Scorpioni princess looked at the others with a hopeful expression and was met with enthusiastic nodding.

—Right, right. It must have been something personal— Adora agreed.

Right after, Entrapta took out her tablet and read —My calculations indicate it's highly unlikely that anything under your control upset the sorceress.

—Wha-what does it mean?— Perfuma asked, almost sobbing.

—That it was *definitely* something at the party what caused her to leave, but nothing you could have prevented— she clarified.

—Why do I have the impression we know *who* upset her?— Catra asked, folding her arms.

—It can't always be her fault…— Adora replied, understanding what she meant.

—If you're talking about Light Spinner…— Glimmer interrupted, finally speaking since they gathered. —I think she may be related, but I don't know how.

—Is that why you've been all serious, Sparkles?— prince Catra asked.

—I'm just… thinking— she began. —Auntie left the party early, mom and dad didn't see her leave, and Light Spinner was just talking with the ambassador and Arden! I also think she's to blame, but I don't know how!

—What else do you know?

—She slept at the palace, in one of the spare rooms, alone. And didn't get up for breakfast. Actually, she didn't leave the room all morning! Only left it when it was time for the party—

Glimmer elaborated.

—I still think it would be appropriate to give her an apology and check on her— Frosta insisted, arms crossed in front of her chest. —She was your guest and left the party early; making sure our guests enjoy their time is *our* responsibility.

—Princess, you can't control everything that happens at a party— Catra argued.

—But you must try, *Prince*— she boldly replied.

—I do want to check on her— Perfuma admitted, looking down and brushing a lock of hair back behind her ear. —At least to know if she's alright, we could… talk to her, right?

—You can always try, but… I think it will be difficult to get her to be truthful— Glimmer commented. —I think we should let my parents talk with her instead. But we could talk with Arden and Delwyn! Maybe they'll know something— she suggested.

—Oh, wait! Here's an idea— Adora suddenly said. —Why don't we go talk with them both *and* with Light Spinner? We can divide in groups, ask them about Castaspella, and then we'll discuss it here again.

—Sounds like a reasonable plan— Entrapta agreed with a bright smile.

—I suppose it wouldn't hurt…— Catra agreed too.

The rest of the princesses nodded at her and, with a much calmer Perfuma, they decided who would speak with who. They would wait for Mermista's speech to be done and then divide in groups to interrogate each of them: Perfuma, Scorpia, and Entrapta would go to speak with Delwyn; Glimmer, and Mermista, with Arden; Frosta, Adora and Catra, with Light Spinner.

Having grabbed some food, the Queen and King of Bright Moon sat at a table with Castaspella. The three of them began eating in silence, clearly hungry, and only after a while, did the King speak up.

—What's been bothering you, Sis? You can tell us— he gently told her, concerned about her expression.

As if to reassure her, the Queen added —Absolutely. We won't tell a soul.

—I don't know…— the sorceress said, looking away.

—Trust us— Angella insisted, calling her attention back to them.

—Alright— she sighed. —I just- It's about Beatrix… I overheard her talking with Arden and Delwyn… about why she broke up with me.

—And!?

—Apparently it was because I was talking about marriage? A-and she said she would… *never* marry me. Just…— she replied, indignant at first. Then, almost sobbing, she let out —What did I do wrong!? How did I lose her!?

—No, no, no. It wasn't your fault. This is on her— Angella quickly replied.

—It was a decision *she* took, Sis. You didn't do anything— Micah seconded her.

—But why would she feel like this!? Why is she so… so- I don't know how to say it, but the way she said it… Her decision is *final*! And-and she didn't even tell me anything, she just ended the relationship!

—Maybe that was just an excuse…— the King suggested, innocently.

—So she wanted to leave me for *other* reasons!?

Her distressed response made it clear he had made a mistake, so he quickly tried to fix it, stammering —I-I mean… It sounds a bit suspicious! Why wouldn't she speak with you about it?

—So I *did* do something wrong!

—No, no! Wait!

But the sorceress had gotten up and was leaving the room.

—Casta!— the Queen called out, but only saw her walk out. —Seriously, Micah…

—I'm sorry. I didn't mean it that way…— he apologized, leaning back on his chair.

—I know…

—Is everyone back?— Glimmer asked, as the princesses gathered again. —Oh, great! We'll start!— she excitedly sentenced. —Here's the scoop: the other day, in Dark Edge, the sorcerers at the table gave her quite the hard time asking about, well, what she plans and all, and Auntie got really nervous. So she's probably been upset since then— she told them. —*And*, that's when both Arden and Delwyn began talking with Light Spinner about Auntie.

—In short, the magician has no idea what has been happening to her, but they also think it's related to that woman.

—Oh, makes sense— Perfuma replied. —The ambassador hinted at the same. That their reunion may have reopened old wounds and, perhaps that accumulated since that… uh… *loud* discussion they had in Bright Moon?— she told them. —And then at my party she couldn't take it anymore.

—My observations on interpersonal behaviour indicate that your aunt is going through grief for the relationship Light Spinner terminated— Entrapta said, looking at Glimmer. —It's an

expected reaction that normally wouldn't be concerning…— she continued. However, she then hesitated and pressed her tablet against her body as she concluded —But I understand your concern is also a normal response, right?

—Yeah— princess Glimmer replied, holding her arm and looking away.

—Well, for us, it was difficult to get Light Spinner to talk— Adora finally spoke.

—Yeah, the woman insisted it wasn't our business and that we "have no right to stick our noses in their affairs, especially after what we did to her"— prince Catra continued, quoting Light Spinner.

—But Frosta managed to get her to talk— Adora said, a bit more cheerful. —I think she likes her personality— she commented, giggling.

—That is irrelevant— the princess of Snows complained. —The important information is that they had some personal conflicts over their past relationship and the sorceress likes to isolate herself in these cases, which means that we can find her somewhere secluded— Frosta explained.

—And *how* do we find her!? The kingdom is huge! your aunt could be anywhere— Catra reflected.

—We can search separately?— Mermista suggested.

—Perhaps we should speak with the three of them again and get their help?— Perfuma agreed.

—Well, actually…— princess Entrapta interrupted, signaling behind Adora and Frosta.

All of them turned to look at Delwyn, Arden, and Light Spinner who were walking their way.

—So you have been doing some questioning— the woman uttered, poorly hiding her annoyance. —It wasn't enough with getting information from me? Why are you asking us about Castaspella?— she inquired, squinting at them.

—Um… because Auntie is gone— Glimmer nervously replied, shocking them.

Gone!?

Light Spinner immediately took a step forward and grabbed the princess by the arms, slightly shaking her as she asked —How long ago!?

—I-I think an hour! Ma-maybe more!

Seeing Glimmer's fear at her reaction, all princesses seemed about to push Light Spinner away from her. But it was Arden who gently moved her back, placing a hand on her shoulder.

—Calm down. We'll find her.

—How!? I have no magic to locate her!— the woman desperately exclaimed.

—But I do. I just need a basin to perform the pulse spells.

—Unfortunately, there are none here— Mermista said, a bit too aloof for Light Spinner's taste.

—You all should have told me immediately!— she reproached them.

—We…

—Um, Your Majesty?— a voice called, interrupting Mermista. A merfolk had just approached the group and seemed to have an urgent message for her. —Sorry to interrupt, but this is important.

—Uh? Oh, give me a moment— she asked the princesses, and followed the sea elf a few steps away from them.

—What can we do, then? Should we try to get a basin to do the spell?— Arden asked.

They all exchanged conflicted looks; the princesses now felt guilty for wasting so much time, while both Delwyn and Arden feared that Light Spinner's behaviour would only get worse the more they delayed the search.

But before anyone could reply, Mermista returned, looking very serious, and said —I… think we found the sorceress…

Very slowly, Castaspella opened her eyes, so disoriented it took her a moment to fully wake up and recognize where she was.

Right.

The previous year she had been in one of those rooms too; she was in Salineas, in one of the chambers for guests and, again, woke up between Light Spinner's arms.

—You came for me— the sorceress faintly said.

—You're awake at last— the woman replied. Carefully cupping her face to make Castaspella look up at her, she sentenced —I could *never* leave you like that. Even if we broke up, I would never just disappear again like when I was banished.

—You mean it?

—I *want* to… get back with you— Light Spinner finally said. —I thought I lost you just now, and realized I've been a fool for trying to stay away from you.

—Bea…— she sighed, letting out a smile. Until she fully registered her words and her expression changed. Now that she thought about it, her nose and throat were sore, and itchy.

—Wait… you thought you lost me? What… happened? A-and why do I feel so sore?

As Castaspella held her neck, showing discomfort, Light Spinner decided to tell her right away.

—Well, to make it short: you almost drowned— she casually said.

—What!?

The sorceress was understandably shocked and tried to push herself up a bit, so Light Spinner helped her sat next to her.

—You were in a cave, the sea washed in and princess Mermista had to swim inside to retrieve you— the woman explained. —We suppose you fell asleep inside and when the tide rose, it covered you. If some passing sea elves hadn't seen you…

—I- Oh, my… I-I'm so sorry.

—You have nothing to apologize for, Love— Light Spinner immediately said. —If anything, I should. If I hadn't been so stubborn…

—Nonsense. I… may have overreacted— Castaspella insisted. —I shouldn't have wandered off like that in a kingdom I don't know— she reflected.

—It's done now. Don't worry about it anymore. You're fine— the woman interrupted. —And if you can get up, there's some people who would like to see you…

—Oh, I imagine— she chuckled, letting out an ashamed smile. —What… time is it?

—It will be midnight soon, I reckon.

—I was out for so long…— she realized.

—A few hours, yes.

—Then we better go now. My family must be so worried…

—Your family, the princesses, the council, Delwyn and his kids…— Light Spinner enumerated. —They *all* care for you, Es.

—They all… Re-really?

Her stunned expression made the woman laugh daintily, and she carefully helped the sorceress up.

—Let's go now…

Chapter 14: Day 6: Kingdom of Snows

Day 6

Kingdom of Snows

Second year

—Auntie!

Princess Glimmer was the first one to see the sorceress walk out of the room and immediately teleported to embrace her.

—Oh, dear— Castaspella laughed lightly. —I'm fine, don't worry— she assured her with a gentle tone.

—We were so worried!— Glimmer exclaimed, refusing to let go.

—I'm so sorry… I never intended for that to happen— she uttered, hugging her back. —I'll be more careful.

She sighed deeply with her eyes closed and, the next moment, when she looked up again, her brother approached to hug her too.

—Happy to see you well, Sis.

—Happy to be well…

The siblings giggled for a moment, and Glimmer finally released her aunt.

—Hey, Auntie! Why don't you stay at Bright Moon tonight and have breakfast with us in the morning?

—I- O-of course! I'd love to!— she replied. Yet, right after, she looked back at Light Spinner, who silently stood by the door, and added —If she can stay too, that is…

—I don't see why not— Micah replied, letting out a smile. Then, he placed a hand on Glimmer's shoulder and said —We should get going.

—Let's go, yes.

Castaspella turned around and approached Light Spinner, took her hand, and they both followed the King and the princess down the hall. When they arrived at Bright Moon, the women were given a room and, once inside, they hugged for a moment before sitting down on the bed, to try and rest for some hours.

By the time breakfast was ready, a guard knocked on the door and informed the sorceress she was being expected in the dining room. The women got dressed quickly and headed straight there, only to be surprised by how many people were at the table.

Delwyn and his kids saw them arrive and called everyone's attention. Along with them, some of Glimmer's friends had stayed too, and they all greeted the sorceress when she sat at the table.

—I… thank you all for your concern— she said, looking away, ashamed. —I'm sorry to have scared you. I shouldn't have wandered off, no matter how upset I was.

—If you don't mind, sorceress, next time just take a room and ask my waiters for some ice cream— princess Mermista told her, smirking. —It's quite efficient, trust me.

—I'll keep it in mind— Castaspella laughed.

—And let's hope there are no problems this afternoon at my party— Frosta then said, her tone a bit severe. —Or any interruptions either…

—I can't promise anything— Light Spinner uttered, right before taking a sip from her cup of coffee.

—Bea…

—I'm joking— the woman said, smirking. —I'll be very busy keeping an eye on you.

—I'm sure everything will go just fine— queen Angella sentenced, keeping a solemn expression as she took a bite of food.

—It better— Frosta huffed, and returned to eat her breakfast.

With more pleasant conversations, everyone enjoyed the meal and it didn't take long for everything to be gone. And so, they all prepared to leave for their respective homes and prepare for the party at the Kingdom of Snows.

Seeing Castaspella and Light Spinner on their way out too, Delwyn and Micah approached them and the King called out —Hey, wait!

—So you're leaving already?— Delwyn politely asked.

—Yes— the sorceress replied. —I have to start preparing the food for tomorrow's party, remember? I got the list yesterday but, well, didn't have time to begin, of course— she replied, smiling ashamedly.

—Then I guess we'll see you at the party— he replied, bowing respectfully.

—Of course! Don't worry, I'll be on time— she assured.

—Try not to exhaust yourself on your way to the Kingdom of Snows, alright?— Micah told her, genuinely concerned.

—Actually— Light Spinner interrupted, taking a step forward and placing a hand on Castaspella's shoulder. —Wouldn't it be more… *intelligent* to travel together? If she tries to keep us warm on her own all the way there, she's bound to pass out— the woman pointed out.

—O-only if you can— the sorceress clarified, realizing it was probably the best idea, but feeling like a burden for her brother.

—I…— he began, noticeably shocked. —Of course! I-I'm glad you asked.

—Well, seeing how I'm unable to help her, it was only logical, I believe.

—Right, right— he let out, smiling nervously. —Should we meet at the foot of the mountain?

—Perfect— Castaspella happily said. —See you then— she farewelled.

Just as promised, later that day, the women met up with king Micah, princess Glimmer, and queen Angella; together they made all the way to the palace on top of the mountain, taking turns to keep the group from freezing. And once they arrived, everyone immediately went for some warm clothes to put on.

—Finally— Castaspella huffed, going for a blue coat. —Well, this year it was much better, right Bea?— she commented, turning around to face Light Spinner.

—I suppose…

Her tone was bitter enough to let the sorceress know she wasn't quite happy about the situation, so she approached the woman and cupped her face with a hand, looking tenderly at her.

—I'm glad you asked for help, Love— she gently said. —I got so worried last year seeing how drained you were…

—I was perfectly fine— Light Spinner argued.

—Sure.

Castaspella giggled and briefly kissed her through the veil.

—Come on now, Es. Let's go before your brother comes back for us— the woman told her, and grabbed her hand to walk her out of the room and into the main hall.

They strolled together at a slow pace, admiring the decorations of that year, somehow more impressive than the year before, and couldn't help but stare at the glistening ice ornamentation.

—This place is always so beautiful— Castaspella sighed.

—It's quite admirable, indeed— Light Spinner agreed, much to her surprise. —I have to say, that princess has quite a mighty power… And knows exactly what she's doing.

—Bea…

—What?

—Not everything is about power, please— the sorceress told her, stopping to face her. She placed a hand over Light Spinner's chest and added —Promise me you'll try to appreciate princess Frosta for something other than her power.

—If it puts your mind at ease, then I promise I'm not thinking anything worrisome, alright?

—Alright— Castaspella sighed, laughing breathlessly in disbelief. —Thank you.

—Shall we find our tables?— the woman offered. —Or perhaps, you'd rather enjoy the music with me for a while before we take a seat?

Even with the veil on, the sorceress could see the woman was smirking; Light Spinner gave her a daring look, extended a hand towards her, and it was enough to convince her. Besides, they hadn't danced in so long…

Castaspella let out a soft smile and took her hand, following the woman into the small crowd of guests that were already dancing. The women seamlessly joined them all, dancing in perfect sync, enjoying the music and focused solely on each other.

They twisted and turned, following the music, until princess Frosta's arrival ceased the music. Everyone turned to look at the girl and gave her their full attention.

However, Castaspella felt a tap on her shoulder and turned to find Norwyn behind her.

—He-Head Sorcerer— she uttered, surprised, keeping her tone low. —What is it?

—We have to talk— he simply said, expression serious.

—Can't it be once the speech is over?

—This is a bit more important, I believe— he insisted. Then, he turned around, ordering —Follow me.

And what choice did she have? It was a direct order.

Castaspella *had* to follow him, so she quickly gestured at Light Spinner, indicating she was leaving for a moment, and rushed to catch up with Norwyn.

—Excuse me, Head Sorcerer. But I believe this is quite disrespectful to princess Frosta.

—Listen to me, Castaspella— he interrupted her, raising a hand gesturing for her to stop. —We need to discuss your position on Mystacor seeing how you have… resumed your relationship with Light Spinner— he began. —As you know, certain privileges were returned

to you after your relationship ended and *because* it ended. Meaning now, as the whole council is aware of the fact that you're back together, I have no other option but to revoke several of those authorizations and benefits, effective immediately.

Of course.

They couldn't wait a single day.

She should have known…

Castaspella closed her eyes and took a deep breath to muster all her calmness and reply —I understand, Head Sorcerer, and I'm fine with that. But does it have to be right in the middle of this party? Couldn't you at least wait until we sit at the table?

He simply shook his head.

—As I said: effective immediately. That means, you will *not* be sitting with us, nor will she.

—That is *not* your decision, as far as I know— Castaspella boldly retorted. —We can always ask the Princess in any case, but I reckon she won't agree with you.

—If so you want, then let's go talk with her right away— he accepted, much to the sorceress' consternation.

And they did, in fact, request an audience with the Princess, which proved Castaspella right. However, in the end, neither her nor Light Spinner sat at the table with the Arden, Norwyn, and the council. Frosta realized the council's animosity had reached a point where having them sit at that table would only bring discomfort, and instead reassigned them to the royal table.

It proved to be a wise decision.

The women were far more comfortable in the company of Castaspella's family and the princesses than they would have been on the receiving end of nasty looks from the council like the previous year.

Later that night, Light Spinner silently took the sorceress back to her cottage, and kept quiet for a long while, sitting on the sofa with a drink as Castaspella went back to cooking for the following day.

However, she couldn't help feeling like Light Spinner wanted to say something, but held herself back.

—Love? What's on your mind?— she gently asked, taking a break from her cooking.

—Nothing…

—Please…

—Es…

—Bea…

—Fine— the woman sighed, standing up to leave her cup on the table. —I overheard you and Norwyn speaking— she admitted. —It was just as I feared. I'm ruining your life… *again*.

—No, no, no— Castaspella immediately denied, approaching her. —Forget about that. I couldn't care less about what they allow me to do, whether I can sit at the same table as them, or whether I can access the archives— she assured her. —I don't mind being just a tutor…

—You have so much potential, Es…

—Not enough, trust me. I'm fine like this— the sorceress let out, looking away with a sad smile.

—You don't understand what I mean, Esmeralda— Light Spinner sentenced, catching Castaspella's full attention. —Remember when I said last year that there are far more skilled sorcerers that could have Norwyn's place?— she asked, holding the sorceress' hands. —I was talking about someone like *you*.

She couldn't be serious…

Of course she was!

—Bea… I- That's nonsense— Castaspella replied, blushing deeply. —I could never be…

—You could. I mean it. You're far better suited.

The sorceress could barely believe what she was hearing. She closed her eyes, took a deep breath, and leant on Light Spinner.

—I appreciate the vote of confidence, but that's impossible…

—Because *they* are making it impossible— the woman uttered, seething. —Those fools…

—Please, my Love, just forget about this— Castaspella pleaded. —No privilege, no position, not even being head of the Guild is worth anything to me if, in exchange, I have to sacrifice you…

—Alright— Light Spinner finally agreed, hugging her closer against her. —I understand.

—Thank you…

Chapter 15: Day 7: Mystacor

Day 7

Mystacor

Second year

Morning found the women lazily kissing in bed. The sun began warming up their skin yet they refused to get up. Neither felt like leaving the bed, nor were they hungry enough, and simply felt too comfortable in each other's arms.

—I insist— Light Spinner grumbled. —Why don't we stay home tonight?

—Bea…

—Those fools already treat you like a lesser acolyte!

—But I have to go, Love— Castaspella replied, although sounding quite resigned. —I'm in charge of the food for the party, remember?

—We can always have it sent to the island.

The sorceress took a deep breath and sighed, resting her head comfortably on Light Spinner's chest. The offer was so tempting…

—Look, I hardly want to see Norwyn or the council, but I really love parties, I *want* to go— she admitted.

That sounded so… *ridiculous* .

Oh, but she loved that ridiculous woman…

—Very well— she sighed. —I *wouldn't dream* of keeping you from your dear parties— she mocked her.

—How funny— Castaspella uttered.

—But, I have one condition— Light Spinner added. The sorceress raised her head to look at her, and she said —You better stay by my side at all times.

—I wouldn't leave you alone there— she replied, smiling. —And I'd rather not be alone either…

After spending all morning finishing the different dishes the sorceress had to prepare for the party, it was time to take all of it to Mystacor, so Castaspella called for some help from both Delwyn and Arden. And hearing about it, even Micah joined them to assist.

Little by little, they all managed to carry all the food into the floating island, where the preparations for the party were in full swing.

Meanwhile, back in Bright Moon, princess Adora and Prince Catra were having a serious conversation with the Queen.

—Yes. It's my honest judgment— she sentenced.

—And it is absolutely unrelated to what recently happened with your sister-in-law?— Catra inquired.

—Completely unrelated— she assured. —In fact, this is something I noticed *before* any of that happened. Specifically, I was surprised when Light Spinner went to the party in Dryl after what happened here in the gardens, but not only did she attend… she also admitted what happened had been but a fit of rage!— Angella elaborated. —Normally, she would be petty about it, spiteful even… She'd argue her reaction was justified, or something like that… but she let the issue go instead!

—I see…— Adora considered.

—Oh, of course. There's also the fact that she asked for help just yesterday— the Queen added. —Micah was so surprised that Light Spinner *admitted* she couldn't help and asked him to do so in her stead— she explained. —It's- Well… it was both, accepting her limits *and* thinking about the risks, in this case, that Casta alone would possibly pass out.

—That's… considerate— Adora let out, surprised.

—It probably- Well, no. I'm *sure* it's because that was about Castaspella— Catra commented. —But, I agree. That's still… considerate enough, for someone like her.

They looked at each other for a moment and perfectly understood what the other meant without saying a word. Adora grabbed Catra's hand and slightly pressed before looking back at the Queen.

—Thank you for your time, Your Majesty.

With a bow, they both retired and walked away, hand in hand, discussing in hushed tones.

—Are you sure?

—I am.

—Adora…

—If you want to be extra sure, we can always speak with Ambassador Zhaleh too.

—It would reassure me if he thinks like the Queen, yes— Catra admitted.

—Then let's go find him!

That afternoon, in Mystacor, everything was set and the first guests arrived at the island. Castaspella was still busy organizing where to set the food, but Light Spinner, true to her word, kept following the sorceress with her sight. Despite being in the middle of a conversation with Delwyn, her full attention was on her woman.

And so, when Adora and Catra approached, asking to speak with the ambassador privately, Light Spinner had no inconveniences…

—Well, that's a tricky question— he said, nervously looking back at where they left the woman. —I can't judge whether she was behaving better or worse than other years because it's the first time I spend an End of The Year week here.

—We know— Catra calmly replied. —So judge according to *your* values and ethics.

—I see… Well, then, I consider her to be fairly respectful when calm— he began. —In Dryl, when I went to thank her for trying to save Kharyn, it didn't look like she wanted to be speaking with me, and I actually expected her to directly tell me to leave. But instead, she behaved quite well, didn't send me away, and even answered my inquiries, despite how personal my question was…

—She didn't insult you or anything?

—Not at all. Oh, and she was very polite to princess Entrapta too— he added.

—She… was?

—Absolutely. Which surprised me because Casta had warned me Light Spinner is easily irked by Entrapta's… *taste* .

—Right. The tiny things— Adora realized. —In that case… I believe it's time we go speak with her, wouldn't you say?— she asked Catra.

—Alright. I'm convinced— she accepted.

—Thank you!— she squealed, overjoyed. —We'll see you later, Delwyn— Adora farewelled, before pulling from her wife and walking away. —Now… Where to find them?— she thought aloud, her tone a bit musical.

—You are dying to go tell them, aren't you?

—Maybe…

—Love, if you wanted so badly to tell them, why wait until I agreed?

—Because I trust your judgment. And I want to be sure I'm not just being soft or anything— Adora explained.

—You're not soft, silly—Catra immediately replied, stopping to hold her by the shoulders. —You're really wise, you've proven as much. So it is *I* who should be getting your agreement when making decisions…

—I don't know— she sighed. —Sometimes it doesn't feel like I know what I'm doing…

—Then I'll be more than glad to give my opinion, but don't let it stop you from doing what you want to do, alright?

—Alright— Adora smiled.

They stood there for a moment, hands on each other's waist, foreheads pressed together, and just enjoyed their small bubble for a moment.

—Come on now, let's go find them— Catra finally said.

Just like the previous year, Castaspella and Light Spinner didn't have an assigned table and had to sit at one of the extra ones prepared for unexpected guests. And like the previous year, the company was less than ideal.

—Well, *excuse me* , but it's hard to imagine the King didn't pull some strings…

—Imagine all you want. It *wasn't* like that— Castaspella retorted, starting to get annoyed.

A scorpioni man that had arrived a few minutes earlier and sat across from them had been asking about their situation for a good while now. And while Light Spinner could easily ignore him, enjoying a drink and some appetizers, the sorceress absolutely couldn't.

—You expect me to believe the banishment was simply ignored without any…

—Yes, it was ignored. Only for today, because of the rules that apply for this week, she can freely come to the island for the party— Castaspella interrupted him. —And why exactly are you so interested in the whys and hows?

—Ah, mere curiosity— he assured her, sounding somewhat drunk. —Which reminds me… do you- Uh, Your Majesties— the scorpioni interrupted himself, upon seeing the Queen and King of Bright Moon arrive at the table.

—Good evening— Angella greeted.

—Evening— the women replied.

—Go-good evening— the man stammered.

—Um, Sis— Micah called. —Wouldn't you want to come and sit with us, maybe?

—We weren't assigned a table, Micah. We can't— she replied, keeping her voice even so as to not betray what she was feeling. —But don't worry. In fact, we just came because I had to bring the food. We'll be leaving as soon as the lights show starts— the sorceress explained.

—I see, it's alright— he sighed.

Staring in utter silence, the scorpioni man only gaped at having the regents so close. And then, if that wasn't enough, seeing Adora and Catra approach further shocked him. He hadn't ever been in such close proximity with influencing figures like them.

—Good evening!— Adora cheerfully said, waving a hand.

—Evening, Princess— Light Spinner replied.

—Good evening. Can we help you with anything?— Castaspella inquired, consciously ignoring the expression on the scorpioni in front of them.

—Well, yes. If you don't mind, we'd like to speak with you and Light Spinner— she answered.

—I see— the sorceress uttered, already concerned. —Are you alright?— she first asked her. When the woman nodded, she stood up, saying —If you excuse us…

They both left the man with the Queen and the King, and he was visibly shaking from the nerves.

—Go-go-good party, right?

—Excuse us for interrupting you, but… we have something we need to tell you—Adora began, once they were far enough from the other guests.

—No need to apologize, Princess— Light Spinner promptly said. —That man had been questioning us non-stop since arriving. If anything, you did us a favor by pulling us from that situation.

—Oh, that's…

—Understandable.

Catra interrupted Adora only to cut the subject short and gave her a significant look, which the princess easily understood.

—Right! Now, what I meant to tell you…— she resumed, smiling apologetically. —We have heard from the Queen and Ambassador Zhaleh a few things that… tell me your behaviour has improved significantly, Light Spinner— she explained, a bit more serious now. —And that's why I decided to tell you that, seeing how Castaspella here is enough of a good influence, if this progress continues I am… willing to give you your powers back— she concluded.

—It had been the plan since the beginning, but I feared it would make you *fake* the progress — Catra admitted, looking at Light Spinner. —But you're proving to be gaining some control over your impulses and, if this continues, if you can prove to be in full control, instead of what we saw last year, you can and will recover your sorcery.

Castaspella looked back at the woman only to find her pale and frozen in place. Neither of them could believe what they were hearing, and it took Light Spinner a moment to fully grasp the meaning of those words.

—You are saying… that this… isn't permanent?

Her voice was faint, shaky, but they all understood. Adora nodded and took a step forward, noticeably wary.

—But again: you have to prove your impulses can't control you again— she insisted. —Only if you're in full charge of your every action can we trust you with your powers again.

—I still think that the investigation should be destroyed…— Catra commented, which made Light Spinner immediately squint at her. —But if you truly understand you can't execute it, *ever* , then I don't see the need.

—We-we greatly appreciate it, Princess— Castaspella finally let out, holding one of Light Spinner's hands. —Right?

—Yes… I-I appreciate it— she managed to say, nodding slightly, yet looking down. —And I… understand— she sighed.

—Then please, let us make a deal— Catra decided. —You make the effort, *honest* effort, to show us we can trust you with your powers back and, in turn, we'll return them and put in a good word for you so the ban is lifted.

—I…— Light Spinner began, but interrupted herself and cleared her throat. —I don't care about the ban as much as I care about the issue with Castaspella's reputation.

—That's part of the deal, of course…— Adora assured her.

—In that case…

The woman extended a hand and Catra immediately shook it.

—It's a deal.

—And right in time! Look!— the sorceress pointed out.

Dozens of shiny dots illuminated the sky above them as the light show began, welcoming a new year. The four of them turned their heads to look up at the show, and both couples embraced each other, keeping their sight fixed on the sky.

—Happy New Year— Castaspella whispered.

—Happy New Year, Love…

Chapter 16: A New Year

A New Year

One year later…

Chapter 17: Day 1: Bright Moon

Chapter Notes

> We're back, my dears!
>
> I had a lot of trouble writing the last months of this year so I'm rushing this a bit. It may be a bit short, but I hope it's to your liking!
>
> And I really hope I can post the rest of the chapters in time <("^_^)
>
> Anyways, happy festivities for you all!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 1

Bright Moon

Third year

The End of the Year Week had begun.

Light Spinner arrived quite early at Bright Moon and wasn't the littlest bit surprised to see Castaspella running up and down handling the final preparations before the party actually began.

She found it interesting that the sorceress was using that attire from Ak'kelon like the previous year, and chuckled when she remembered how embarrassed she felt in that golden dress she had used two years before. Besides, the woman couldn't deny how much she liked that outfit; *totally* unrelated to how it exposed her legs…

She was about to approach Castaspella, a tease at the ready, when she thought better about it and refrained. Instead, she went to a table and took a seat, purposely looking away from the sorceress.

For a long while, she was completely unbothered before the most unexpected person joined her at the table.

—Good afternoon, Light Spinner— Delwyn greeted her.

—Afternoon— she replied, her tone neutral.

—May I ask why you're sitting here alone?

—I just took a seat here and no one else did.

—Can I ask…

—Is this about Casta?

—Yes.

—Then you *cannot*— she severely said. —Unlike last year, I have no intention of discussing why I left her.

—Then don't tell me about that. Just… Have you seen her? I mean, *really* seen her? Have you noticed how brokenhearted she's been the past three months?

—Of course I have!

—Then you still care…

—Contrary to what you all may think, I left her *because* I care!

—Is this about how you supposedly ruin her life, again?— Delwyn tentatively asked.

—I said I wouldn't discuss this…

—Right, of course— he accepted, apologetically. —In that case, I'll… leave and stop bothering you.

—I'd appreciate that.

With a polite bow, the ambassador walked away and Light Spinner let out a sigh. She closed her eyes, while taking a deep breath, and tried to push aside the thoughts triggered by that conversation.

However, she was quickly interrupted by her stomach rumbling, and decided to go for some aperitifs before dinner was served.

She had barely finished eating the first one when she felt observed and turned to find Castaspella looking at her just a few meters away. Smirking under her veil, she approached the sorceress without hesitation this time and tilted her head with curiosity before addressing her.

—What now?— she asked, her tone condescending.

—"What" about what?

—You're staring…

—I was not— the sorceress retorted, trying to hide her nervousness.

—You were, and I can almost see the gears turning inside your head— she mocked her. —What is it, Es?

—I-I was just wondering what you could possibly be doing here… You don't even like these parties! I've had to drag you to them every time!

—Must be the force of habit at this point…— the woman replied, dismissive.

—Don't be ridiculous!

—No need to raise your voice…

—I am not- Ugh!

—Yes you are— Light Spinner insisted, more serious than teasing. —And I would rather not attract any attention…

—Why did you- *What* are you doing here?

—Enjoying a party, of course.

Castaspella lowered her head, frustrated, and massaged her temples as she asked again —Why *now*?

—I don't think I understand the question, Es.

—Stop playing dumb, Beatrix. I'm talking about how you disappeared again for three months and now suddenly return for this party like you did two years ago!

—Ah, that… Is it so hard to believe that I didn't mean to disappear?

—Then why were you nowhere to be found!? Not even at home!

—I presumed it would be better if I gave you space, wouldn't you say?

—You're a jerk…

Without allowing the woman to reply or complain, Castaspella turned around and stalked away.

Sighing like before, Light Spinner closed her eyes for a moment, grabbed a cup of wine, and returned to her seat in time for dinner.

Meanwhile, having witnessed everything from the other side of the room, Micah decided it was possibly a good time to talk with his sister about something he'd been meaning to tell her for three months.

He first waved to call her attention, but Castaspella was a bit too abstracted to notice him, so he rushed her way.

—Hey, Sis, can we talk?— he asked, tapping her shoulder.

—Uh? Sure, Brother— she agreed, pushing away her annoyance. —What is it?

Shyly looking away and scratching the back of his neck, he began —I've… been meaning to tell you this for a long while but…

—Excuse me, King Micah— someone interrupted him. —The Queen requests your presence.

—Do-does it have to be now?— he asked back, between perplexed and frustrated.

—She sounded quite urgent, yes. She and Head Sorcerer Norwyn are arguing and require your assistance.

—Ah…— he sighed. —Alright. We'll talk later, then, Sis.

—Of course, don't worry— she replied, smiling gently.

She stared after him as he walked away, inevitably wondering what it could be that he wanted to tell her.

However, she quickly returned to her senses as the smell of food filled the air. She walked back to her table, reluctantly, as she didn't really want to sit with her "fellow acolytes", but stopped in her tracks as she noticed Arden was gone. Curious, her first instinct was to search for Delwyn, and just as expected, they were talking with the ambassador.

But that wasn't all…

Whatever Arden told him made Delwyn stand up, politely bow to the people he was sitting with, and follow the magician, along with his children. Confused, Castaspella observed them for a moment, until it became clear what they were doing: they all were heading for Light Spinner's table.

She could see the woman was sitting alone, but knowing her, she didn't mind and most likely preferred it that way… So what were they doing and *why*!?

Unable to help it, and secretly wanting to, Castaspella walked their way and arrived just in time to hear the woman complain.

—Well, I don't recall asking for any company…

It was exactly what she expected.

—Oh, of course… I know as much, but we saw fit to come over and keep you company regardless— Delwyn argued.

—Exactly! I know we have a lot we could talk about!— Arden chimed in. —Certainly more than what I could discuss with my fellows…

—Oh, really? I doubt it, unless you wish to discuss all the forbidden magics I can no longer perform…

They immediately laughed at her comment and dismissively replied —I still like that sense of humor…

—Hey…— Kharyn shyly let out, greeting Castaspella as soon as he noticed her. He was a bit hidden behind his father, but gathered the courage to approach her instead, and asked — Would you… sit with us?

—What… Ah, you. What a surprise— Light Spinner uttered, looking over her shoulder, unamused. Returning her sight to the magician as they took a seat next to her, the woman rolled her eyes and complained —Don't any of you have anything better to do right now?

—No…

—Not really…

—I do! But then I see *this* happening and can't help looking into whatever is going on here— Castaspella angrily said, after Delwyn and Arden's aloof responses.

—Which means you have no reasons to be here…— the woman pointed out. —In that case, don't waste more time and leave already…

—You do *not* tell me what to do…

—Neither do you… *Here*. This is a public event, Es… Much as I may like following your commands in private, here's not the place…— she boldly mocked the sorceress.

—Can you *stop* making such jokes in front of children!?

—They look pretty grown up to me…

—If I may…— Delwyn interceded. —They would be considered teenagers by your standards.

—Then I see no issue with my comment— Light Spinner insisted.

—It's still an issue since we are, just like you said, in public!

Finally fed up, the woman turned to look over her shoulder again and condescendingly said —If you have so many problems with me, if my presence is so disturbing to you, why don't you just ask me to leave already?

—Because that's not what I want to do, Beatrix!— Castaspella exploded. —But it's not like you care about what I want, do you!? Of course, you don't…

—Es…— Light Spinner called, catching the sorceress' wrist just as she turned to leave. —Wait.

—No— she refused, before yanking her hand from the woman's grip. —I'm tired of waiting…

Without another word, she walked away and didn't stop until she reached one of the balconies. A loud scream of excitement startled her right as she walked in, but as soon as she realized it was just Princess Entrapta rushing past the balcony with a beeping device, she calmed down, let out a sigh, and rested her arms on the edge of the balcony.

She closed her eyes and took a deep breath, trying to ease her racing thoughts, and barely held back a sob.

It was just so hard…

Meanwhile, back at the table where Light Spinner no longer sat alone, a heated discussion was in full swing.

—We’re just trying to understand…

—No.

—It’s but honest concern!

—I don’t need your concern.

—But it makes no sense!— Arden insisted. —You left her *again* because you care about her!? Why would you choose to break her heart like that and claim it’s for her own good!?

—After last year, we all thought you’d never leave her side again… When she almost drowned, you were so anxious…

—I know perfectly well how I was, what I said, and it’s none of your business why I still decided to leave her!— the woman retorted, with her last bit of patience.

—But it's evident that neither of you are happy without the other! A-and after almost losing her for good… how can’t you see that this situation is the same or even worse!?— Delwyn indignantly expressed.

—That’s enough!— Light Spinner exclaimed, severe but collected. —Why exactly are you two doing this!? And don’t try to tell me it’s because you’re worried about Casta! No! You two just can’t deal with your own conscience, right!?— she accused them. —You! It’s clear you still feel guilty for betraying me all those years ago! Don’t you!?— she began, pointing at Arden. —And you, mister Ambassador…— she went on, turning towards Delwyn, and speaking with a tone that was almost mocking. —You can’t fool me. You just see yourself in Casta like you seem to see your late spouse in me. What are you trying to do!? “Fix” things for us because you can’t fix them for yourself!? Do you feel it’s unfair that we’re separated despite having the chance of being together while, in turn, you can’t because your spouse is gone and won’t ever return!? Talk about guilt-tripping!— she concluded, knowing perfectly well how her words sounded.

Delwyn’s expression immediately went dark, but he said nothing. Instead, it was Kharyn who reacted.

Slamming a hand down on the table, he stood up, fixed his glare on Light Spinner, and all shyness was gone as if replaced by a furious flame evident in his mismatched eyes when he sentenced —You are a *cruel* woman! You are *nothing* like theyi! You have no right to talk about them like that, and you don’t deserve our father’s concern!

With a final huff, the boy turned and stalked away, ignoring his sister who called out to him and rushed after him wherever he was going.

Light Spinner slightly squinted as she followed the kids with her sight, feeling undeniably wrong for what she did and having to recognize Kharyn was right, even if she hated that fact. Far too bitter, when she looked back to find Delwyn still sitting next to her, looking down at his hands with a forlorn expression, she couldn’t help letting that hatred show.

—Won't you leave too? Your kid was pretty on-point— she let out, venomous.

—So were you…— he admitted, without looking up. —I shouldn't project my… relationship issues into yours. Whatever I- Eh- I mean… if I made you feel guilty, I apologize— he stammered, as he slowly raised his sight.

There was something incomprehensible in his fully dark blue eyes. Whatever it was, it completely put out that hatred Light Spinner was feeling.

—I… apologize too— Arden began, calling both their attention. —It's completely true that I still feel guilty. For snitching, for marrying Casta just to avoid banishment, and for… well… just… everything.

The young magician was extremely ashamed and couldn't help scratching the back of their neck while speaking.

—Alright, you both. Stop it. I think the boy established pretty clearly that I was just being cruel— Light Spinner argued. —I'm supposed to be apologizing here, much as I don't want to.

—Perhaps you were cruel but… it doesn't make your words any less true.

—That's… one of the things Casta always praises about you— Arden pointed out. —Your manner of speech is cruel, mostly disrespectful, and utterly condescending, but you *don't lie*.

—Most people wouldn't apologize after being spoken to in such a way, but we understand where you come from, and we truly want to help— Delwyn assured her. —We won't keep bothering you, of course, but do know we can and will help you and Casta in any way possible.

Having said that, both the ambassador and the magician moved to stand up, but Light Spinner extended her hands towards each of them, gesturing to stop them.

—You don't have to leave if you don't want to. I was just being petty.

Arden and Delwyn immediately exchanged a hopeful glance and took a seat again, thanking her.

Back at the balcony, Castaspella was still looking down at the kingdom extending beneath her, when she heard familiar voices behind her. She turned in time to see Kharyn stumble onto the balcony, followed by his sister right after.

Before she could say anything, and after a moment of being frozen in place just looking at her, Kharyn rushed to hug Castaspella.

—Oh! Hey… Are you alright?— she asked him, gently wrapping her arms around him. However, as he wouldn't answer, she looked at Namai and asked —Did something happen?

—Well…— she hesitated. —It's just that… Light Spinner was mean…

—About what!?

—Father and Arden were trying to get her to explain why she left you… they just wanted to help, and she accused them of having… ulterior motives— she explained.

—What did she say?

—She said…

—She told Father he's making her feel guilty and trying to fix your relationship because theyi is gone and won't come back!— Kharyn exclaimed.

The sorceress' shock was evident in her expression, and she didn't wait a second to hug him tighter. Namai's expression fell immediately and she couldn't help stepping closer to hug him too.

—I know it hurts; you'll always miss your theyi, but they remain within you both— Castaspella assured them. —Don't let her words affect you… Beatrix is… difficult to bear, and I'm sure she didn't mean to hurt you.

—Then why did she say that if Father is trying to help her!?— Kharyn insisted.

—She never took it well when people tried to help her. It makes her feel weak— she explained, releasing him.

—That's just stupid— Namai commented, looking away.

—Maybe, but… I don't know…— Kharyn hesitated.

—You don't know what?— Castaspella gently asked.

—I don't know if… dad's so wrong— he replied.

—About what?

—About wanting to help you both… I said she doesn't deserve his concern, but…

—Your father is a good man and won't give up easily. I think he shouldn't waste his time with this but… it's not like I can stop him— Castaspella giggled.

—Dad is too good sometimes— Namai uttered. —But… we also want you to be happy.

—That's very sweet of you, but my happiness shouldn't depend on one person.

—Then what do you need to be happy?—Namai asked, curious.

—Knowing there are people around me who care about me unconditionally is more than enough for me— she assured her with a smile.

—Do we make you happy?

—Of course, Kharyn! I'm so glad you get to visit us so usually, it's always the highlight of my year— she assured them.

—Perhaps we should come more often— Namai commented with a smile.

—I would certainly like that, but you depend on whether there's a spaceship available.

—That's it! We're gonna learn how to pilot a spaceship and get our own so we can come whenever we want!— Kharyn decided, excitedly looking at Namai.

—Oh, yes! Yes! I'll start the engineering course next year! You should do the piloting course meanwhile— she suggested.

—Those sound like very good ideas, but… aren't spaceships a bit… expensive?

—We learn how to craft our own spaceships in the course, and craft one for the final exam— Namai explained. —The student with the best score gets to keep it.

—Then I wish you luck with the course!— Castaspella cheerfully said. —Now, we should probably return to the party. It will end soon…

Chapter End Notes

Ahem, so... Yes. They separated again.
This year's chapters are so dramatic, you have no idea XD

But well, I had a great idea, and there's also a bit of a surprise! Have you seen the new tags?
In that case, you can guess why Entrapta left the party early hehe

Anyways, no more spoilers

Until tomorrow it is!!

Chapter 18: Day 2: Dryl

Chapter Notes

Enter Hordak

Day 2

Dryl

Third year

The following day, Castaspella woke up after lunchtime in Bright Moon, and had to rush a bit to eat and get ready for the party at Dryl.

Despite the little mishap, she still managed to arrive before Entrapta's welcome speech, and walked around alone for a while, trying not to call any attention to herself.

Eventually, as was inevitable, she came across Light Spinner, whom she had avoided the rest of the party the previous day, not wanting to argue with her about the comments she made and how it had affected Delwyn's kids.

But now it seemed like she'd have no other choice and braced herself for the imminent argument.

However…

—Sis! There you are— Micah exhaled, relieved, arriving just in time. —You weren't there at breakfast, and we *really* need to talk— he explained.

Surprised, Castaspella looked back at Light Spinner for a moment, only to see she was walking away, seemingly not wanting to interrupt her conversation with her brother.

When she turned back to him, she was smiling gently as she said —Ah, yes. I'm sorry, I overslept—. She purposely left out that it was because she had stayed awake crying for what has been happening with the woman; what would be the point of mentioning it? —And I suppose this is about what you wanted to tell me yesterday, yes?

—Exactly. I-it's really important, and you're probably going to hate me for not telling you sooner, but, I simply couldn't find the right moment…

—And now it is?

—More like… I think I shouldn't delay this anymore. I should have told you months ago— he replied.

—Micah, what is this about?— she asked, getting more and more curious.

—It's about something I overheard…

—Who did you overhear?

—Well, it was…

—King Micah? Excuse me, Head Sorcerer Nolrem is looking for you— an acolyte interrupted.

—What?

The King seemed distraught, while his sister was completely hiding her annoyance. She didn't particularly like this petulant young acolyte. She wasn't sure why, but he simply rubbed her the wrong way.

And with all due reason, seeing how, despite her not knowing, this was the same acolyte who snitched on her and Light Spinner two years before…

—I'm sorry, your Majesty. Wasn't I clear? The Head Sorcerer is looking for you…— he repeated. —Please don't ask me why, I don't know. All I know is that it seemed pretty urgent.

—I'm in the middle of something important here!— Micah complained.

—With all due respect, family chatting can wait…

Yes, indeed.

Castaspella *really* couldn't stand him.

—I can't believe this— the King huffed. —Fine, I'll go. And I'll be right back, Sis.

—Of course, don't worry, Brother.

Once again, she watched as he walked away, and let out a sigh.

What could he have overheard that was so important for her to know? *Who* did he overhear? And why had he waited months to tell her if it was so critical?

All those questions would remain unanswered for the time being, because they were interrupted once again, and so were her thoughts as Princess Entrapta began her welcome speech.

—Everyone! Thank you for coming to my social gathering today!— she started, cheerful as always. —Do enjoy the tiny food and drinks! There is plenty for everyone's consumption!— she went on, in a very generic manner. However, she then seemed especially excited. —And now, let me introduce you all to my new friend! He is... Um... Well, he has no name, but comes from something called "Horde", so I think "Hordak" would fit him!— she exclaimed, presenting an unknown man. —He came through a portal yesterday! Isn't that great!?

The person in question was a tall, slender man with a face that resembled a skull, black-blue hair, red eyes and teeth; he had a pair of pointy ears that looked like those of an animal more than those of other etherian species like Light Spinner's, and despite his frail appearance, his stance was slightly intimidating.

—A portal? Is that why you left early yesterday, Princess Entrapta?— Queen Angella immediately asked, calling everyone's attention.

—Indeed! My computers picked up a signal and I *had* to be the first one there! And so I found him!— she explained, even more excited.

—Why wasn't I informed at once, Princess?

—Oh, I was distracted until this morning learning *all* about this Horde he comes from, and I concluded it would be ninety percent more efficient to let everyone know about this now— she nonchalantly explained, completely unaware of the scowl in *Hordak's* face.

—I… suppose that's correct…— the Queen had to admit.

Immediately, as if suddenly out of their shock, plenty of the guests began asking questions, almost speaking at the same time.

—But… What is this "Horde" you speak about?

—I…— Entrapta tried to reply, before being overwhelmed by more questions.

—What do you mean he has no name?

—That's what he said…— she managed to explain, yet was once more interrupted by plenty more questions, and hardly noticing how people were closing in on her and her new friend.

—Why would you call him "Hordak"? Does it have a meaning?

—Well, that…— she stammered until interrupted again.

—Who exactly are you and how did you come to our planet?

—I…— Hordak uttered, being addressed directly, but couldn't speak either.

—And why *now*? Why are you here!?

With so many more questions drowning them, Entrapta hid her face behind the digital device she was carrying, while Hordak tried to take a step back, only to find himself against a table.

—Ugh… Enough!— he finally yelled, fists tightly closed. —Stay back, impure beasts!

Immediately, Adora was standing between the crowd and both Hordak and Entrapta.

—Hey, hey… It's alright, yes?— she calmly said, looking at Hordak with a gentle expression. —No one meant any harm— she assured him. Then, she turned to the guests and explained —Please, everyone, you're overwhelming him…

But they were quite angry…

—He just called us "impure beasts"!— someone complained.

—Who do you think you are!?— another voice cried out.

They were furious and relentless, that much was obvious, and the more threatened Hordak felt, the more aggressive his expression turned.

Adora knew this could get out of hand easily.

—I think you just scared him, so please keep your distance and calmly ask your questions— she insisted. —Now, Hordak, was it? I think we all want to know more about you, seeing how Entrapta introduced you…— she began, speaking calmly as the crowd took a few steps back.

From a certain distance, Castaspella observed everything, not daring to approach or make questions of her own despite having *many*. She could see how dazzled this stranger was, and quite perplexed after Adora's question.

—You want to know about *me*?— he asked, his voice deeper than when he yelled before.

—Oh, well, he doesn't really speak about himself… more like about his leader…— Entrapta quickly clarified, realizing why he seemed so puzzled.

And just as she had said, Hordak began —The glorious Horde Prime. The pinnacle of perfection. I am but a mere subject, a flawed copy of his majesty. I was exiled from the Horde because of it, but I will become perfect for him again, so that I may be called back into the embrace of his light.

Everyone kept silent for a moment.

He had called himself a copy of this "Horde Prime", and a *flawed* copy, no less… Could he be talking about his frail appearance? How it seemed like some of his muscles were atrophied in his arms and shoulders?

Whatever the case, Adora felt something ache inside her upon hearing the way he described himself.

—You were… exiled for being flawed?— she gently asked.

But he didn't seem the littlest bit forlorn; on the contrary, he seemed to fully agree with that assessment.

—There is no room for imperfections in the Horde— he quickly explained. —*He* is on a mission to perfect the whole universe, and you all, imperfect and impure creatures, should bow to his greatness!— he then added, as if repeating a speech.

And that was probably a mistake.

The people once again grew indignant and angry; they began speaking at the same time, or rather, shouting like before.

—Bow to *whom*!?

—We would never bow to *anyone*!

—You claim to be flawed yet call *us* "imperfect"!?

Adora stood in place, making sure Hordak wouldn’t be overwhelmed again, so he didn’t react like before. Instead, he once more spoke in a manner that seemed… fanatical.

—I have been created in his image, therefore I only need to prove my worth to return to him — he assured them. —But you all have been born amidst an impure world, one that has yet to be touched by *his* light! When the time comes, you will finally ascend to perfection!— he exclaimed, looking up as if this leader he was talking about was in front of him.

Curious but wary, Prince Catra approached carefully to ask —And what does that "perfection" of yours entail?

Her look was suspicious, but he entirely missed it as he replied, full of adoration, —You'll be free from impure thoughts and needs. You shall know his magnificence and only ever obey his command. You will be blessed with the ultimate honor: becoming part of the hive mind.

Hive mind!?

Indignant whispers initiated among the guests, until the Queen spoke up, with a commanding voice that silenced everyone.

—Princess Entrapta. Can you explain what he's talking about?

She was still hiding slightly behind her gadget, but looked up immediately and said —I'm sorry, your Majesty. I understand as much as you do. I don't have enough data yet to properly draw any conclusions—. Then, she looked down into her digital device and skimmed through her notes. —Most of what he speaks about is unheard of!— she assured her. Then, addressing Hordak, she said —But… What I do understand is that your leader, Horde Prime, makes everyone identical to him.

He nodded solemnly.

—Why wouldn't you want to be part of his perfection?

Entrapta seemed quite shy as she replied, looking away, —Because no one wants to lose their individuality.

—Individuality?— he asked again, confused this time.

—You know, like… what makes you unique. Like your personality, your *name*…— she explained.

—I have no *name*. That nonsense of calling me "Hordak" would never be tolerated by him— he sentenced.

—But how are we supposed to call you? How will *he* call you if you have no name?— she insisted, while everyone else kept silent, between curious and perplexed.

—I… have not- No, I have no need for a name— he insisted, albeit hesitant at first. —Once I rejoin the hive mind, I shall answer his call whenever he so wills.

—You really have no idea what individuality is…— Princess Entrapta lamented.

—And why would you cling to your impurities!?— he questioned her, almost indignant.

However, it wasn't Entrapta who answered this time…

—Because losing your individuality is akin to dying. Conforming to the norms makes you nothing but a pawn, and some of us value our independence, our souls— Light Spinner said, calling everyone's attention.

—Soul?— he uttered.

—Individuality makes us all precious in our own way— Perfuma chimed in. —There is no beauty in a world where everything is the same. If there weren't different flowers, we wouldn't be able to appreciate their beauty— she said, producing a set of assorted flowers. —We would tire of their presence sooner or later…

—I have never seen a more tainted life-form before…— he commented, tilting his head to the side as he took a closer look at the flowers.

—Tainted?— she repeated, surprised.

—You don't like the different colors and forms?— Entrapta asked.

—There must be but one superior design among them, making all the others nothing but imperfect copies— he assured them.

—That's not how flowers work…— the Princess countered.

—Leave it, Perfuma— Mermista interrupted. —I could show him all the marine fauna, and he would only try to find the perfect animal— she argued, rolling her eyes.

—Your world knows not true perfection.

—It depends on how you define "perfection". Your definition is far from ours— Queen Angella stated, poorly hiding her annoyance.

—I have been in the presence of such magnificence you couldn't begin to imagine it— Hordak argued.

And, while the discussion on perfection and individuality went on between Hordak, the Queen, and some princesses, the rest of the guests decided to ignore it and returned to their mingling through the party.

Quite a relief for Adora…

Castaspella had to fight her curiosity to stay away from the discussion too; a part of her wanted to join in, but she knew it wouldn't be a good idea. So, instead, she went for a few appetizers.

She was honestly expecting Micah to find her again and finally tell her whatever he meant to tell her, but he was apparently caught up in the discussion along with his wife. So, rather than him, it was Light Spinner who approached her.

—I'm surprised you made no comments after the claims of our… special guest— she said.

—What could I say? He sounds more stubborn than you— the sorceress replied, rolling her eyes.

—Perhaps… But at least I don't worship some so-called perfect superior being and wish everyone to submit to them…— she pointed out.

—That would be the only thing missing for you to finally become public enemy number one — Castaspella hissed.

—What an unexpected tone…

"Unexpected"?

The sorceress let out a deep sigh and turned to face her as she asked —Why are you talking to me now? I wasn't staring this time.

—I wanted to know your opinion on this… Hordak person.

—I don't know what to think, if I'm honest. And being *more* honest, I don't know why it is of your interest…

—Why wouldn't it be?

—Why *would* it be!? You ditched me! Again! It's clear I'm of no interest to you— Castaspella remarked, both angry and pained.

—I suppose I can't blame you for thinking like that— Light Spinner conceded. Looking away from the sorceress, she picked up a tiny cup and carefully drank it before adding — However, being in a relationship or not is unrelated to being interested in each other's opinions, wouldn't you say?

—I… don't think that applies here— she replied, her tone lower this time, although not any less angry. —Because, if you had any real interest in my opinion about literally anything, you wouldn't still refuse to give me a proper answer…

—I told you…

—There's "no particular reason"?— Castaspella interrupted her, her tone incredulous. —You said the same last time but turns out there *was* a reason, and one I found utterly ridiculous!

—If that will be your argument, no matter what "my reasons" are, then why do you even want to know?— the woman inquired, fully turning to look at her.

—Because if it *is* just something ridiculous, I want *you* to understand that! I-I don't intend to retain you against your will. If you don't love me like you did in times past, I understand. But…

—Whether I love you or not is…

—Don't say "irrelevant"— Castaspella pleaded. However, Light Spinner's absolute silence said enough. —If you will keep dismissing your feelings and prioritizing ridiculous things that I don't care about… then perhaps separating *was* the right choice— she stated, folding her arms and looking away.

All her body language screamed insecurity, sorrow, awkwardness even. So the woman didn't push the matter any further.

Without a word, she tilted her head at Castaspella as if bidding her farewell, and promptly left the party…

Chapter 19: Day 3: Dark Edge

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Day 3

Dark Edge

Third year

Early morning found Light Spinner with a cup of wine for breakfast.

She simply hated everything that day.

Why… Why did she have to miss her so much!?

After the events of the party in Dryl, she had retired early, as she felt unable to continue arguing with Castaspella while holding inside the truth about her decision. More specifically, as she felt unable to keep herself away from the sorceress' personal space.

Ugh, she wanted her again!

What wouldn't she give to have another taste of those lips, to embrace her curvy figure while allowing her hands to roam free…

She wished she could sleep with the sorceress at least one more night…

Furious at herself, she chugged down the rest of her wine, and slammed the cup down on the table, almost hard enough to break it.

—Don't ruin it all just yet, Beatrix— she told herself. —I know why I'm doing this… I know…

Meanwhile, back in Bright Moon, the Queen, the King, and Castaspella were sitting at the table sharing breakfast. They chatted about several things, but none as interesting for the sorceress as was her niece's compromise.

Taking advantage of Glimmer's absence, Angella and Castaspella had been discussing ideas for the wedding party, and kept slightly teasing Micah, which made him forget about the *very* important thing he had to tell his sister about.

It completely slipped his mind until much later, when he found her sitting alone in the gardens. The moment she opened up about how she was feeling, he remembered he still had to tell her what he overheard, and it was *the* perfect moment.

But first, he would hear her out…

—I don’t know how to do this anymore, Brother— she began.

—How to do what?

—*This*! Pretending I’m fine, pretending I’m alright living… *without* her! Pretending I feel nothing but contempt for her, as if I didn’t want… to… to have her close to me, as if I weren’t dying to hug her every time she steps into my personal space!

—Sis…

—I know it’s stupid! I know my happiness shouldn’t depend on a single person being with me, especially not *her*, but while I wouldn’t say she’s my happiness, I must admit she’s one of the conditions for me to be happy!— she insisted, expressing everything she had been holding inside. —What I mean is… it’s not that I can’t be happy without her, but rather… that I can’t be happy if someone I love, whom I *know* loves me back, isn’t with me! Because… because that’s the real problem! She… hasn’t said she no longer loves me…

—Then why did she leave you again?

—That’s what I don’t know! It’s what drives me insane!— she promptly replied, pacing around and throwing her hands up and down, emphasizing her exclamations. —If she didn’t love me anymore, I’d only have to… well… learn to live without her, little by little give up my feelings… eventually forget her… all of which I had *almost* done before her return two years ago! But now… it’s not the same because she hasn’t- She never- A-as she didn’t ever say that she doesn’t love me anymore, and because she even told me she still cares about my opinions, I can’t help but cling to the last bit of hope I have that maybe… she’ll eventually come back to me— Castaspella reflected.

Micah closed his eyes, took a deep breath, and exhaled deeply as he looked up at her again. Offering a hug, he approached and they both embraced for a silent moment.

—I can’t blame you for feeling like this… And you shouldn’t either— he eventually told her.

—I’m being stupid, Micah. She’s probably just toying with me…

—I disagree— he firmly stated, breaking the hug. It was time. —Listen, there’s something you need to know…

—About?— she asked, confused but interested.

—About why Light Spinner…

—King Micah!— someone interrupted, rushing into the gardens. —There you are! It is almost time!

—Please, just *please* let me talk to my sister!— he begged, no longer making any effort to hide how annoyed he was about being interrupted.

But the agitated servant completely missed his tone and insisted —We need to get you ready for the party at Dark Edge, King Micah! Your Majesty, the Queen, is expecting you!

—But I *am* ready!

—No, you're not!

—I am!

—This is ridiculous, your Majesty— the servant let out, with a pitiful expression. —But if you insist, then I'll have to comply.

—Thank you— he sighed.

—In that case, we have to depart at once!

—But…

—You can speak on the way there, your Majesty— the servant proposed, while ushering them both to the entrance.

—That's right, you can just tell me on the way there, Brother— Castaspella agreed, giggling. However, her smile vanished as soon as they crossed the threshold. Towards the right, the way they had to go, the Queen expected them both to finally be on their way to Dark Edge. However, to the left, the sorceress could see a familiar figure looking out through a large window. —Excuse me… You go first, I'll… catch up later— she told him, her tone low and serious, right before walking away.

And there she went; once again, he couldn't tell her.

All he wanted was to let her know what he overheard three months ago before she encountered Light Spinner again… And yet, there she was, walking with firm steps towards the woman, still oblivious of the truth…

—Good morning— she greeted the sorceress, without looking back at her. —Let me guess: you want to know what I'm doing here…

—Yes— Castaspella admitted, arms folded.

—I was admiring the view…

—Don't take me for a fool!

—I don't have to, Esmeralda… You make a fool of yourself without my help— she mocked her.

—You try so hard to be cruel to me that this is starting to look pitiful— the sorceress uttered, rolling her eyes. —Why are you here, at the palace, at this exact moment, instead of being on your way to Dark Edge or simply back at your home?

—Take a guess— Light Spinner challenged her, moving a step closer to Castaspella and leaning over her.

There was silence for a moment.

The sorceress' sight was fixed on the woman's emerald green eyes, who, in turn, stared back with the same intensity. If it weren't for the veil, they would be feeling each other's shallow breaths…

Castaspella's parted lips hadn't been so close to Light Spinner's face in such a long time that it made her *nostalgic*. She recalled all the times they were both in a similar situation, and how it would always lead to both of them kissing each other thirstily.

But the sorceress wouldn't let it happen this time.

She closed her mouth tightly, swallowed hard, and took a step back.

—We're not doing this…— she uttered. —I can't keep doing this with you.

—What do you mean?

—I can't just let you invade my personal space without consequences! I- Beatrix! I don't want to be but a toy to you!

—Who says I'm toying with you?

—I say so! You just- E-every time you step into my personal space, we end up… i-in each other's arms like… like we belong there! But it's clear you don't think we do, so just *stop* creating these situations in which it's either giving in to-to passion and lust, or having to force myself to remember that *you* ditched me again!

—Right…

—Beatrix!

—What?

—Can't you *please* take this seriously for *once*!?

—I may be a bit out of sorts this morning— she admitted, smirking under the veil.

—I can't believe you're already drunk… And it's the afternoon! The party at Dark Edge is about to begin!— she corrected her.

—Huh… Right. Perhaps I shouldn't go— she sighed.

—Why?

—If I have to hear that man… uh… "Hordak" speak about his "glorious" leader while calling us "imperfect and impure" again, I *will* chop his head off— she replied, looking away with disgust.

—Just ignore him…

—Easier said than done— the woman insisted.

—Bea, why don't you… try, at least, to have some fun at the party instead of…

—Don't pity me, Es. Not now…

—I would never— Castaspella immediately assured her. —But I can't help worrying… still.

—Alright— she sighed, after a deep breath. —I shall try, but don't say I didn't warn you…

—If necessary, I'll stop you, alright?

—You better— Light Spinner replied, smirking under the veil.

And it was as if she foresaw what would happen, because it didn't take long for the outsider and the woman to start a noisy argument that attracted the attention of the Queens of Dark Edge themselves.

—How can a lowly creature like you ever hope to understand *his* magnificence!?— Hordak defied her.

—How can a poor excuse of a paltry "clone" like you ever hope to be accepted again after being discarded!?— Light Spinner retorted, purposely trying to sound more wicked than necessary.

—I am a scion of Horde Prime! I was born from perfection and to perfection I shall strive!— he immediately replied. —But you were born from an impure species in an imperfect world — he went on. —You can't *ever* hope to know true perfection!

They were *almost* at each other's throats. So much so, that Adora had stopped eating to pay attention instead, ready to jump into action if necessary; after all, Hordak looked far more menacing now that he had a new exoskeleton reinforcing his atrophied muscles.

And while, for the most part, Castaspella had been telling herself it wasn't that bad yet, and that it wouldn't escalate much more, she eventually had to abandon the idea of finishing her meal.

—If I may…— Princess Entrapta tried to interrupt.

—No, you may *not*!— Light Spinner spat.

—You dare speak like that to her!?

—I speak like this to any and all princesses, why do you care!?— she angrily retorted.

—She, who can make me perfect at last, deserves- No, *demands* your respect! And so do I, who have reached a new stage of perfection!— Hordak argued.

—You think I care about whether you're perfect or not? I will not "respect" you just because you demand it. *Earn it*!— she began. —And I'll keep showing the Princess the minimum respect…

—Minimum is acceptable— Entrapta quickly assured, before Hordak could speak again. —Now, cease your argument. Please and thank you!— she told them both. —My calculations indicate the current state of discomfort between the guests is caused by your discussion, and is expected to be reduced by seventy-five percent if you cease at once— she explained.

—I see…— Hordak let out, pensive. —Understood.

—What the…

—Thanks, Hordak!— Entrapta exclaimed, interrupting the confused woman, and hooked her arm around his to drag him away.

As soon as they were gone, Light Spinner deflated. All her anger was gone, replaced by tiredness.

However, she looked even more intimidating like that…

The woman's first instinct was to look for Castaspella, but the sorceress was sitting with a large group of acolytes and she absolutely refused to approach them. Hence, after little thought, Light Spinner left Horror Hall and walked into the Crimson Waste, always making sure she stayed within the safe area, of course…

Just an hour or so had passed when King Micah found the woman sitting on a large vine that worked as a bench.

—Good evening, Light Spinner— he greeted her.

—I am not in a good mood. What do you need?— she grumpily asked, not even looking back at him when he sat next to her.

—I know.

—You know *what*?

—Why you left my sister this time— he specified.

—Do you? Then please, by all means, enlighten me— she mockingly said.

—I overheard your arrangement with Norwyn…

—Ah…

—And I *will* tell her about it— he promised.

—I can’t stop you…

—But it should be you telling her, not me…

—She will listen to you, Micah— Light Spinner argued. —We’ll have time to discuss it *afterwards*, trust me.

—Then you… *want me* to tell her?

—Of course— she nodded.

—Why?

—Because I’m just as tired as her of this pitiful game we’re playing.

—What does that mean?

—Wouldn’t you want to know?— the woman let out, smirking under the veil as she looked back at him.

—Just don’t… don’t hurt her anymore— he begged.

—I never intended to… And with any luck, she’ll see reason eventually and stop hurting on her own— the woman sighed.

—You really think she’ll accept that… arrangement? She’ll never be “okay” with it!

—I’ll make her see reason. She’ll have to understand. It’s not a sacrifice, it’s being *patient*.

—One would think you’d know her better by now…

—I do, that’s why I know what I will have to tell her *afterwards*— Light Spinner assured him. —Wait until tomorrow, take her aside, and tell her everything without much adornment or context. I’ll give her the necessary context once she comes to confront me.

—A-alright.

With his hands on his knees, he pressed forward slightly as he looked straight ahead, pensive. Light Spinner had her reasons… he kept repeating as much to himself.

But, as his sister would say, they were ridiculous reasons…

Chapter End Notes

I know, I'm evil. I still won't let you know what happened that made LS leave Casta...

EHE ;P

You'll soooooon soooooon know, I promise!!

On another note, however, the progress is not looking fine... I mean, I think I finished writing next chapter? I think? But I'm not fully contented with it, and I definitely don't have the rest of the chapters written at all at all
Can't even say I know what will happen... I have, like, an idea of where I want to go, what will happen in the end, but not HOW things will reach that point and that's NOT GOOD

So, let's hope I'll have a good ol' ADHD hyperfocus rush tomorrow so I can finish this thing once and for all... TT^TT

And thank everyone for reading!!! <3

Chapter 20: Day 4: Plumeria

Day 4

Plumeria

Third year

The party in Plumeria began quite early, like every year.

Since seeing her at breakfast, Micah had been itching to finally tell his sister everything he knew about Light Spinner's little deal with the Head Sorcerer, but he knew he had to be patient.

So this time, he waited until Princess Perfuma was done with her welcome speech to drag Castaspella away from the crowd.

—Alright, let me just… do this— he began, setting a barrier around them to make sure this time they wouldn't be interrupted. Once satisfied with the security measures taken, Micah took a deep breath and faced his sister. —Now, I'll finally explain it all, and *please* don't hate me for not mentioning it earlier…

—I won't, I won't. It's not such a big deal, Brother.

—It is.

—Alright, if you say so…— she sighed, letting out half a smirk.

—So, about… three months ago… I went to- Well, actually, I was looking for you, but I couldn't find you, so I went to Light Spinner's place to see if maybe you were there.

—Okay…

—And when I was almost there, I…

—Micah, your hesitation is making me nervous. *What* happened?— Castaspella interrupted, impatient.

—I saw Norwyn at the entrance.

—What?

—He was shaking hands with Light Spinner, and… I stayed hidden to eavesdrop on them…

—Brother, *what* are you talking about?— she asked, serious, stepping forward to grab Micah by the shoulders.

—You were always right: she never left you because she didn't love you, Sis. She did, because she struck a deal with Norwyn!

—Why!? Wha-what does the deal entail!?

—He promised to… well, to nominate you for Head Sorceress if she left you, a-and to speak with Adora to restore her powers— he told her.

—I can't believe…

—But she didn't care about her sorcery— he quickly interrupted. —She didn't want to exchange you for it. Norwyn's proposal was a bit more complex.

—How!?

—He told her that, if she was patient enough, once you're Head Sorceress, you could even lift the ban so she can return to Mystacor— he explained. —If you become Head Sorceress, you will have the freedom to restore your lives!

—What!? Head So- No, no, no! I don't- That's not- No!

—Casta, what do you mean?

—None of that makes any sense, Brother!

—I know what I heard, Sis. And it-it actually *makes* sense! Perhaps Light Spinner should have told you instead, but… she's really doing what's best for you— he argued.

—Bullshit, Micah!— she angrily retorted, hands closed in tight fists. —It's not as "good" as you think! And it's definitely not what's "best" for me!

—Casta…

—No, no. This is ridiculous, I cannot believe it at all.

—But, Sis…

—I refuse to believe that they mounted that whole scheme like that!

—It's the truth, Sis. Norwyn… apparently convinced her when he pointed out how she "must know" that her relationship with you kept you from growing in Mystacor's ranks…

—But I don't give a damn about Mystacor's ranks!

Her exclamation was barely muffled by Micah's spell, otherwise it would have called everyone's attention. And it certainly was enough for Micah to understand how mistaken he was.

—I'm sorry, Casta… I should have told you sooner— he uttered.

—Then why didn't you tell me before?

—Be-because… uh… well… I thought Light Spinner would tell you eventually… I hoped— he stammered.

—Well, she never did. Probably never would— she angrily huffed.

—Yesterday she told me *I* had to tell you because you would listen to me…

—I would have listened to her too!

—Would you?— Micah asked, serious.

—I-I… O-of course!

—I think we both know that's not entirely true, Sis— he pressed on.

—Then what do you think I would have done!?

—You would interrupt her arguing that it's ridiculous before ever hearing the whole story— he replied, not daring to look directly at her.

—But it *is* ridiculous! And I don't care whose idea the deal was, if she *knew me* , she would have *never* agreed to such stupidity!— Castaspella exclaimed.

Her increasing lack of control worried Micah more with each passing moment, and he no longer knew what to do.

—Casta…

—No, no. Forget it.

—Forget what?

—I can't be here today…

—Are you going to leave the party?

—Yes!

—But, Sis…

—Whatever you want to say, save it. Just…— she began, but interrupted herself, gesturing all around. —Get rid of these spells and let me go! Oh, and *you* will have to control that woman if she starts discussing with the man who came through the portal!

The King could only accept resignedly, and dismiss his spells. He watched as Castaspella walked away and eventually disappeared, then rejoined the party in time to find an unamusing scene: Light Spinner arguing with Hordak again, both of them most likely drunk.

—This has to be a punishment of some sort…— Micah sighed.

The woman and the "special guest" began the party far from each other, possibly on purpose; it did seem like Princess Entrapta and Adora were keeping Hordak away from Light Spinner. In the same way, Delwyn and Arden tried their best to keep her distracted with meaningless conversation.

At first, everything was going quite fine. Light Spinner even apologized to the ambassador's kids…

But then, that infamous plumerian distillate made its way to both of them, and gave everyone the impression they were far "calmer" than usual.

Believing that was their first mistake.

And the second was allowing them both to participate in the same conversation, even if they were sitting across each other, bonfire in between.

It still seemed like they were ready to jump on the other at any given moment.

—You must be insane to think a single person can subdue a whole planet— Light Spinner argued, her tone uneven.

—We are hundreds. Thousands! *Millions*, I dare say!— Hordak replied, gesturing with his hands again.

—So there's an army… And they all are like you?— she asked, incredulous. —What a joke…

—No. They are all *perfect*copies of our leader— he quickly corrected her. —But it's not just us. We have most powerful technology, weaponry, androids, and bots! You cannot fight against the might of the Horde!

—Etheria has *magic*, and that is not only more powerful than your technology, I'm sure, but also far more menacing than your army…

—Alright, now, calm down— Adora interrupted, with a nervous chuckle. —It's not like we're going to war against this… Horde Prime.

—Of course not— Hordak agreed, relieving her for about a minute. Until he added —I am sure you would recognize *his* prowess and voluntarily accept his rule, of course.

—What!?

Everyone around that bonfire exchanged nervous glances, most were shocked, and some confused.

Light Spinner stood up immediately and pointed at Hordak, accusatory.

—Oh, no…— Micah muttered, realizing this was about to escalate.

—You do not know the first thing about us, Etherians. We do *not* hand in our freedom without a fight!— she exclaimed. —I may not have my magic anymore, but I can, and *will*, use all my knowledge to keep fighting— she sentenced. —I can still craft potions that could melt your skin and the metal of your bots, and I have enough of a brain to strategize against your "perfect" leader— she assured him.

—You would dare defy *him*!?— Hordak exclaimed, shocked. He looked at everyone around him and realized they all had determined expressions that showed not even an ounce of hesitation. —Why?

—How would we not!?— Catra asked back.

—This is our planet. We'd never simply hand it in to the first tyrant that appears— Queen Angella argued.

—Don't you feel free, Hordak?— Bow gently asked.

—What… do you mean?

—You don't know what freedom is!?— Glimmer interceded.

—Freedom is being able to do whatever you please, whatever *you* wish to do. Not what some… hive mind tells you to do— Adora explained. —Just like now; you decided to come to these parties without him telling you to do so.

—But…

—And, you got this enhancement without his help or anything— Bow noticed. —He discarded you when you only needed some help to fix the incidents in your cloning— he pointed out. —Don't you like how you feel now? Thinking for yourself and improving on your own?

—This… is freedom?— he asked, looking down at his hands.

—It is— Light Spinner uttered. —Here you're free from that leader of yours. Yes, you can choose to pursue perfection to return to him, of course, that's part of what being free means… but you can take my word for it: perfection is a trap. Seeking perfection makes you slave to unrealistic standards— she assured him, condescending.

Adora and Catra exchanged a glance, surprised to hear *her*, of all people, saying this. And they weren't the only ones surprised; Micah knew full well how far Light Spinner had gone, pursuing power and perfection, so this was most unexpected coming from her.

Hordak stared at her for a while as everyone remained silent.

—Is… having a name being free?

—You could say so, yes— she nodded.

—Then… I… Hmm…— he hesitated. After a moment, however, he shook his head, as if trying to clear his mind, and angrily said —No. This… this drink you gave me is messing with my head! I do not need a name, and I don't care about yours either!

Hordak immediately turned around and walked away from the bonfire, leaving everyone quite shocked.

—But…— Entrapta sighed. —Hordak, wait!

She didn't miss a second and rushed after him before anyone could stop her. Light Spinner stared for a while, then rolled her eyes and stumbled back when she tried to sit down again.

—Perhaps I should leave too— she let out.

—Do you need help?— Arden offered.

—I'm fine, I can… handle myself— she assured them, but right after attempted to draw a spell, and it took her a moment too long to realize she… couldn't. —Ah, right.

—Are you *sure* you don't need help?— Delwyn insisted.

—I can still handle myself without magic— she groaned, and stood up again. —Good night to you all… I think it's better for me to retire before midnight; I know why I say it.

Indeed, it was close to midnight so, little by little, most of the guests retired.

After a while, the only ones left around that bonfire were Queen Angella and Micah, Adora and Catra, Arden, and Delwyn with his kids.

—Your Majesties, can we ask something?— Catra eventually dared say.

—O-of course— Micah agreed, surprised but mostly curious.

—We want to know what you think of Light Spinner. Would you say she has made any progress in the past years since… her sorcery was sealed away?

—That's a complicated question— Angella answered, noticing Micah was far too hesitant. —I don't think we are the best judges of that.

—Knowing her, well, I can say she has changed a lot, but… whether those changes were for the best…— Micah commented, but interrupted himself as he didn't know how to finish the sentence. He shook his head and tentatively concluded —At times it seems so, but then something happens, and it feels like you only imagined her progress.

—We had the same impression— Adora admitted.

—From experience, I believe the more she progresses, the worse her reversions will be. Because, as her ability to recognize when she's wrong gets better, her anger at herself only

increases, which results in far more violent fits of rage— Catra explained. —From what we heard, she's become far more petty, even if for a moment, but then eventually apologized for her behaviour, which is exactly what I referred too. Whenever she recognizes she was in the wrong, her first reaction is to be hateful about it, instinctively, because she's raging inside. Her fury is directed at herself, but it taints her interactions with others, making her bitter.

—That makes sense.

—At such moments, you hate everything because you hate yourself. So, until that feeling is gone, I wouldn't expect anything different— she concluded, looking away as she let out a sigh.

—Then, yes, that sounds like what has been happening— Micah confirmed. —We mostly heard things like that from Arden and Delwyn; besides them, hardly anyone interacts with Light Spinner. We seldom do, and Casta has… mostly been arguing with her every time they "interact".

—Hopefully, that won't continue that way— Queen Angella let out, casually.

—Has something changed?— Adora curiously asked.

—I don't know… What would you say, Dear?— she asked Micah, giving him a knowing look.

—Fine, yes. Probably now that Casta knows what actually happened three months ago, their interactions may be different— he accepted. —Whether that means they'll fight less, that I don't know— he then added. —It depends on how Light Spinner handles it when Casta goes to confront her. What she says and how…

—If anyone can see through her bitterness and self-hate, enough to discover what that woman is truly feeling, that's Castaspella— Adora assured them.

—But what if whatever she sees only worsens their relationship even more?— the King asked, noticeably worried.

—That will depend entirely on Light Spinner— Catra sentenced. —It's out of our hands.

—Of course, of course— Micah agreed. —But, um… thank you for your concern.

—Thank you too— Adora replied, smiling gently. —We should now speak to Arden and Ambassador Delwyn then.

The ambassador was still sitting in front of the bonfire with his children, who had fallen asleep on him, one on each side; he had also closed his eyes while embracing them, seemingly tired, but not enough to retire yet.

Adora approached him carefully, and gently called his attention.

—Oh, good evening— he managed to say, opening his eyes as soon as he felt her hand on his shoulder. —I apologize, but the night is so peaceful right now, I couldn't help closing my eyes for a moment— he excused himself. —Have we overstayed our visit?

—No, of course not— Adora reassured him. —You can stay for as long as you wish.

—Thank you. But… we still shouldn't.

—Then you'll probably need some help carrying them?— she giggled, referring to the sleeping kids.

—Yes— he admitted, letting out a breathless laugh.

—Would you… mind if we ask you a few things first? Then I'll gladly help you— she requested.

—Of course, I don't see why not— he agreed.

—Thank you— she said, before turning to gesture at Catra to approach.

—Evening— the Prince said, arriving with Arden in tow.

—Good evening— Delwyn greeted them. —So… what did you want to know?

—We… are asking about, you know, Light Spinner's behaviour as of late— Adora explained.

—Don't tell her for now, but as we're considering restoring her powers this year, we're doing a little… research first— Catra explained. —We aren't following her movements or anything, so we are talking with those who interact with her.

—I see…— Delwyn sighed, pensive.

—Dad— Kharyn called. —Can I?

—You want to… talk about Light Spinner?— he asked, confused. When his son nodded, he seemed surprised but allowed him. —Then, go ahead.

Kharyn turned to Adora and Catra and took a deep breath to begin —I- Um… I wanted to say… I think she's… a really cruel woman.

—Brother— Namai called, but he closed his fists tightly and shook his head.

—She was mean to dad and Arden. She took their concern for interest, accused them of having ulterior motives instead of real worry— he went on, looking away. —And for that, I told her she didn't deserve their concern— he admitted. As Catra and Adora exchanged a glance, he looked back at last, and concluded —But it doesn't mean she hasn't… improved. I think she's just… bitter because she's away from Casta. While she shows her sadness, Light Spinner doesn't, so instead she's… full of rage.

—Kharyn— Delwyn called, placing a hand on his shoulder and giving him a smile. —Thank you.

The kid nodded and Arden smiled too, quite moved.

—I agree with him— the magician said. —The woman… has a personality. We can't expect her to become a sweet person, but she's changed. Perhaps only for Casta, of course, but it's something.

—So you both think she'd be responsible with her sorcery back?— Catra asked, serious.

The ambassador glanced at Arden, and then back at them to say —No.

—No?

—Not in this… state— he added.

—You mean, alone?

—Without Casta, it's evident she thinks nothing is… worth it.

—That's right— Arden agreed. —As long as she can't be with her, she has no reasons to care at all about Etheria… Or so we thought.

—You don't think that anymore?

—Well, she said just earlier how she would fight for our freedom even without her magic— Delwyn reminded them. —I would take that as a sign of progress too. But, at the same time, she would probably consider her… project to be what we need to have an edge against Horde Prime if we *were* to go to war…

—Hopefully that won't happen, but I see your point— Catra let out, thoughtful. —Without someone keeping her in check, and as long as she believes we're threatened…

—We can't know what she will do— Adora completed, looking down. —Then, I guess it's… not a good time, indeed.

—You know why we're doing this, my Love— Catra said.

—Yes, I know.

—Thank you both, Princess Adora, Prince Catra— Delwyn said, tilting his head forward as if bowing.

—That's right, thank you. It's very considerate— Arden nodded. —I'm sure Casta would say the same— they added.

—We never intended to make this permanent. And the fact that, at least Casta thinks that there's goodness in her, enough to realize when she's wrong, gives me hope— Adora explained. —What I saw, however, is that her mind is… unstable, to say the least; so, when

she's out of sorts, there is *no way* she can recognize right from wrong without someone like Casta making her see reason— she went on. —So, I believe it's like you said: it's not the time yet.

—It will be, eventually— Catra assured her.

—I hope— Adora sighed. —Now, let me help you with your kids, Ambassador…

Chapter 21: Day 5: Salineas

Day 5

Salineas

Third year

When midnight arrived, Castaspella was grabbing her second bottle of sake from the kitchen…

On her way back to the room, she couldn't stop crying silent tears, but mainly, she couldn't stop cursing herself.

How had she been so stupid to let it happen again?

How had she allowed the same people to meddle in her life *yet again*?

And why did she have to adjust to whatever the Head Sorcerer wants… *again*!?

It all felt so unfair…

It *was* unfair!

But…

But what could she do?

The same old issue returned to haunt her, and yet she still had no idea what to do other than try her best to just… survive.

Once again, she found herself trying to understand why she was just "hanging on", waiting for something that may never arrive.

Alright, yes, last time it did arrive, even after five years, but… she lost it as fast as she got it. Not only once but *twice*. So why would she wait around for it yet again?

Even if she got Light Spinner back, in some unexpected turn of events, there would be no guarantee she wouldn't lose her again!

—Ugh!

She grunted loudly, making a guttural sound that echoed around the hall, and knocked back the bottle of sake without hesitation.

She wasn't exactly proud of how she was drinking right now, but she couldn't care less. The corridors were empty…

Or so she thought.

As she turned on the corner, she noticed a dark figure approaching, and hid the bottle behind her back, hoping to pass them by without a word.

However…

—Wandering the halls, are we?— the woman condescendingly said. —And here I thought you would be in your room, fast asleep like a good girl…

—Ah… you— Castaspella uttered, rolling her eyes. —Why on Etheria are you here?— she asked, with an uneven voice.

—Honestly? I don't know…— Light Spinner replied, looking away and sounding dismissive. —I suppose I tend to gravitate towards you when I'm drunk… Don't I?

—Funny you think so… Must mean you haven't been drunk the last three months, uh?

—Smart…— the woman recognized, tilting her head to the side, smirking under the veil, and leaning forward ever so slightly, towering over Castaspella.

—I know what you're thinking, and I'm not letting that happen— the sorceress stopped her. Wanting to avoid the inevitable, because yes, they always ended up sleeping together when drunk and angry, she decided to confront her. —We have something to discuss.

—Here in the middle of the corridor?

—Ugh… Fine. Follow me. But *don't* think I'm letting this go anywhere…

—As you wish, Es.

Castaspella huffed and stalked towards her room, followed closely by Light Spinner. Once they were both inside, door closed, the sorceress put down the bottle and turned to face the woman.

—Micah told me why you left me— she began. —Is it all true?

—What if it's true?— Light Spinner asked back.

—Then you're an idiot, and I'm utterly pissed!

—Of course you would be.

—But you don't know why. So let me tell you: I'm angry because you made a deal with Norwyn despite everything that has happened the last two years, because you made a *ridiculous* deal knowing full well I couldn't care less about my position in Mystacor, and because you didn't even tell me yourself!

—This reaction is why I didn't tell you before, and I preferred it if Micah told you because I knew you would listen to him— Light Spinner argued.

—But what I'm pissed about the most is that this only proves that you *do not know me*, even after so many years!— Castaspella added, feeling tears form in her eyes.

—I know you, Esmeralda, far too well. That's why I'm doing what's best for you in this way. You wouldn't do it yourself. Your foolish feelings keep you from achieving greatness!— she insisted.

—*Foolish feelings*!?— the sorceress repeated, before finally breaking down. —You don't understand the first thing about love, do you!? I told you so many times, I don't care about greatness! I don't… I-I'm so- You have no idea how hurt I felt, and still feel, since you left me again, after promising last year that you *wouldn't* leave me again!— she began, unable to control herself anymore. —Was me almost dying not enough for you to, I don't know, see that we may not have as much time as you think to spend together before one of us- Ugh!

—Es…— Light Spinner sighed, taking a step forward.

—I never *ever* wanted to "grow in Mystacor's ranks" at the expense of losing you! I've said it a million times, but you never seem to listen!

Of course… she was right.

The woman couldn't help it anymore and finally closed the distance to embrace the crying sorceress.

—You know I can't bear seeing you cry…— she muttered, holding her tightly. —Es, when I told you two years ago that there are far more skilled sorcerers who should have Norwyn's place… I was talking about *you*— she explained, sighing.

—You told me last year, remember?— Castaspella reminded her, between sobs. —And I said, back then, that I didn't want to exchange you for a position…

—Yes, I… know.

Fully leaning on her, the sorceress added —You said you understood… So, why?

—Norwyn came to me with an offer I considered most beneficial— Light Spinner replied, caressing her hair. —I just want… what's best for you— she insisted, now tilting the sorceress' head up to look her in the eyes. —And, for once, I considered his decision to be most sensible— she added. Leaning forward until their lips brushed, she concluded —I'd give anything for you…

—But… why give *me* up… *for me*?— Castaspella asked, voice broken and breathless.

Light Spinner didn't reply, just closed the gap and, through the veil, they finally kissed once again, for the first time in months…

The sorceress was still crying as they kissed, but they were both equally thirsty, having missed each other so much. She got the veil out of the way, guided the woman towards the couch, and they kept on kissing for a long while.

Castaspella made it clear she didn't want to do anything else so, as the night advanced, they eventually fell asleep, cuddling together.

When morning arrived, they were far too comfortable in each other's arms. They both woke up at the same time, stirred a bit, but didn't open their eyes.

—Es?— Light Spinner groggily muttered.

—Bea?

—Morning…

—Good morning…— the sorceress replied, smiling a bit.

—Hmm… I missed this.

—I missed cuddling you too— she admitted.

—Perhaps you're right…

—About?

—How stupid I was… to give up all of this— the woman explained.

—Yes, you were… Fool— Castaspella giggled.

—Whatever shall I do about it?

—What about resigning that stupid deal?

—Sorry, nor can do, Es…

—Why?

—I'm not wasting all the time I've been away from you… We just have to wait until the last day of the year, and you will become Head Sorceress— Light Spinner replied.

—You still… won't understand— the sorceress muttered, before pulling herself free from the woman's embrace.

—Wait, Es…

—I told you I'm tired of waiting, Beatrix.

Despite the morning ending in quite a bitter tone, it was notorious how much Castaspella's mood had improved. So, when the party at Salineas began, no one hesitated to mention how happy they were to see the sorceress is such good spirits.

But every time someone mentioned that, her expression would darken a bit, and she would dismiss it…

It was a bittersweet feeling. Yes, she was feeling much better, but still heart-broken and wondering what to do with the information Light Spinner revealed to her.

—What are you thinking about?— a voice suddenly said, extracting Castaspella from her reflections.

—Oh, goodness, Arden— she reacted. —It's just… Well, nothing important.

—It doesn't look like that.

—I swear it's… nothing.

—Are you sure it's not? Because *someone* told me you…

—Who is that someone?— the sorceress interrupted them.

—Fine, it's Light Spinner. She said that now you know what happened three months ago— they admitted.

—Yes, and I'm as disappointed as you'd expect.

—Even though it got you quite an opportunity?

—One I *do not* want!

—Then what will you do?

—I don't know yet— she sighed, looking away. —Now it's *my* turn to call Norwyn a…

—To call me what?

Norwyn's sudden appearance interrupted Castaspella right in time.

—I- No, um… I wasn't going to- Ahem— she stammered, and cleared her throat. —I was just going to say that…

—Don't fret, Castaspella. I didn't come to interrogate you— he interrupted her, raising his hand. —I just intended to ask you how you are enjoying the party.

—Quite, indeed. Thank you, Head Sorcerer.

—Let's hope nothing happens to you this year. It… seems like you always tend to have some kind of incident here in Salineas— he pointed out.

—You're… right, yes. But I don't see why that should happen again— she replied, a bit ashamed.

—Well, excuse me, I have other matters to attend to. Oh, and I believe you have already been issued your duties for this year.

—Yes, of course— she lied, as she didn't even know *where* the letter with her duties was.

—Good.

And so, apparently having bought the lie, he finally left.

Castaspella stared after him, confused, then looked back at Arden, who had a suspicious frown.

—What?

—Is there… anything wrong with him?

—Why wrong?

—He was too nice…

—Well… it may be related to what… Bea said. To what she did…

—Please explain— they begged. —She refused to share any details.

—Three months ago, she made a deal with him; he offered… to nominate me for Head Sorceress if she left me— she explained, looking down at her hands. —Now, she's sure I will- That at Mystacor's party I'll be given the title.

—What!? Oh, Stars, Casta! That's…

—Don't say "great", please. That's what I don't know what to do about— she interrupted them.

—Oh… I see— they deflated. —In that case, I'm sorry…

—Don't worry. I don't want to dampen the mood, you know— she apologetically said.

—But I don't want you to be all gloomy here, either.

—I'll be… fine.

It could be said she was indeed fine the rest of the party. There were no incidents this time, and she had a relatively uneventful night.

Until, of course, a new argument broke out between Light Spinner and Hordak.

It was getting repetitive as they always fought over the same matters and, this time, Castaspella had to get between them both to keep the woman from throwing her hands around his neck.

The problem began when, by mere chance, Light Spinner overheard Hordak say he planned to contact Horde Prime so that he may know of his progress in achieving perfection, and so that he could come to purify Etheria. Several people began speaking against him, but only Light Spinner approached him, yelling with rage.

—How dare you!? This world welcomed you! We have tried to teach you about freedom! And yet you haven't learnt anything!

—Wait, wait!— Castaspella exclaimed, suddenly stepping in front of her, hands raised. —Please, calm down.

—How can I calm down when he threatens our world!?

—Bea… why are you getting so worked up?

—I abandoned my people long ago. They didn't want to fight, so I left them to die without so much as a "good luck"! Do you want me to do that again!?— she roared.

—No, no. But, please… you can't just jump on him like this. It won't help anyone. You won't solve anything with violence— the sorceress insisted.

—You have too much faith in people sometimes— Light Spinner hissed. She then walked past her and approached Hordak again, spatting —You're nothing but a pitiful man with a poor little brain that can't process anything other than the tyrannical teachings of your so-called perfect leader!

—Beatrix— Castaspella severely said, grabbing her by the arms before she could reach him.

—Grow a backbone! Think for yourself!

—You have no right to speak about *him*— Hordak said, frowning but surprisingly calm. —How can you know he won't improve your lives?

—At the cost of our freedom!?

—What is so… good about this freedom you fear losing? You have no guide, no one to show you the right path— he argued, still quite calm, albeit sounding just as angry as Light Spinner.

—We must find the right path ourselves— the woman hissed. —I have made so many mistakes, I can tell you, it certainly has *not* been easy for me to take responsibility for my actions. But I freely chose to do everything I've done, and wouldn't ever let anyone else decide that for me. Even if they could keep me from making any more mistakes!

—Then you are a fool for rejecting perfection— Hordak replied, fists tightly closed as he tilted forwards, seemingly wanting to approach her too.

—But what if it isn't perfection what Horde Prime offers?— Entrapta asked in a tone that surprised everyone around them. Stammering a bit, she returned to her usual manner of

speech as she said —I-I've run all kinds of calculations a-and found it's a ninety-six percent improbable that the perfection you talk about can ever be achieved… Even by you.

—No! I-I can! I'm a scion of *his* perfection!

—Whatever makes you think Horde Prime is perfect!?— Prince Catra joined in. —All you've ever known was the Horde you came from, so how exactly would you be able to tell what perfection is?

—I… No, I-I can't doubt now— he let out, shaking his head. —Stop confusing me!

—Hordak…— Entrapta called, concerned.

—Stop calling me that!— he exclaimed.

—Go ahead. Keep rejecting freedom… And face the consequences when the time comes and your leader rejects you again— Light Spinner spoke, her tone acid. Castaspella was still holding her back, but now she wasn't trying to approach him anymore; just squinted at him with disgust. —You will have to face it sooner or later: perfection is an illusion.

With that, she finally gave up and took a step back; the sorceress released her, and she walked away, fuming.

The party ended a little after; neither Hordak nor Light Spinner were seen after that, and many concerned guests went to either Princess Entrapta or Queen Angella to beg them not to let Hordak call his leader like he had said.

Meanwhile, the Head Sorcerer sat alone and pondered for a while. Eventually, he left the party and went to look for Light Spinner at her home.

She opened soon after he knocked, and her expression betrayed her disappointment.

—Good evening, Light Spinner.

—It is almost midnight, Norwyn. What *are* you doing here?

He took a deep breath, looked away briefly, and finally explained —I came to see if our deal is still on.

—Why wouldn't it be?

—Well, Castaspella seemed far less upset at you, and it was quite sudden. The way she held you back tonight…

—Are you really complaining?— she asked, her tone incredulous. Without either of them noticing, someone arrived right that moment but kept hidden, listening in as Light Spinner went on —But to answer your… indirect question, no. Castaspella and I are not back together or anything. The deal is still on.

—I see.

—You should be thankful I still listen to her— she quickly added, severe. —Otherwise, no one would be able to keep me from unleashing my fury to my heart's content. With or without magic… I can still easily use potions to get my way. So do *not* test my limits— she then warned him.

—Understood, Light Spinner. I'll take your word for it— Norwyn finally accepted, vowing slightly as a farewell.

Castaspella remained there hidden, eyes closed, holding her breath while on the verge of tears, and the woman never noticed her. She could hardly believe it. The sorceress had to wait until she returned inside before finally rushing back to Bright Moon, head reeling…

Chapter 22: Day 6: Kingdom of Snows

Chapter Notes

Omgs, sorry for the delay!! I really needed to sleep, but it's still the 30th, so it's still on time!!!

I hope you enjoy! We're almost done!!

Day 6

Kingdom of Snows

Third year

Arriving at the Kingdom of Snows the following day wasn't easy for Light Spinner. She had rejected all the help she was offered because she didn't want to go at first… until she learnt that Castaspella had overheard her the previous night. The servants in the palace of Bright Moon were gossiping about how late the sorceress returned, crying so much she didn't notice them, and it all made sense to her.

Hence, she had no choice but to brave the snow with her potions alone; now that she knew this, she needed to speak with Castaspella as soon as possible…

So, when she arrived at the party, her third and last warming potion almost worn out, the guards had to rush to get her a coat. Ambassador Delwyn happened to have just arrived and saw it all with a confused expression; he had been one to offer the woman help, had been emphatically rejected, and absolutely didn't expect her to be there that evening.

—Light Spinner?— he called, approaching carefully.

—I know… But things changed— she said, guessing what he would ask her. —I need to speak with Casta *now*. Where is she?

—I'm sorry, I just arrived. I wouldn't know…

—Then I'll find her myself— she decided, walking past him while embracing herself, wanting the coat to warm her up faster.

It didn't take her long to spot the sorceress chatting with Arden and Micah, but as soon as Castaspella noticed her approaching, she promptly walked away, not even giving them a reason.

—What was that?— the King asked, confused, until he and the magician turned to see Light Spinner. —Oh…

—Evening— she greeted them. —Before you ask, no. I wasn't coming to the party, but I *have* to speak with Casta— she explained. —Where did she go?

—She didn't say— Arden replied, looking away. —But she's obviously avoiding you, I'm afraid…

—Then I'll have to keep searching.

—What happened now, Light Spinner?— Micah asked.

—I believe she heard something last night that may not- Ugh… Something we should discuss before she does something stupid— the woman explained, noticeably frustrated.

—Then we should help you, no?— Arden proposed.

—It's not necessary.

—Let us— Micah pleaded. —She didn't say anything, but it's obvious in her expression. You two should talk as soon as possible.

With that, the three of them parted ways to cover more space, and eventually managed to lure Castaspella into a "trap", so to speak.

After Frosta's speech, Arden found the sorceress talking with Delwyn and used a little spell to let Micah know without anyone noticing. In turn, the King went to look for Light Spinner and told her to hide in the room full of coats. There she would wait for Castaspella.

With everything ready, he set the plan into motion…

—Hey! There you all are!— Micah exclaimed, approaching them three. He gave Delwyn a look, like a warning, and subtly nodded at Arden, before addressing his sister. —Casta, you need to try this…

—What is it?

—I don't know, but it's good!— he insisted, pretending to be drunk while passing her a full chalice. And just as she was about to grab it, he subtly let it slip through his fingers. —Oh, Stars! So-sorry, Sis— he apologized, exaggerating just a tiny bit. —You should probably get another coat— he suggested, with an ashamed laugh.

—Goodness, Brother. I can't believe you still can't hold your wine…

—I'm really sorry…— he let out, still looking apologetic and ashamed until she was far enough. —Good luck, Sis— he finally let out, dropping the act.

—That's all we could do, King Micah— Arden said. —Now it's Light Spinner's turn.

Indeed, just as they said, it was all they could do. When the sorceress stepped into the room full of coats, groaning as she searched for a new one that felt comfortable but also combined with her clothes, a figure emerged from behind the racks and Castaspella almost jumped back.

—What on Etheria!? Beatrix!

—Es…

—What are you doing here!?

—I need to speak with you. I couldn't find you today…

—Because I was avoiding you— she interrupted, angry.

—I suppose… it's because you heard us last night?

—Yes! And just like you, I decided to-to simply stay away!

—Es…— Light Spinner sighed, approaching.

—No!— she quickly refused, stepping back. —Don't you dare!

—Please, listen to me at least— she pleaded.

They both were too focused on each other to notice the man that walked into the room for a second; he quickly stepped back out, having heard their loud voices, but remained there, curious.

Hordak frowned in confusion as he heard Castaspella retort —You didn't give me such a chance, so why should *I* listen to you now!?

—Just because I was a fool and a jerk, you'll be the same?— the woman asked back, a bit too cocky for the sorceress' taste.

—Oh, no. You are *not* playing that card like it's nothing! You, hypocrite!

Castaspella couldn't take it anymore; she broke down, feeling unable to keep calm much longer, and began crying. She just couldn't hold it back…

—Es, please— Light Spinner sighed, closing the distance to embrace her without hesitation. The sorceress fought at first, trying to break free from her, but crying weakened her, so it wasn't long until she gave up and leant on the woman. —I know it hurts… It hurts me too. But that's why I'm asking you to be patient, please. Just… do it for us. Do it for all the time we have had to suffer…

—I can't… It's no-not just… so simple!

—Es, understand. All I've done, all you've suffered, it will mean nothing if we ruin this being so close to the finish line!

—But I can't…

—Please…

—Bea, I love you! I can't do this!

—You can— the woman insisted, holding her closer and caressing her hair slowly. —It will be our final act, our final goodbye, only until you step up as Head Sorceress and make it possible for us to share a future in Mystacor.

—You're… too confident— Castaspella sobbed, finally managing to push Light Spinner away from her. —Forget it. Leave me alone and let me grab a coat— she requested, folding her arms and looking away.

—Ah… Alright— she resignedly agreed. —Just… Please think very well about what you will do tomorrow…

—And you should think very well about what you *say* you feel for me— the sorceress retorted, without looking back. —And start acting accordingly…

That hurt her.

It always hurt when Castaspella cast doubt upon her feelings.

She was, in fact, so pained, that she didn't notice Hordak on her way out.

The man stood there, confused, not knowing how to interpret the display of passion he had witnessed.

However, he was too curious, and saw no reason why he couldn't just… talk to this sorrowful sorceress.

—It's a shame how you all devote your love to people who don't appreciate it…— he began, startling Castaspella. As she turned to look at him, eyes wide open in surprise, he went on —Horde Prime would *never* do such a thing, no. He holds everyone within the light of his love.

—What?

—We are all his most precious possessions, that's why we must be perfect— he assured her. —All our efforts are repaid in kind, and far more.

—What are you trying to say, Hordak?— she asked again, still sniffing a bit but no longer crying.

He approached a bit and, in a manner that seemed almost empathetic, he said —That all this effort you put into one person, the love you seek, and the love you give, it would never go to waste if you dedicated yourself to *him*.

—Well that… sounds like a nice change of pace— Castaspella first said, letting out a breathless laugh. —But, I can't help feeling it also sounds like he's just a tyrant trying to control everyone through so-called love instead of fear. But… That's only brainwashing, Hordak. If you loved yourself as you are, you'd see you don't need to be perfect to be loved back.

—What makes you say that? Why wouldn't you want his love?— he asked, genuinely confused.

—Because love isn’t something to be given only to those who will return it— she began. —Much as it hurts us, we don’t choose who we love; honest love can’t be controlled, it just… happens.

—I don’t understand…

—One can't decide who they feel love towards, and it won't just fade only because that love is not mutual.

—Then *what* is the point!?

—There is no point, Hordak— she replied, placing a hand on his shoulder. —Love, like freedom, can’t be encapsulated by simple definitions. You need to experience them to understand.

—So you… choose to suffer and cry?

—I choose to love freely…

She gave him a gentle smile, he looked back in confusion, blushing slightly, and didn’t move until she left the room.

—But why?

The sorceress never heard the question, but part of her supposed he probably wondered as much. Talking to Hordak had been… interesting, to put it some way. Especially after her argument with Light Spinner. In a weird, indirect manner, he had helped her calm down; not only did she stop crying, she also felt better, more confident in her feelings, and sure of what she had to do the next day.

That general wellness of hers was taken as a good sign by her brother, the ambassador, and the magician. The three of them went to look for Light Spinner to ask, but the woman had left the party once again, although not before apologizing to Princess Frosta herself.

Remembering previous years, some of the guests were a bit nervous knowing the woman left so early, so the princess gave in and revealed that Light Spinner had thanked her for the hospitality, praised the beautiful decoration and enjoyable atmosphere, but elected to retire before making a scene arguing with their special guest.

—Since when is that woman so considerate?

—Considerate with whom?

—Everyone other than herself!

A couple of partygoers discussed that as Castaspella walked by, and she couldn’t help stopping to listen. However, they noticed her, and immediately changed subjects…

—Of course— she muttered, continuing on her way. She took a deep breath with her eyes closed for a second, and opened them in time to see she was about to walk into the Head Sorcerer. —Oh! I'm so sorry…

—Don't fret, Castaspella. I was just looking for you.

—You were?

—Yes. You said yesterday that you received your instructions for tomorrow, but I wonder… did you open the envelope?

—I'm… sorry, Head Sorcerer. I don't really know where the envelope is…— she had to admit, looking away.

—Ah… I see— he sighed. —In any case, that would be irrelevant. The envelope was supposed to be empty, after all…

—I'm sorry?

—You're dismissed from duties for tomorrow. You're only expected to attend— he explained.

Castaspella stared at him with a mix of confusion and indignation.

She was dismissed!? But from duties and just expected to attend!?

Was this because of what Beatrix said? Would she really be given the title of Head of the guild?

—I don't think I understand…

—I think you do— Norwyn interrupted. —But I won't bother you any longer. Enjoy the party — he farewelled, walking away before she could reply.

She was left alone, blinking in utter disbelief, head empty.

—Casta?

She was shaken awake from her momentary trance by Namai's voice.

—Oh, my Stars… I'm sorry, what happened?— she said, shaking her head slightly and putting a gentle smile on her face.

—Are you alright?

—Yes, yes. Please don't worry.

—Father is talking with the King. They are worried. Did the Head Sorcerer say something mean?

—No, not mean. Just… confusing. But never mind, it's quite alright— she assured her. —Why don't we go for something to eat?

The girl nodded enthusiastically and they both walked across the dance floor to pick up a plate each. However, such a simple action was enough to darken Castaspella's mood again.

She was reminded of the last time she danced with Light Spinner… and realized she missed dancing with her.

The times they danced without any music, under the moonlight, alone at home, sometimes dressed, sometimes naked…

The times they danced to the music of a party, amidst the crowd, but as if they were the only ones on the dance floor…

What wouldn't she give for one more dance…

Meanwhile, at the Princesses' table, a curious conversation kept their attention. It had started earlier, when Entrapta invited Hordak to join them; he had just spoken to Castaspella, and his puzzlement was evident in his expression, so they all asked what he was thinking about.

Without any context, he asked what love and freedom have in common.

After many unsatisfactory replies of all kinds, he questioned once more —But how can you choose to love freely, if you can't decide *who* you love? Is love free or not?

—Do you even understand what love is?— Prince Catra asked back.

—I don't think I do, but I was told… I had to experience it— he replied, sounding quite angry. —Why would I want to experience something so complicated it can't be explained?

—It's… definitely more complicated to understand than science— Entrapta agreed. —But it's not difficult to feel! You just have to allow it! Love can be felt for anything! I *love* science! And tiny things!— she cheerfully said.

—She's right. Love can be felt for anything, even yourself— Glimmer nodded.

—Especially for yourself— Bow remarked. —Through loving yourself, you learn to love others, and learn to appreciate individuality… freedom.

—To love is to embrace and appreciate all of what makes someone or something the way they are— Scorpia said. —And to be free, is to be able to *express* all of what makes you who you are… What we call individuality, or personality, or soul— she concluded, looking at him with gentleness.

—Hmm…— Hordak hummed, looking down with a pensive frown. —So… what love and freedom would have in common is this… *soul* you've told me about. What that woman said…

—That's… a way of putting it, I guess— Mermista accepted. —If you consider how you can't feel love if you have no soul, and how you can't have a soul if you're not free…

—Not in the literal sense, of course. I think we all have a soul but it can't flourish without freedom— Perfuma chimed in.

—Yes, yes. That. But the point is, he's… right— Mermista concluded.

—I would say so, yes— Adora agreed.

—Then why is that woman- Hmm…— he began asking, but interrupted himself.

—Who are you talking about?

—The woman with her face covered— he replied. —She first mentioned this "soul" thing, but it doesn't sound like she's… free— he added.

—What do you mean?— Glimmer asked, confused.

—I heard her today, speaking to the sorceress that stopped her yesterday— he began. —I then spoke to the sorceress and she said you can't choose who you love, that she chooses to love freely. In contrast to her, it sounds like that woman isn't "loving freely"; there are rules she's following that won't let her, and instead of defying those rules, she wants to… change the ruler entirely.

—I'm so confused…

—So am I— Adora had to admit, looking back at Glimmer. —Can you start from the beginning?

—Hold on— Catra interrupted. —Hordak, the woman with her face covered is called Light Spinner, and the sorceress is called Castaspella. Now tell us what you heard, please.

—Alright— he sighed, a bit exasperated. —The wo- Light Spinner and… Castaspella, they were arguing; they spoke about a deal, and Light Spinner told her to be patient, that after tomorrow, when she would become Head Sorceress, whatever that is, they would be together again— he began, shocking them all. —But Castaspella doesn't want to be Head Sorceress, so she was… crying. She only told Light Spinner she can't because she loves her.

—What happened then!?— Perfuma asked, intrigued.

—When she left, I spoke to Castaspella, told her Horde Prime would never reject her love like that, but she said he sounds like a tyrant, that his love is just… brainwashing— he told them. —She is suffering and crying *because* she chooses to love a woman who isn't choosing the same.

—Hold on, he's right!— Glimmer exclaimed. —Instead of going against the rules of Mystacor, she's trying to get the rules to change by… changing the ruler!

—I don’t know if that’s incredibly smart or incredibly stupid— Mermista uttered, rolling her eyes.

—This explains a lot…— Catra sighed, pressing her temples. —Are we going to let this happen?

—We can’t do anything about it— Adora pointed out. —It’s… ironic but this would be the first time I hear of her actually respecting authority.

—Just how twisted is that woman’s brain?

—Enough that even progress seems *wrong*.

—Then… what are you going to do?— Bow asked them, now concerned.

—We should wait until tomorrow— Catra decided.

—We’ll see what happens and… hope for the best— Adora agreed.

—I feel bad… gambling with Auntie’s feelings like this— Glimmer lamented, looking down.

—No one is gambling with her feelings, my Love— Bow quickly said. —I think Casta is the one in control now. No one can force her to do anything she doesn’t want to do. Let’s trust her, alright?

—Alright…

Chapter 23: Day 7: Mystacor

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Day 7

Mystacor

Third year

The last day had arrived.

Castaspella could hardly sleep that night, anxious about what would happen at Mystacor's party, and lamented not having to prepare any food this time. She would have cooked some desserts regardless… if she weren't banned from the kitchen at Bright Moon!

In fact, she was so restless she considered going to Light Spinner's place and raid the kitchen… But that wouldn't be a good idea, not after everything she told the woman.

Hence, she could only sit to knit all night. But it wasn't even relaxing, she mostly messed up a lot; the stitches were too tight, she missed a few loops, or stitched two together by accident…

By the time the sun entered the room, she was on her fifteenth try at knitting a scarf. Obviously, she gave up, threw the knitting on the bed, and went for breakfast.

—Good morning— Micah said, arriving at the dining room a few hours later. —Ho-how long have you been here?

—Since sunrise— she replied, monotonous.

—Did you sleep?

—No?

—Um… Sis, are you okay?

—I'm fine— she replied, raising the pitch of her voice a bit.

He recognized it was a lie. With that tone, he knew he should be concerned.

—What has been happening, Casta? You're obviously not okay, especially since yesterday after talking to Norwyn.

—It's nothing, Brother…

—Please— he begged, placing a hand on her shoulder.

—Listen, I'm just a bit… nervous, I guess. You'll soon know why— she finally admitted.

—Is something going to happen at today's party?

—Yes.

—Is it perchance related to the deal Norwyn and Light Spinner made?

—Yes— she said again, not looking back at him.

—But, he only promised to nominate you… maybe you won't be chosen— he pointed out.

—Beatrix is convinced I will… Norwyn did *not* assign me any duties this year and told me I'm just expected to attend… He's also been far more polite than usual, even Arden was suspicious— she enumerated. —I said you'll soon know, because I knew you'd doubt it.

—Well, it… sounds improbable with how much contempt the council has shown towards you, but… it would be for the best so that Light Spinner's sacrifice isn't in vain— he replied.

That again…

—Why does everyone think it's a good thing!? I don't want the title! I only want Beatrix! Am I so wrong for wishing she'd feel the same!? Is it too selfish to want her to stop doing what she *thinks* is best for me without ever caring for what *I* think!? For what I feel!?

Castaspella's outburst left Micah speechless.

He shyly began —No, of course. You're right… I just- Well, it would be beneficial for you both to have the authority to finally choose her without being demoted for it, but…

—But I don't want that. And, like I said before, you'll soon know why. You all will— she interrupted, severe. —So I suppose I'll see you later at the party…

She walked past him and left the room, leaving the King distraught.

—I'm sorry, Sis— he muttered, lowering his head.

Afternoon arrived fast, and the guests of Mystacor soon filled the area prepared outside. Almost all tables were occupied, even the ones for unexpected guests, so some were mingling instead, hoping a seat would soon be open.

When the King and the Queen arrived, they first searched for Castaspella; Micah was still worried and, having told Angella, so was she.

However, instead of her, they could only find Light Spinner, leaning against a wall near a corner, drinking alone.

—Good evening, your Majesties— she greeted them.

—Evening— Micah replied, briskly. —Have you seen Casta?

—Not yet…

—Damn it— he complained. —If you see her, tell her I'm looking for her, please.

—I believe that will be difficult as she's avoiding me…

—Really?

—Can't blame her— Angella uttered. Light Spinner raised a brow and she added —You went against her wishes and haven't listened to her at all; she loves you so much she can't simply hate you for it. Of course she's avoiding you!

—Right— she scoffed. —I'm the heartless, cold, and cruel bitch everyone believes me to be… Am I not?

—I-I'm sure she didn't mean it that way— Micah rushed to say. —It's just that… ma-maybe you should be more understanding.

—I can't be understanding of her insensible decisions. I did what I had to, to make sure her future won't be wasted just because of her feelings for me— the woman argued.

—She doesn't see it that way— the Queen insisted. —Hasn't she told you that about a million times!?

—She's too naïve.

—Light Spinner, I don't think…— Angella was saying, when she got interrupted by the Head Sorcerer calling everyone's attention.

As he began speaking, the three of them approached to hear him better; they knew it was time. While he welcomed everyone to the party, Micah looked around and finally found Castaspella standing near the doors.

Right as he let them know, Norwyn began —Now, I hope you don't mind if we open this last party of the year with an important ceremony. It's the end of a cycle, and the beginning of a new one; befitting for this day, we believe.

—It's truly happening— Micah muttered.

—I will now allow our foreman-councilman to take the word and direct this important ceremony— he concluded, taking a few steps back to join the rest of the council while another man, short and chubby, went to stand in his place.

—Hello, everyone. As a representative of the council, I extend our sincere thanks for your attendance and hope you will enjoy today's party like every year— he first said. —It is my duty to share this day some important news: Our Head Sorcerer, Norwyn, has decided to retire.

The crowd began whispering in surprise, some in disbelief and some in confusion. Near the back, Hordak and Princess Entrapta were standing with Glimmer and Bow, who had to briefly explain to the man what this all meant. He remained puzzled until Entrapta told him this ceremony to elect a ruler would be like choosing who leads the Horde.

—If, one day, Horde Prime decided to retire, someone else would have to take his place, right?

—That would never happen; no one could fill his place.

—Well, I don't know how your species works but we are finite species and will eventually die of old age if no accidents happen— she explained. —So a new leader is necessary.

—Hmm… Then this must be like Lord Prime's transference ceremony— he reflected. —When his body shows signs of decay, he chooses a new vessel, maintaining his magnificent perfection. But you are not clones, so you must choose someone new to replace the previous leader— he realized.

—Exactly!— Entrapta excitedly agreed, while Bow and Glimmer exchanged a concerned look.

They couldn't speak any further because the foreman-councilman called everyone's attention once more.

—I believe you've had enough time to process the news, so I shall now proceed with the ceremony— he declared. —The council has chosen one among many candidates to be the successor of our Head Sorcerer. Now, you may find our decision highly irregular taking into account events from the past few years that are of public knowledge, but as our Head Sorcerer proposed her, we decided to consider her for the position— he explained, building anticipation. The sorceress' heart was racing as she knew what his next words would be and closed her eyes before hearing —After arduous deliberation, we have chosen her to be our next Head Sorceress. So it's my pleasure to invite Castaspella to join us as Head of the Sorcerer's Guild!

With a surprised gasp from the crowd, a new round of whispers began, a bit louder this time, as many people had heard, first or second hand, what had happened years before, and could hardly believe what the council had decided.

They chose the woman who fooled them with a fake marriage for *years*.

They chose the same person who defended the crazy woman who kept endangering Etheria until her sorcery was taken away.

They chose the sorceress always returned to the "traitor", even if that meant losing her privileges…

Of course they would be shocked.

She sighed deeply and resignedly approached to take the spot of the foreman-councilman.

She was expected to give a speech now, accepting the position, promising to guide the Guild with responsibility…

But she'd be damned if she did.

Castaspella cleared her throat and confidently spoke, without allowing a second for anyone to interrupt her, —Good evening. I imagine this is quite a surprise, and I am just as surprised as you all. So I'll get to the point. While this is certainly an honor, I must decline.

—What is she doing!?— Light Spinner muttered, eyes wide open and almost letting her cup fall.

The whole council behind her was in utter disbelief, and Norwyn went pale; but none of them could interrupt her with how she was speaking.

—I do not want to conform and adjust to the council's wishes, much as I respect them. I refuse to abandon who I love, to lose my individuality and become just another member of the council who perfectly follows a set of given norms— she went on. —It would be very easy for me to accept the position, and use the authority it would give me to lift Light Spinner's ban once and for all, allowing me to be with her without consequences. However, the current council and their way of ruling is *not* something I can agree with, even if I respect their authority; I'd rather be frowned upon than conform, only to be to be accepted by them, or to be held in high regard *if* I'm able to become exactly like them— she added. —I think we all remember the first day our guest from another universe was introduced to us, how we all despised the idea of becoming exactly like Horde Prime, as Hordak preached. And I believe you all remember what Light Spinner told him, about not wanting to lose her soul— she recalled. —So, I hope this answers your questions from yesterday— she said, looking at Hordak. Then, she turned to the council and told them —I thank you for your consideration, but I refuse to pretend you never looked down on me for my decisions.

—Sis…— Micah sighed, pained.

—Beatrix— she then called, returning her sight to the crowd and immediately finding her. —Remember what I told you when you had just lost your sorcery: I am never giving up on you, and it is *my* turn to be a bit more possessive and selfish— she reminded her. —I don't care if everyone, you included, think I don't have a future with you; I disagree. For me, there is no future *without* you.

With those final words, she turned to the council one last time, bowed respectfully, and walked into the crowd towards Light Spinner. People moved to let her pass, and stared in shock as she confidently approached the woman.

Without hesitation, she threw her arms around her neck and kissed her through the veil. It didn't take long for her to reciprocate; she couldn't possibly resist…

—Es…

—I love you, Bea— she interrupted, smiling brightly. —Would you leave this party with me?

Light Spinner stared for just a second, bewildered, until a smirk appeared under the veil and reached her eyes.

Damn, she had just reminded her why she loved this sorceress so much…

—Gladly.

Whatever happened next, they never knew.

Had Norwyn and the council chosen another candidate? Or did he put off his retirement?

Were people still talking about them?

What were her fellow acolytes thinking now?

They didn’t know and couldn't care less.

Resting comfortably on Mystacor’s beach, the women lay down side by side. They both were smiling and had closed their eyes, almost falling asleep.

Time passed so fast that, before they noticed, the lights show had begun.

It was midnight.

—Happy new year, my Love— Castaspella said.

—Happy new year, Es— Light Spinner replied. —I’m sorry…

—Then you better make it up to me— she smugly told her, smirking naughtily.

The woman took off her veil, grinning softly, and cupped the sorceress’ face. They leant forward at the same time and kissed gently.

A silent promise to never allow this drama to repeat.

Not anymore.

Chapter End Notes

And so, we have reached the end!!

Happy new year everyone!!

I hope you enjoyed this, thank you very much for reading, for the kudos, and the comments.

Your support means a lot to me, and you have helped me bear this festive season, like the past few years.
I also hope to see you again next December!!

So, once again, thank you, and I hope your 2024 starts well! Happy new year! 🎊

Chapter 24: A New Year

A New Year

One year later…

Chapter 25: Day 1: Bright Moon

Chapter Notes

We're baaaaaack!!

Happy holidays, everyone!!
I hope you're starting the week on a good note.
And if u aren't, I certainly hope reading this new installment of my yearly festive fic helps :)

Anyways...
There's a LOT of people here at home rn and I'm editing this while everyone else is doing a really loud karaoke session ._.
Hence, I apologize in advance if I missed any mistakes 😭

But regardless, I welcome you! And hope you enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 1

Bright Moon

Year four

The party of Bright Moon was in full swing. The guests danced and mingled while waiting for dinner, which would be served soon…

However, at a secluded corner, Castaspella and Light Spinner were busy with something else.

—Es…

—So?— the sorceress asked, hope shining in her eyes.

—I can’t. I’m sorry.

—What!?— she uttered, expression falling as her illusions shattered.

—There are several reasons why I can’t— the woman insisted.

—Bea… why?

—For starters, it’s for your own good— Light Spinner began. —I cannot bring you any honor- In fact, I might just taint yours.

—Honor!? What do I care about that!?

—That’s not all…— the woman stopped her. —There’s something quite important I’ve never told you— she sighed, looking away yet remaining solemn. —As per my species' standards, I am not qualified to marry since I never got my elders’ blessing to be recognized as a woman…

—You’re… refusing to marry me… over *that*!?

—Es, you must understand…

—No, no! This is ridiculous! Since when do you give a single damn about your species' standards!? You *have* to be joking!

Looking away again, expression contrite, Light Spinner asked —So it will be you leaving me this time?

—Of course not— she immediately replied, drawing her attention back to her. —I refuse to lose you again, much less over this… But-but I’m- Ugh, I can’t believe what you’re telling

me!

—Es, I…— she began, placing a hand on Castaspella's shoulder, who pulled away immediately.

—What?— she asked, voice about to break.

—It's for your own good…

—Bullshit! I- No!

—But why marry, Es!? We can just… live together without marrying!

—I *want* to marry you! I want to-to be your wife! I want us to be together for real! And be recognized as a couple! A-as a *family*!

—That's impossible with me. And it's not something I can control.

—You're not even trying to make it happen! You're literally giving up without a reason!— the sorceress insisted. —If you don't want to marry, if you…

—I *said* I can't! It doesn't matter whether I want or not.

—It matters to me!

—Es, I haven't even seen one of my elders in decades… There is *nothing* I can do about this.

Frustrated, Castaspella decided that returning to the party would be better and headed back, yet stopped cold in her tracks when she saw a man about Light Spinner's height albeit hunched, with her same skin-tone, pointy ears, and eye-color.

—Maybe that will change now…— she muttered.

—What?

—Look— she told her, gesturing at the unknown man who stood out among the rest of the guests.

Light Spinner rushed to her side, only to stare in shock at him while blabbering incoherently.

Castaspella gave her a few moments before placing a hand on her arm to call her attention, and that was when she finally pronounced —Moosah.

—You know him?

—Of course…

—So he *is* one of your elders, right?

—Yeah, you're… right.

Light Spinner felt numb.

How was this possible!?

And why *now*!?

It seemed almost on purpose…

—We should go talk to him!

—No!— the woman stopped her, right as the sorceress attempted to rush forward. —Don't you dare…

—Bea, why? You just said…

—Exactly! He won't be pleased to see me, and I'm far from it myself!

—But…

—Esmeralda, listen to me! It's a bad idea!

—Just… let me have a chat with him— Castaspella pleaded. —You don't have to come with me if you don't want, but… I would like to talk to him.

—Why!?

—Why not!?— she insisted, frowning. Letting out a frustrated grunt, she stepped back and sentenced —*I* will go speak to him. *You* can do whatever you please.

Immediately, the sorceress stalked away without letting her reply.

—Es!— Light Spinner called out, raising a hand towards her to stop her yet unable to move at all. —This is bad…— she then muttered, closing her fists tightly.

She had to find the regents…

Castaspella confidently strode towards Moosah, smoothing her dress down, and the man hardly noticed her until she was close enough to tap his shoulder.

—Excuse me… Hello, good evening— she began, smiling gently when he turned around.

—Evening— he nodded, cordially bowing.

He was dressed in black and white.

For a moment, the sorceress was taken aback by his tall figure covered with a long, light gray tunic, with a black neck covering his shoulders and half his back, along with a riveted black border at his feet.

—May I introduce myself? I'm Castaspella… You are?

—The name is "Moosah"— he replied, stirring the cup in his hand with perfectly controlled moves. —A pleasure to meet a sorceress from the Guild— he added.

—Ho-how do you know…

—The dress and the cape, as well as the badge, of course, tell me enough— he interrupted, answering her question.

—I- Well, I haven't lived in Mystacor for a few years now, but yes, I used to be part of the Guild…

—Used to?— he repeated, raising a brow. —Excuse me, your name… Now that I think better about it, I'm almost sure I've heard it before. Weren't you supposed to be made Head Sorceress last year?

—What? Oh, no, no. I was nominated, yes, but I… rejected the position… actually— Castaspella shyly explained. —Norwyn is still the head of the Guild for the time being…

—Then you must be quite a commendable individual if you were offered the position despite having left the Guild— he reflected, tapping his chin slightly with his free hand.

—Oh, no… I wouldn't- I wouldn't call myself "commendable"— Castaspella replied, shyly scratching the back of her neck and looking away. —I-I mean… There are far more skilled magicians out there…

—Humble too, I see— he laughed, before taking a sip. —Now I'm curious… Why have you left the Guild?

—Oh, well, I have my… opinions on how the Council rules the Guild, and, in fact, that's precisely why I rejected the position of Head Sorceress… I can't possibly take the responsibility to rule with a group of people whose opinions are so fundamentally different from mine to a degree that we can't find any kind of consensus.

Moosah thought for a moment, holding her sight.

—That reminds me of someone… Ah, but that was a long time ago— he finally said, dismissive.

—Oh, speaking of a long time, I don't mean to sound rude, but I don't even recall the last time someone like you attended these festivities.

—Like me?

—I mean, your species, your age, and… skills— Castaspella clarified.

—So you know I'm a sorcerer?

She let out a small smirk.

—It’s almost imperceptible, but you’re using sorcery to stir your drink, aren’t you?

The man laughed discreetly and nodded.

—Very observant…

She had certainly learnt to be observant with Light Spinner; this was nothing.

—So, if you don’t mind, was there any reason in particular why you came to the party this year?

—Oh, I invited him!

Far from the young sorceress and the unexpected guest, Light Spinner had gone to question the Queen herself about his appearance there… Only for her to cheerfully admit she personally went for him.

—Why!?

—I-I thought it’d be a good thing!— Angella replied, now confused as she wasn’t expecting such indignant rage from the woman.

—But why!? Why *now*!?

—I only found the survivors of Candila’s eruption about two months ago!

—And why exactly did you think it’d be such a *brilliant* idea to invite any of them!?

—The-they are your people, are they not?

—They don’t regard me as one of them, nor do I consider them my own either!

—A-alright, Light Spinner. Calm down— Micah interrupted, trying to keep it from escalating.

—Calm down!? Your sister is now talking with that old fool! This is all *her fault*!— she retorted, gesturing at Angella.

—My fault!?

—Alright, alright. Enough— the sorcerer insisted. —I’m not joking. Don’t start arguing now.

—How is this my fault!?— the Queen insisted.

—I’m not saying it is, but you *did* invite him without telling anyone. So why don’t we go fix this now in a civilized manner?

—How exactly?— Light Spinner asked, letting out a scoff. —Es is already engaged in conversation. He won’t let her out of his grasp now…

—What do you mean?

Folding her arms, the woman explained —As soon as he knows I'm- that she's *my* partner, he'll make sure to undermine our relationship until she sees me as nothing but an unworthy brat…

—Wait- What does that mean!?

—Exactly what I said, Micah!

—Why would he do that!?— Angella questioned her, in complete disbelief.

—The fact that you're asking that further proves how idiotic your decision to invite him was. You don't know the first thing about my species…

—I-I'm sorry, but…

—Quit making excuses and go pull Es out of there!

—Right! Right, let's go— Angella nervously nodded, standing up.

Without losing more time, Micah followed the women as they approached Moosah and Castaspella, who interrupted their conversation right as they were within earshot.

The sorceress turned around almost immediately when his expression changed, guessing Light Spinner must have approached, yet was surprised to see her brother and the Queen too.

—Oh, you're all here!— she noted, curious.

—You know them?— Moosah immediately asked.

—Yes, of course. Queen Angella and King Micah, my brother— she introduced them. —And…

—Beatrix— he interrupted. —How unexpected to learn you've surrounded yourself with such fine company…

—What does that…

—How unexpected to learn you're still *alive*— Light Spinner retorted, closing her fists tightly.

—Hold on…

—Not thanks to you, of course— he remarked.

—If you had *listened*!

—Alright, I think that's enough…— the Queen awkwardly tried to stop them, without success.

—Can you please calm down!?— Castaspella managed to intercede, physically stepping between them.

—Oh, I am quite calm…— Moosah sardonically dismissed her. —Can't say the same is true of her…

—Wait…

—Now you're just trying to provoke me!— Light Spinner growled.

—Can you- Seriously, stop. Respect, please— the sorceress reminded her, trying to be as gentle as possible.

—Don't waste your time with her. Such a disgrace for our people… That traitor to our society wouldn't know respect even if it could slap her across the face— he suddenly scoffed.

—What!?

—In fact, you shouldn't even be wearing that veil anymore. What honor do *you* have to protect!?— he mocked her, taking a sip of his cup.

—You know what!?— she spat, reaching for the veil. —You win.

—No!— Castaspella immediately reacted, catching her hand before she could take it off. —What are you doing!?

—He's right! So let's get this over with!— Light Spinner angrily replied, still trying to yank it off.

—Are you *insane*!? How many times have we spoken about this!?

—Oh, this can't be…— Moosah suddenly let out, realizing what was happening. With another laugh, disbelieving this time, he said —You're her *partner*, aren't you!?

—Yes. What about that?

—It shouldn't surprise me— he sighed, shaking his head. —Of course you'd further disgrace us— he went on, fixing his sight on Light Spinner. —You're with a human instead of one of your own kind! The *least* you could do would be to procreate and save us from extinction!

—Excuse me!?— Castaspella reacted, ignoring the gasps of nearby guests, or that Angella put a hand on her shoulder. —You can't possibly be serious…

—I am. And it is in your best interest too, young lady.

She looked back at Light Spinner, filled with indignation and expecting the same from her. Yet she looked… defeated.

Devoid of strength.

—That's ridiculous…

—Is it? Let me summarize her… greatest feats. First: she defied us, her elders, and ran from home to study sorcery before being of age… Second: she returned, defied our rule this time and tried to give orders as if she had any authority! Third, but not least: she left us all to *die*.

Normally, those who knew her would have expected Light Spinner to excuse herself or completely dismiss the gravity of his accusations and recognize it was all true. However, this time, Light Spinner didn't even look back at him.

For once, she remained silent.

For once, she looked… *humble*.

For once, her defiance was gone.

It inevitably called the attention of Adora and Catra, who had been reticent to pay attention until that moment.

—Well, I think you're *wrong*— Castaspella decided to confront him. —Don't misunderstand. I *know* all you've said is true. But I think that's also why you're wrong— she clarified. —If you consider her such a disgrace, if you're so appalled by her "treason", then you would agree she owes you and your society *absolutely nothing*.

More gasps raised among the guests close enough to listen, which caused the rest of the party to fall silent.

Perhaps it was time for the Queen to intercede…

…Or not.

—You're *not* tied to her, therefore should *not* be getting involved in things you don't understand— Moosah finally replied, emptying his cup and leaving it on the tray of a nearby servant so he could join his hands behind his back and stand a bit more straight.

Now he looked taller and more intimidating, yet Castaspella kept her firm sight on him.

—I may not be her wife, but I will *not* stop defending her, especially from people like you.

Far from impressed by her determination, he only shook his head, laughed sardonically, and insisted —You don't understand. You will *never* be her wife. You *can't*. As far as we're concerned, she's not even *a woman*. Neither I nor any of my fellows will *ever* give her our blessing or recognition…

—Why!?

—Why what?

—Why are you behaving like this!? So stubborn and intransigent! Not only are you proving *her* right, but also, it's like the polite conversation we had a moment ago never happened!— Castaspella cried out.

Everything fell silent for a moment.

No one, none of the guests, wanted to make a single move.

They all expected Queen Angela to do something, *anything*, but she was a bit too shocked and felt increasingly guilty.

—Excuse the interruption…— Adora finally dared say, breaking the tense and silent atmosphere. As she approached the group, closely followed by Catra, she inquired —Can I ask what's going on here? I'm sorry to say you're making quite a scandal.

—You're right, Princess. I apologize— Castaspella immediately responded, ashamed.

—Princess? Ah, excuse me, you're correct, indeed— Moosah apologized too.

—I- Tha-thank you, Adora— Angella stammered.

—Alright. Now that we're all calm… What was all of that?

—Nothing of importance…— Light Spinner uttered, walking away, head hanging low.

—What? Wait- No! It was important!— Castaspella indignantly refuted. —Listen, Adora. I don't know what's going on with her, I-I just don't know… But this man over here is one of her elders, and he insists she's not "a woman" while *also* demanding she "procreates to save their species". I suppose you can see why the discussion got a bit heated up.

—Before you say anything, Princess…— Moosah began, raising a hand. —May I remind you that neither of you is familiar with our customs? You want to question our ways without any knowledge of us…

—I understand what you mean— Adora nodded, as he trailed off and didn't conclude the sentence. —However, I also understand Castaspella's indignation here.

—For the sake of the party, and out of respect for the rest of the guests, I believe you should either put this discussion aside or leave the party— Catra seriously told them.

—Oh, I'm definitely leaving— the sorceress nodded. —Sorry, Brother— she apologized, briefly placing a hand on Micah's shoulder before walking away.

—I suppose we can continue the party now?— The Queen awkwardly asked him. When he nodded, she took courage and loudly said —Alright. Please return to your mingling and enjoy the rest of the party, everyone.

After Moosah walked away to take a seat, Angella discretely thanked Adora and Catra, and the couple returned to their table.

—I don’t like this, Dor.

—Me neither…

—What’s the point of her making any progress if then a single guy will thwart her efforts? Because, I mean… she did make progress, right? I’m not insane…

—No, you’re right— Adora agreed, with a sad smile. —But I think… Well, I think she went from one extreme to the other, you know?

—How so?

—She went from overreacting to everything and anything that happened, to remaining… passive— she explained. —Her rage used to be unjustified and extreme. But now… she had every right to be furious yet seemed… resigned.

—Yeah. The sorceress’ reaction was more appropriate, even if scandalous.

—Do you think I… went overboard? That taking her powers broke her will?

—No, Love, no— Catra immediately replied, holding Adora’s hands. —It’s… normal. I mean, someone like her only knows extremes and… well, there’s a chance she’s afraid of reverting to how she was, making things worse, and losing Castaspella in the process. So it’s only normal to latch onto the opposite extreme for someone like her…

—You think she can learn to balance her behaviour?

—With some help and effort, yeah…

—We should probably talk to them one of these days, then— Adora considered.

—Sure. We will, don’t worry.

—Beatrix, wait!— Castaspella called, arriving at the edge of the woods right before Light Spinner walked into the darkness.

—Won’t wait anymore, keep up…

—You didn’t wait *at all*!

—Oh, trust me, I did— she insisted, marching on.

—Ugh!— the sorceress grunted, rushing to catch up with her.

—Come the fuck on! Why are you being such a jerk *now*!? The moment was *before*!

—Hah, sure… You would have told me off, like always, had I jumped on his throat as I wanted to, literally or figuratively…— Light Spinner scoffed, reproaching.

—What!? No! You-you were being insulted! You were being… slandered! It was *the* time to react as you usually do!

—Right…

—Beatrix, listen to me!— Castaspella insisted, finally reaching for her arm and forcing her to turn around and look at her, before she could reach for the door of their cabin.

—You must be really angry to call me my full name…

—I *am*! Because you…— she was replying, when a strong wind rushed through the Whispering Woods and forced the women to cover their faces for a moment. Then it passed, and the sorceress didn't pay any attention to the bright spores that now surrounded them. She only resumed —As I was saying: you suddenly lost your backbone and let that *fool* have the last say!

—What do you *want me* to do!? When I react, because I react… When I don't, because *I don't*! What- just, *what* do you want from me!?— Light Spinner complained, yelling loudly.

More and more spores surrounded them, it didn't seem nighttime anymore, and yet… they only pushed away the ones that got between them.

—What do I want? You really need to *ask*!?

—No, I'm trying to waste your time- *Yes*! I am asking for a reason!

—I think I'll just leave you thinking for the night…— Castaspella finally replied, expression forlorn. —And let's go inside. This damned bright stuff is making my head hurt.

Light Spinner couldn't insist.

She realized she had probably fucked up.

For once, she really wanted to make it up to her, but she also had no idea *how*! And it seemed like it was a really important thing for Castaspella that she figured it out on her own…

So, what now?

What should she do?

And where the heck had all those spores come from!?

It didn't matter.

No, it didn't.

The only thing that mattered now, was getting through the night and figuring out how to fix this…

It was close to midnight when they finally stepped inside the cabin, and it took them a moment to notice the door to their room was ajar.

—What the heck, now?

—What is it?

—Es…— she muttered, gesturing at the door.

The sorceress gasped and covered her mouth, looking back at the woman with a mix of fear and shock.

—On three— she finally whispered, and silently counted with her fingers. —Now!

—What on Etheria!?— Light Spinner exclaimed, stopping in her tracks after barging into the room together. —Who are you!?

It couldn't be…

Or could it?

After a moment of hesitation, Castaspella looked back at the woman, eyes wide open.

—She's… *you*?

Chapter End Notes

Well, is anyone intrigued? Hehe

I'll see you tomorrow with a -hopefully- better chapter lol

Ahem...

Thanks you for reading!!

Chapter 26: Day 2: Dryl

Chapter Notes

> Time for things to get… interesting
>
> I hope you like ✨ drama ✨

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 2

Dryl

Year four

—I'll ask again: Who the *fuck* are you!?

—Asking a dozen times the same question has never changed the answer, nor will it do so now… As she said, I am *you*.

—That's impossible!— Light Spinner rebuked. —I don't have all those… *scars*.

The mysterious apparition smirked and folded her arms.

—No, that's true. I suppose you haven't performed the Spell of Obtainment… Meaning I've been sent to some… alternate reality, and without my mask. So much for hoping death would be the end of it…

—*Death*!?

—The Spell? There is no way… Why would the spell scar you like that?

—Really? *That's* what you care about?— Castaspella indignantly asked. —She just- She said she's *you* from an "alternate reality", and that she *died*! But all you care about is that-that stupid spell!?

—Further proof that we're one and the same…

—No, I refuse to believe it— Light Spinner insisted.

—Bea, it's… clearly true.

—She *knows* our real name!? Oh, wait. You two are together, aren't you!?— the apparition laughed. —I wonder how many things are different here… No "Shadow Weaver", no Spell of Obtainment… Don't tell me Micah doesn't hate me— she snickered.

—Should he?

—Wait. What's a "Shadow Weaver"?— Castaspella inquired, immediately after.

—*I am*. Went from "Light Spinner" to "Shadow Weaver" for *obvious* reasons— she explained. —Now, why don't you indulge me and explain why exactly you never performed the Spell?

—I wasn't allowed…

—Neither was I. And Norwyn paid the price.

—That doesn't sound good— the young sorceress let out. —Look, my brother first backed down when he was very young, and she was warned about attempting the Spell. But she continued working on it, and then she almost performed it with help from Arden, but they *also* backed down at the last moment, and… she got banished.

—That name doesn't really ring a bell— she first admitted, pensive. —Yet what I find curious is that Micah backed down. In my world, the threat of the war was enough to convince him until the very moment the Spell failed.

—*War*!?— Castaspella exclaimed, exchanging a shocked look with Light Spinner.

—What do you mean? What war?

—The one Hordak waged against the rest of Etheria since crashing on our planet?

—Hordak? That's the… alien that appeared here last year— the sorceress recalled.

—He didn't crash here, just appeared through a portal. The Geek Princess went to find him and presented him to everyone. He's… far from a threat.

—There's no… Horde here?— Shadow Weaver uttered, baffled. —What a pampered existence you all have here…

—You sound jealous…

—You know what? I don't care about any of this— Castaspella finally grunted, anticipating the bickering that would start between those two. Yawning, she headed for the bathroom and concluded —*I* want to sleep. I'm tired *and* angry. If you two want to measure who's the better you or who should be jealous of who, go do it *somewhere else*.

With that, she slammed the door behind her.

—I would ask what you did to upset her, but truth is… I can imagine— Shadow Weaver smirked. —What I *can't* even imagine what it is like to be in an actual relationship with her. One would think she'd consider me too much of a nightmare to be with…

—*You*, perhaps. But I'm not. She's angry, and I… guess I'll sleep on the couch tonight.

As Light Spinner left the room, the apparition observed her with a brow raised and snickered. Then, when she heard the door of the bathroom open, Shadow Weaver vanished from view.

Light Spinner woke up the following morning to the worst neck-pain she had had in a long while.

But if she thought that was *the* reason to regret sleeping on the couch, she was in for a bit of an unpleasant surprise.

Hesitant, she went to see if Castaspella was awake already.

She wanted to apologize. Or at least try…

She wasn't sure *how*, and that made her waver.

That and the fear of making things worse.

Just… how could she apologize?

She really *sucked* at it, after all, and it was clear the sorceress wouldn't forget about the matter any time soon…

So how?

She felt too conflicted.

But all of that was forgotten as soon as she finally opened the door to the room.

Frozen in place, she could only stare speechless as her heart hammered in her chest.

Their uninvited guest, about whom Light Spinner had completely forgotten, was lying next to a sleeping Castaspella, *cuddling her*.

How dared that-that "Shadow Weaver" woman touch *her* partner!?

She was ready to bark at her but the other spoke first.

—Why the annoyance? I am you, remember?— she asked, a sardonic smirk appearing on her face.

As if!

—Bullshit! You can't possibly be exactly like me if our stories are so different!— Light Spinner retorted, indignant.

—Is that what you think? I'm pretty sure of it, and you *must* feel it too, even if you refuse to acknowledge it.

Did she?

She'll be damned, but… well, she had this ominous sensation it was true, indeed.

—And I shall keep refusing— she muttered between gritted teeth, squinting at her.

—Well, then… Why don't we let her decide, in that case?

—How?

A chill crept down Light Spinner's spine.

She sounded suspicious, and that smirk was still there…

—I bet, if I kiss her, she won't realize it's not you…— Shadow Weaver maliciously proposed.

—*What*!?— she scoffed, disbelieving. —You're clearly delusional!— the woman retorted, trying to hide the sudden fear that it might not be as far-fetched as she hoped.

—Then you won't mind if I try…— she defied her, her tone condescending.

Taken over by overwhelming dread yet refusing to show it, she didn't think twice before spatting —You know what!? Go ahead!

But she regretted it the second she finished speaking.

Whether Shadow Weaver was her or not, it didn't make any difference for her. Seeing someone else lean down to kiss Castaspella still made her heart shrink in pain.

For a moment, it was the worst experience she had ever been through…

However, it was about to become the second.

Much to her dismay, the drowsy sorceress kissed her back.

Now *that* was the worst thing to ever happen to her.

—Es!— she exclaimed, unable to hold back, sorrow and betrayal clear in her voice.

Only then did Castaspella actually wake up.

With a gasp, she pulled back, startled, and covered her mouth with a hand, unable to believe what had just happened.

There was no way…

—Oh my Stars— she muttered, eyes wide open in shock still. She looked between Shadow Weaver and Light Spinner, put two and two together without much effort, and felt her eyes sting as she admitted —I couldn't… You *really* are her.

—You…

—I'm sorry, Bea, there's… I-I didn't notice it wasn't… I-I mean, it was just like… kissing *you*— she stammered, struggling to sit up on the bed.

Sorrow was replaced by great annoyance and rage; the woman closed her fists tightly, suppressing the urge to scream and tear Shadow Weaver apart with her own hands, and instead growled —You win.

Seething, Light Spinner stalked out of the room.

Castaspella's expression fell and she hunched over, feeling numb.

She did… nothing?

She just… accepted it!?

The sorceress' disappointment was evident to Shadow Weaver.

And she could hardly believe it, either.

—So much for being "me"— she scoffed. —What the heck was that?

—I… don't know. She's been like that for a while now.

—Like that? You mean ridiculously submissive?

—And not in the *fun* sense— Castaspella attempted to joke, trying her best to hold back her tears.

—Unbelievable— Shadow Weaver spat, rolling her eyes and sounding clearly disgusted. —This must be my punishment. I was sent to witness the most pathetic version of myself— she grunted. But then she seemed to have… a realization. Her expression completely changed; the machinations in her head were almost visible in her eyes. Looking back at her, she began —Let me propose something…

—What?— the sorceress sighed, feeling defeated.

—A deal.

Eventually, Castaspella left the room to have breakfast.

However, the women kept to themselves for the next couple of hours until it was time to leave for Dryl's party, and didn't exchange a single word.

When they were about to leave, the sorceress took a deep breath and stopped Light Spinner before opening the door.

—Listen: I… think we should keep certain things private. You know how much people like to gossip, specially this week during the parties— she began. —Once out of here, let's remain civil and…

—Pretend nothing happened?

—Not exactly. I'm still mad at you since yesterday, and I'm sure you're mad at me for this morning. But it'd be better if we keep appearances.

—Right… I don't want people talking about us either— Light Spinner sighed, looking away. —Nor do I like the silence between us, you know?

—I don’t like it either.

—And about… our guest…

—Not a word either. We can’t explain it, so it’s better if no one knows— Castaspella pointed out.

—Agreed.

—Alright— she sighed. —Shall we go, then?

As the sorceress offered her arm, Light Spinner felt relief lightening the weight on her chest, and hooked it with a small smile.

—Let’s go.

Despite their arrangement, it wasn’t difficult to notice the sorrow tainting the women’s every interaction.

They arrived together, arm in arm, yet looked tense.

They remained close, but barely looked at each other.

They stood by the same apéritifs table, but it seemed like an invisible wall had been set between them.

And yet, the guests’ gossiping was focused on something else.

Juicier drama, apparently…

According to what could be heard, the newest councillor, Arden, had been involved with an infamous shape-shifter some time ago… Someone known as Double Trouble. For the gossipers, it wasn’t very appealing *per se*, but some quick math revealed it had been during their marriage with Castaspella…

And yet, that *wasn’t* why people were so interested!

What motivated all the rumours, and the reason for the affair to have suddenly become public knowledge after so many years, was a loud argument Arden had with the shape-shifter shortly after the beginning of the party.

For whatever reason, this Double Trouble character had chosen that day to be honest to the councillor, and admitted to have been taking different appearances to keep dating them over and over again after they broke up.

And so it downed on Castaspella.

That was what she saw three years before at the Salineas party!

Concerned about Arden after hearing all of that, the sorceress and Light Spinner finally exchanged a glance and walked away from the table, silently agreeing they should check on them.

However… that would have to wait.

A certain elf intercepted the women on their way to find the councillor.

—So you remain together…— he casually said, stepping on their way. —After yesterday, I hoped you'd see reason.

—See reason?— Castaspella scoffed. —I thought *she* was proud, but you clearly must be even prouder to believe we would let *you* have that much influence in *our* relationship.

—It's in your best interest to cut all ties to her— Moosah insisted. —And you, Beatrix, seemed to agree with me yesterday.

Light Spinner looked away, gritting her teeth, but didn't answer.

—Alright, cut that bullshit. I can't tolerate you treating her like that— the sorceress decided to defend her, pushing away her disappointment. —If you excuse us, we have no time for this.

Grabbing the woman's hand, Castaspella pulled her along and walked past the old elf.

That was enough.

—I hate it, but he *is* right.

—He is *not*. And that's the last I'll say about this. We should focus on Arden now— the sorceress sentenced, letting go of her hand. —Over there.

Light Spinner took a deep breath, nodded silently even though Castaspella wasn't looking her way, and followed her to an empty table next to which the magician stood alone.

—Leave me…— they uttered, hearing their footsteps approach.

—Not happening— the sorceress refused.

—Casta— Arden realized, their head shooting up. —And Light Spinner… You already know, don't you?

—I'm sorry— she sighed, leaning back against the table, supporting herself with her hands. —Everyone is… talking about it, unfortunately.

—I'm aware. And that's… Well, I don't have to tell you how bad it is— they uttered. —I should be worrying about the council kicking me out now that everyone knows it happened during… our marriage. But… I don't care about that, to be honest— they admitted, giving her a sad smile. —I mean, I *would* care if it also affected you…

—Arden, it's… understandable. Really— Castaspella tried to comfort them.

—If you don't care about the council, then why are you agonizing here?— Light Spinner asked, genuinely confused but also worried, even if she wouldn't admit it.

—Because- Ah… It will sound stupid, and-and probably pathetic, but I'm *so* conflicted because of what they did and…

—You feel cheated— the woman realized.

—Yes, *but*… the-the way they framed it… I mean- They deceived me, not only while we were dating the first time, but also every single time afterwards. That's despicable, I hate it, seriously. Except that they insist they did it be-because…

—They refused to lose you— Castaspella completed when they trailed off.

—Exactly— Arden sighed. —How do I- Ho-how can I ignore any of it? I mean, the lies… I can't pretend they were "okay" in any way. But…— they began, looking down. Then, they hesitated, looked up again, sight unfocused as they took shallow breaths, and finally admitted —No one ever wanted me *that* much.

—Yet they *lied* instead of apologizing and asking for a second chance— Light Spinner pointed out. —That, uh, Double Trouble sounds… well, like *trouble*. How can you trust them?

—They said- I mean, if they were telling the truth this time, they thought I wouldn't forgive them or give them a second chance. They were afraid of being rejected and resorted to what they do best instead— the councillor explained, scoffing at the end. —They wanted that second chance so bad that they-they…

—They took away from you the choice of granting it— the old woman remarked, guessing they didn't want to say it. —I am no standard of morality myself, and dread having to apologize. So you can be sure I know what I'm talking about when I say they are hardly reliable.

—I know— Arden nodded. —I realize I can't trust them after all of that, but… I can't help cherishing the hope that they chose to be honest now, in… an attempt to make up for it.

—You want to believe they have it in them to learn from their mistakes— Castaspella reflected.

—I knew you'd understand— they said, giving her a sad smile. —Remember I said I wanted a relationship like yours?— they reminded her. —Well, I… suppose that would start by following your lead; giving them a chance, even if I don't forgive them right away, to let them prove they mean it.

—You'd have to be ready for disappointment, in that case— Light Spinner uttered, ashamed. —People like… *us*, we tend to fall back into old habits at the first sign of "danger".

—I won't deny I've suffered my fair deal of disappointment…— the sorceress admitted, expression somber. —But I don't regret giving you not one, but several chances, Beatrix— she stated, serious. —So, I think, maybe you should… go with what your heart tells you, Arden. As she said, be prepared for disappointment, but… don't give up on your hopes if you choose to give them another chance.

—I fear I'm just being too gullible… naïve.

—Listen, kid— Light Spinner sighed. —"Following your heart" does sound quite stupid in most cases— she began, much to Castaspella's indignation. But before she could complain, the woman went on —And yet, I have experienced myself the benefits of that advice. So, ridiculous as it sounds, I have to agree with her. You can't go wrong if you do what you *feel* is right. The only other option is to do what's *expected* of you, and that's likely to make you miserable instead.

Castaspella's indignation vanished immediately; she gave the woman a soft look, and her hopes rekindled.

—Thank you both— they smiled, pensive but less gloomy.

Arden left shortly after, wanting some time to reflect on their own, and so the women returned to mingling for the remainder of the party.

It was slightly uneventful, except for the few people who approached them only to ask if it was true that they were separating.

The sorceress' indignation only rose with every person who asked them the same, making her snap more and more angrily each time.

Light Spinner, on the other hand, rolled her eyes, never replied, and insisted that Castaspella should do the same. Whatever reason these gossipers had to believe they were separating was *not* worth making a scandal.

Yet they soon found the origin of that damned rumour: Moosah himself.

He was convinced they would "see reason" soon enough and go their separate ways…

That only worsened the sorceress' mood, but what truly sapped Castaspella's patience was Light Spinner's resignation.

Enough was enough.

Without another word, the sorceress went to say her farewells and promptly left the party.

Finding herself alone, the old woman realized she had made a huge mistake, yet again, and finally settled on returning home too.

Perhaps she could still apologize…

It was very late when she arrived at the cabin, once again close to midnight, but she knew Castaspella couldn't be asleep yet.

Still hesitant, Light Spinner had to force herself to walk inside and stop dallying.

She felt so ridiculous for behaving like this… but she had no time to dwell much on the feeling as familiar voices called her attention.

Right…

Their *guest*.

Castaspella was… laughing with her.

What could be *so funny*!?

As anger rose and overwhelmed her, Light Spinner stalked into the room; she wasn't thinking, she had no idea what she would do, but she couldn't tolerate it…

And yet…

Just like that morning, the woman halted as soon as she saw Shadow Weaver holding *her* partner by the waist.

They were standing in the middle of the room, "talking", but they were *so close*!

—…and now I regret not doing more with the you of my original world— she smirked.

—What is this!?

—Oh… You're back…— Castaspella noted, barely looking her way.

—Ah, if it isn't the most pathetic version of me…— Shadow Weaver mocked her.

But the insult was entirely ignored in favour of the *real* problem here.

—What exactly do you think you're doing with *my* woman!?— Light Spinner reproached her, her anger *very* clear in her eyes.

—What I'm doing? I'm simply enjoying this… second chance I've been given— she condescendingly replied, her smirk widening.

And then, as if to reinforce her words and make sure the woman understood what she meant, Shadow Weaver suddenly kissed Castaspella.

After the initial surprise, the sorceress gave in and kissed her back.

That was too much to bear.

Light Spinner couldn't handle it and immediately left the room, slamming the door behind her.

She wanted to do *something*, she… wanted to yell, reproach Castaspella, kick out that Shadow Weaver apparition; she wanted to let her rage out.

But if she did… that'd definitely be the end of it.

No, no… it-it wasn't worth losing her over.

And it wasn't… that bad, anyways, right?

—She's me… She is *me*. It's… Es is still choosing me… She's just a version of me who *did* perform the Spell of Obtainment— Light Spinner reflected. —Meaning, even if I did that, even if I got corrupted as a result, she'd still love me…

Chapter End Notes

OwO

See you tomorrooooow!!

Chapter 27: Day 3: Dark Edge

Chapter Notes

Alright, so… another day, another chapter!

Now that Ao3 is back up I can finally post this lol

The drama grows intense in this one XD

I hope you enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 3

Dark Edge

Year four

Light Spinner woke up early the next morning.

Surprisingly, Castaspella did *not*.

In fact, the sorceress didn't leave the room until it was almost midday.

The woman observed her silently as she went straight for a cup of coffee, hair messy and nightgown wrinkled.

She was also light on her feet and humming a tune…

—You seem to be in a good mood— Light Spinner commented, part of her hoping she wasn't that mad at her anymore.

—Oh, yes, I feel quite good this morning…— she admitted, her tone seemingly happy. However, reproach tainted it when she added —Not thanks to you, though…

—What is that supposed to mean?— the woman asked, squinting.

—I'm sure you *know* what it means— Castaspella scoffed, leaning back against the counter while drinking her coffee.

—I get it, you feel like I'm neglecting you— she replied, clearly upset. —But I'm starting to feel cheated.

—Oh, are you? Because I haven't heard you complain *at all*— the sorceress remarked, offended. —Besides, she's literally you.

—I know. That's precisely why I'm… tolerating this.

—"Tolerating"? Stars, what exactly has gotten into you, Beatrix!?

—I'm doing it for you…

—Don't you *dare*— Castaspella interrupted. —You cannot blame me for the way you're behaving! How is your inaction *my fault*? How is your coldness *my fault*? I only asked you to marry me, and not only did you reject me, but you've also… distanced yourself— she rebuked, hesitating at the end as sorrow darkened her expression. —We didn't break up, yet you act as if we had…

—I'm just giving you space!

—Are you!? Or are you just leaving me gradually enough that I wouldn't notice it!?— the sorceress defied her. —You keep saying Moosah is right! You're listening to *him* instead of your own *partner*!

She was… right.

Light Spinner hated it, but there was no denying it.

She only looked away, forcing down her rage, and didn't see Castaspella's expression.

Oblivious to her sorrow and weeping, the woman finished her tea and returned to the couch without another word as her head insisted she must *hate her* now.

The sorceress was left on her own, silent tears falling into her cup while anguish knotted in her throat.

Due to their fight, the women went their separate ways upon arriving at Horror Hall. They had been placed at the same table, yet they took seats away from each other…

It started to be suspicious, rumours arose, but they pretended nothing was happening.

Even when Delwyn directly asked her, Castaspella attempted to deflect.

But he knew her well enough.

—Please, be honest with me.

—I…

—You can trust me— he insisted.

—I know— she sighed. —It's just that I- Why can't she be more like *her*!?— the sorceress muttered, between gritted teeth, without realizing what she was saying.

—"Her"?

—I-I mean… I- Well, I *feel* like I have been… *imagining* this… uh, version of Light Spinner that still shows me the same love and care she gave me *before* rejecting my proposal— Castaspella lied, trying to cover up that slip of her tongue.

—Oh, I see… So she's… acting cold and distant, right?

—Yes…

—But you haven't broken up.

—No, I- She didn't break up with me after rejecting me, but is acting like she wants to. And, actually, she thought *I* would break up with her for it, but the first thing I told her was that I would not let that rejection ruin our relationship, as in, that I wouldn't break up with her over that. And yet…

—You think it ruined it anyways.

—Because it clearly did! Or… No. That elder of hers, Moosah. Do you know him? He's been saying she's "such a disgrace" that we all should cut relationships with her "for our own good".

—I have spoken to the man, yes. Yesterday, because of the argument you two had in Bright Moon, I decided to approach him.

—Bad idea.

—It was… The kids were *very* angry about the way he treated you and… well, they have experienced firsthand the issues me and my partner had because of their personality, mainly. But that wasn't all. Because of their origins, they were oftentimes dismissed as lesser, their personhood wasn't recognized by those of my status. And if you think that's bad… The kids had to hear people calling them "polluter of the dignitary blood".

—Oh, Stars. That's awful!— Castaspella gasped. —And I can see why they were so angry, yes…

—Exactly— he sighed. —So… I have nothing good to say about him, and my kids have only bad things to say.

—Can't blame them. Or you— the sorceress sighed. —I had quite a pleasant conversation with him before she showed up. Afterwards, he only insulted her, and got all pedantic when he learnt of our relationship. No, perhaps that's not the right word… More like he got full of himself, he became suddenly arrogant and *very* invested in convincing everyone of how "awful" Bea is…

—It's exactly that, yes… I'm so sorry you two have to go through this.

—It wouldn't be this bad if she- Ah… never mind.

—I know it sounds strange, but I think she's just… afraid, you know?

—Of what!? Of him!?

—Of losing you— Delwyn clarified.

—Really? Because everything she's been doing is what will cause it— Castaspella scoffed.

—I can only advise you to give her some time… Maybe, give her until the end of the week— he suggested. —If by then she hasn't committed to defending your relationship as you deserve… then you can make a decision.

—Right… I should, yes— she nodded. —I don't want to lose her, but this… is a *nightmare*.

Meanwhile, Light Spinner had made the… unwise decision to face Moosah alone.

She was sick of this.

Of all of this!

She was *done* playing his games…

She had to put at end to this *now*!

And yet… things unfortunately didn't go as planned.

—What exactly do you want, Beatrix?

—You *know* what I want!

—What? To forgive and forget what you've done?— he began, disgust tainting his voice. —To pretend nothing happened? To acknowledge you as a woman? To give you my blessing to marry a human when our species is *dying*?

—I never…

—You want me to free you of the burden you alone brought upon yourself! And that, Beatrix, will *not* happen any time soon— Moosah remarked. —But you *know* that already, don't you?

His expression was… so confident and defiant.

As if he were privy to the information that Light Spinner attempted to hide from him…

—What do you mean?

—You *know* I am right in my decision. You *know* you don't deserve forgiveness… And you *know* how bad you are for that human sorceress— he confronted her, moving closer and causing her to retreat, intimidated.

—No, I- No. That's not… true.

—Deep down you *know* it is— he insisted.

Was it?

Perhaps… she was just in denial?

Castaspella would disagree, of course, but Light Spinner couldn't find it in her to keep fighting.

Not like this.

Because, if she pushed the matter, if she stood her ground, her instincts would take over and he would finally shut up… *forever*.

But that was exactly the problem.

If, on top of everything, she became a murderer, he would ultimately be right…

Queen Angella and King Micah observed the interaction between Light Spinner and her elder, noticed how he easily intimidated her, and exchanged concerned glances when she walked away, seemingly resigned.

—I don't think I've… ever seen *her* so sad before— she commented.

—I don't think I've ever seen her *sad*. Period— he replied, in utter disbelief.

—I really made a big mistake, didn't I?

—You mean… by inviting Moosah?— Micah asked, wanting to be sure. As she nodded, looking away in shame, he rushed to reassure her —You couldn't have *known*. Angie… you thought it'd be a good thing! Ho-how were you supposed to foresee he'd be even worse than Light Spinner?

—Well, that doesn't matter. What matters is what's happening *now* because of what I did— Angella scoffed. —Just look at your sister! It's clear that yesterday they were hiding how bad things are between them, but now they aren't even trying! Casta looks so hurt, and it's my fault!

—Angie, please, listen to me. You're *not* to blame for this! And they aren't even… that bad. They can't be! They still go home together, a-and… look: they just walked out together, hand in hand!

—I- No, well, but… they may be sticking together for whatever reason, but you can see they *both* are… I don't know, like hiding something. Things *aren't* right between them.

—So, you want to talk to them?

—No, no… I wouldn't- I don't want to make things worse, or anything…

—It's alright, Angie. I think they will sort it out… whatever it's going on.

—Alright, I don't think anyone can hear us here— Castaspella sighed. As the women took a stroll outside Horror Hall but careful not to tread out of the marked path, she asked —What is it?

—I just realized- Well, I don't know why I'm thinking about this now, but what are we supposed to do if anyone wanted to, for instance, visit us at home? How are we going to

explain that apparition? We can't hide her forever!

—I know, Bea… I actually have been considering the same— the sorceress admitted, hesitant. —I almost spilled the secret to Delwyn— she admitted, shrinking a bit.

—I beg of you: tell me you didn't.

—No, no. I pretended I meant to say I was "imagining" an alternate version of you…

—Right…

—Listen, we don't need to figure out right away what to do about Shadow Weaver— Castaspella began, shaking her head. —We can probably wait until the end of the week and think it carefully.

—You know what? Sure…— the woman sighed, resigned. —At this point, I just want this week to end.

—So I'm guessing that means you want to leave already?

—I'd say so, yes…

—And I'm guessing if you haven't yet, it's because you're waiting for me?

—Perhaps— Light Spinner admitted, with a rather soft smirk.

—Sure— Castaspella chuckled, unable to hold back as she felt a warm sensation bloom in her chest. She had missed that warmth… —Just let me have a quick dessert and then we can bid the hosts farewell.

—I don't think the Queens would notice if we left without saying goodbye.

—The Queens, maybe… but the Princess will, and you should know by now how she is. She'd think we didn't like something about her party!

—*Right*! Right…— Light Spinner conceded. —Then let's get your dessert already…

As the women returned to the interior of Horror Hall, Adora observed them from her seat, a leg shaking up and down nervously.

—I think I'll go ask them…

—Want me to come with you?

—Sure— she smiled, standing up and heading their direction. She took a few deep breaths and cleared her throat upon reaching the couple. —Hello, good evening.

—Oh, evening, Princess Adora. Prince Catra— Castaspella replied, setting down the plate with dessert she had just picked up. —To what do we owe the pleasure?

—Well, this is… a strange question to make, but you *do* live in the Whispering Woods, so I was wondering if you've… felt anything strange lately.

—Strange about the Woods?— Light Spinner asked, raising a brow and exchanging a glance with the sorceress.

—Precisely. It might be anything… The air feeling heavier, or energized. Maybe there are strange animal sounds you never heard before, or on the contrary, the usual animal sounds have stopped? Just… whatever strange behaviour you may have noticed the past few days.

Oh, there was *one thing*.

But they were not going to mention it…

—No, absolutely nothing strange— the woman denied, closing her eyes and remaining calm.

—She's right. Nothing out of the ordinary… There were only some… bright spores all around the night after Bright Moon's party, but it hasn't repeated.

—Could that have been it?— Catra asked Adora, who looked pensive.

—No, no. It's something I can still feel…

—You're feeling something strange related to the Woods?— Castaspella inquired, hiding her discomfort.

—It's like something has come to this world and… doesn't belong here. And I don't mean like when Hordak came through the portal last year. No. In fact, he even adapted well to Etheria— she began explaining, looking back to the table where Entrapta was entertaining Hordak with a seemingly exciting conversation. —No, this is something that doesn't belong here or anywhere. Or it must be. And it's clearly fighting to stay here too…

Fighting?

Light Spinner felt a chill.

Fighting *how* exactly!?

As if reading their thoughts, Catra rushed to tell them —But don't worry. It's obviously nothing you have to worry about. Otherwise, you would have noticed something.

—So, if you *do* notice anything that feels remotely suspicious, don't hesitate to tell us, alright?— Adora requested.

—Of course, rest assured we will— Castaspella lied, while Light Spinner remained frozen.

—Then we'll let you continue eating. Good night— the Princess smiled.

As the couple walked away, the sorceress rushed to finish her dessert.

—What are you thinking?

—I just… should have *known* she'd notice something. Her connection with Etheria is so deep; how would it *possibly* get past her that an intruder appeared on our world!?

—Calm down. She doesn't know enough, or she wouldn't have asked us…

—I know, I know. But…

—*But* that makes it more complicated to hide it from them, I know…

—Thanks for not telling them— Castaspella finally sighed.

—We agreed to keep it a secret for now…

—Yes, but they just said…

—Unless that "fighting" they mentioned is anything concerning, I don't see why I should tell them without you agreeing to it.

—Thanks, Bea— she sighed, smiling faintly.

Later that night, the women arrived at the cabin in quite a good mood.

Perhaps that was why Shadow Weaver immediately jumped to taunting her counterpart as soon as Castaspella stepped into the bathroom…

—For once you bring her back happy. *Well done*.

The mockery was… so infuriatingly subtle in her tone yet so blatant in her eyes.

—What? Does it upset you?

—On the contrary. I'm thrilled to see you're giving her the treatment she deserves, at long last— Shadow Weaver clarified, condescending. —After all, Casta is such a great lover… She deserves the *best* treatment. Had I known before my death, I would have done more with that sorceress in my own world…

—You- Ugh!— Light Spinner barked, yet immediately held her tongue, tensing up from head to toe as she resisted the urge to jump on her. Instead, she mustered all her willpower and seethed —If you weren't me… I would have already *killed you* for touching my woman…

—Your woman?— Shadow Weaver scoffed, sardonic. —You call her that yet keep neglecting her…— she reproached her. Then, looking away and changing her tone to something more condescending again, she nodded —But yes, we're one and the same. It shouldn't surprise me… We certainly suck at treating people as they deserve.

—You have no idea why I'm doing this.

—Oh, but I do— she countered. —You're doing this because that old fool *said so*. Since *when* do we listen to authority figures we have no respect for? How pathetic…— she concluded, disgust poisoning her every word.

—I'm not doing it for them, I'm doing it for her!

—Prove it!

—I have nothing to prove to you…— Light Spinner snarled, right as Castaspella walked out of the bathroom.

The sorceress could only watch her immediately stalk away, her intentions of making amends and inviting her to return to the room for the night vanishing into thin air.

As she looked back at Shadow Weaver, distraught, the woman silently shook her head; a clear answer to her unspoken question.

She's not quite there yet…

Chapter End Notes

XD

I'm so sorry for being this evil to you all

But, trust me, this will all make sense soon! Or… eventually.

I promise LS will learn from everything! You'll be proud of her!
…eventually.

XD
Ok, ok, no more teasing!

See you tomorrow!!

Chapter 28: Day 4: Plumeria

Chapter Notes

Omgssssss it's the 28th alreadyyyyy

And tomorrow's chapter isn't ready TT-TT
I have 24hrs to finish it, AND I'll probably have to rush the last two too…

Just great

Anyways!
Welcome to today's chapter!
I certainly hope you'll enjoy it!

Today I bring you: DRAMA XD
Featuring everyone's favourite shape-shifter ksjsjs

Alright, I won't rob you of any more time!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 4

Plumeria

Year four

Sleeping on the couch was starting to get on Light Spinner's nerves.

Her neck hurt, her head hurt, her throat felt sore as the lounge was colder than the room, and all her joints cracked every morning.

Ugh… if it weren't for Castaspella, she'd have already recovered her room.

If it weren't because she doesn't want to push the sorceress further away, she'd done *something* about all of this already!

But no.

She's doing nothing.

For now.

She barely dared peek into the room, afraid of what she'd see…

Fortunately, all she saw was Castaspella, almost curled into a ball, cuddled by Shadow Weaver.

Annoying, yes, but it could certainly be worse…

So she only went for some breakfast.

Then a while later, she peeked again.

And she was still… like before.

She hadn't moved an inch.

It was strange, but Light Spinner didn't know why it also felt so suspicious.

However, a few hours later, it was almost midday and Castaspella was still *not* up.

Maybe it was time to interrogate Shadow Weaver…

When the woman walked into the room, she was determined.

Squinting, hands tightly closed into fists, steps firm, she approached the bed with absolute confidence…

And then she saw the sorceress sleeping soundly and looking so… small all curled up; her heart shrunk in pain.

—What is it?

—I want answers— Light Spinner began, trying to appear determined again. —*Who* exactly are you?

—I am you, of course…

—That's what you've said.

—And she confirmed it. Don't you trust her?

—Shut up! I'm the one asking questions now— the old woman retorted, keeping her tone as low as possible despite wanting to yell. —Now: How are you here?

—I don't know— Shadow Weaver denied, a bit too casual.

—You don't know… Bullshit.

—I have no idea how the magic of our world- of our *worlds* works. All I know is that I died in my own, and now appeared here— she insisted.

—Well, none of that explains why you're *so* invested in Casta. What do you want from her!?

—You may not understand this, but for *me* this must be a… second chance I was given. And I intend to make the most of it— Shadow Weaver smirked.

—A second chance!? With my- No, no. You're… Ugh!— Light Spinner reacted, fighting the urge to cry as she felt on the verge of breaking. —You're me. Right… You are… me— she muttered, like some mantra. —You are me. This is… insane.

Repeating those words under her breath, over and over again, the woman finally left the room, missing the way Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes, clearly disappointed.

And right after, Castaspella stirred awake.

—Morning…

—Morning, Bea- Oh, right…— she sighed.

—Disappointing, isn't it? I tend to be…

—You're not… It's- I mean, Bea is just… *stubborn*.

—You just missed her— Shadow Weaver revealed. —She came here all fierce, questioned me… and then gave up.

—I wish I knew why she's being like this…— Castaspella groaned, trying to get up.

—I told you: the idiot is scared of something. I would say she's scared of losing you, but if that were the case, she'd do *something* about it.

—So?

—She must be more scared of the consequences of doing something… Unless she grows a backbone and takes the risk…

—I know, I know…— the sorceress interrupted, standing up.

A bit later, after brushing her hair and getting dressed, Castaspella walked into the kitchen and fixed herself some breakfast.

Light Spinner was there, silently drinking a tea and considering whether to speak or not.

Eventually, she dared say —May I accompany you, Es?

—Didn't you have breakfast already?

—I can have lunch…

—I- Well, sure. You don't have to ask, Bea.

The woman still seemed dispirited as she heated up a bowl of soup, and Castaspella couldn't help feeling her chest tighten.

This whole situation couldn't be *worse*.

Or maybe it could…

Once she sat at the table with her meal, Light Spinner asked —Why do you… spend so much time with that… Shadow Weaver?

—What?

—You… are sleeping more. And that… means you spend most of the time here *with her*.

—I- Beatrix. She's *there* for me— Castaspella began. —I don't- I'm not replacing you with her, if that's what you mean. But she's always there… she *wants* to be with me, and… if you're implying I'm giving her more love than you- I am not. I'm giving that version of you the same love I would give *you*. She never got any, from anyone, and I just feel… she deserves it too.

—How do you know?

—She's you. Why wouldn't I love her as much as you?— the sorceress argued. —But… in case you didn't notice, she's not… rejecting me like you— she then reproached her. —She's a version of you who's not afraid to love me, Bea.

—I'm not afraid to love you!?

—You are. Or you have been, as of late…— she insisted. —Something happened, either my proposal or Moosah's apparition, and you've been scared of showing me love as you used to!

—No- That's not- Wait, Es… I…

—Save it, Bea. It's… fine— Castaspella interrupted, letting out a long sigh. Looking away, she added —Clearly her apparition here was to let you take a break from loving me… or whatever.

—Es, don't be ridiculous… I don't- That's far from what I want!

—Then why does it feel like it's the actual truth and that you're in denial or something!?

Silence.

That was all the answer she needed.

Disappointed, the sorceress rushed to finish her breakfast, or rather her brunch, and left the table.

It was time to get ready for Plumeria's party.

As expected, once in Plumeria, there was a noticeable distance between the couple that the guests didn't hesitate to discuss. It wasn't surprising that the sorceress was so distant after Light Spinner rejected her; they were bound to have issues now.

But then *why* did Castaspella return to the woman's home when she could instead take a spare room in Bright Moon?

The gossipers were a bit too eager to figure it out… And that, of course, slowly got into Princess Perfuma's nerves.

She tried really hard to deviate the conversation every time the topic was raised in front of her, but it was quite difficult and *so* draining!

Fortunately, *juicer* drama soon took over the guests' attention.

It was the shape-shifter again. That Double Trouble character.

Shortly after the bonfires were lit, they went to find councillor Arden. And what began as a private conversation soon turned into a scandal.

—But you *lied*! So many, *so* many times!

—What choice did I have!? You didn't even want to see me! How else was I supposed to approach you!?

—I literally broke up with you *because* you were all secretive and lied about the most basic things. And your *brilliant* idea was to deceive me even *more*!?

—I didn't know what else to do! Please, Ardy, what else do I have to do!?— Double Trouble pleaded, looking genuinely sorrowful.

—Just give me *space*! Being suddenly honest doesn't immediately fix all you've done- Actually, you even caused me *more* problems!

—What!?

—I *almost* lost my position as councillor! If Norwyn hadn't vouched for me…

—I'm sorry! I really am! I didn't mean to, Ardy. Believe me!

—I can't! And quit calling me that! It-it sounds so-so *fake* now!

—I'm- No, I *swear*: I've never faked my feelings for you— they insisted.

—How am I supposed to trust that!?— Arden countered, waving their arms around in a clear display of indignation. —You- I've seen you flawlessly fake a variety of emotions one after the other, never giving out a single hint that it was all an act. How is this different!?

—Why would I be doing all of this if not because I mean it!?

—That's what I don't know! You are a *mercenary*! You always go where the payment is better! I don't even want to know what you'll get from all of this— Arden accused them, voice breaking and tears threatening to fall.

—I'm not doing this for money. For once, I'm going against *everything* my instincts tell me. It'd be easier for me to forget you and move on, but I can't! I haven't- I haven't… been able to shift the past few months— Double Trouble finally admitted. —I feel uncomfortable instead of confident as I used to. Because, every time I put on a new disguise, I remember how I- what I did to you and feel… *guilty*.

—But…

—It used to be my favourite thing in the world… Now I don't even know who I am! I feel so-so *out of character*!

—Really? Because you just put up a whole show that is *literally* your signature.

—I didn't…

—Mean to?— Arden interrupted. —Well, you did. Everyone's looking at us, my fellow councillors are probably judging me, and I'm now even more angry at you— they pointed out. —So, if you *actually* mean it, give me space to *think*.

With that, they lowered their head and turned to walk away, intending to find the farthest bonfire and sit alone. However, Castaspella rushed to join them and offer her support.

Double Trouble was left feeling ashamed.

Perhaps they *had* handled this the wrong way.

All they knew was how to make a scandal, cause an impression, deceive…

Maybe they needed time to reflect too.

From a distance, Light Spinner followed the shape-shifter with her sight, deep in thought as she couldn't help but relate to their situation. The circumstances were wildly different, but she could understand what Double Trouble was feeling.

And it suddenly made her hear Castaspella's voice in her head, pointing out how the shape-shifter *at least* tried to salvage their relationship with Arden, doing everything they could and refusing to give up.

Had she… given up?

Before she could dwell much on it, her attention was called by Princess Adora and Prince Catra, who had just approached her.

—Good evening.

—Evening— the woman uttered, closing her eyes for a second a taking a deep breath. —Excuse my bluntness, Princess, but if you're here to ask about the Woods again, I still have nothing to report.

—That's not it. I- Ahem… I've been meaning to talk with you about, uh, your *powers*.

—Is that so?

—You know we have considered restoring them if you demonstrate to be in control of your emotions, opposite to how you were three years ago— Catra began. —But you may have misinterpreted what we meant.

—How exactly? I'd like to believe I *am* in control; if I weren't, do you think that foolish elder of mine would still be in one piece?— Light Spinner scoffed. —I don't expect you to restore my powers any time soon, Princess, and I won't demand it, either. Yet I'd rather you don't give me any false hope or fake praise— she complained. —Unless you're instead trying to tell me that, opposite to what I thought, I am failing to control my impulses? Am I doing it all wrong, Prince?

—That's not what I meant to say…

—What Catra was trying to explain is that you… went from one extreme to the other— Adora quickly interceded. —Right now you're defending yourself angrily but without overreacting. That's the kind of behaviour I hoped you would learn.

—I sense a "but".

—*But*, if I may be honest, that's not what we observed in Bright Moon at the beginning of the week.

—Like she said, you went from one extreme to the other. Before, you always wanted to jump on anyone who upset you in any way, no matter how small; when it came to power, that was even worse and you were clearly out of your mind— Catra elaborated. —However, back in Bright Moon you had *very* valid reasons to act exactly as you did just now, at the very least, but you didn't.

—You don't want me to react to Moosah— Light Spinner warned them, looking away.

—No, but… you don't have to resign yourself to what he says, either— Adora insisted. —So I must ask: why are you letting him disrespect you and your partner without even *trying* to argue?

—There's no way on Etheria I can hold a civilized argument with him. Confrontation will only end *bad*, Princess— the woman replied, gritting her teeth. —You should be *glad* I'm choosing this "extreme" behaviour.

—I am not— she insisted. —I can see how this is hurting your relationship, and it seems like you're accepting this as if you deserved some sort of punishment. But I did *not* intend to punish you. I gave you a chance to learn and grow.

—You can't seriously be worried about how I feel— Light Spinner scoffed again, disbelieving.

—Of course she is— Catra retorted, folding her arms. —The concept might be foreign to you, but there's something called "empathy"…

—Which you shouldn't waste with me— the old woman interrupted. —I'm doing what's best for Castaspella; you wouldn't understand.

—How do you know what's best?

—It's common sense, Princess.

—Is it? Because I don't see her being happy as of late; "the best for her" would *never* strip her from her happiness.

—And neither should you— Catra remarked.

Light Spinner didn't like it one bit, but the young couple had left her thinking.

Castaspella wasn't happy.

That seemed to be the general consensus.

And, of course, she knew the sorceress was far from happy as of late, but… she hadn't realized how generalized that was.

Her happiness, not the fleeting emotion but rather the state of being happy, was gone, wasn't it?

Was it her fault?

Maybe… that was what the apparition provided her now?

Maybe that was why the sorceress remained with *that* version of herself most of the time between parties?

Plagued by these questions, Light Spinner decided to stop Castaspella before they entered the cabin.

—What is it?

—Es…— she hesitantly began. —I must ask: are you… happier with Shadow Weaver?

The young sorceress gave her a confused look for a moment, feeling at a loss for words.

She wasn't expecting anything like this.

But maybe this was the right time to gave her the final push.

Time for a wake-up call.

—I am happy with my Beatrix— she began, with a sad smile. —Either version of you can make me happy, but right now, you're choosing to ignore and neglect me, while that version of you craves my love as much as I crave yours— she explained, scoffing in disbelief. And finally, with a sorrowful look, she concluded —But you don't understand. Do you?

Chapter End Notes

Well, I suppose I should apologize for the angst…

Truth is, this will hurt even more tomorrow…

BUT

This is a festive fic! You can rest assured that I’m giving you a happy ending!

All this sourness will make it even sweeter! I promise!

For now, I bid you farewell and see you tomorrow!

Chapter 29: Day 5: Salineas

Chapter Notes

Alright! Ready for heartbreak?
Grab some tissues and sit back, this chapter is… loaded.

This whole year has been loaded, am I right?

But trust me, they are far from “ok” like this and are DYING to kiss each other again (to say the least), SO! Bear with me just this last bit… is the, uh, the final curve. Alright? We’re in day 5, it’ll be the “rock bottom” point of the fic, and you can expect next chapter to begin the way upward!

But I’m getting ahead of myself…

Please, enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 5

Salineas

Year four

Sleeping that night was difficult for Light Spinner.

The question lingered in her mind, bouncing around to claim her attention until she could answer it.

Did she understand what Castaspella meant?

Perhaps?

Perhaps *no*?

Ugh… how *difficult*!

Morning couldn't arrive soon enough…

But it eventually did and Light Spinner fixed herself some breakfast.

After her first cup of tea, she soon brewed another, finished her buttered bread, and didn't hesitate to look around the kitchen for more food.

Great, now she was stress eating.

She had to find something else to distract herself with… but, what?

A book!

Yes, a book should work…

Fortunately, it did.

The morning went by reading, and Light Spinner only noticed it was lunch time when her stomach grumbled.

Wait- How was it midday already?

Castaspella wasn't up…

Setting her book aside, the woman sat up on the couch she had been laying on, double checked the door to the room remained closed, and pushed herself up.

Alright, time to check on the sorceress.

Light Spinner took a deep breath, slowly sighed, and dared open the door.

Castaspella slept, curled up against Shadow Weaver.

She looked peaceful, or perhaps… seemingly weak.

—Es?

—Shush, now… Don't you see she's asleep?

—It's lunchtime already. She's a morning person. *Why* is she still asleep?— the old woman asked, annoyed.

—She's tired, for sure— Shadow Weaver nonchalantly replied. —All this stressing about you must be draining her.

—You're accusing me of- How is this my fault!?

—You have such a pampered existence, indeed…— the apparition scoffed. —Don't you know? *Everything* is our fault. All the evil in the world— she laughed. —We ruin people…

—So you agree? I am bad for her…

—No, that's the thing. *She* is better for us than we can ever be bad for her— Shadow Weaver countered. —Besides the fact that you have *not* ruined anyone in your life, opposite to me, the truth is, even *I* couldn't ruin Castaspella… On the contrary, she pushed me to admit my mistakes, recognize my wrongs, see how at fault I had been most of my life… and probably set the grounds for my final decision.

—What do you mean? Who-who did you ruin?

—The names "Adora" and "Catra" ring a bell?

—Yes. But… I barely know them.

—That's for the better— Shadow Weaver smirked. —I am the worst thing that happened to those girls…

—What did you do?— Light Spinner inquired, part of her feeling like she wouldn't like the answer.

—You won't like the answer— the apparition confirmed, as if reading her thoughts. —But to summarize it… I sought out the evident power Adora held, which I felt since she was a baby, ignored the potential Catra had, which I could have nurtured, refused to show them any love or care when raising them…— she enumerated. —After performing the Spell, I became bitter

and far more selfish. And didn't admit it to myself, despite being called out on it, until the very last moment.

—Why?

—Tell me something: would you say Castaspella is the voice of reason for you?

—Certainly— Light Spinner admitted, scoffing slightly at how ridiculous the question was, as if it were obvious. —I've always been too reckless; her apparition in my life completly changed things. She made me see that recklessness, how my modifications to the Spell of Obtainment weren't enough to guarantee my security, at the very least. I have always been willing to risk it all for power… but she- Well, she cared enough for me to think about my safety— Light Spinner explained, looking fondly at the sleeping sorceress. —Also about the potential collateral damage, another thing I didn't even think about.

—You were lucky to meet her, then— Shadow Weaver assured her. —I performed the spell when Micah was young, she must have been a toddler… If your Micah hadn't backed down, you would have fallen into the same path I did.

—Because no one else cares about us…

—Micah did, the girls did, but of course I wouldn't believe it after my corruption— the apparition admitted, albeit looking in physical pain doing so. —The thing about her isn't just that she cares, but also that she goes out of her way to keep everyone safe. Even if you don't want her help, she won't just leave you to your own devices…

—Not like we would.

—Precisely.

—I don't want to lose her… I *can't*.

—Then why aren't you fighting for her? I am you, I *know* for a fact you're willing to do anything to get what you want. Why are you suddenly giving up?— Shadow Weaver asked, disgusted. —You're being pathetic… If I were in your position, nothing would stop me from fighting for the one person that changed my life so significantly. I can't believe I actually *wish* I were.

Light Spinner felt asahamed for a moment.

The woman was right.

But…

What did she just say?

—You *are* fighting, aren't you?— she suddenly inquired. —Princess Adora apparently feels your presence in our world, and she says you're "fighting to stay". *How*? What exactly are you doing? You just said you'd do anything…

—I did say that, yes…

—…And that nothing would stop you.

—Correct.

—Not even hurting someone else?— Light Spinner pressed on, suspicious.

—My choice of words made you connect the dots… Smart.

—What are you doing to her? She's sleeping so much as a consequence, isn't she?

—That's an unfortunate side effect, yes— Shadow Weaver admitted. Despite feeling the sorceress stir next to her, she still went on —But this is the only way I can stay with her; I am just going after what I *want*.

—You said all this stress must be draining her. But it's *you*! You're leeching her energy!

—Her magic, actually.

Before Light Spinner could reply, indignant beyond words, Castaspella yawned and turned to look at her.

—What are you two… talking about?

—Es!— the woman exclaimed, rushing to kneel next to the bed. —You're awake… How do you feel?

—Tired, but I'm fine.

—Are you sure!?

—Bea, what's going on?

—That-that Shadow Weaver just admitted she's leeching your magic to stay here! That's what Adora meant by "fighting"!

—I know.

—You need to get away from her- Wait… you- So you knew?

—Yes. She told me she needed that to stay. And I don't mind.

—What!? Why!?

—Don't you see? This version of you understands it…— she began, pushing herself up. —I am willing to give everything for you.

—Even your life!?

—I am not a long-lived species like you, Bea, I'm mortal. I'm bound to die before you. And if keeping her in this world, a version of you who wants to be with me, means I'll die sooner, then so be it— she sighed, looking away. —Because, at least, she understands the kind of sacrifice I am willing to make.

—You would rather die for me than become Head Sorceress!?

—Exactly.

—But… It was you who said you preferred me to lose my magic rather than die!

—Because, for you, that is worse than dying. I know it and you said it yourself. Dying is no sacrifice for you…

That… was true.

Light Spinner felt like her decision was bullshit.

However, she perhaps understood now…

The things she asked of her, the sacrifices she asked of Castaspella weren't worth it for her.

This, on the other hand, apparently was.

But *why*!?

The woman couldn't understand it.

Yet she… didn't want to question Castaspella any further.

She looked so weak.

So sad…

—I see— Light Spinner finally sighed. —I… am sorry, Es— she uttered. As the sorceress didn't reply, she decided to ask —Are you- Do you have enough strength to go to the party? Salineas isn't far but…

—I'm fine, don't worry— Castaspella interrupted. —I want to go.

—Alright— she accepted. —But if you want to return early, just tell me, please.

Going by foot and boat to Salineas took a really long time.

The women arrived way after Princess Mermista's speech was done, and Light Spinner took the sorceress directly to a table.

Silent, she brought her some food, kept her company, and many times feint at talking to her… but never dared.

Light Spinner wanted to let her know she would never sit back and watch as Castaspella sacrificed her life for her.

She wanted to remind her how many people love her, how many would miss her, how important she is to so many…

She needed the sorceress to know that this was excessive selflessness, just as bad as her recklessness…

In the same way that Castaspella cared so much about Light Spinner's safety when working on the Spell, she now cared about the young woman's life; she had to tell her.

But she… said nothing.

This time it wasn't fear, like before.

Now it was just shame.

She wasn't in the mood to be at a party…

So, after a long while of hesitating, she decided to leave Salineas.

—Hey, Casta…— Arden called, joining her at a table. —Light Spinner asked me to take you home when the party ends or whenever you want to return. Is… everything alright?

—So she left?

—Yeah, she… didn't look well. And neither do you.

—I'm just tired, but I don't want to leave yet.

—Alright, then… what do you want to do?

—I think I want to eat dessert and chat a bit, if you don't mind— Castaspella faintly smiled. —Are you better after yesterday?

—I am… I- What would you want for dessert? I'll bring you something and… tell you more.

—There was one with submarine fruits, right?

—Something like that— they laughed. —I'll be right back.

At the same time, Princess Glimmer crossed the beautifully decorated corridor and reached the area where most guests were mingling while listening to Sea Hawk's singing. Hesitating a bit, she approached her parents with a sorrowful expression.

—Hey, Mom, Dad— she called. —Can we talk for a sec?

—Oh, Dear. I thought you were with your friends. What is it?— Angella asked.

—You don't look well, Baby Girl.

—I'm… worried about Auntie— the Princess sighed, rubbing her hands together nervously .

—We… know. She seems to be having some trouble— the Queen nodded, looking away.

—Do you know what's happening? Please, just… tell me. Even Adora and Catra don't want to speak about it. What's going on!?

—We know as much as you do— Micah replied, apologetic. —She, uh, proposed to Light Spinner at our party. But she rejected Casta, and then that guy, Moosah, appeared; they have been acting strange ever since.

—Have you talked to Auntie? Or at least to Light Spinner?

—We can't meddle with whatever is going on between them, Glim— Angella denied. —I'm sure Casta would appreciate the support, but… if we try to "help" without her asking for it, we'll probably make things worse.

—I know, but- I just can't stand seeing Auntie like that, and I still don't know what Adora and Catra aren't telling me, and…

—Hey, hey. Calm down, Baby Girl— Micah interrupted, placing his hands on Glimmer's shoulders. —If you want, we can talk to Casta. She must be eating at the other chamber.

—I think that would make me feel better, yes.

—Alright, let's go— he nodded.

The three headed for the corridor connecting both chambers, walked through it in silence, as each tried to imagine how the conversation would play out, and finally reached the dining area.

—Wait, she… was right there— Glimmer realized. —I saw her right before going to find you!

—Do you think she left already?— Angella asked her husband.

—Well, she usually returns before midnight— he recalled.

—But this party lasts a few hours more!

—I know, Dear. But she probably isn't feeling good enough to stay— her mother sighed.

—Tomorrow. Please let's find her as soon as she arrives at the Kingdom of Snows' palace— Glimmer pleaded.

—Of course, Baby Girl.

Meanwhile, back in the Whispering Woods, Light Spinner arrived at the cabin and dragged herself inside.

Like the first night, the door to the bedroom was ajar and the woman approached without thinking much.

—You're back alone… I can't believe you would leave her after all that scandal earlier.

—Shut up. She's in good hands. Someone who can *actually* teleport her here will bring her back. Much better than my useless self…

—You surprise me yet again, and for the worst. Every time I think you're as pathetic as can be, you reach a new level of disappointment— Shadow Weaver reproached her. —I never expected there to be a version of me who can be so… *spineless*.

—Stop calling me that! Is it not enough for you to steal my woman!? You must also insult me!?

—I'm stating *facts*. You have only stood there, watched me kiss "your woman" and allowed it— she pointed out. —I might be you, but is that really the reason why you let me do what I want with her? In your own room!? Or is it because you're a coward who bought the bullshit your elder told you!? That you're not a woman and have no honor to safekeep— she went on. —"What honor do you have to protect" were his exact words, right? Since when are you so *weak*!? Why allow him to influence your relationship!? Is she "your woman" or not!?

—She is!

—Prove it!

—I said I have nothing to prove to you!

—But you have— Shadow Weaver insisted. —And it's not "to me". It's to *yourself*, remember?

Light Spinner couldn't answer before the door to the cabin opened.

Castaspella was back.

Chapter End Notes

Now yes!!

As you can see, the scene is set and ready for the beginning of the ascension back to the happy ending!

LS shall resurface from this whole mess, born anew! I promise nothing but happiness for the couple in the last two chapters! ^v^

But I shall not spoil you XD

See you tomorrow! (Pray for my mental health to any and all known gods… I have yet to write next chapter TT-TT)

Chapter 30: Day 6: Kingdom of Snows

Chapter Notes

Omgs, I must apologize for the delay… it's 6am here and I have JUST finished the chapter… I don't know what I'll do for tomorrow's chapter. I'm in such a predicament…

I am also Struggling™ in general cause my PC's motherboard died right before the 25th, meaning everything that wasn't ready by then had to be handled on a lended pc or now on the tablet which is a nightmare sometimes
For instance, just yesterday I lost at least 20mins of writing I had -well- written, because the app on the tablet was crashing…

Truly a nightmare.

BUT HEY! BACK TO THE PARTIES NOW!

PLEASE ENJOY TODAY'S CHAPTER!
LET THE FLUFF BEGIN!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 6

Kingdom of Snows

Year four

The second Castaspella stepped into the room, Shadow Weaver dismissed Light Spinner and walked past her towards the sorceress, immediately embracing her.

Alright, that was *enough*.

This time for real.

The woman remained shocked barely a few seconds before finally reacting, and didn't hesitate to physically separate them, stepping in the middle.

Rude or not, she didn't care.

She was overwhelmed by so many emotions, they should be *thankful* that she only pushed them apart.

—I can't bear it anymore!— Light Spinner began, fist tightly closed. On the verge of tears, she stood protectively in front of Castaspella, and faced Shadow Weaver. —You might be me, but those kisses are mine! Every single touch, every embrace, every moan you might have provoked, it's all *my privilege*! And *you*, even if you're me, have no right to take it from me!

—If that's the case, why have you allowed it for so long!?— the apparition questioned her.

—I don't know!

—You do!— she immediately reproached her. —You bought Moosah's lie! You believed yourself to be undeserving of her! But I have *never* doubted my womanhood! I *never* needed those foolish elders to recognize me! *We* never needed them! Do you really *want* her!?

—Of course I want her!

—Do you love her!?

—More than I'd like to admit!— Light Spinner replied, unable to hold back a sob.

—Are you ready to prove it!? To everyone!?

—If that's the only way to get her back, then I will!— she confidently nodded, straightening her back. —Moosah be damned…

—So you finally understood— Shadow Weaver smirked. —You've proved it to yourself… Now it's time to *show them*. We never bowed to the whims of old fools. Be it Norwyn, Moosah, or whoever dares get in our way— she declared. —My only aim was power, all my life… Yours? Is it her?

—It is…

Stepping forward, Shadow Weaver placed her hands on Light Spinner's shoulders and nodded —Then *fight* for her.

Right after, as the apparition smirked proudly, she dissolved into bright spores like the ones that had appeared that first night.

A sob called the woman's attention back to Castaspella behind her and she immediately turned around.

—Thank you…— she muttered, before the last spores disappeared. And once out of her shock, she stepped forward and hugged Light Spinner tightly, taking a deep breath, realizing how much she missed her. —Bea…

—I'm *so* sorry, Es.

—I'm sorry too, my Love— Castaspella sobbed. —I-I made a deal with Shadow Weaver to-to make you realize what you were doing, ho-how you were letting everyone push you around, and how you had been so… *afraid* to stand up for yourself, even *to yourself*.

—A deal…

—That first morning, she explained to me what she knew about her status here. She-she was just an illusion conjured by the Whispering Woods, my yearning for your love, and your passiveness— she explained. —So she considered her mission here, the reason why she appeared, was to help us.

—I really behaved most pathetically, didn't I?— Light Spinner smirked, holding the sorceress close to her. —I'm sorry, Es. I was so afraid to lose you… that I almost did.

—I just hope you didn't really feel like I was cheating on you— Castaspella then sighed, looking away in shame.

The woman spent a few moments pretending to be thinking about it, until the sorceress' expression turned fearful and, only then, she dropped the pretense. Without a word, she finally smirked, leant forward to kiss her hungrily, and took her to bed.

The following morning, the women woke up between each other's arms for the first time since the beginning of the week.

They felt happy, relaxed, *relieved*.

Castaspella was no longer tired, her magic and energy had been restored, and so they both got up early to start cooking together the food for Mystacor's party.

—Tell me something, Es…

—Say.

—Why on Etheria do you still handle the katering for Mystacor's parties if you already left the Guild?

—Oh, that?— she asked back, surprised. Without stopping her stirring, she explained — Well… I told Norwyn I didn't mind keeping this duty regardless… They've always depended on me and another four magicians for this task, and if I stopped helping, the others would be loaded with more stuff to cook and bake, and… Well, remember how I needed help back when Adora and Catra married? I'm just trying to save them the trouble until they find someone to cover my spot.

—They should at least pay you now…

—They cover the costs, that's enough.

—Alright, alright… Your decision.

Like that, morning went by beautifully.

Perhaps too much.

Light Spinner's sense of dread lingered in the back of her mind but moved closer as the time for the party at the Kingdom of Snows approached.

However, she kept pushing it away.

It was nothing…

It couldn't be anything…

That afternoon, the women decided to rendezvous with the royal family in Bright Moon so they could all go together to the Kingdom of Snow's palace.

Light Spinner had arrived deep in thought, still thinking about Shadow Weaver's last words before disappearing, but Glimmer's indignant voice soon brought her back.

—…So don't you dare do that again!

—Excuse me, Princess, but I don't think I understand what has you so upset.

—That you did… *whatever* it is that you did to Auntie the past few days!

—Come on, Glim, it was nothing that severe— Castaspella tried to calm her.

—Not severe!?— her niece scoffed. —You didn't see your face yesterday! I thought she had straight up ditched you!

—Fortunately, Princess, that was *not* the case.

—Yeah, I can see that. So *whatever* happened, don't do it again or I'm sparkle-punching you!

—Of course, your Majesty. I'll take your threat seriously— the woman replied with a smirk.

—Alright, enough you two— Angella interceded. —We should get going. And… I'm glad you're both fine. It's good to see you happy again.

The Queen wasn't the only one to notice and compliment the improvement of their relationship.

Since arriving at the Kingdom of Snows, many who had previously talked to them asking about the rumours Moosah had spread returned to express how glad they were to see them both happy again.

However, the feeling of dread haunting Light Spinner finally took over as she realized what its origin was: Moosah.

She had yet to face Moosah himself.

The woman had told Shadow Weaver she was ready to prove it to everyone that she loved Castaspella… but the real challenge would be proving it to *him* that she loves the sorceress more than she fears him.

She was afraid.

She didn’t feel ready.

But one look at Castaspella’s bright smile was enough to harden her resolve.

During the first half of the party, the sorceress made all kinds of efforts to keep Light Spinner away from her elder, but she knew it’d be a question of time until they crossed paths…

And finally, they did.

He stood behind her and let out a very audible sigh, which made her turn around.

—How stubborn…— the man said, looking away and holding a cup. —What do you expect to achieve, Light Spinner?

—With what exactly?

—This behaviour. Clinging so desperately to your… relationship with that young sorceress, who clearly has great potential!

—I only hope to achieve happiness, of course. It might be a foreign concept to you… But I have no ulterior motives— she confidently replied, standing tall in front of him.

—You have nothing to offer her; no honor, no status, no future, *nothing*.

—Oh, I certainly agree. I have nothing like that to offer her— she nodded, taking a step forward. Then, leaning closer, she whispered —But here's a secret I recently understood: she doesn't want *any* of that. All she wants… is *me*.

—You!?— he scoffed, indignant. —You aren't even a woman!

—And I don't have to be. That's not something she cares about…

—But she seems to care about marrying you, and that won't happen. I will not…

—I don't need your permission to be with Castaspella— Light Spinner interrupted. —I don't need anyone's permission other than *hers*.

Keeping her head high and her eyes on him, the woman waited for an answer.

Moosah held her sight, tense but keeping his anger under control, and after a moment, squinted at her.

But then Castaspella approached, placed a hand on Light Spinner's arm, and called her attention.

—Bea…

—Es— she replied, immediately turning to face her and pretending Moosah wasn't there. —If… you still want to marry me, then I'll help you find a way. If you don't care about my lack of honor, if you want to be with me regardless, then I won't stop you anymore— she promised, holding her hands.

The sorceress felt her heart skip a beat, elated, and replied by throwing her arms around the woman's neck to kiss her through the veil, never sparing a thought for who was around.

—Preposterous!— Moosah exclaimed, calling everyone's attention and causing the music of the party to stop.

—No, no. "Preposterous" is what you've been doing this week! "Preposterous" is *your* behaviour!

Light Spinner didn't waver.

She remained calm, looked smug, smirked proudly under her veil…

She was back.

And then, almost as if she were expecting it, Princess Frosta interceded.

—What is the meaning of all this scandal!?— she sternly inquired, approaching them, flanked by two guards. —Your name was Moosah, correct?

—Yes, your Majesty.

—An elder of Candila. I have heard *many* things about you and I'm far from impressed— she declared, severe. —I can understand having your personal issues with this woman, and I certainly have my own since a few years ago— she began, vaguely referencing the infamous interruption of her party. —But you are not, and I mean it, you are *not* allowed to harass her or any other guest!

—Your Majesty, you don't understand…

—I understand perfectly! But you are still being warned: if you don't leave the rests of my guests in peace, I shall have to invite you to *leave*.

Just as Light Spinner had always shown great respect for Princess Frosta, it seemed like Moosah saw the same as her and held her in great steem. So, of course, he wouldn't dare defy her in the slightest.

—Of course, your Majesty. I apologize— he retreated, bowing respectfully.

—Good! Now, let the party continue, shall we?

Castaspella and Light Spinner silently bowed in thanks, and the Princess returned to her table without another word.

—Oh, my Stars…— the sorceress sighed. —That was scary for a second— she admitted, squeezing the woman's hand still in hers.

—*He* was lucky— Light Spinner scoffed. —Another word and I would have…

—Better- Uh, better *don't* say anything else— she interrupted, looking around to make sure her threat hadn't been heard. —The Princess might consider it inappropriate to say such things.

—Right…— she sighed, giving up. —But I stand by what I was going to say. He better keep it to himself from now on.

—You do your best to remain civil, alright? Let the Princesses remind him that we are *not* at war— she suggested.

—Right. He's quite belligerent himself…

—Precisely.

—Alright, I'll do my best— she promised. —Now, let's return to our table… I can see the dessert is being served— Light Spinner suggested, with a knowing look.

The party lasted a couple of hours more, and the women left a bit before midnight to return to their cabin in the Whispering Woods.

Soon, they had arrived, but before walking in, Castaspella stopped her.

—Bea, I… have a question.

—About? Can't we discuss it inside?

—I just… think the night looks beautiful, and the Moons of Enchantment look so pretty…

—Alright, alright. What is it, Es?— she asked, humoring her.

The sorceress recognized the tone, let out half a smile, and raised the woman's hands to her mouth to kiss them briefly.

—I am so grateful for the time spent together with you, and… I want you to know how much I appreciate all the efforts you've made lately…

—Es…

—So I must ask again— she went on, determined. —Would you grant me the honor of becoming my wife?

A second passed in silence, then another.

The veil fluttered with the breeze.

Emerald green eyes looked back at the sorceress…

But she couldn't understand if there was any answer in that look.

So she waited a bit longer…

And, finally, Light Spinner pulled her closer, whispering —It'd be *my* honor.

Chapter End Notes

Seee?? I promised you a happy ending!
-But this is not the ending yet- I SAID I PROMISED A HAPPY ENDING AND YOULL GET IT

No, I have no idea yet what the last chapter will look like, but this is the beginning of the end and the tone is set, alright? Rest assured…

Anyways, I'll see you tomorrow, probably at this time again, and I hope you're enjoying this!

Bye!

Chapter 31: Day 7: Mystacor

Chapter Notes

I'm gonna cry, it's so late… literally 4.30pm…
It's 2025 already somewhere 😭

But the end is finally here!!

I apologize for it's short, BUT it's the promised happy ending :D

In any case, I certainly hope you like it, and happy reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 7

Mystacor

Year four

The women celebrated their engagement their own way.

They had been living in the middle of the Whispering Woods for so long yet rarely sat to enjoy the scenery, the stars, the sounds of nature… So, of course, they decided to take the couch outside, garb their favourite drinks, and sit to enjoy the night.

Castaspella took a long sip of her cup, rested back, and let out a deep sigh.

Eyes closed, she heard the rustling of the wind through the leaves, the chirping of insects and night birds…

Then, opening her eyes, she observed the bright stars populating the night sky, the dark trees framing her view, the shine of the Moons, and… Light Spinner's face, barely illuminated next to her.

—The night is beautiful, isn't it?

—Of course… That's why I settled here.

—I tend to… forget to look around me and enjoy things.

—We have that in common— Light Spinner snickered. —Taking a moment to sit back and contemplate everything might be what we need. We should do this more often.

—I would certainly like that, yes…

—Then it's a deal.

The following morning was expected to be a nightmare…

They knew it'd be hectic, having to take all the food to Mystacor during the morning, and they felt tired just thinking about it.

But they were also pretty nervous and it was difficult to fall asleep…

So when morning arrived, sun shone into the cabin, and the women *hated* it.

—Ugh— Castaspella groaned. —Get up…

—No…— Light Spinner groaned back. —You get up…

—No, you…

—Forget it…

And like that they spent at least an hour, trying to get the other to get up first and handle breakfast.

Until realization hit the sorceress: Her brother and some acolytes would arrive any moment now to help carry the food to the island!

—Well, damn it…— she finally cursed, pushing herself up. —Bea, can you please make breakfast while I get everything ready to be delivered?

—Do I have to?

—It would be *nice* if you could help me with that…

—Alright, alright— the woman sighed, brushing her eyes. —I'll fix us something to eat…

—Thank you— Castaspella replied, pressing a kiss to Light Spinner's forehead before finally standing to get her clothes.

She did as promised and it allowed the sorceress to focus on the delivery without skipping breakfast…

Castaspella gave her brother and the acolytes everything they could carry, and finally took herself the last few dishes to Mystacor.

She had left barely minutes before when Light Spinner heard a knock on the door.

—Norwyn? All the food is being delivered, and…

—I am aware— he interrupted her, raising a hand. —That's precisely why I am here.

—Come to speak with me alone?

—Indeed. May I come in?— he inquired, raising a brow.

—Sure…

Resigned, Light Spinner stepped aside to let him in, and they both stood a bit awkwardly in the middle of the living room.

—Well, uh… let me begin— he eventually said, clearing his throat. —I have come to apologize. I know how it must sound to you, but after everything that happened this week

with your… elder, I couldn't help noticing that I have been unfair to you both. I regret the things I've done, but I can imagine that must be unbelievable coming from me.

—Quite— she agreed, folding her arms.

—Of course…— he sighed, looking down for a moment. —Light Spinner, I must say I have noticed great improvement from you, and I am glad to see it. I can only hope you will continue to get better and, who knows, eventually recover your sorcery…

—Much as I appreciate the vote of confidence, I don't see why you had to come all the way here to say this…

—Right. The reason I wanted to speak privately with you would be that I have an offer for you and Castaspella— he began again. —Nothing like last year, of course— he quickly clarified, as she gave him a questioning look. —Taking into account what you said yesterday, I believe it would be of your interest.

—Just spit it out…

—I would be willing to officiate your wedding, regardless of what your elder says— he finally said. —You could consider it my way of… compensating you for… well, everything.

Had he just…

Impossible.

Or was it?

—You mean it?

—Of course— he nodded. —Although, in secret, I'd say.

—Hah!— Light Spinner scoffed. —Of course. We wouldn't mind the secrecy. Neither of us wants to make a big deal of it…

Norwyn nodded, a small smile curving his lips, and extended a hand for her to shake.

Eventually, it was time for the party of Mystacor to begin, and the couple walked in together, making a point of ignoring Moosah.

Fortunately, he had been assigned a table quite far from theirs…

—While I'm gladly surprised we have been assigned a table, for once, I can't help but feel this all is *very* purposeful— Castaspella commented.

—Oh, of course it is— Light Spinner confirmed. As they both took their seats, she explained —That old ram might be a fool, but he's not cruel. Even he is appalled by Moosah's behaviour and made sure he wouldn't bother us.

—Really!?

—Good afternoon, ladies— Delwyn accidentally interrupted, joining them at the table. —I'm so glad we get to sit together this year!— he smiled.

—How are you doing, Casta?— Kharyn asked, while his sister silently seconded his concern.

—I'm quite alright now, thank you— she softly replied. —What about you two?

—We're fine. We weren't harassed half of the week…— Namai scoffed, clearly bitter. —You can tell us if you're upset.

—Trust me, I am not, Kids— she insisted. —I was, I'll admit that… but everything is more than fine now, I promise you.

—Indeed, you can trust her— Light Spinner chimed in, smirking. —She's quite fine, I'm making sure of it.

—What took you so long?

—Namai!

—It's alright, I like her new boldness— the woman noted, snickering. —I'll tell you what took me so long: learning to recognize the value of what's in front of me.

—Bea…

—Before you say I'm mocking her or you… no, I am not. I mean it. Which I *hate* to admit, but she asked— Light Spinner rushed to clarify.

The sorceress pressed her temples and let out a sigh while Namai stared incredulously at the woman.

—You're kidding me…

—I'm not particularly fond of joking.

—No, no. You *have* to be! How can someone be *so stupid*!?

—Alright, that's enough— Delwyn told her off, severe.

—Let her speak her mind. She's quite right— Light Spinner laughed.

—Don't enable her. She can't "speak her mind" unfiltered— the Ambassador complained.

—But shouldn't go around saying white lies just to keep everyone happy either.

—I'm not saying that. I just want my children to learn some diplomacy. Hold it together and keep it respectful.

—It's *difficult* to keep it respectful when it comes to *her*, Dad— Namai complained.

—You're clearly at the age where you would have been in perpetual disagreement with your Theyi— Delwyn lamented, thinking about how similar his partner was to Light Spinner.

—And all kids go through that— Castaspella pointed out. —So let's keep it civil.

—Can I say something?

—Don't ask for permission, Kharyn, just say it— his sister exhorted him.

—I was worried about you both— he began, earnestly looking at the sorceress. —But you're fine now. I trusted you would handle it, and you did— he expressed. —So, I think we shouldn't give her such a bad time— he then told Namai.

—Fine!

Castaspella couldn't help laughing wholeheartedly at her exhasperated groan, and the rest soon followed.

Even Light Spinner.

They slowly calmed down, and only then noticed Arden had approached the table.

—Good evening— they shyly said.

—Oh, Arden!— Castaspella beamed.

—Councillor— Delwyn respectfully nodded.

—Ah, young Arden… Joining us?

—Yeah— they confirmed. —If you don't mind them joining too— Arden added, moving aside to reveal Double Trouble.

The shape-shifter let out a sheepish smile, and awkwardly waved.

—Of course they can join us, we have an extra seat— Castaspella smiled.

Clearly overjoyed, the couple sat down and the councillor introduced everyone.

Then, the inevitable question was finally spoken by Light Spinner…

—So, you have decided to try again after all?

—We… have, yes— Arden shyly smiled.

—We'll try, indeed. And I promise: no secrets this time— Double Trouble added. —I swear on my…

—Don't swear on anything— the councillor interrupted. —Please.

—Fine, Ardy, I won't. You all will just have to trust me, then— they snickered.

Light Spinner immediately looked at Castaspella, and the sorceress gave her a warning look.

She knew it'd be better not to provoke them, and silently let her know she wouldn't do it…

Instead, she asked —And are you two sure about this? Your arguments were pretty explosive.

—Oh, that was a hundred percent *my fault*— the shape-shifter began. —Drama is my life, I never even consider the importance of privacy for such matters… But Ardy asked for space and time to think, and I decided to do the same. So, yesterday, when I approached them again, I made sure to keep it all between us.

—They showed real improvement and understanding of everything I had reproached them, so yeah… we decided to give our relationship another chance now that they're more aware…

Amidst friendly chatting, the evening went by fast.

Soon it would be midnight, the New Year was upon them, and Castaspella wanted to speak with her family.

After all, she had good news!

Hence, she dragged Light Spinner across the party to find Micah and Angella, hopefully with Glimmer close by.

—Micah!— Castaspella called when she found him.

—Oh, Sis! Came to see the year off with your Brother, this time?

—Maybe— she chuckled. —But first, I want to talk to you, Angella and Glimmer— she clarified.

—Sure! Angie just went to look for Glim. They'll be here soon.

The sorceress impatiently waited for them, and as soon as they appeared, she began —Alright. What I wanted to tell you is… very important for me, and also very recent…

—We're engaged— Light Spinned cut her. —Since last night.

—*What*!?— the Princess exclaimed, voicing her parents' shock.

—Beatrix! Why didn't you let me say it!?

—You were talking too long…— the woman dismissively replied, rolling her eyes pretending to be annoyed, albeit smirking amusedly. —We both know it'd be new year before you finally said it…

—Mean! That was *so* mean!

—Wait, wait. You're engaged!? For real!?— Glimmer inquired, still in shock.

—Yes!

—Auntie! That's awesome! I'm so happy!— the Princess exclaimed, jumping to hug her. —You have to tell me everything!

—I will, I will…— she laughed.

—And… give me some tips to do it…— she then muttered.

Castaspella's expression completely changed and, eyes wide open, she looked at her brother only to find him just as shocked.

—Are you planning to…

—Shush!

—Alright, I won't say anything— she giggled. —But my first tip would be: go and propose at midnight— she whispered, winking.

—Wait, wait. I- Are you really- Bu-but you're just a girl!

—Dad, I'm Adora's age and she is already *married*!

—But… Baby Girl…

—I'm not a baby anymore, Dad— she gently told him, holding his hands.

Right after, Angella placed her hands on his shoulders and silently encouraged him to accept it.

—You're right— he sighed. —Then you better hurry, it's almost midnight— he smiled.

—Thanks, Dad!— she exclaimed, jumping to hug him.

She ran off almost immediately, and right after, a pair of acolytes appeared with trays offering a drink to welcome the year.

—Well, that was unexpected— Light Spinner commented, sipping hers.

—I'd say about time— Castaspella chuckled. —Are you… alright, Brother?

—O-of course! Yes. I- uh, when does the light show begin?

The three women couldn't help laughing wholeheartedly, but none of them mocked him; not even Light Spinner despite how tempted she was…

—I think it's about to start— Angella told him, placing a hand on his shoulder.

And indeed, it was.

The four turned their eyes to the sky as the first lights appeared, and only looked away when they heard the guests gasping at the Princess of Bright Moon suddenly proposing to her boyfriend.

With a soft smile, Castaspella glanced at Light Spinner and leant on her, sighing deeply.

—Happy New Year…

Chapter End Notes

And we're done!
Bye, bye, 2024!

I hope you all liked it, really, I'm so sorry for the delay, and thank you so much for accompanying me this year again!

:D see ya next year!!

Happy 2025!!

Chapter 32: A New Year

A New Year

One year later…

Chapter 33: Day 1: Bright Moon

Chapter Notes

Hi everyone!!

Welcome back! Fifth year doing this, I'm excited (/v\)

First of all, happy holidays everyone!
Second, I hope you enjoy this year's iteration of my festive fic, and hopefully I'll manage to finish the last two chapters in time…
I had a bit of a hard time writing this year…

Anyways, no more delaying
Please enjoy!! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 1

Bright Moon

Year Five

The End of The Year Week had finally arrived.

At last… What a long year it had been…

As usual, preparations for Bright Moon's party were in full swing. However, this time, Castaspella was *not* the one taking charge of it.

It certainly came as a surprise to most of the palace servants, all of them used to her organizing this party every year, but they didn't give it much importance.

After all, it had never been her duty, she was just helping…

Similarly, when those who knew Casta learnt she wasn't handling the party preparation, their first thought was that it was strange, yet a good thing! At last, she had taken some time to rest!

How wrong they were…

The young sorceress was at home, sitting on the couch, drinking something while staring at the distance.

That was certainly not what Light Spinner expected to see when she walked out of her room…

—Morning?

—Afternoon— Castaspella corrected her, without looking back.

—What? Uh… What day is it?

—Yes, Bright Moon's party is today— she replied, guessing what the old woman meant, with a tone that made it clear the sorceress was quite upset.

—I'm rather surprised you are here and not…

—Don't even mention it.

—Es, are you… alright?— the woman finally decided to ask, joining her on the couch. —Talk to me…

—No, I'm *not* alright!— Castaspella snapped.

—Can you tell me what happened?

—You'll just tell me I'm exagerating…

—Why don't you let me be the judge of that?— Light Spinner insisted.

—Bea, I would prefer not to get mad at you too.

The woman let out a long sigh and pulled Castaspella closer to kiss her neck briefly.

—I think I can handle that— she smirked.

—This is unfair…— the sorceress complained, resisting no more than a second. —I'm just… It's…

—Alright, let me help you a bit— Light Spinner decided, letting go of her and taking a more serious approach. —I know you always organize that party, and pretty much look forward to it every year… So why aren't you doing it this time? Did something happen with your brother?

—No, no…

—So?

Looking away, noticeably upset, Castaspella hesitated a bit before answering.

—Bow's fathers are taking care of it.

—Really?

—They heard I always organize the party and, now that their son married Glimmer, they wanted to help but… they insisted I had to "rest and leave it to them".

—But- Tha-that's a good thing!

—No!— Castaspella immediately rebuked, indignant. —I- It should be- I'm… supposed to be…

—No, you're not— Light Spinner interrupted her. —You know full well it is *not* your responsibility. It never was, and you helping has always been something…

—Don't start…— Castaspella interrupted her, whining.

—Es, I'm serious. It wasn't just me. How many of us have told you it is *one* thing to help, and *another* to take charge the way you did? Seriously, it was *never* your job to…

—I wanted to do it!

—Why?

—Why not!?

Light Spinner closed her eyes for a second, thinking.

This was going nowhere.

—Alright. Let's change the approach: Es, Love, why are you *so upset* about this?

—I… don't know? I'm just… I feel…— she began, but trailed off. For a moment, she was at a loss for words, but Light Spinner silently waited for her to find her speech again. And finally, she managed to express —*Useless*.

Well, that certainly made no sense, but Light Spinner could prefectly understand what she meant.

—You… do know that you *aren't* useless if you're not constantly helping, right?— she began, but the sorceress only looked away, ashamed. Gently taking Castaspella's hands, the woman insisted —Es… your worth is *not* measured by how much you do for others, or how much you give. Tell me you understand that.

However, Castaspella refused to look back.

Resigned, Light Spinner pulled her closer again, hugged her tightly, and held her for a while, thinking…

Eventually, she got an idea and took the sorceress to Bright Moon.

Later, with the party in full swing, Light Spinner sipped her cup calmly, observing Castaspella and her family from a distance.

As she put her cup down, letting out a smirk, the woman turned to look at the man approaching her.

—Greetings.

—Evening, Ambassador— she replied.

—You don't seem surprised.

—Took you long enough to come to me. Now, let me guess… You want to ask something about Casta.

—Yes— he admitted, taking a seat next to her. —I heard she wasn't organizing today's party earlier, and…

—I imagine it was quite hard to believe.

—Well, I was actually glad she wasn't, for once. But…

—So was I. She, however, wasn't.

—I don't understand— he admitted.

—I'm not sure why, but being… kept from organizing this party actually affected her very much.

—Why would it? Three years ago she seemed quite tired of it, and pointed out repeatedly that it was *not* her responsibility…

—Well, of course— Light Spinner scoffed. —She's aware of it, logically, but that only proves it's a rather unconscious thing what happened this morning- *afternoon*.

—Care to explain?

—She was so upset… You have no idea. It seems she feels useless if she's not always doing something for others— the woman sighed. —I tried to make her see that's ridiculous, but… she won't listen. So I brought her here and convinced Bow's fathers to let her help, at the very least.

—You threatened them?— Delwyn asked, raising a brow.

—I prefer the term "coerce"— she replied, smirking.

—Same difference— he sighed. —However, that's quite worrisome.

—Indeed.

—So?

—I will try to talk to her, of course— she nodded. —I'm just giving her some time to enjoy the party before I do, lest I ruin her mood…

—That makes sense— he nodded. —If I may… why did you bring her and…

—You have no idea how bad she was. The only way to… calm her down, at least for now, was to convince those two of letting her help— she began, interrupting him. —I panicked, needed time to think.

—Ah… Right. I guess that wasn't a bad idea. At least for now.

—Don't worry. I'm not leaving it like this. I won't keep feeding her belief that she *must* be giving and giving all the time.

Meanwhile, somewhere else in the palace, Princess Glimmer had just learnt about the little incident that morning and wasted no time before talking to her in-laws.

—Oh, Glimmer! Good evening!— Lance happily greeted her.

—Evening, Princess— George smiled, nodding cordially. —How do you like the party?

—Oh, uh, evening to you two too— she first replied, a bit awkward. —The-the party is great, but, uh… funny enough, I wanted to talk to you about it…

Exchanging a glance with his husband, George immediately nodded —Of course. Anything the matter?

—Yes, well, I mean… It's nothing bad, it's just… I heard that you had- Is it true that you took over Auntie's organization this year?

Once again, they exchanged a brief glance, mainly confused.

—We heard she always did, and thought we could help instead and let her rest— Lance argued.

—No, yeah, that's perfect, but… she never let anyone… Ho-how did you manage?

—We insisted?

—But she still joined us later to finish preparing everything— George sighed.

—Alright— Glimmer sighed too. —Here's the thing. I heard Light Spinner was a bit…

—Oh, that?— Lance interrupted, laughing awkwardly while scratching the back of his neck. —It's nothing, really, don't worry, Princess.

—No, you… don't understand— Glimmer denied, gloomy. —I-I know you think you were doing something good for Aunt Casta, but… uh, getting in the way of her party-organization is never a good idea— she hesitantly explained. Now they were certainly at a loss for words, so the princess immediately went on —Trust me. We all want her to take it easy and rest sometimes, but you have no idea how she gets. Light Spinner threatening you to let her help was *nothing* compared to what… I've heard.

Neither said a word for a long moment.

Confusion had turned into concern, and now the men had no idea what to say.

Eventually, George dared ask —What do you mean, Princess?

—I've noticed how intense Auntie gets with these things. I've… tried to get her to leave the matter on someone else's hands before, and it never turned out well— she began. —When I heard you actually managed it, I was actually quite worried… And then I heard Light Spinner had- Well, that she… So-sorry. I'm probably just confusing you both a lot.

—Glim?

—Oh, Bow!— she reacted, turning to find her husband had approached.

Despite trying to hide her unease, he noticed clear as day that she wasn't exactly talking about the weather with his fathers, so he had approached and now held her comfortingly.

—Were you, maybe, talking about your aunt?

—Yeah…

—Why don't you let me explain?

—Explain what, Son?— George inquired, worried.

—Well, it's just that…— he began, briefly looking at Glimmer, waiting for confirmation. When she nodded, he went on —We noticed her aunt reacts rather intensely to being… kept from helping.

—Were we wrong to…— Lance began, but trailed off. —We just wanted to help too.

—I know, Dad. It's fine, you guys didn't know. A-and actually, I've always said it's not right for Casta to react like that. I-I mean… it can't be right.

Glimmer looked down and sighed deeply, wrapping her husband in an embrace and resting against him.

—I know that, but I *don't know* what to do about it, and I was worried for your dads, Bow…

—Perhaps we shouldn't have interferred— George considered.

—Forget it, Dad— Bow replied. —You guys did nothing wrong, alright? And then you three organized the party, there were no arguments… I think we can forget the matter.

—Should we apologize to her?— Lance asked, worried.

—No, no. Better- He-he's right. Better pretend nothing happened— Glimmer replied, shaking her head.

The party went on without any issues or drama.

Just as promised, Light Spinner let the sorceress enjoy it and only about an hour before the end, did she ask her for a moment to talk.

—If it's about earlier… I-I'm really sorry, Bea. I was upset, and…

—Of course it is about earlier— she interrupted. —But I don't want your apologies, I want… to understand— she explained. —Es, why are you so…

—So what?— she asked back, folding her arms.

Well, she was definitely getting angry already…

Maybe a different choice of words.

—Love, listen to me: I want to understand why you have such a *need* to always be helping, giving, and facilitating things for others. And how could somehting so *simple* as not letting you help with this party make you feel so bad about yourself.

—I wasn't- No, I-I didn't feel bad about myself— Castaspella promptly denied, looking away. —I was upset, but… I-I mean, I just *wanted* to help, alright? For no reason! Just because I can!— she assured her. —Seriously. What's so wrong about being selfless?

—Okay, no. Hold on three seconds. That's not- Es, you take "selflessness" to a ridiculous extreme, alright?

—Or maybe that's how *you* see it…— Castaspella insisted, arms folded again as she turned around a bit.

Was that… possible?

Could Light Spinner be seeing it as "too much" selflessness because she herself is too selfish?

No, no… There's no way this is right.

Castaspella should *not* feel "useless" just because she was told to leave the party organization on someone else's hands…

There is *no way* her crying over that is a *normal* reaction.

Besides, that ambassador seemed to agree with her about this matter.

Then what was she missing?

—Es…— she finally sighed, realizing something. —Remember when… uh, when you told me how I wasn't there for five years… that I didn't know what you went through? Is there anything you need to tell me? Is there something I should know?

Lowering her gaze, the sorceress hesitated a moment but let Light Spinner hold her closer.

Shaking her head at first, Castaspella tried to deny it. However, as the woman cupped her cheek and made the sorceress face her, she finally gave up.

Thinking better about it, Castaspella let out a sigh and let herself rest against Light Spinner's chest.

—Well, if you must know… Those five years were… *a thing*— she began. —I had to constantly prove my worth, for which I had to help as much as possible, make myself

useful…— she admitted. However, she then let out a weak smile as she added —But it wasn't that bad. Really. I mean, I already was like that since before. After all… I *did* help you with that damned spell without reservations despite my general wariness towards you.

The sorceress giggled sheepishly and hugged Light Spinner tightly for a moment, noticiably tired, while the woman was left thinking.

She hadn't… thought about it before, but it *is* true that she had always been a bit *too* selfless, even back then.

They probably wouldn't have gotten involved if she hadn't been…

However, that only meant this was maybe worse than Light Spinner initially thought.

She was far more concerned now.

This meant the issue ran deeper than imagined, and maybe further away in time too.

Perhaps it would be a good idea to talk to Micah a bit, and learn more about Castaspella's childhood.

Chapter End Notes

Alright!
That was all for today!!

See you tomorrow!!! ^_^

Chapter 34: Day 2: Dryl

Chapter Notes

Alright!
Second day of the week!!

So, as you've already noticed, I guess, this year the focus won't be LS and her problems/progress, but rather Casta's!!
You know, I didn't know what to write about this year. I could just do fluff and domestic moments with no plot, but… My psychologist had a better idea.
Thing is, I always focused on LS, and never really paid much attention to Casta, and what happens to her. Why she's constantly giving, and… what happens when she *can't* give/help.

And, you know, I always write those moments of LS/SW telling Casta she's "too nice", but you know what? I've been told exactly that. Like, a lot.
I've been told I apologize too much, etc etc, and like you may or may not know, everything I've put LS through, are things I myself went through. So, yeah, I went from one extreme to the other, and I'm currently in Casta's extreme, trying to work it out, just like Casta will be…

So, uh, yeah, this is a thing, and I really hope u enjoy it :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 2

Dryl

Year Five

To no one's surprise, and despite Castaspella being quite tired, the sorceress still wanted to help tidying and cleaning up at the end of the party. Light Spinner was pretty sure she had never stayed so late to help with that part, but she reckoned it was because she felt she hadn't done "enough" this time around…

In any case, she decided to indulge her, and take advantage of the time to speak with her brother while she was busy.

—Oh, Light Spinner— he reacted, surprised when she approached him. —What are you doing still here?

—Didn't you hear? Your sister wanted to stay and help clean up…

—Why is she… Ugh, never mind. Did you want to talk to me, or…

—Yes, I do— she nodded. —It is, in fact, related to Casta staying to clean.

—What do you mean? You *know* we didn't ask her to…

—Of course, Micah, I know— she interrupted. —She's staying to clean because she feels she didn't do enough for you this year, since Bow's fathers took over organizing and only let her join in near the end… because I *asked* them to.

Closing his eyes, the king took a moment; he seemed confused for a second as he tried to piece together the information.

Finally, brushing his face with both hands, he let out a sigh.

—Alright. Then, what did you want to talk about?

—Just about her childhood, if you don't mind. What can you tell me?

Her… childhood.

Well, that would be a problem for him.

—I-I'm sorry, Light Spinner. I can't… tell you much.

—Why?

—Be-because… uh…— he hesitated, ashamed.

—I see. You don't know.

—Look, I… I don't remember much before I was twelve. And most of the time after I began my studies, I was… following you— he began. Noticeably ashamed, he added —I guess I didn't pay much attention to her… But I do remember she always offered to help me with my homework, you know?

She did?

But she couldn't have been ten yet!

How… and *why* would she?

Perhaps it would be better to ask Castaspella herself.

—I see…— she sighed. —Well, that's something at least. I'll figure this out somehow.

—I wish I could help more.

—Don't fret, Micah. I'm certain there will be other ways you can help… eventually.

—Just let me know whenever— he pleaded, getting a nod from her.

Once the women finally left Bright Moon and returned to their home in the Whispering Woods, Light Spinner couldn't help but notice how quiet the sorceress was.

She had been silent herself, mainly just… thinking, but she thought Castaspella would say something at some point.

Since that wasn't the case, the old woman would have to start the conversation herself.

—Es, can I ask you something?

Closing the door to the bathroom behind her, the sorceress nodded —What is it?

—You brother told me something that… has me quite confused— she began, sitting on the bed. —He says you helped him with his homework back in Mystacor when you were kids.

Sitting next to her, Castaspella let out a smile as she confirmed —Yeah, I did. I would read his books, explain the theory to him… I mean, he could do anything flawlessly, but he had no idea *what* he was doing, or *how*, so he was absolutely clueless when it came to his homework.

Giggling like a child, the sorceress rested against her, lost in pleasant memories.

On the other hand, Light Spinner remained confused. She asked a few more questions, but Castaspella got sleepy soon enough and she preferred to let her rest.

Unfortunately, she couldn’t do the same.

Staying wide awake, she hugged the sorceress against herself while going over the matter.

She just couldn't stop thinking about it.

Micah, the prodigy…

If what the siblings said was true, he wouldn't have graduated without Castaspella's help!

And the more she thought about it, the more sense it made…

That was rather shocking.

However, it also made her consider the possibility that Micah wasn’t the only one who got her help.

What if…

Well, no. Maybe she was just letting her imagination run too wild.

Yet she couldn't shake the feeling that, maybe, Castaspella's need to help everyone around her was the result of being raised *to be like that*.

Or, again, Light Spinner may just be delusional.

Not everyone is calculating and manipulative like her.

In any case, maybe that line of thought was still worth investigating.

She may, perhaps, be imagining things, but the only way to be sure would be to ask.

Letting out a long sigh, Light Spinner closed her eyes, trying to will herself to sleep.

It was decided.

She'd speak with Arden at the next party, either confirm or discard her theory, and… she'd see what to do with that information.

She'd help Castaspella.

Fortunately, the old woman managed to catch some sleep. She was no stranger to sleepless nights, but if she wanted to continue her little investigation, she couldn’t afford to be anything less than sharp.

They both spent the morning together, soon got ready for the party, and then left on their way to Dryl.

Castaspella seemed fine to anyone other than Light Spinner.

As if nothing had happened…

But the old woman could notice details no one else would ever pay attention to.

The sorceress was somewhat silent. Not mute, of course, yet it was evident to Light Spinner that she kept holding back from making comments she'd usually express.

It was as if she felt ashamed.

She only exchanged pleasantries with those who greeted her, answered briskly if asked something, made no questions of her own as if trying to avoid conversations…

For someone who usually spoke her mind without thinking, this was highly unusual.

In fact, Castaspella didn't even say a word about the party being hosted by none other than Hordak.

Light Spinner expected some comment about how he seemed to have adapted to Etheria quite well, or about how different he behaved compared to when he had just arrived…

Nothing.

—Es?— she decided to call, after standing with Castaspella in silence for a while. —May I ask what's on your mind?

—Huh?

—What has you so pensive, my Love?

—Nothing…— she faintly replied, before taking a sip of a tiny cup.

—Why waste your breath lying to me if you know I *won't* buy it?— the woman smirked, wrapping her arms around her. —Es, talk to me— she then whispered, brushing her lips against Castaspella's ear.

—I'm fine. Seriously— the sorceress replied, smiling weakly.

—Refusing to accept you're not fine won't just fix your mood, you know?

—Oh, come on. I just need to… distract myself a bit— Castaspella insisted.

—Sure— Light Spinner sighed. —Then why don't you go with your family for a bit? I'm sure they can take your mind off of… whatever "nothing" you're stressing about— she mocked her, kissing her forehead tenderly afterwards. —Go…

—Thank you, Bea.

The old woman let out a sigh, watched her walk away until she met her brother, and once she was sure Castaspella was in good hands, she knocked back a tiny cup and went to find councillor Arden.

Somewhere else inside the Crypto Castle, the magician and their partner shared some tiny appetizers while pretending they were hearing some old councilman lecturing them.

—…Am I clear?— he was sternly asking when Light Spinner reached them.

—Absolutely, Sir. You can be *sure* we perfectly understood— Double Trouble immediately replied, very obviously mocking him albeit making such a show of looking complying that it'd be quite hard to call out their farce.

The old woman was quite impressed and didn't try to hide her amused smirk.

However, she knew better than to call unwanted attention to herself, and waited until Arden was alone to approach them.

—What a handful…— she first said, startling them. —How fortunate you have someone who can handle him no problem— she then smirked when they turned to face her.

—How long have you been there?— Arden immediately asked, with a hand on their chest as they felt their heart hammering.

—Just enough…

—I didn't notice you. Like you *blended* with the shadows, or something…

—I'll take that as a compliment— she snickered.

—Suit yourself— they sighed. —Now, let's cut to the chase. What do you need? I intended to go ask you about Casta, but if you came to me first, I bet you need something— they reflected.

—Well, aren't you one smart kid… But, relax. I only have a simple question for you— she confirmed. —What do you know about Casta's past? Expecifically her time as a sorcery student before she graduated.

—Uh… how specific. And inconvenient…— they let out. Arden was very clearly at a loss, much to Light Spinner's surprise. But, that would soon make sense to her. —So I'm not wrong to think she's going through something… But how would it help her to know about her youth?

—It would help *me* understand what's going on inside that stubborn head of hers…

—I see— they nodded. —It's a shame I don't really have much to tell— Arden lamented. —You see, uh, back then, all I knew about her was that she was the one that stupid arrangement referred to. Frankly, I loathed the thought, so I hardly interacted with her. I knew she had no involvement and probably hated the arrangement as much as me, but…

—I get it; it's natural, I suppose.

—The thing is, if it wasn't for *you*, Casta and I wouldn't have interacted much beyond basic pleasantries…— they went on. —And if things hadn't gone *so wrong*, we definitely wouldn't have married. We became friends because we wouldn't survive that farce otherwise.

—Interesting— the old woman let out, feeling a bit conflicted. —Then I suppose I'll need to find someone else to tell me about her growing up…

—What are you looking for?— they inquired, curious.

—We both know she has always been quite diligent, helpful, selfless… But have you ever wondered *why*?

—Not really. It's not a bad trait.

—It shouldn't be, except that she had a crisis over *being kept from helping*— she remarked. —If you offer your help to someone, and because it gets rejected, you lose your mind, that's a problem. And if you offer your help, yet aren't rejected but rather offered the chance to rest for once instead of helping as usual, and that completely collapses your self-steem, that's not just a problem, that's a *warning*. It's a symptom of something bigger and quite worrisome.

Arden was left speechless for a second.

—I never… thought about it. You're right, Light Spinner— they nodded, looking down. —I can't think of many times when her help wasn't immediately accepted, but… it makes so much sense— they sighed. —You know, the first thing I noticed about her when… you were banished, the only thing that made me trust Casta with my whole future, was the fact that she showed no interest in fixing things for herself.

—Continue.

—Everything Casta did since that day and for five whole years, the marriage, the pretense, obeying Norwyn and the council… it was all just for my sake. To help me, to-to save me from… losing everything— Arden elaborated, expression sorrowful.

—Ah, yes. She mentioned that— Light Spinner recalled. —When I asked why she didn't simply abandon Mystacor and go to Bright Moon with her brother instead of staying there to suffer, she told me she knew you didn't have as many options as she did, and… that was the one way to help you.

—And I truly couldn't turn down her offer— they admitted, looking ashamed. —I guess I did take advantage of her, didn't I?

—You had no ill intent and were desperate— Light Spinner sighed, trying to ease their guilt, much to their surprise.

Arden had no idea what to say, too flustered to think properly, and stared at her for a long moment.

The woman, on the other hand, didn't think it was such a big deal; she was simply stating facts.

However, before either of them could say anything else, the host of the party appeared.

Quite fortunate for them both, in fact.

—Good evening, steemed guests— Hordak began. —I don't intend to take too much of your time. Can I ask if everything in the party is up to your liking?— he formally asked.

—Relax, will you? Everything's fine— Light Spinner sighed, rolling her eyes.

—Your tone suggest something is bothering you— he insisted.

—And if what bothered me was none other than you?— she retorted, mocking him mercilessly.

Arden face-palmed, expecting the worst, but was up for a surprise.

—If that's the case, I must be doing something wrong— Hordak considered, serious. —Interactions outside of a hive-mind rely on proper communication since I cannot read your mind. So I must ask: what am I doing to bother you?

Light Spinner raised a brow, in complete disbelief, trying to figure out whether he was serious or not. Briefly glancing at Arden revealed they were just as shocked, so there was no point in asking them.

—Alright. I'll bite: What bothers me from you is how you're acting. Seems fake. Why are you pretending to be so… polite and respectful, if the first thing you told us all was that we were "impure beasts"?— she confronted him, disregarding the possibility of making a scene.

And yet, that seemed far from happening.

—Ah, I see…— he nodded. —I never considered the possibility of giving that impression. I merely discarded my initial thoughts about you all since my assessment was flawed. It's a regular procedure. When a hypothesis is proven wrong, there's no point in maintaining it. Why should beliefs work any different?— he explained. —Even more so when the origin of those beliefs is the same thing shrouding the truth.

That… made sense.

Light Spinner was actually quite surprised to realize as much.

—Right— she sighed. —Well, in that case, I suppose nothing… really bothers me. Pretend I said nothing— she grunted, pressing her temples.

Hordak seemed hesitant, but eventually dropped the matter and continued on his rounds.

Light Spinner didn't have much more to discuss with Arden, and felt like she was making them a bit nervous, so she promptly returned with Castaspella and, soon after, they returned home.

This time, at least, the walk back wasn't silent.

Whether the sorceress noticed her odd behaviour on her own and made an effort to seem "fine now", or if she was genuinely better, Light Spinner wasn't sure, but it still brought her some relief to hear her ramble again.

This was the Castaspella she knew.

The one who loves her family and friends dearly and constantly talks about them, their feats, and happily shows her pride for their achievements as if they're were her own.

So she didn't interrupt her while she told her about Delwyn's kids, how the girl had crafted her own space-ship, while the boy had completed his piloting course in record time… She was really excited for them, wasn't she?

It shouldn't surprise her, of course. Castaspella had mentioned several time she wished they could freely come and go between Ak'kelon and Etheria…

Well, this also made Light Spinner realize something.

That ambassador.

He may not know about Castaspella's past, but… why not ask anyways?

She had a hunch…

Chapter End Notes

Ehe, end of day 2 XD

I'm sorry, these will all be this short, I apologize…

ANYWAYS!

See you tomorrow!! :D

Chapter 35: Day 3: Dark Edge

Chapter Notes

Hiii!! Welcome back!!
It's day 3!! WOoOHOoo!!

Ahem, anyways, so… today we have a bit more Casta angst…

And, uh, well, you'll see… LS is really doing her best here…

But never mind my yapping! Please enjoy!! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 3

Dark Edge

Year Five

Morning soon arrived, the women woke up together, and stayed in bed for a bit longer before getting up to prepare breakfast.

While eating and drinking their teas, Light Spinner observed Castaspella for a bit.

Just as she suspected the previous night, the sorceress was far from better, and now it showed.

—Es, anything you would like to talk about?

—Huh? No, I don't…

—You don't? How odd…

—Why?

—I know you, that's why. You've been unusually low on social battery; haven't interacted with anyone outside your family and closest friends, opposite to your usual mingling during these parties— Light Spinner explained.

—Oh, please, that's not true…— she scoffed.

The way she kept deflecting and refusing to speak told the woman enough. Castaspella was still upset about the Bright Moon party thing, yet refused to accept it…

So, perhaps, Light Spinner needed to change tactics; make her realize on her own how undeniably under the weather she had been feeling.

—It *is* true and I'll prove it— she smirked. —The Esmeralda I know would never fail to express her excitement about the little newborn presented in Bright Moon's party— she began, making Castaspella open her eyes wide. —Unless, of course, you didn't even know about them— she added.

—What are you talking about, Bea?

—Alright, I'll quit messing with you: Princess Adora and Prince Catra presented their kid, Finn— she directly explained. —Do you understand what I mean?

—I- Yes— Castaspella sighed. Leaving her cup to the side, she rested her head on the table and let out —I guess I'm a mess, aren't I? They probably think I don't care or something…

—What? Wait— Light Spinner immediately interrupted. —Love, that's *not* what I meant. It's not that big of a deal… It's just proof that you're far from fine. That part is what should matter to you!— she pointed out. But the sorceress remained resting on the table, clearly feeling miserable. —Listen, you can just meet Finn today in Dark Edge's party. Alright? No one will think less of you for it…

—You can't know that…

—Es, seriously— the woman grunted. —I need you to please talk to me at some point. Can you do that?

—I- So-sorry, Bea. I'm being all gloomy and depressing… But I don't want to make it your problem— she admitted, finally pushing herself up. —I'll try to get over my… whatever. I don't know why I'm like this— she sighed, looking away.

—Alright, let's do something: today, take your time to meet the baby, enjoy the party, try to forget about Bright Moon's, and we'll talk later— Light Spinner offered. —Talk, or… do something *else*.

—Deal— Castaspella giggled, making an effort to push her sadness away.

The women arrived at Horror Hall slightly later than intended, but just in time for the welcome speech. After it ended, and once they found their assigned table, Light Spinner encouraged Castaspella to approach Adora and Catra so she could finally meet their kid.

She observed her for a while, glad to see her so cheerful again, and once she had a drink, the woman went to find Delwyn.

The ambassador and his children were just starting to eat, probably a bad time to interrupt, which she usually wouldn't have cared about.

Except that, for some reason, now she *did*, so she turned to leave, deciding to wait until later.

Or that was the idea, except Delwyn called out to her.

—I thought I felt someone approach… Did you need something?— he asked.

—Ah, yes. I- But it can wait— she replied, waving her hand dismissively.

—Are you sure? If it's something important, I don't mind leaving my meal.

—I just need to talk, alright? Nothing urgent.

—Is it about Casta?

—Yes— she sighed, looking away.

—Then why don't you sit for a bit? If you don't mind us eating while we talk— he suggested.

—I don't mind, but I seem to recall your children weren't so fond of me.

—What do you say?— Delwyn asked them, looking at each with a gentle smile.

—I'm fine— Kharyn accepted, shy as usual.

Namai, on the other hand, wasn't so quick to accept.

—Why do you need to talk to Dad about Casta? Is something wrong?— she inquired, suspicious.

—That's what I'm trying to figure out— Light Spinner replied. —Your father could give me some insight, I believe…

—Huh… Alright. I guess I'm fine too, then. If it's to help Casta— Namai finally accepted.

—Thank you both— Delwyn smiled. —Have a seat.

—Alright— Light Spinner accepted. —I guess I should start with a simple question: what is your general impression of her?

He stopped eating for a second, raised a brow, and swallowed immediately so he could ask back —What do you mean? Impression?

—How you see her- Ah… Wait, I'll start again— she sighed. —For context: This year, Bright Moon's party was mainly organized by Bow's fathers. I convinced them to let Casta help at least a bit before it started, despite preferring to leave it to them for once, because she was having a bit of a breakdown. Yet, in the end, that wasn't enough of a remedial…

—I'm sorry, let me see if I understand: Casta got upset because she *wasn't* in charge of the party?— Delwyn asked.

—A bit more than just upset, but yes, that's basically it. I had to convince those two to let her help because she wasn't listening to me, and felt… useless not helping, a-and I guess I panicked— Light Spinner admitted. —It would seem she's till not over it, so I can't help but be *sure* that her constant need to help everyone isn't mere selflessness, but rather a sign of something *else*, and I mean something *bad*.

—So you've been asking around?

—Correct— she nodded. —It could always be that I see her as too selfless because I've always been too selfish, but from what Micah and Arden told me, that's not the case.

—Could I bother you to tell me what they said that makes you so sure?

—In short, Micah admitted she always helped him with his studies, even before she was of age to start studying herself, while Arden confirmed what she had told me years ago about putting up with that marriage and the bullshit of the Council in Mystacor just for their sake, not for herself— Light Spinner briefly recounted. —At the same time, neither of them had much recollection of her childhood, Arden because they avoided her, and Micah because he was always after me.

—So there's no way to know if she was purposely raised to be this diligent, to prioritize others above herself, and feel bad if she *isn't* helping… but that's your theory, isn't it?— Delwyn reflected.

—Perceptive— she smirked. —Is your quick deduction a sign you may have noticed something?

—Yes— he admited, looking down at his plate. —If she grew up with the mentality that she must help at all times otherwise she's "worthless", it would explain a few things— he considered. —Even the reason why we met— he chuckled.

—Go on…

—Well, Casta had been living in Bright Moon for a bit at the time, right? And by mere chance, or so I thought, she was there when I first arrived, hence why she offered to help me get around and understand Etheria— he began. —Except that it was no coincidence, right? She had been helping around Bright Moon, doing all kinds of things, and she had gone there *specifically* to offer her help…

—Seriously?

—Yes. She even spoke about the way things worked in the palace as if she did all of that- Perhaps she helped with everything at least once. Except for the kitchen, since she was banned, but… I guess I never stopped to think about it that much— he admitted. —When I was told she could help me with anything I may need, I thought she'd find me someone to provide that help for each specific thing. Instead, she was the one doing it *all*; I felt quite indebted, and that's why I started to invite her for meals and such…

—And got to know each other better, I suppose— she reflected, seemingly unbothered.

—Exactly. We-we were both quite lonely, had some things in common, so we tried to have a proper relationship to move on from… our past, our sorrow— he went on. —Instead, we realized neither of us could forget our past loves— he admitted with a sad smile. Delwyn maybe felt his children looking at him because he lovingly patted their heads before continuing —So, once we realized that, and accepted it as a fact, we decided to go along with it until you returned. We helped each other, my kids loved her, and we didn't really have anyone else to spend time with…

—Makes sense— Light Spinner sighed. —So, let's go over it: Es must have been raised with this idea that if she doesn't contribute to society in some way then she's worthless… As if not giving to others constantly made her a waste of oxygen.

—Apparently…— Delwyn let out, raising his brows in surprise at how bad that was.

—Doesn't that ring a bell? The talk about serving a purpose?— Light Spinner then noticed.

—It does- Oh, I know: that man, Hordak— the ambassador remembered. —Fortunately he doesn't anymore, but on his first year here he did talk a lot about being perfect, having purpose, being of "use".

—Indeed— she sighed. —Gives me a few ideas, I think… But I still need to learn about her upbringing to be sure…

—Have you spoken with Norwyn?

—Not yet— she admitted, smirking slightly. —Could be worth a shot.

—I'd say so. And, I certainly hope this was a helpful conversation— Delwyn smiled.

—Absolutely— Light Spinner nodded, standing up. —Have a pleasant evening.

The women spent the rest of the party together, with Castaspella seemingly much more at ease, and returned home a few hours before midnight.

Since the sorceress was in such a good mood, Light Spinner didn't want to ruin it with serious talk, not yet, so she delayed it a bit in favour for much needed intimate time.

Starting with teasing touches and kisses, the woman took Castaspella into the bedroom, both giggling like teenagers, and they soon got rid of their clothes…

Happy and careless, they enjoyed the feeling of their bodies together, pleasing each other the way only they could manage, and didn't stop until their breathing got shallow.

Eventually, Castaspella was tired enough that she couldn't lift her head from the pillow, yet not enough to fall asleep yet. Light Spinner rolled over her, caressed her face, and sighed upon seeing her smile.

—Bea…— she let out, leaning onto her touch.

—You… are aware that-that you're worth more than you can give, right, Es?— the woman began, her tone low but perfectly audible. —That you have people who love you for who you are, not… what you can offer?

—And yet… if it weren't for your interest in… in the help I could give you… we wouldn't have gotten, you know, intimate, and all that— Castaspella pointed out, looking away with a smirk.

—That's- No, I'm serious. A-and I'm not even a good example, I'm the exact *opposite*! Besides, that may have been at first, before we- Es, I fell in love with you for who you are! I haven't cared about whether you were "useful" or not in such a long time, that I hardly

remember the time when I did!— she immediately replied, in a rather loud tone. —I just want you by my side because I cannot stand *not* being with you! My time in exile was torture solely because of that!

—But…

—I was so upset when I learnt about your marriage be-because, for me, that meant…that I could no longer have you. And I knew… if I returned, right there and then, I would destroy *everything* to get you back. *Everything*…— she went on, clutching the sheets at both sides of Castaspella, head hanging low.

The sorceress was shocked for a moment, looking up at Light Spinner, her hair like a curtain around her face.

Without thinking, she finally spoke —I'm sure… it was just… because I-I offered you the protection you always neglected. You must have…

—No!— Light Spinner yelled, frustrated. Her breath became more laboured, tears formed in her eyes, and before she knew it, Castaspella had been pinned down on the mattress. Immediately after, the woman kissed her deeply, and let her tears fall. She tried to put all her desire into that kiss, she wanted the sorceress to feel it… After a while, she had to break the kiss and breathe, but she kept her face just over Castaspella's. —I need you to… to *please* stop with that and *listen* to me, Es. You're worthy beyond what you can offer. This world should be *thankful* to have you, and that you're such a nice person!— she sighed, laughing bitterly in disbelief. —If you were… half as mean as I am, or as I used to be, I guess… everyone would be a *damned mess*— she scoffed. —I'm sure of it.

—Bea-Beatrix— the sorceress stammered, sight fixed on Light Spinner still above her.

Little by little, the woman let go of her, and Castaspella reached up to hug her tightly.

Both started sobbing, Light Spinner wrapped her arms around the sorceress too, and finally felt her strength vanish.

They kept crying in silence until they fell asleep, for they may have been overwhelmed by emotions, but felt safe enough on each others arms.

Chapter End Notes

:D

I know, that was a bit sad, but I swear, it was necessary…
Casta will get there… eventually (/v\)

Ahem!
So! Thanks for reading and see you tomorrow!! ^_^

I hope u r having a gentle festive time :)

Chapter 36: Day 4: Plumeria

Chapter Notes

We're back UwU
New year approaches, ~~insanity approaches~~ and we've arrived at day 4 :D

So, anyways, this time I bring u a very unexpected chat :3

I certainly hope you enjoy it! >v<

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 4

Plumeria

Year Five

Morning sun washed into the room, waking Castaspella up.

She was still hugging Light Spinner, and the feeling of dry tears on her skin soon reminded her of the previous night.

Sorrow invaded her, but the sorceress only looked at her partner lovingly before deciding to get up for breakfast.

A bit later, she returned to the room, woke up the woman, and offered her a tray with a small smile.

They quietly shared their meal for some time, knowing they had plenty of time to prepare for Plumeria's party later, despite its earlier beginning…

However, it didn't escape Light Spinner that Castaspella was unusually silent, pensive too, and decided to give her some time and space.

She had told her everything she needed, everything she could say with her current information. Hence, it'd be better to let her reflect on her own for the time being.

The woman remained attentive in case she needed anything, but didn't bother the sorceress in any way.

Upon arriving at Plumeria, the women were received by Micah, Delwyn, and Arden. They had arrived quite early this time, so they would have to wait for Perfuma's speech and the party to officially begin.

—Why are you all here so early, then?— Castaspella asked, surprised.

—Oh, well, Glimmer and Bow wanted to arrive early, and with Angella we decided to come along already— Micah first replied.

—I didn't have anything else to do, and my kids love Plumeria particularly, so we decided to get here earlier too— Delwyn then said.

—As for me, well, Double Trouble has been trying to convince all princesses to let them perform at their parties, so they brought me along with the excuse to talk to Perfuma before

her speech…— Arden explained, earning a raised brow from Castaspella, who didn't buy it. —And I didn't want to travel with the rest of the Council.

—I knew it— the sorceress smirked.

—Now, why don't you come with us? Angella told me she had been meaning to discuss something with you but forgot— Micah offered, placing a hand on her shoulder.

—Uh… sure— she accepted, briefly glancing at Light Spinner. —You…

—I'll find you later, Es. Go ahead— she encouraged her.

Smiling gently, she nodded at her and went with her brother, soon followed by Arden and Delwyn, after they both wished Light Spinner luck and pointed her towards the Head Sorcerer.

No time to lose now.

The woman found him sitting at the furthest unlit bonfire, on his own, looking deep in thought.

—There you are— he let out, as soon as he noticed her approaching. —I was told you needed to ask me a few things…— he added, gesturing at her to sit next to him.

—Indeed, Norwyn. I believe you can shed some light on the issue I have— she admitted, sitting down.

—What do you need, Light Spinner?— he sighed.

—Just information.

—How unusual— he let out. —Have you been taking care of your wife? Usually she speaks to me on your behalf…

—I *am* taking care of her. Or trying, in any case… That's precisely why I'm here myself. I need to… know how her upbringing was like— Light Spinner finally explained. —She was your pupil, so if anyone knows how she could grow up with that twisted mentality regarding her worth, it would be you.

—Her worth?

—As in needing to be useful at all times.

—What are you…— he was insisting, confused, yet trailed off as it clicked for him. The memory came like a sudden flash and he just knew what she meant. —Ah… I think I know what you mean. And it may be my fault— he admitted, looking down.

—What did you do, Norwyn?— Light Spinner inquired, sounding more resigned than angry as he had expected.

—Listen: Castaspella's childhood was… solitary, I'd say. She had no one else besides her brother, she struggled to make friends, and usually wanted to stay with Micah during his classes— he began. —I had to send her off every day, but may not have… worded it in the best way.

—Explain— she requested, serious but still showing no signs of anger.

—Instead of telling her she was too young to attend the class, or that Micah needed to focus, I… told her she had no reasons to be there, and not only did she provide nothing to the class, but also would be a distraction…— he confessed, shaking his head. —You must understand I was far younger and didn't know better. I let my pride speak, thought nothing of it… Thinking back now it's easy to see how I may have- Ah… I made mistakes, I suppose. I can see that now.

—Yes, that's quite an unfortunate choice of words, but I don't see how that alone could have shaped her whole mentality— Light Spinner pointed out. —Unless there's more?

—There is— he nodded. —You could say I… challenged her to find something to offer the class, and I'd consider letting her join— he admitted. —I am- Of course I didn't mean to challenge her, I understand that was- I just meant to *discourage* her, and back then I would have never thought someone so young would… take it to heart— he went on. —But she did. And she- Interestingly enough, she actually beat me in my own game.

—What does that mean?

—She found something to offer: namely, explanations that were clear enough and so easy to understand, that no matter how hard the theoretical material was, she could make my pupils immediately understand it— he replied, his expression a mix of pride and, perhaps, jealousy. —What I taught was nothing too advanced at the time, but the material was ancient and cryptic. Usually, we expected pupils to get used to that format and learn to understand it on their own, which left plenty of them frustrated; it was a way of… filtering acolytes.

—Seriously…

—She was such a tiny kid too, but somehow understood maybe even better than me— Norwyn chuckled. —So I let her join. I got her to explain things, including *how* she had comprehended the obscure wording of the texts, and so my pupils still developed that skill. She helped them with their studies without doing it *for* them… The perfect assistant.

—And then she became your pupil when she was of age.

—Precisely— he nodded. —I think she may be the reason why I was later chosen as Head Sorcerer, but… that may be why I failed to notice what I had done. What my words did to her — he lamented. —I understand now. I was so caught up in the benefits of her diligent help, that I neglected the rest of her skills. Or lack thereof.

—How?

—Limits, Light Spinner. She never really learnt to put limits to her assistance. But I never thought it was bad in any way. Anyone who asked, got her help. Unconditionally— he replied, serious. —However, it makes sense now; if she measured her worth according to how much she could do for others, then that explains why Castaspella wouldn't just be willing to assist anyone who asked, but also actively searching for ways to help even those who *didn't ask for it*.

—Sounds like her…

—At the time we all just considered her to be very selfless and eager to help. Perhaps even bored, hence seeking to busy herself with anything— Norwyn recalled. —But still, I should have realized something was wrong even before she graduated. There were clear signs. It should have been enough to see how dangerously extreme her *need* to help was.

—Something serious happened?

—I can't recall when exactly, but she was young, had gotten seriously hurt, and couldn't do many chores on her own. She needed assistance herself— he began. —Yet she kept refusing the help offered, and trying to get up and do things she was in no shape to do!

—That sounds- Wait, I think I remember this. I had heard of some acolyte, someone close to graduating, who was being a brat and had to be confined to her room. I never cared about that enough to ask what happened— the woman recalled.

—That was her, yes. She needed to rest for a week or so, yet kept leaving her room. She had to be… sedated, put on medication, and locked in her room until she recovered— he went on. —With Micah's consent, of course! It didn't last long, and he was with her as much as he could. Once she finally recovered, she immediately went back to helping around, even when told to take it easy… Micah was concerned, but she didn't- He couldn't explain why he was concerned, she assured everyone she was fine… We did nothing because we didn't think there was anything to do.

—You had to sedate, medicate, and *lock* a woman to *force her to recover*. But didn't saw a problem with it?— Light Spinner scoffed, indignant.

—I know… I understand now; if someone had spoken with her back then, or if this had been pointed out before, maybe Castaspella wouldn't have gone much longer without setting healthy limits. She would have an easier time recognizing her own worth…— he reflected. —You know, she was always praised for her selflessness. It was extreme, indeed, but I suppose no one ever said a thing because it was convenient… for everyone but her— he sighed.

Light Spinner closed her eyes and leant forward, supporting herself on her knees, both hands covering her face.

After taking a deep breath, she straightened again and admitted — It was convenient for me too, at first… And perhaps it's now too late to make her understand this, to make her see why

it’s wrong. But I’ll try regardless.

—Curious that you say that— Norwyn smirked. —You didn’t notice how much you’ve helped her already, did you?

—Huh?

—Since your return four years ago, you’ve been helping her all this time. Every year, she’s become just a bit more selfish than before— he insisted. —Yes, she still does too much for others, giving and giving without receiving in kind… Except that she did set one firm limit.

—You mean…

—She has been choosing *you*, over and over again; regardless of the consequences, she made sure to stay with you, at whatever cost, Light Spinner— he clarified, looking back at the shocked woman with something akin to pride. —It’s certainly not enough, she’s far from understanding she needn't be of help, of *use*, to deserve her place in this world, but at the very least, she’s set a limit for utterly selfish reasons, that prioritizes her happiness. She’s willing to give everything from her, but she refuses to give *you* up.

Castaspella refuses to give her up…

Yes, that’s what she’s been telling Light Spinner all these years, isn’t it?

And Norwyn, of all people, noticed it first?

She couldn’t help but chuckle in disbelief.

—You must have gotten to the stage when “old” is finally accompanied by “wise”, Head Sorcerer— she mocked him. —I appreciate the help…

—You’re welcome, Light Spinner— he nodded. —I’ll let you return to you wife now…

—I’ll see you around— she nodded back, standing up. Pensive, she approached the crowd, and soon Castaspella found her. —Ah, Es…

—There you are! You missed the speech!

—I did?

—You were talking to Norwyn? You better not be planning to leave me again— she joked.

—As if he’d let that happen— the woman laughed, pulling her closer. —Forget about that. Just enjoy the party with me, will you?

—Gladly— the sorceress smiled, giving her a quick kiss. —But let’s keep that damned distillate far from us, yeah?

—Deal— Light Spinner accepted.

The night around the bonfires was quite pleasant.

Perfuma considered it one of the best parties in the past few years and was quite pleased with the lack of drama for once.

She had allowed Double Trouble to present a short act, which people found quite entertaining, and the mood improved only further when an impromptu band began playing music.

People danced, laughed together, and chatted merrily until midnight.

It was a precious night…

Castaspella and Light Spinner rested against each other's shoulders, looking at the sky, the moons, and the stars.

—Bea…

—Es?

—I'm falling asleep— the sorceress sighed.

—Want me to take you home? I can carry you— she offered, smirking.

—I would say no, but… I'm… beat— Castaspella admitted, yawning.

—Allow me, then— Light Spinner insisted, pressing a kiss to her forehead. —Feel free to sleep.

Chapter End Notes

So! Fun times, fortunately XD

This is easily the most relaxed year they've had <("^_^)

Anyways! What do you think? :D

I'll see you tomorrow with more!! ~~And hopefully I'll get the ending written soon TT-TT~~

Chapter 37: Day 5: Salineas

Chapter Notes

:D Hiii!!

Glad to have you back! Days are flying by, tbh

Anyways! I'm happy to have you back, and I hope u enjoy today's chapter!
There's a little anecdote here that is entirely inspired on… real-life events…
Unfortunately.

But, at least it makes for a great plot-point!

Whatever, don't mind me. Please enjoy ^_^

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 5

Salineas

Year Five

The following morning found the women lazying in bed.

Castaspella greeted Light Spinner with a smile, convinced her to stay for a bit more, and they began chatting about the party the previous day.

The sorceress was surprised with how pleasant it had been, and even joked about the lack of drama. Precisely what she wanted… An enjoyable, drama-free End of the Year Week where nothing too transcendent happened.

—Really? That's what you want?

—Well, yes— Castaspella admitted, looking down. —I just… want to be able to relax. I guess…

—I'll take it that you still feel a bit… down?

—Please, Bea, it's nothing, really. I guess I don't want to stress myself this year.

—And that's quite understandable, Es, but I… can see you're struggling too.

—It'll pass eventually.

—Listen, Es, you've helped me so much over the past few years. More than I'd like to admit… And I think it's time I help you in return, wouldn't you say?— Light Spinner smirked.

—Oh, no, no. Don't- Bea, don't feel obligated to…

—I don't— the woman chuckled. —I *want* to help you. Talk to me— she whispered, before kissing her briefly.

Letting out a long sigh, Castaspella closed her eyes for a moment.

She wants to help her…

That's the same thing the sorceress told her several times when Light Spinner insisted she "didn't have to" help…

Why did part of her *doubt* she did?

Maybe because that same part of her admitted that, sometimes, Castaspella didn't really want to help people.

Just like when… she was little.

Well, if Light Spinner wanted her to talk, maybe this was the time.

—Alright… I suppose- Well, I mean, you just reminded me of something, so I could tell you about it.

—Please do.

—Wow, you even said "please"? You really want to help me…

—Obviously— Light Spinner scoffed, pulling her closer. —Come on, tell me what you remembered.

—Of course— the sorceress sighed. —There was a time, when I was little, which I can't recall that well, but parts of it returned just now. Another acolyte, I think someone younger than me even, had this stupid project thing. I don't know. I can't remember what it was about, but I can remember despising it. I can clearly recall *not* wanting to have anything to do with it.

—But?

—But… I think that guy was, I don't know, busy with stuff all the time, or so he claimed, I guess, while I just spent time reading in my room. So, he would come to… tell me to "please" do some… *thing* for his project, I don't know what, but like, contribute, because he had "little time" and needed the help, while I was always in my room with "plenty of time", and what not…

—And you didn't want to.

—Of course not, Stars! I refused… And I told him so. *Several times*— she scoffed. Noticeably angry, Castaspella went on —But you know what? My reason to refuse, which he demanded to know, was that I simply didn't want to. Nothing else. And that was… *not a valid reason*. Not to him…

—But…

—I know what you will say, but… he just insisted until I had no choice…

—No, you didn't have "no choice". He insisted until he broke your *will*. He…— Light Spinner began, frustrated. —It makes all the sense in the world that, being forced to do something you had no reasons to do, and did *not* want to do, while also getting your feelings *invalidated* in the process, would completely fuck you up…

—Hey!

—Was this… before or after you started to help Norwyn with his classes?

—Before… I- How did you know?

—It makes so much sense— Light Spinner scoffed, shaking her head. —And I know because he told me about his… poor wording when trying to keep you away from his classes; he feels responsible, in fact, because of how he pretty much challenged you to find something to "provide" to his classes…

—I- Well, I wouldn't say- I *guess* his wording did have some influence, but it wasn't his fault…— Castaspella sighed. —Now that you mention it, I can tell you that it *surely* reminded me of… what I told you before. Having to help wasn't something I could skip because I just didn't want to do it, and I didn't want to just give up, anyways.

—Es…— the woman sighed, reaching for her chin. —Thank you for telling me— she whispered, before kissing her once more.

Their conversation that morning seemed to have eased Castaspella significantly.

Light Spinner knew it wouldn't be enough, but at least the sorceress had let out some stress and possibly wasn't on the brink of breaking down anymore.

Which meant she had more time now, but shouldn't squander it. She had to talk with Norwyn again, maybe Micah too, and get their opinion on what Castaspella told her.

In short, the sorceress was basically raised in an environment that taught her she had to be always contributing, always helping, for no proper reason at all, and that she couldn't refuse to do something, even if she didn't want to, unless she had a perfectly reasonable excuse.

Quite a double standard.

Why did she need a "reasonable excuse" to refuse, but others didn't need proper reasons to get her help?

How could Castaspella not realize the unfairness of it?

Light Spinner let out a sigh, right as the welcome-speech of Salineas' party ended.

—Everything alright?

—Of course, Es. I was merely thinking…

—Clearly— the sorceress giggled. —Why don't we get something to eat so you can feed your brain a bit?

—Good idea— Light Spinner smiled, following her into the corridor leading to the area where they could sit and have a meal.

Later, once filled, Castaspella proposed returning to the main area and maybe dance together for a bit.

However, they found Sea Hawk had replaced the band to sing his shanties.

Hopefully it wouldn't last that long…

—Can we wait until the band is back?

—Sure, Es. Don't worry.

—Hey, Auntie!— Princess Glimmer suddenly called, rushing to them. —Do you have a moment to talk? I didn't want to interrupt while you were eating, so I waited. But, uh, I don't want to interrupt now either…

—Oh, of course. If you don't mind, Bea— she replied.

—Not at all. We have time until the band returns, I guess— the woman pointed out.

—Perfect! Let's go find Mom— Glimmer exhorted her.

Once they left, Light Spinner scanned the crowd until she found Norwyn. Curiously enough, he happened to be talking with none other than Micah.

How fortunate.

Considering it a good moment, she approached them, pondering the best way to explain her chat with Castaspella to them.

—Ah, Light Spinner!— Micah quickly noticed. —What a coincidence. We were just discussing what you told us about Casta…

—Good. I came to talk about her too. I had a conversation with Es this morning and… I'd like your opinion— she explained.

—Sure— Norwyn accepted.

—To begin with, she doesn't think you caused her unhealthy mentality regarding her self-worth depending on how much she could do for others, which at least she seems to recognize now, at the very least— she began. —However, you did reinforce that idea.

—So she already had this mentality…

—But why?— Micah inquired, confused.

—What she told me doesn't explain why she measures her worth that way, so it probably was a later development as a consequence of being invalidated and guilt-tripped into helping regardless or whether she wanted to, unless she had a "proper" reason to refuse.

—Huh? Ho-how?— the King insisted, growing concerned.

—She can’t properly remember, but apparently some… younger acolyte had a project she didn’t like, asked her to contribute, and when she refused because she simply didn't want to do it, he insisted it was not a valid reason, which pretty much made her feel guilty until she gave up and helped him— Light Spinner briefly recounted.

—Oh…— they both let out.

After exchanging a glance, Norwyn admitted —I didn’t even remember… I know who you mean. But it was- The project never really worked, it was abandoned after a few years, and we knew Castaspella was helping, albeit reluctantly.

—But it was… something so ridiculous— Micah went on. —I can’t believe it would affect her so much… Or- Well, I think I can see now why it did.

—Then, what can we do?

—Help her see how wrong that mindset is. Help her stablish limits, learn some sort of criteria to decide when she should really help, and when she can choose *not to* if she doesn’t want to — Light Spinner considered.

—How do we do that?— Micah then asked.

—We should be able to come up with some… strategy to manage it— Norwyn considered.

—Maybe we can organize something, gather Casta’s friends and everyone who cares about her. We can show her it’s not about what she gives us, and…

—Wait, Micah— Light Spinner suddenly stopped him, noticing the Head Sorcerer seemed to agree. —We can’t do that. Every time I’ve tried to help her like this, plotting behind her back, it… ended bad— she began, making Norwyn look away ashamed as he understood what she meant. —I’ve always assumed what’s best for Es, without asking her, and… failed to realize it— she pointed out, looking defeated. —So, forget it for now. Let me first speak with her a bit more, then… maybe, we can all help her. But instead of planning behind her back, we can talk to her directly. *Listen to her*— she proposed. —After all, we agree that validation seems to be exactly what’s always missing for her.

—You’re right— Micah sighed. —I hadn’t thought about that.

—Worry not. I know you just want to help her; so do I. But I can’t keep making the same mistake I made the past few years.

—Of course, of course— he nodded. —Then, I guess I’ll head back to Angella now.

Getting a nod from Light Spinner and Norwyn, the King walked away. The woman was about to follow, yet got stopped.

—A moment, if you don’t mind— the Head Sorcerer requested. Confused but also curious, she decided to stay and hear him out. —I must admit I’m glad to see how much you’ve improved— he began. —I just wanted to…— he tried to continue, but got interrupted by sudden coughing. Bending over, he kept coughing for a moment, and it sounded quite bad.

Light Spinner found herself genuinely worried, attempted to hide it, yet he apparently noticed. —I'm not fit to keep leading. I need rest before life abandons me without warning… Now I lament having ruined everything with Castaspella— he admitted. —I know she won't ever accept leading Mystacor, regardless of what she is offered… And after this conversation, I suppose I'd be just doing it all again, forcing her to do something she does *not* want to do.

Light Spinner chuckled and let out a smirk.

—Well, I'm also glad to know you've learnt something from the past few years— she began. —I must say I would also want her to lead; I always considered her to be a better fit for the position than you…

—And you might be right— he laughed.

—But she made it clear: the current Council has always been very critical of her, there is practically no chance she'd ever be able to reach an agreement with them; they are so fundamentally against her ideals that if they *did* support her, it'd be obvious they don't mean it. There would be no trust between them. She won't ever bow to their whims again, she won't adapt… nor would she lead like a tyrant.

—True, indeed— Norwyn had to accept.

—I suppose there's always the possibility of changing the Council altogether. Old members could retire, the newest ones could be reassessed instead… Only Arden would surely fit a council that can respect and genuinely support Casta— Light Spinner suggested. —It's your decision, of course. Either you look for someone else to take your place, or for once, you make sure to accommodate to her for a change…

Closing his eyes for a moment, he only hummed, pensive.

—Well, one last thing: Since you told me how she… reacted to being displaced as Bright Moon's party organizer, you'll have to handle Castaspella not being assigned any duties for Mystacor's party this year either— he sighed, completely disregarding Light Spinner's suggestion. —In fact, please let her know that we have found someone to take her spot in catering duty so she can finally forget about it. And convey my apologies on Mystacor's behalf for imposing this duty on her even after she *left* the Guild.

—Leaving the heavy lifting to me, huh?— the woman scoffed. —Sure…

—Hey, Bea— the sorceress suddenly called from behind.

—You're back.

—I am, and the band has *just* returned— Castaspella nodded. —You owe me a dance.

—I suppose I do— she smirked. —If you'll excuse us, Norwyn…

—Absolutely— he accepted.

The women danced together a few songs, took a break for a moment, grabbed a drink in the meantime, and then danced some more…

Castaspella had the impression this was the first time she could enjoy Salineas' party so much.

She was surely right, in fact, since some people even started whispering about that.

But also, they seemed to be talking about how the sorceress and Light Spinner had been engaged a year, since the last End of the Year Week, and that reminded them that… people didn't know.

—Do you think- Should-should we let people know… the truth?— Castaspella suddenly asked, while they swayed to a slow song.

—About?— the woman asked back.

—Our, uh… marriage?

—It's none of their business. Just ignore the gossipers— Light Spinner replied. —*We* know, the people who matter know… That's enough.

—You're right— Castaspella sighed, smiling gently.

Chapter End Notes

Welp! That was it for today!!

I hope you liked it!! :D

Ah… Isn't LS growing fast? Haha

In any case, tomorrow's chapter is quite a thing, no one's ready, *I'm* not ready tbh, and… Ch7 isn't either TT-TT

But I'll see you tomorrow :D
Thank you for reading!!!

Chapter 38: Day 6: Kingdom of Snows

Chapter Notes

Hi!! Welcome back!!

No way, tomorrow ends the year!? Wow…

Anyways… Today we have *checks notes* a moving chapter! Or at least it could be? You see, Casta and Micah will have a really touching conversation, which could move you to tears, or not quite enough…

But it doesn't really matter. It's moving for Casta XD

Now, enough of my talking, please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 6

Kingdom of Snows

Year Five

Fortunately, the previous night they arrived late and tired enough to immediately go to sleep.

That way, Castaspella could rest through the night and only freaked out in the morning when she finally tried to find the letter assigning her tasks for Mystacor's party.

—Bea, wake up…— she gently called, placing a hand on Light Spinner's shoulder.

—Hmm…— the woman groaned. With some difficulty, she finally brushed her eyes and looked up at Castaspella. —What is it?

—I'm sorry to wake you up, Love, but… have you seen my letter?

—Huh?

—You know what letter I mean.

Light Spinner wasn't sure that moment, since she was still half asleep, but after a few seconds groaning and trying to sit up, she finally realized it.

Right.

The letter… Which had *not* been sent to her…

—Es, listen. Let-let me get up, yes? And we'll talk.

—Talk? Do you know something about my letter?

—Es…— Light Spinner insisted. —Seriously. I don't want to end up yelling at you. Let me wash my face, and once I have a coffee, I'll be less likely to be rude.

—Fine…— she scoffed. —I'll prepare you some coffee, then… But please, get up.

—Of course, of course…

After a bit, the woman was half-way through her coffee at last, feeling much better.

—So…

—Won't you have breakfast?— Light Spinner interrupted her.

—I-I… no. I want you to tell me what you meant just before. What do you want to talk about? Where's my letter?— Castaspella insisted.

—There's none.

—Huh?

The woman took a deep breath, sipped her coffee with her eyes closed, and then finally looked back at the sorceress to explain —There is no letter. You weren't sent one. Because you've been relieved from catering duty.

—Huh!? Are you *serious*? You have to be joking- Bea, what…

—Calm down. You're starting to panic again, Es.

—I'm not panicking! I-I'm…

—You're literally *yelling*— Light Spinner sighed. —Can you at least breathe?

—I am- I-I'm *fine*! I just… I- O-okay, I can't… You're right— the sorceress had to admit as her breathing became shallow.

—Take a deep breath, hold it a moment, then exhale slowly— she instructed.

Trembling as she felt her heart racing, Castaspella followed her indications, then repeated it a second time, and eventually managed to normalize her breath.

Her heart still hammered inside her chest, but it felt less noisy.

Now the sorceress could think… and answer Light Spinner's questions.

—I'm sorry, Bea.

—Don't apologize. Just… tell me: What are you feeling? Why are you so anxious? Do you… think you'll be blamed if anything goes wrong when you're not helping?— the woman gently asked, moving to sit closer.

—I… don't know. I'm not sure… how to explain it— she admitted, looking at her wife with eyes full of tears. —I just… It's like- I feel…

—Don't be ashamed. Just tell me, however you can. I won't mock you *this time*.

Castaspella couldn't help but chuckle, yet getting that reassurance was strangely helpful.

—I mean, if I don't help or contribute in some way… what right do I have to attend the party?

—Huh? Es, my Love…

—I’m serious.

—So am I— Light Spinner's insisted. —Literally *every* guest from outside Mystacor is only expected to attend the party and enjoy it! Esmeralda, since you left the Guild, *that’s what you are*! A guest from *outside* the kingdom!

—But…

—Just- Help me understand something: two years ago, you weren't assigned duties either. But-but you weren’t half this anxious— Light Spinner pointed out. —What happened?

Castaspella looked away for a moment, confused.

She wasn’t?

Or she hid it better…

Or…

Right, that was when they were going to give her the title of Head Sorceress.

—I’m sorry, Bea, but… that’s bullshit— Castaspella scoffed. —You weren’t there, you *weren’t* with me that time. You have no idea how I was.

—Tell me. *Please*— she begged, taking the sorceress’ hands between hers.

—That year I… was unable to sleep, for starters. My anxiety was mainly related to how I would be given the title of Head of the Guild, of course, but… regardless, if I hadn’t been in Bright Moon, being banned from the kitchen and all, I would have cooked all night to relieve some stress.

Light Spinner's couldn’t help but look away too, squeezing Castaspella’s hands between hers.

She felt so ashamed now…

—You’re right. I forgot… you were kind of a mess that year, but with the title thing… I suppose anyone who *could* notice your distress would have thought that was the only thing making you anxious— she sighed. —Probably even you didn't notice the lack of duties worsened your anxiety, huh?

—I guess— she admitted. —I mean, I couldn’t sleep at all, I ended up trying to knit all night and completely messed it up… and as soon as the sky cleared, I got up to have breakfast— Castaspella explained.

Of course…

And last year she was on catering duty again, wasn’t she?

In fact, that was when Light Spinner asked her about it!

She only put up excuses to keep doing it…

Good thing at least Norwyn recognized now how ridiculous that was.

Which reminded her —Ah, yes, I almost forgot. The Head Sorcerer asked me to let you know he apologizes in the name of Mystacor for imposing that duty on you.

—Oh, come on— Castaspella scoffed, folding her arms. —I *offered*. Alright?

—Sure, of course. But you didn't get anything in return! You should have- Listen: since you no longer live in Mystacor, they don't provide anything to you. It was one thing when you resided there, alright? But after you left, they only covered the cost of the ingredients to prepare everything. And that was the *bare minimum*!— Light Spinner insisted. —I dropped the matter last year, but now I regret not pushing it further back then.

Still annoyed, the sorceress looked away, tightening her crossed arms.

—You know what? I don't… want to talk about it anymore— she seethed. —I… actually think I shouldn't attend the last two parties.

—Es, why? Is this about thinking you have to "earn the right" to go?

—No! I- Forget it…

Light Spinner let out a deep sigh before reaching for Castaspella's shoulder.

—Then, whatever the reason, I could stay here with you.

—What? N-no, Bea, that's not necessary— she immediately replied, dropping her annoyance. —I wouldn't… want to ruin it for you.

—And how exactly would staying with my wife ruin anything?— Light Spinner smirked, raising a brow.

—I…— the sorceress began, yet trailed off as she felt a lump on her throat.

No matter how hard Castaspella tried to hold it back, she simply couldn't help it. She began crying, a few tears at first, then more and more, until the lump in her throat forced her to gasp for air, sobbing uncontrollably.

Light Spinner immediately pulled her into a tight hug, eyes closed as sorrow invaded her.

She let the sorceress cry for a while, caressing her back as soothingly as possible, and eventually muttered —What's upsetting you? Can you tell me?

However, Castaspella couldn't reply.

Not yet.

She hugged Light Spinner back, just as tight, and tried to speak but found it quite hard.

And yet, the woman didn't insist; she'd wait until Castaspella calmed down.

After taking her to the couch and letting her cry as much as she needed, the sorceress eventually stopped crying.

—I just… don't understand what I'm… su-supposed to do— she sobbed. —I-I mean… Selfishness is always considered a-a bad thing. I was- I was always praised for m-my selflessness… And now I'm *too selfless*?— Castaspella scoffed, voice broken still. —So it's actually a-a bad thing, and… you always told me I was "too nice", whi-which I didn't even think could be a bad thing… But again, it appears it *is* be-because I'm taking it to-to an extreme?— she went on, indignant. —So I-I suppose I'm upset because… how can I figure out a way to "measure" niceness, so to speak? How can I balance selflessness and selfishness!? I don't- It makes no sense to me!

—Oh, my Love…— Light Spinner sighed, cupping her face.

—What am I supposed to do?— Castaspella sobbed, looking up at her wife.

The question took the woman by surprise, leaving her speechless for a second.

Why was she… asking *her*?

Clearly, the sorceress had to be very out of sorts.

Unless, of course, this was just another symptom of her mentality. Of feeling unworthy…

Unsure of how to explain it, but still wanting to try, Light Spinner replied —You shouldn't need others to tell you what to do, Es. What are you afraid of?

—I don't… know? Failure? Making a mistake?

—I can understand that, but… You're allowed to make mistakes; you're allowed to rest, to prioritize yourself over others— Light Spinner reminded her. —Like I said, I can understand what you mean. After all, finding balance is… hard. I know. I haven't figured out how to do it either. Selflessness and selfishness, being nice or mean… Last year I was- Well, you know. I went from one extreme to the other, remember?— she went on. —In fact, Adora and Catra told me I had the right to lash out to Moosah; not to kill him like I wanted, of course…— she then laughed. —But I definitely didn't have to lower my head and accept his every word.

Letting out a deep sigh, Castaspella rested against Light Spinner's chest, mumbling —I know…

—So, I can't possibly tell you how to find balance, Es. It's… unfortunately, something you can only find yourself by trial and error. Or so it seems to me, I suppose— the woman concluded. —As long as you're afraid to fail, you… won't achieve balance.

—How wise— the sorceress chuckled, still sobbing slightly.

—Obviously— Light Spinner smirked. —And here's another piece of wisdom: not only can you attend parties *freely*, you can also leave whenever you feel like it. Hence, I propose we attend the last two festivities and whenever you feel uncomfortable, or tired, not in the mood, or whatever, just tell me and we'll return home. No need to explain why— she offered, kissing the top of Castaspella's head.

—I'd appreciate that, Bea— she replied. —You're right, we should go, I suppose… Besides, I wouldn't want Princess Frosta to feel insulted or like she did something wrong— she then giggled.

That evening, they arrived the at the Kingdom of Snows a bit later than intended.

However, they were still warmly welcomed and offered some coats.

—Oh, good. Our table is far from Mystacor's council— Light Spinner quickly noticed.

—Fortunately…

—You don't sound so sure about that.

—No, no. I am, trust me— Castaspella replied, with a weak chuckle. —It's just that… sometimes I have these… moments when I remember how I grew there, put so much energy and dedication into building a life there… never once considered I might ever leave— she began. —And then, it all just- No, *I abandoned* it all. I didn't "lose it", I *gave it up*. It didn't "vanish", I *threw it all away*.

—Do you regret it?

—I don't regret *that*, to be honest— the sorceress admitted. —I suppose what I regret is… not leaving sooner. Since I left after all that scandal, it looked more like me leaving out of guilt— she explained. —If I had left earlier, I think, maybe, it would have sent a message. The Council would have been questioned, most likely. They maybe would have questioned themselves.

—But this way, everyone, the Council and the rest of Etheria, think that Mystacor wasn't to blame for anything. Is that what you mean?

—I'm sure everyone thinks they were in the right all along, that the problem was *me*, that the Council's behaviour is fine and reasonable… And the exaggerated one, who left without being actually banished, is *me*— she sighed. —And don't get me started on the Head of the Guild title thing. That was even *worse*. Once again it made them seem so magnanimous and like they prioritize what would be best for Mystacor, hence wanting me to lead despite having left the Guild… And I was "ungrateful" for rejecting them, huh?

—Then why do you think they offered you the title?— Light Spinner asked. —Besides my deal with Norwyn, of course. After all, *he* came with the offer. It wasn't my idea.

—Isn't it obvious?— Castaspella scoffed. —That was an attempt at roping me back into the Guild, force me to subject, or maybe dare me to either comply or become a tyrant, making me, once more, the- Ah… the villain of the story, unreasonable and condemnable— she explained, sorrowful.

—I hadn't thought about that— Light Spinner admitted. —But I guess I understand better now.

—A-alright. E-enough of that. I don't want to end up crying in front of my family, you know? — she stammered, taking a deep breath.

—Sure thing— her wife accepted. —Let's take a seat, then.

Together, they reached the table where Micah, Angella, and Delwyn with his children were sitting, and Light Spinner opened the chair for Castaspella next to her brother before taking a seat herself.

—Welcome!— the King greeted them. —We wondered whether you would come.

—We had a bit of a delay— his sister smiled. —I see Glimmer and Bow are sitting with their friends.

—Well, yes. Since Bow's fathers were assigned a different table, they didn't want to choose either there or here, nor did they want to sit separated. So Princess Frosta got a bigger table set for all the princesses and their partners— Angella explained.

—That sounds like a good solution— Castaspella nodded. Right after, she noticed Micah seemed to be looking at Light Spinner to silently tell her something, and couldn't help asking —Is there anything wrong, Brother?

—Huh? No! No, don't worry…— he nervously replied. —I- Uh, so… how are you doing, Sis?

—I'm… okay. Why do you ask?

—Just asking! I- It's nothing— he stammered. —Can't I want to know how you…

—Sure…— she interrupted. Glancing back at Light Spinner, she noticed her talking with Delwyn, very conveniently, and immediately rolled her eyes. —Just tell me directly, will you?

—I- O-okay— he accepted, lowering his head. —I've been thinking and… I wanted to ask you if, when we were young, you ever felt like you *had* to help me. Out of obligation…— he finally asked.

—What!? No, no… I- no.

—I had to ask— he sighed. —But, I still want to let you know that, even if you hadn't helped me with my homework, I wouldn't have loved you any less— he assured her. —I wouldn't

have pushed you aside, I would have still tried to make as much time as possible to spend with you, alright?

—I… But…

—Of course I appreciate your help and diligence, all the times you organized our parties, and the assistance… But I really don't want to make you feel like it's the end of the world if you can't help or even refuse to help— he went on. —You wouldn't be wrong for any of it, you *wouldn't be a bad person*. Alright?

—But…

—Listen, you may not want to do something, you may not be in the mood, be tired, or just plainly *not* want to; those are all *valid* reasons— he once again interrupted. Placing a hand on her shoulder, he concluded —Sometimes, you needn't even explain yourself. You-you *shouldn't* have to explain why you refuse when you're asked to help as a favour, when it's not a matter of life-and-death… It's true that some people may say you're “bad" for refusing, but seriously, trivialities and emergencies are completely different matters. As long as you can tell them apart, you'll be able to tell when they are just guilt-tripping you.

—Mi-Micah, why… are you telling me this?— Castaspella finally managed to ask, sobbing.

—Because you're my sister and I want you to be… happy. With yourself, I mean. Just…

—Micah— the sorceress half-laughed, tearing up. The siblings immediately hugged, tightly as they realized they hadn't hugged in a long time. Finally, when they let each other go, Castaspella brushed away her tears, trying to smile, and admitted —I seriously didn't want to cry in front of you.

—No shame in crying, Es— Light Spinner assured her.

—Hypocrite— she replied, laughing again. —Alright. Enough, please. No one else make me cry, okay?— she pleaded.

—Fine. We'll leave our comments for tomorrow's party— Angella joked, looking at Delwyn.

—Oh, Stars, please no…

—Well, dinner's here— Light Spinner pointed out. —Better not delay. You can continue afterwards.

—I'd rather we *don't* continue— Castaspella sighed.

—No way you're escaping from this— the Queen firmly sentenced. —But for now, let's enjoy our meal.

Chapter End Notes

:D

Yes, that was all for today!!

I finally have at least half the last chapter written, meaning I may be able to post in time!!!!

But, in any case, I certainly hope to see you again tomorrow, to enjoy the last chapter, and the last few tough-love conversations with Casta!! :D

Thank you very much for reading!! Bye!!

Chapter 39: Day 7: Mystacor

Chapter Notes

> Welcome back for the final day!
>
> I'm sorry, it's later than usual. Last night we had a blackout before I could finish, so, no internet, and like… it lasted until 5am aprox…
>
> Anyways! Here is the last chapter! Wow, I'm surprised…
>
> But never mind that. Lemme just drop here the link to this tumblr post showing what Casta wore for this last party and I'll let you go read now! :D
>
> Please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 7

Mystacor

Year Five

The previous night, when the women arrived home, Castaspella seemed fine until the moment they went to sleep.

She suddenly broke down and started crying in silence.

Light Spinner noticed her shaking, and when she checked on her, the sorceress' cheeks were wet.

This had to be her inner conflict, right?

The more time she had to think things over, to consider what her brother told her, the worse her struggle became.

But this was something she had to face alone.

Light Spinner wanted to keep helping her, but with this, she could only make sure to be there if Castaspella needed her.

The rest would be for the sorceress to handle.

The following morning, they woke up almost at the same time, hugging each other comfortably.

Castaspella only kissed her gently but didn't say anything before getting up and heading to the bathroom.

Meanwhile, Light Spinner decided to prepare breakfast, and had it ready for when the sorceress joined her in the kitchen.

—Morn- Oh…— the woman gasped, seeing Castaspella's outfit. —I hadn't seen you wear that since…

—Our time tutoring together?

—Yes…— Light Spinner smiled. —I had forgotten how beautiful it looks.

—I'm glad you still like it— she smiled back. —I haven't worn it in years, but… I thought today would be a good chance to do it again.

—Certainly.

—Lately, I've been thinking so much about the past that I… remembered I still had this. And it looks a bit more fitting for parties than my usual clothes— Castaspella admitted. —I actually don't know why I didn't wear that Ak'kelon outfit this year…

—I wondered the same, to be honest, but I didn't want to pry— Light Spinner nodded. —Now, have some coffee and eat a bit.

—Thank you.

—And… besides nostalgic…— the woman went on, while sitting down with her own mug in front of her wife. —How are you feeling?

—Conflicted, I'd say. But you already noticed last night, didn't you?

—Yes— Light Spinner confirmed. —I can imagine why you- Ah… Listen: If you are upset, if… me talking about you with your family and your friends… upsets you, please let me know— she then said. —I know I'm quite bad at recognizing when I'm making things worse instead of helping as intended.

—No, I- Actually, I think you've… probably done exactly what I needed— Castaspella chuckled. —I asked you to show me your love, I asked you to choose me like I choose you… and I… guess I got what I wanted. You listened to me, paid attention, and keep trying to make me feel loved despite… despite how stubbornly I insist I'm undeserving lately.

—But you never questioned whether you deserved my love, did you?— the woman asked, after taking a sip of her coffee. —I mean, you… actually had to convince me that *I* deserved your love… and how there wasn't "something better" for you than me, because… you were the one who decided what was best for you.

—I know… I'm a bit contradictory sometimes…— the sorceress sighed, looking down into her mug. —I've been acting like an idiot…

—No, of course not— Light Spinner immediately denied. —You're acting the same as usual, which is far from "idiotic", just that I'm… finally paying enough attention to notice. And circumstances this year made it more evident just how unwell you are— she went on. —You're not acing like an idiot, you're just acting the way you were raised to behave, and… we're finally realizing how wrong it is.

Sniffing, Castaspella let out a smile that didn't reach her eyes and simply drank her coffee.

She didn't know what to say at this point, and maybe there was nothing to be said now.

Not yet, at least.

As expected, Castaspella's change of outfit draw a lot of attention when they arrived at Mystacor's party.

Although it was considerably shy attention, since no one even dared ask about it.

Or gossip.

This was the first time people seemed to pretend they weren't staring, stealing glances, or forcing themselves to look away, instead of shamlessly whispering their opinions…

The sorceress wasn't sure how to feel about it, but one look at her wife was enough reassurance to simply find their table and ignore everything else.

Soon enough, they had arrived at a large table with many people already sitting there.

Queen Angella and King Micah, George and Lance, Glimmer and Bow, Delwyn with his kids…

—Oh, this is a lot of people, what a surprise!— Castaspella noticed. —I didn't expect you to be here with us this time— she then told Glimmer.

—Oh, well, we… wanted to join in the fun this time— the Princess smirked.

—Fun?

—Of course! It's our turn now, isn't it?— Angella interrupted, noticiably amused.

—No way…

—She did said we'd leave our comments for today, remember?— Delwyn chuckled.

—No, please, I don't want to cry again…— Castaspella whined, dropping down on a chair.

—Too late— Light Spinner mocked her, sitting next to her. —But don't worry, if you need to leave after they are done, we can…

—I'm almost sure I will…— she muttered.

—Listen, Casta— Angella began, letting out a long sigh. —I won't try to say that I understand what you're feeling, because I don't want to lie. The kind of struggle you're feeling, the belief that you must be "useful" or somehow need to "earn" the right to be alive is something I got over too many years ago to properly remember. But I can still tell you that, regardless of your life-span, everyone deserves their place in the world by default. You included— she began. —And before you argue some people have done things that should get that right revoked, trust me, I can understand that feeling, but at the same time, it's still not true. People may do terrible things for which others may hate them with all due reason, but regardless, deserving to live is not something that should be taken away. If we started to grant and revoke that right, where would we draw the line? And how exactly would we ever agree on who gets to decide that?— she went on, shaking her head, oblivious to the sorceress' efforts to hold back her tears. —The point is: nothing you do or don't do should ever dampen

your worth. Your actions and attitudes can affect other people's appreciation of you; but your own?

—Really?— Castaspella sobbed. —So if I just… lived in your castle that whole year without-without doing anything… to-to help around… you wouldn't ha-have called me lazy? O-or freeloader?— she asked, sniffing.

—Of course not!— the Queen immediately replied. —I-I'm not saying no one would ever ask you to help around with something, but you absolutely didn't need to be assisting everyone at all times! You didn't have to "earn" the right to occupy a room, have your meals with us, and dispose of your free time!

—And yet… when I first moved there…— Castaspella sniffed, looking away. —All I heard was that I was "lucky" to be Micah's sister, so I could do nothing all day and just mop in my room…

—Wha- Who said that!?

—Shit- The guards— Glimmer interrupted, grunting. —I remember hearing that, but I didn't know they repeated it so much or… when you could hear them, Auntie— she apologetically explained. —I told them- I warned them about speaking like that, I told them off…

—You didn't have to— the sorceress denied, brushing away her tears. —They were right.

—Of course not!— Angella, Micah, and Glimmer exclaimed, indignant.

—Bullshit…— Castaspella laughed, increasingly depressed.

—This is getting annoying— Light Spinner decided to intercede. —Love, your stubbornness is no longer endearing, alright? Can you *listen* to them?

—I can't…— she denied. —You're just… telling me what you consider I need to hear, not… what you really think of me.

—Why would they do that?— Bow interrupted, genuinely concerned.

—Auntie, we…

—Seriously, it's fine. I don't mind— she then lied, gesturing dismissively with a hand.

—Now you're the one saying what you think they want to hear— Delwyn pointed out. —Did you notice?

—Huh?

—Casta, as a friend: You keep doing what you then reject from others— he began. —What you're doing now, doesn't it sound exactly like when Light Spinner denied everything you told her? When she insisted you were lying and you insisted you were genuine?

—It's not the same…

—It is. You keep helping people, feel upset and useless if your help is rejected, but then you *also* reject help for yourself!

—No, no!— Castaspella exclaimed, crying more now. —I don't… I…

—Es, my Love— Light Spinner whispered, placing a hand on her back. —Do you feel *less* than others? Like you don't deserve as much as everyone else?

—Shut up…— the sorceress sobbed. —Please, just shut up…— she begged, covering her face with both hands.

The woman was about to reply in agreement, but instead, she quietly pulled her into a hug.

—I'm so sorry…— George sighed. —We caused this, didn't we?

—It's not your fault, Dad— Bow assured him. —No one could have known…

—We should have… handled it better— Lance considered, sorrowful. —We should have asked, instead of assuming it was also the best for her…

—But it's still not your fault— Glimmer insisted. —No one knows everything- None of us would have known of this otherwise— she realized.

—Excuse me, Casta— Bow decided to call. He waited until the sorceress looked up, face red and wet with tears, and then gently offered —Here, have some.

As he extended his arm across the table to set a glass of water in front of her, Castaspella's breathing calmed down and she stared at the glass for a moment before tentatively picking it up.

After drinking some water, while everyone remained quiet, she let out —Thank you.

—Of course— he nodded. —So, uh, I understand what you want to do, alright? I think it's a nice gesture, but I also think Casta isn't ready right now.

—Right…— Light Spinner sighed. —I did say I wanted to listen to her this time— she admitted. Then, placing a hand on her wife's shoulder, she apologized —I'm- Sorry, Es. We'll leave it here if you don't feel… comfortable.

—Please…— she replied, sniffing. —Thank you, Bow.

—It was nothing— he smiled. —I think we should all just enjoy the party today. This is an important matter, I agree, but it's also something we can't just fix in a single week.

—Of course, you're right— Delwyn nodded. —I suppose we didn't consider it.

—I wouldn't want- Ple-please don't feel guilty— Castaspella then said. —He's right, I can't deal with this now. But you didn't… I know you want to help me. I appreciate it.

—Then, yes, of course we'll give you time— Angella assured her. —We'll be here when you're ready.

—Thanks— the sorceress smiled, brushing away her tears.

—Oh, great! Food's here!— Glimmer then noticed. As the dishes were set in front of each of them, the Princess couldn't help but notice Castaspella's conflicted expression. —Hmm, they smell good, but clearly we've had better here…

—Yeah! Let me just… hmm— Bow began, quickly catching up, and trying the food. —You're right. The seasoning is a bit off.

—Oh, seasoning is hard…— Castaspella chuckled. —Especially when you try to please everyone…

—Right?— they both replied, giggling.

With a lighter mood, they all began eating and tried to enjoy the party as much as possible.

The music wasn't great, entertainment was minimal, and there was still time before the lights show… but they could always chat between themselves, catch up with everyone… The usual.

By the time the lights show would finally begin, Castaspella was falling asleep on Light Spinner's shoulder.

—Es?

—Huh?

—You're tired, aren't you?

—I'm fine…

—Should I take you home?

—No! I want to see the lights show…

—And how will you do that if you keep falling asleep?

—I am not…

—You are— Light Spinner interrupted. —I understand why you want to stay, but…

—Please, Bea— she begged, right before yawning. —Just a bit more.

—Ah… Alright— the woman sighed. —Come over here, then— she invited her, pulling Castaspella by the hands and holding her close. —Just a bit more, and then I'll take you home.

—Yes— the sorceress smiled, looking up at her. —Thank you…

With quite some effort, she managed to wait just enough. She kept having to resist sleep with all her might, but each time her eyes closed for a bit longer…

And then…

—Es?

—Huh?

As she opened her eyes, a thousand colorful lights illuminated the woman's face while she whispered —Happy New Year, my Love.

—Happy New Year, Bea— she replied with a smile, before sharing a kiss with Light Spinner.

Chapter End Notes

That was it! Happy new year people!!

I know it's kinda odd to leave it there, Casta didn't exactly grow enough or anything, but trust me, I'm not ready yet to represent that growth because I myself haven't achieved it yet… so, yeah… I'm leaving it for next year <("^_^)

Whatever, enough yapping…

Many thanks for reading, I apologize for any mistakes I may have missed, and see you soon, I hope!! ^_^

Works inspired by this one

Flowers for Scorpia by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!